Moments of valour and glory
Etched in stone.
Love, passion, feasting, divinity...
Arrested in the sensitive chisels of master-craftsmen.
Meandering rivers, lush forests
Hills and ravines.
The roar of the tiger.
It's the magic of a many-splendoured land.

Madhya Pradesh
The very heart of Incredible India

Some destinations are changeless. They grow on you slowly but their allure is everlasting. Welcome to Madhya Pradesh...the land of Khajuraho, Sanchi and Bhimbetka, all World Heritage sites. And then there are the equally famous medieval townships of Mandu and Orchha which house matchless forts, palaces, temples and pavilions. Chanderi, Datia, Dhar, Vidisha and Bhojpur are some other heritage gems.

Madhya Pradesh is also the land of the tiger. This magnificent beast is found abundantly in the primeval forests of Kanha, Bandhavgarh, Panna, Pench and many other National Parks along with a wide variety of other mammals and an amazing array of birds. Shivpuri is a serene heritage and wildlife resort.

The vast plateau of Madhya Pradesh is dotted with the spectacular Satpura and Vindhya mountain ranges, verdant valleys and life-giving rivers like the Narmada, Shipra, Betwa, Chambal, Ken and Sone. Pachmarhi is easily the most pristine among the hill-resorts in the country. Its wooded landscape is dotted with cascading waterfalls which form natural bathing pools of amazing beauty. No less spectacular are the dazzling marble rocks of Bhedaghat on the banks of the mighty Narmada near Jabalpur. Bhopal, the capital city of Madhya Pradesh, is a fascinating amalgam of natural beauty, a rich heritage, and unique modern edifices that speak eloquently of imaginative urban planning. Indore and Jabalpur, along with Gwalior, are not just vibrant modern urban centres, bustling with commercial activity but they are also a showcase of Madhya Pradesh's unique cultural wealth.

The holy cities of Ujjain, Omkareshwar, Maheshwar, Maihar, Chitrakoot and Amarkantak attract millions of pilgrims from all over the world. Ujjain is also the land of the Simhastha, the grand Kumbha Mela, held once in 12 years.

Few people know Madhya Pradesh as well as Hugh and Colleen Gantzer. They have toured the length and breadth of the State many times during the last 25 years, and they obviously love the unique destinations they have visited and written on extensively over the years. Now, you can discover the Incredible Heart of India through their eyes.

Madhya Pradesh

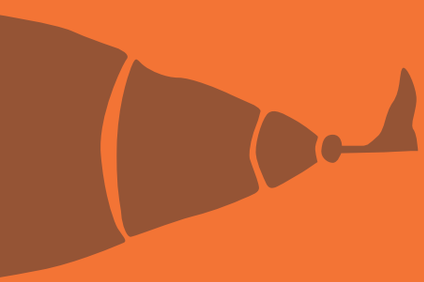
The heart of Incredible India

The heart of Incredible India

Discoveing

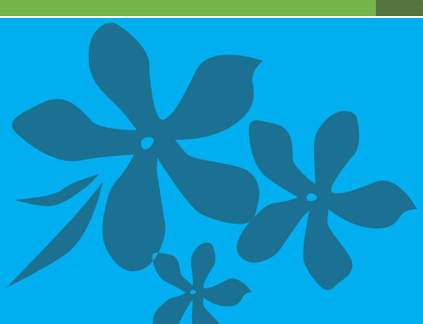
MADHYA PRADESH

Heritage



Pilgrimage

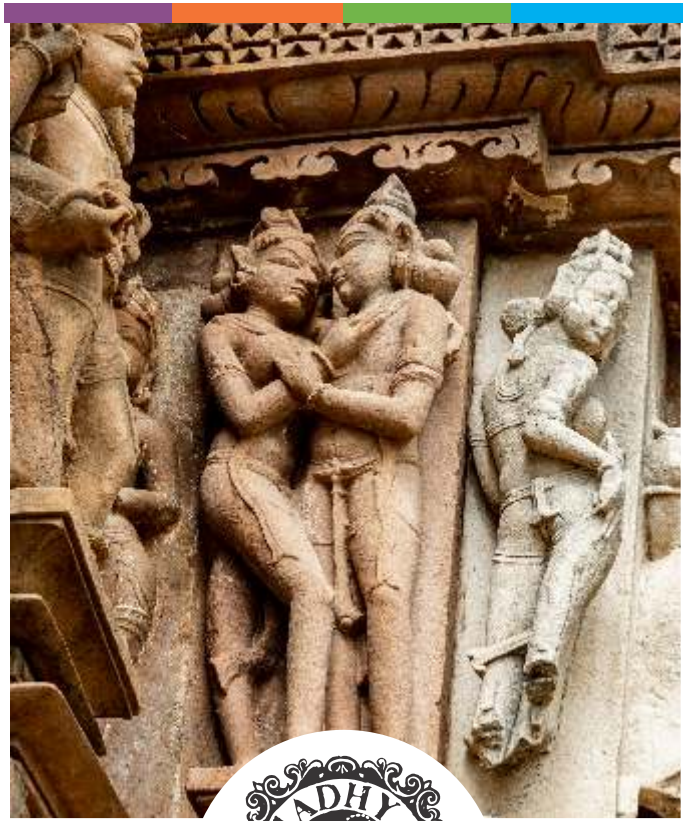
Wildlife



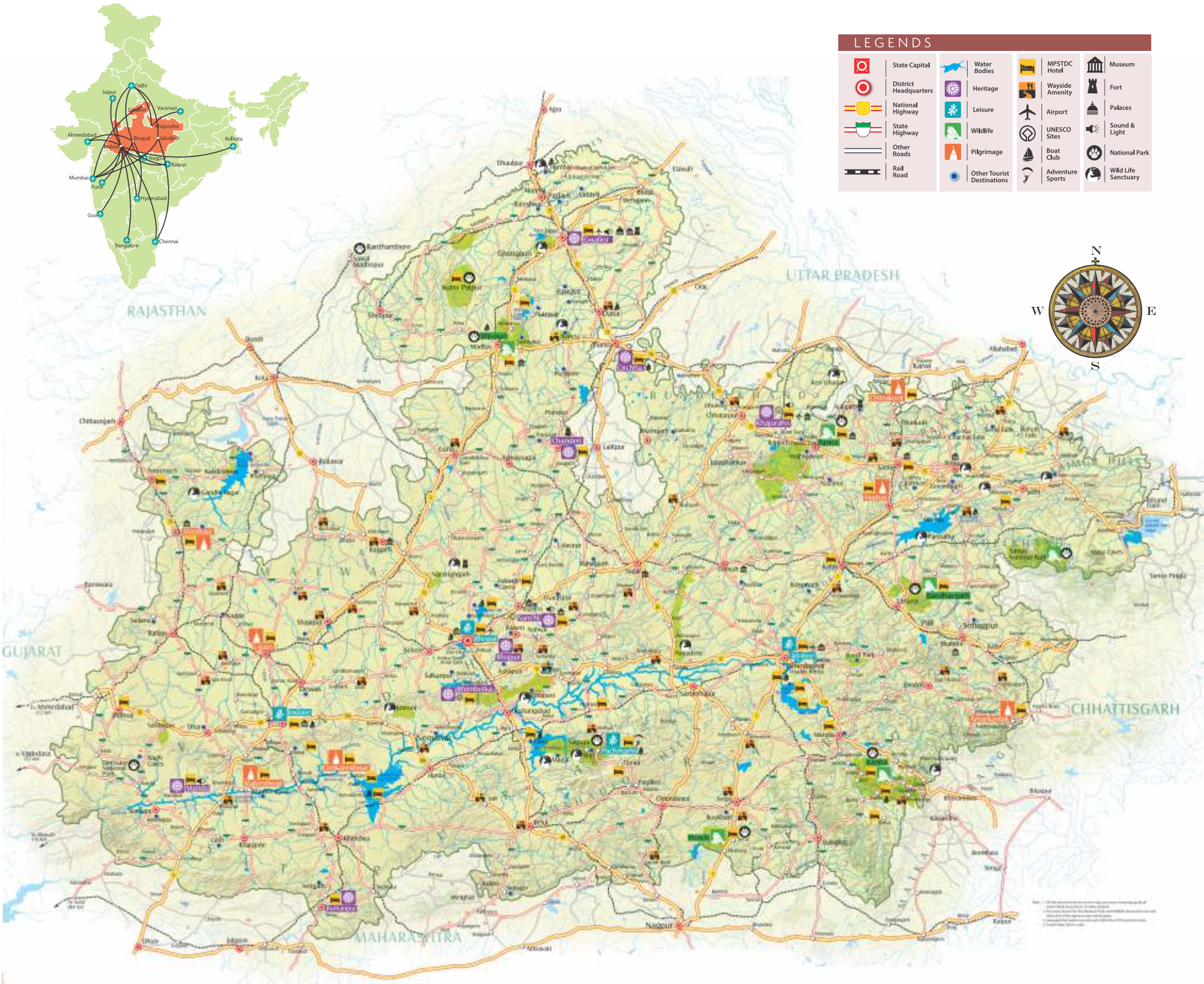
Leisure

Discoveing

Madhya Pradesh



The heart of
Incredible India


LEGENDS
State Capital
District Headquarters
National Highway
State Highway
Other Roads
Rail Road
Water Bodies
Heritage
Leisure
Wildlife
Pilgrimage
Other Tourist Destinations
MPSTDC Hotel
Wayside Amenity
Airport
UNESCO Sites
Boat Club
Adventure Sports
Museum
Fort
Palaces
Sound & Light
National Park
Wild Life Sanctuary
N
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RAJASTHAN
UTTAR PRADESH
GUJARAT
MADHYA PRADESH
CHHATTISGARH
MAHARASHTRA
Delhi
Jaipur
Agra
Varanasi
Gwalior
Khajuraho
Ahmedabad
Bhopal
Jabalpur
Indore
Kolkata
Nagpur
Raipur
Mumbai
Pune
Hyderabad
Goa
Bangalore
Chennai

The heart of
Incredible India

First Edition 2025

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The objective behind publishing this book is to provide serious yet extremely readable material to the tourists visiting or intending to visit the fascinating destinations in Madhya Pradesh. Although the writers and the publishers have made every effort to provide accurate information on the destinations covered in this book, we would appreciate if readers would call our attention to any inaccuracy in text.Please write to: The Managing Director, M.P. Tourism Board., Lilly Tradewing, Jehangirabad, Bhopal

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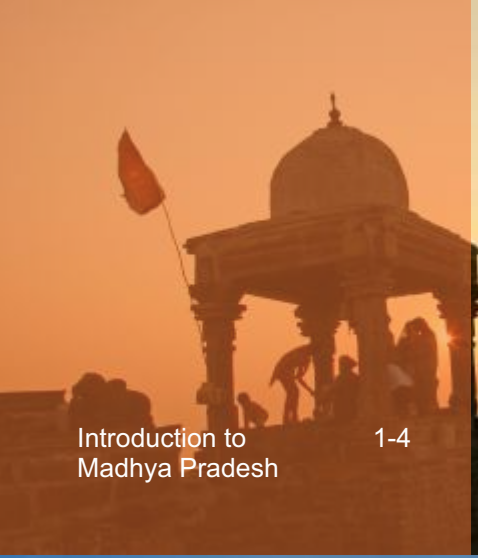

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Madhya Pradesh

In the beginning...

Before India was born, Gondwana existed. It lay, snuggled tightly, in the vast womb of a Mother Continent, somewhere to the west of Eurasia That was 135 million years ago. Then, strange things began to happen to the Earth. Currents in the mass of molten rock deep within the planet, the magma, began to move and tear the landmasses asunder. Gondwanaland split and, slowly, the gigantic pieces began to float away from each other, suspended on the currents of magma. Antarctica went down south, Australia drifted south- east, and a huge wedge floated cast.

On its slow voyage, the sub-continental wedge of land crossed a hot-spot where the magma was spouting out from deep inside the earth. The wedge developed cracks and the magma welled up through them becoming lava. It spread over the land, and cooled; and spread, and cooled, and spread and cooled. And as layer built up upon earlier layer they formed flat-toped hills and gigantic steps of hard, basaltic, rock. This is known as the Trap Country and accounts for much of the central Deccan Plateau. Visitors can identify Traps fairly easily in Malwa and Amarkantak. Not all of it, however, remained as prominent physical features of the landscape. When some of this ancient lava was eroded by wind and weather, it decomposed and formed black soil rich in minerals bled from the heart of the earth.

But India had still not been born.

The wedge of Gondwana now floated north towards the continent of Eur- asia. Implacably, 120 million years ago, it nudged into the continent's southern boundary, its leading edge burrowing under it like the blade of a titanic bull- dozer. Slowly, over millions of years, the warm, tropical sea that had enriched the southern lands of Eurasia was pushed, inexorably, centimetre by grudging centimetre, higher and higher into the sky. Eventually, the bottom of the sea, the Tethys Sea, became the highest mountains in the world: the Himalayas.

The wedge sutured itself to the southern edge of Eurasia.

India had now been born.

And the rich Heart of India, much of the original Gondwana, is now called Madhya Pradesh.

You can see evidence of these stupendous geologic events written all across the landscape of MP. In the centre of this 3,08,252 sq km state, the land was hunched up like a rucked table-cloth to create the Satpura, Vindhya and Kaimur ranges and the Mahadeo and Maikal hills; and the Malwa plateau within the great central plateau of the Deccan. Rains fell on these mountains; forests bur- geoned like those in the National Parks of Pench, Kanha, Bandhavgarh and Panna, great rivers like the Narmada, Betwa, Sone, Chambal, Ken and Shipra poured down off these highlands gouging out gorges and ravines, spreading through forests and farmlands, fertilizing fat river valleys in the plains below. The caves in Chitrakoot were formed in that distant tumultuous age as were the caves of Pachmarhi. The rock-shelters of the world's greatest Stone Age gallery in Bhimbetka were stacked like gianı, haphazard, steps by those monstrous earth movements. Then, to this varied and wonderful heartland of the sub continent, humans came.

Some may have evolved out of the first hominid, or pre-human tribes: India's own Ramapithecus. Others may have evolved in Africa, like the little Negritoes who intermarried with later races. Then came the Austrics, possibly also from Africa. Later many of them crossed over to Australia. An Ice Age had lowered the level of the sea by over 150 meters, making it easier for people to migrate from landmass to landmass. The Kols, and the Korkus of Pachmarhi are an Austric people and anthropologists believe that they laid the foundation of Indian civilization, cultivating rice and vegetables and making sugar from sug- arcane. Many centuries later, the Dravidians followed the Austrics. The Dravid- ians are a race with the same blood-lines as the people of ancient Crete and the pre-Hellenic Ageans of Greece. The Gonds-after whom the Mother Continent was named Gondwanaland-are a Dravidian people.

When those Early Men settled in Madhya Pradesh they set the trend for wave after wave of migrants like the Bhils, Baigas, Bharias and Sahariyas who mixed with each other and created new racial strains with new skills. The Bhila- las, for instance, were born out of the merging of two races in Omkareshwar And as these early settlers farmed the rich lands of Madhya Pradesh, created vil- lages that grew into towns and prospered into cities, others were attracted to the promising Heart of India. These vigorous migrants, conquerors, local warlords and princes set up their dynasties and kept altering the internal boundaries of MP like the shifting patterns in a moving kaleidoscope. Their chequered names read like a Who's Who of MP's Heritage of Princes.

Here, like the drum-beats of history, is an honour roll of some of those leg- endary dynasties. There were the Mauryas, Sungas, Satavahanas and Guptas; the Chalukyas, Rashtrakutas, Pratiharas, Kalachuris and Paramaras, Chandel- las, Bundellas, Ghoris, Tomars and Mughals. Then, as the great Mughal Empire aged, became weak, and began to collapse, a chieftain under the Mughals broke away and established the dynasty of the Nawabs of Bhopal. At about the same time, the Marathas moved in and the new dynasties of the Holkars and the Scindias began to rule their own kingdoms in the heartland.

Great dynasties build great cities; out of great cities, civilizations are born; in the security provided by such civilizations, art and religion grow and pros- per. Ujjain, Vidisha, Orchha, Khajuraho, Chitrakoot, Mandu, Bhopal, Indore and Gwalior became the centres of great cultural traditions. And out of the prosperity that they spread along the caravan and riverine trade routes span- ning India, other centres of faith and finance blossomed in the Heart of India.

The legendary wealth of this focal land attracted the attention of the East India Company seeking to enhance and enrich its sphere of influence by a deceptive blend of guile, realpolitik and the force of arms. They absorbed these Central Provinces, as they called them, into the Empire on Which the Sun Never Set. They established many effective systems of governance to increase the flow of wealth into their misty isles. But as their self-confidence grew so did their alienation from the people of India. Eventually, in many parts of the Heart of India, people revolted against the increasingly harsh and exploitive ways of the Company. This seething discontent culminated in the great Revolt of 1857, That is when the sun of the Empire started to cross High Noon. Ninety years later, in 1947, India became independent.

Today, Madhya Pradesh is one of the 28 states of the Indian Union with its own state legislature elected every five years, its elected representatives in Parliament, and a democratic system that reaches down to elected civic rep- resentatives who oversee the governance of towns and cities and an elected panchayat in every village.

These elected representatives are aware that their state has always wel- comed people from distant places, eager to discover the many facets of Madhya Pradesh. That tradition has been deeply ingrained in the hearts of the people of the Heart of India. This book is the latest expression of that very long tradition.

Heritage Sites

Bhimbetka
Burhanpur
Chanderi
Datia
Damoh
Dhar
Gwalior
Indore
Khajuraho
Mandu
Orchha
Rewa
Sanchi
Vidisha

Madhya Pradesh

A people's present is conditioned by its past. It grows out of the achievements of i its ancestors: the wars they fought and won; the bloodlines they absorbed; the varied cultural trends that formed the matrix from which their roots draw strength and sustenance. This is the Heritage of Madhya Pradesh: extremely rich and very old.

It starts from the Stone Age when tribes of hunter-gatherers painted their fears and dreams on rock-shelters where they hid from wild animals. Later, as our ancestors began to dominate the earth, they built great fortified cities to protect themselves from the rapacity of their fellow men. These powerful cities still stand, steeped in the bloody legends of war, assassination and intrigue.

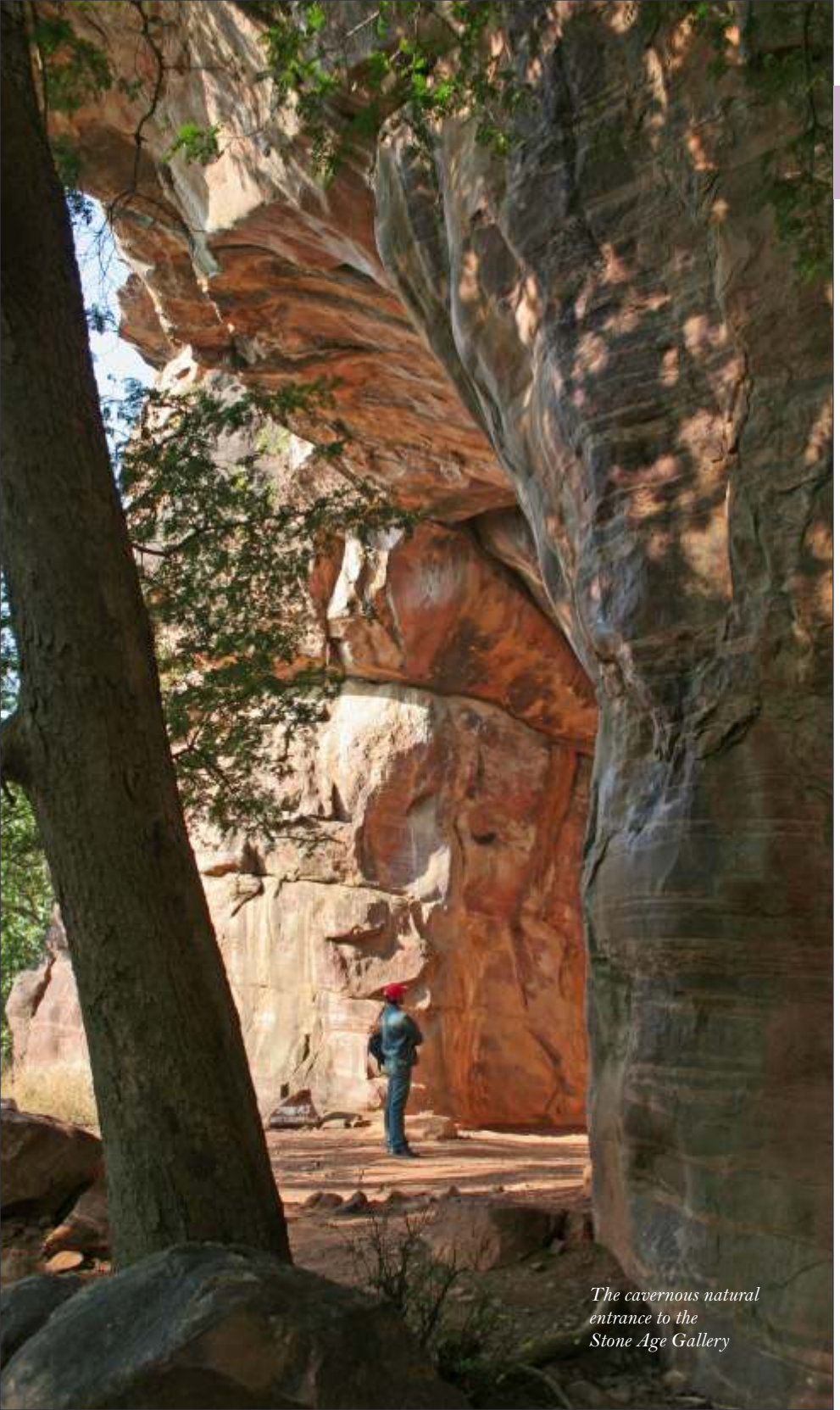
Then one of the greatest warriors that the world has ever known, turned his back on violence and embraced the gentle faith of the Buddha. He marked his conversion by erecting a great monastery atop a hill. This has become a virtual history in stone of the earliest days of Buddhism.

Subsequently, a millennium ago, a forest people evolved a society so creative, and socially advanced, that even our most liberal-minded sociologists are amazed to see the activities that they have carved on the walls of their soaring temples. They were, obviously, considerably ahead of their times and this is probably why they vanished without a trace. Some fantasists theorise that they were an extra-terrestrial civilization and that they vanished back into outer space. But that theory, though entertaining, has no basis in fact. To this day, the aboriginal people of India have social and cultural traditions that are far in advance of ours. It is more than likely, therefore, that they elaborated on these conventions when their dynasty established its own kingdom in this area.

Then to this rich and fertile terrain, came invaders from west and central Asia; and Afghanistan. Initially, they ravaged the land, as all invaders do. But gradually, India worked its magic as it has always done. They merged into our genetic pool but not before they had left their distinguishable imprint on this state. An Afghan fortress-city that became a pleasure dome, still spreads over the mountains of Madhya Pradesh and embraces a living hamlet and curious trees brought from Africa.

Warriors now carved out states for themselves, established dynasties, swore their fealty to the British who had conquered much of India. These princes, often educated in England or by English tutors, accepted the supremacy of the British and found it expedient to emulate the British royal family when they decorated their palaces. With the coming of Indian Independence, the Princely States were absorbed into the Union of India but many of those palaces still stand, monuments to the fashions and fads of those colonial days.

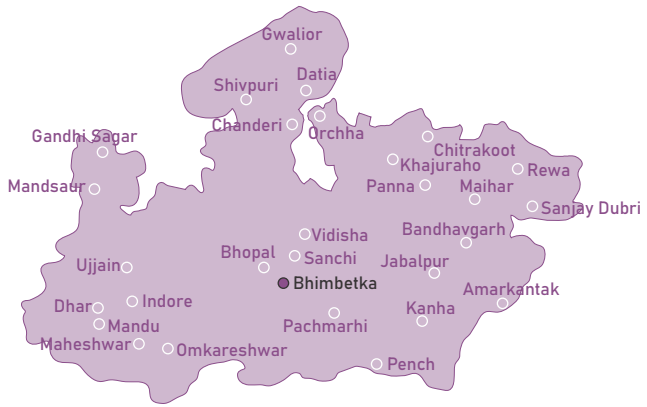
The monuments of Madhya Pradesh, however, do more than testify to the chequered past of this state. They speak of the successive tides of history that have swept over our country, leaving their indelible impressions on the beating Heart of India.



The cavernous natural entrance to the Stone Age Gallery

Bhimbetka

A 98,000 year-old art gallery hides amongst the massive, black boulders of Bhimbetka.



It should really be much better known than it is. But if you miss the sign on the right of National Highway 69, from Bhopal to Pachmarhi, then you're likely to miss Bhimbetka. The sign carries the UNESCO emblem of a World Heritage Site, and indicates a road that bears to the right. Travellers then bump over a manned level crossing and enter terrain that resembles the Olduvai Gorge in Tanzania where Louis and Mary Leakey discovered remains of the world's first pre-humans or hominids. Here, as in Olduvai, is a sere sub- montane land of parched grass, few trees, slabs of rock and rising black boul- ders. The road winding up through this austere landscape ends in a green and wooded parking lot to the left, carved out of the hardwood sal (Shorea robusta) [orests. Across the road, a fence demarcates the area protected by the Archaeological Survey of India and de- clared a World Heritage Site with a descriptive board telling one what lies ahead.

A rock perched like prehistoric tortoise: look-out point for our Paelolithic ancestors

THE STONE-AGE GALLERY

A saddled deer, unknown in Indian tradition

These caves were discovered in 1957-58. Out of the 750 rock shelters, 500 are adorned with paintings.

This was the centre of human activity right from Lower Paleolitic times upto the medieval period: linear depiction of human figures, hunting, riding, communal dances, warfare, etc. and day to day activities of ancient man.

Mineral colours used are green, red, ochre and white.

The cup marks made on the rocks date to 100,000 BP (Before the Present).

This pushes back the date of the cognitive development of man at Bhimbetka to many thousand years earlier than similar sites in various parts of the world making it the earliest cognitive human evolution. (As described by the Archaeological Survey of India)

Indian Archaeologists generally accept that the Lower Paleolithic Age in our land extended from 500,000 BC to 100,000 BC when humans preferred to live near water and used the pebbles found on the shores as weapons and implements.

The Middle Paleolithic covered the period from 100,000 BC to 36,000 BC. During this period mankind's preferred materials changed from quartzite to flint and jasper and their technique changed from chipping to reveal the hard core of these stones, to flaking them down to the required shape and sharpness.

In the Upper Paleolithic, from 38,000 BC to 9,000 BC, their techniques had advanced to the creation of figurines and the making of bone tools and harpoons. The age of a site is largely determined by the presence of these typical man-made creations.

Looking straight ahead, down the line of the path that arrows through the trees, one sees huge masses of rocks towering above the forest. They look rather like a natural fortress which is probably why our ancestors chose this site. Nine hundred and eighty centuries ago, Bhimbetka stood in a dense, wet forest with lakes and green swamps glistening through the tropical trees. It was then the home of herds of elephant, In- dian bison and rhinoceros, possibly tigers and leopards. Early Man needed a place from where he could spot the movements of wildlife and watch out for other, possibly, hostile tribes. This great outcrop of rocks provided an excellent vantage point for him.

Although we tend to call our ancestors Cave Men, not many of them preferred caves for their dwellings. Caves offered confined spaces with a limited number of entrances. Rock shelters of- fered the advantages of easy access and a clear view of approaching dangers. Here, in Bhimbetka, Early Man chose either narrow passages between two enormous rocks - which is what the first shelter is - or rocky overhangs which is what the vast majority of the shelters are. The ASI has, however, referred to them as 'Caves' and that remains a convenient way to identify them.

Paths have been laid accessing the more in- teresting shelters and watchful guards ensure that visitors do not add their contributions to the cave paintings. It would be advisable to budget two hours to go around the rock shelters and even then you will not be able to see all of them. But do keep your eyes open and linger over every likely rock surface: you might find something that the most astute scholars have missed because the sun's angle was just right when you visited. Many visi- tors, for instance, spot the elephants on the bulging rock at the entrance of the first shelter but fail to notice the curious ostrich-like figure on their right. It could be a large bird or even perhaps a prancing man dressed like an animal psyching hunters the way jouncing cheer- leaders inspire teams today (See Box The Paintings) There is, however, an even clearer painting of a very large and aggressive bird outside Cave No. 8

One of the towering rock shelters that attracted ancient humans

The Zoo Cave, identified as such, teems with animals and hunters and a man riding a giant elephant with enormous tusks. One of the hunting techniques employed by prehistoric tribes was to panic herds of prey ani- mals, like deer and bison, to stampede and plunge over a cliff or into a bog They could then be butchered at lei- sure. As part of this hunting scene, at the lower part of the Zoo Cave, there is a man carrying a shield and some- thing resembling a boomerang. The Austrics of India are believed to have migrated to

Australia when the last Ice Age had frozen much of the oceans and made it easier for people to hop from island to island, landmass to landmass. What one sees in this cave painting is a throwing weapon before it migrated to Australia along with the Indian ancestors of the Australian Ab- origines. Perhaps!
Initially, men hunted on foot but later they tamed elephants. Still later, possibly after the Indo-Iranians came galloping in from the Central European steppes,

Looking straight ahead, down the line of the path that arrows through the trees, one sees huge masses of rocks

THE PAINTINGS

Our Stone Age ancestors lived in a frighteningly uncertain world. In the early days of the occupation of Bhimbetka, they were hunter-gatherers: the secrets of agri- culture had not been discovered. Slaughtered animals provided them with food, clothing, and in the Upper Paleolithic, materials for tools and weapons. But hunting is a very iffy thing: animals can migrate; weapons might miss their mark; predators could decimate the hunting party, accidents could crip- ple them the list of misfortunes was endless.
To bring some order to the unknown, the tribe called upon its shamans. These people were considered to have the power to communicate with the spirits that guided the destinies of the tribe, and controlled animals. The shamans would dress up in animal skins and by using drugs and working themselves into a frenzy 'talk' to those invisible, but very powerful, beings and convince them to give success to the tribe in its life-threatening activities.
To help them achieve this exalted state of consciousness, they painted their dreams and wishes on the rock walls of their shelters. These mystic pictures captured the life-force of the animals. If a successful hunt could be captured in these pictures then, by sympathetic magic, the real hunt would also be successful. Whatever they could paint realistically would come true: even a festering finger successfully amputated, or a saddled sambat, or killing a menacing giant bind
So, mixing coloured carths, vegetable dyes and soot with animal fat, they applied them with brushes shredded out of fibrous twigs, or filled charcoal outlines with fat and blew powdered pigments on to them through hollow bones. In time, the fat and pigments became absorbed by the cellular structure of the rocks and, very slowly, they became as lasting as tattoos on human skin.
This is why we can still share their hopes and dreams and uncertain lives, nine hundred and eighty centuries on through the timeless magic of Bhimbetka.

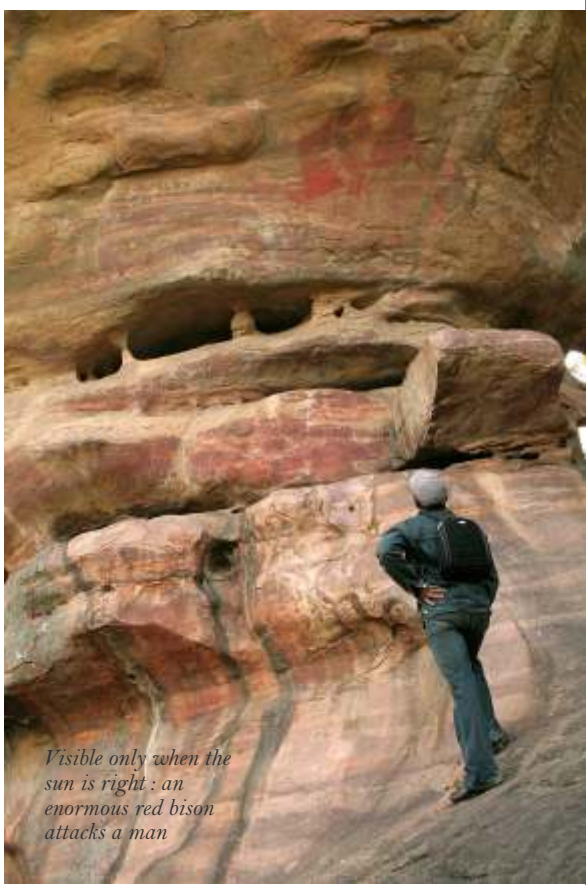
horses were used. Cave No. 7 has a clear painting of two equestrian hunters holding spears aloft. A beautiful white horse and a large elephant with its handler has been painted outside Cave No. 9. Judging from the very artistic manner that the horse has been depicted, this would seem to be a much later painting than the horses in Cave 7. There is also a very curious domesticated animal painting. It has been seen fairly often, and even photographed but, ob- viously, it appears only when the angle of the sun is just right. It shows both a saddle and a saddled deer. Today, only Laplanders use their reindeer as pack and riding animals, if one excludes Santa Claus!

In another, now-you-see-it-now-you-don't, vignette, a hand has been shown with the first digit of its index finger amputated. Strangely, the excised digit has been depicted, separately, just above the chopped finger. No one has, also, been able to explain why a tree has been painted on the surface of Cave 10. Most of the old religions have legends of sacred trees and possibly this was one of those. Below the tree, a hunter brandishing a weapon, has just at- tacked an animal which is rearing with a mortal wound. The hunter carries a bucket which could indicate a blood ritual. Sacrifices were, often, made to sacred trees.

While hunting occupied much of the time of the early inhabitants of Bhimbetka, and consequently are most frequently depicted in the rock shelters, there are interesting scenes of group dances. In Cave 6, men and women hold hands and move in a circle as, in- deed, many of the tribal people of Mad- hya Pradesh do to this day.

Many lucky visitors believe that the most powerful painting is one made on a rock-face high above the road. Here again, if the angle of the sun is just right, an enormous red bi- son leaps into view. It's huge, horned, head lowered, it has almost reached a man fleeing for his life. The depiction of the animal is so graphic that one can almost hear its bellow, the thun- der of its cloven hooves, the agonised shriek of its victim.

The sounds have been lost in the silence of the centuries. But the hopes and fears of those early humans live on in the galleries of Bhimbetka.

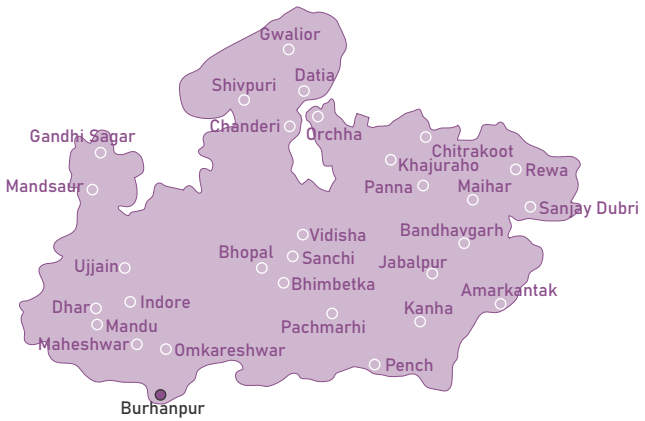


Visible only when the sun is right : an enormous red bison attacks a man

Shehzadi ka Roza

Burhanpur

The Medieval Gateway to the Deccan



Burhanpur town, founded in 1400 Ad by the Faruqi ruler, Nasir Khan on the northern banks of the Tapti river, and strategically critical throughout medieval Indian History to any king who wished to rule the Deccan, bears traces of its dramatic past in its crowded bylanes and sprawling, often ruined, suburbs.

The casual visitor may be surprised by how much there is to see here. In fact, at almost every turn in the older part of town, now known as 'Seetee' there seems to be a medieval mosque or sarai, or gurudwara or temple, a towering gateway or a solitary grave. Its immediate outskirts, too, within a 20 – odd km radius offer the massive Asirgarh Fort to the north, the luxurious

Tomb of Shah Nawaz Khan

pleasure palace of Mahal Gulara to the east and the sacred Icchadevi Temple to the south, with numerous, old dargahs, temples, and medieval ruins on the way. Indeed, though Burhanpur may appear at first glance to be little more than the average small town, to those who care to peel away its layers, it offers a glimpse into a truly glorious past.

A past in which great battles were lost and won epic love flourished and died , ambitious journeys both political and spiritual, were embarked upon, and formidable architectural feats were accomplished to engrave the town's name forever in history.

JAMA MASJID

Built when Bibi ki Masjid, became too small to accommodate Burhanpur's growing population, the miraculously well-preserved Jama Masjid, is located at the very centre of town in Gandhi Chowk. Its over 36m high minars tower over the mosque arched compound and the bustling bazaar outside.

Jama Masjid

KALI MASJID

One of the oldest Faruqi monuments is Kali Masjid (black mosque). While locals insist that this is Burhanpur's oldest mosque, the MP District gazetteer, 1969 attributes it to the last Faruqi ruler, Bahadur Khan(1596-1600). It is looted in the Daulatpura Mohalla, a 10-minute walk uphill from the Rajghat along the Tapti.

BIBI KI MASJID

Further inside the town, about 15 minutes by foot from the Rajghat area is another Faruqi monument, Bibi ki Masjid. For more ornate than Kali Masjid, Bibi ki Masjid was built between 1520 and 1540 by a Faruqi queen.

Tombs of Nadir Shah and Adil Shah : About 3 kms from the centre of town are the tombs of several Faruqi rulers and their queens, set within a walled enclosure. Most noteworthy of these are the tombs of Nadir Shah and Adil Shah.

Bibi ki Masjid

BADSHAHI QILA

A prolific builder of the Faruqi dynasty and the ruler under whom Burhanpur enjoyed most prosperity, was Adil Khan II cr. 1457-1503. The king propelled the construction of a citadel, with walls pierced by eight gates stretching around Burhanpur. This was known as the Badshahi Qila.

DIWAN-E-KHAS

Outside the baths are the grounds of the Diwan-e-Khas, its lawn beautifully maintained by the Archaeological Survey of India, which also has its offices here.

DIWAN-E-AAM

Adjacent to the Diwan-e-Khas is the Diwan-e-Aam, the delicate frescoes on its walls and arches faded except in a few places.

Zenana Hammam : The Mughals added enormously to Burhanpur's architectural treasures. Within Badshahi Qila is the Zenana Hammam. Built in a combination of Mughal and Persian styles distinctive of early Mughal architecture, the baths were once decorated with beautiful frescoes on the ceilings, some of which still survive.

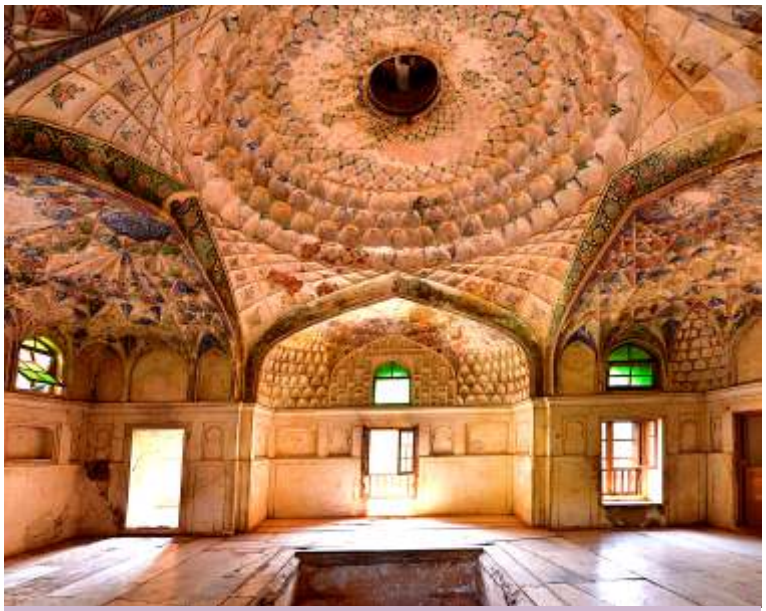
KUNDI BHANDARA

The Mughal pleasure in water- fountains, canals, baths is well known.Burhanpur boasts of what may be one of their most elaborate system for transporting water demonstrating an unparalleled constructional technique. Even today, these remain glorious relics of Mughal engineering, ingenuity and skill.

TOMB OF SHAH NAWAZ KHAN

On the northern outskirts of Burhanpur, about 2 kms from the town, is a beautiful Mughal monument, the tomb of Shah Nawaz Khan, on the banks of the Utaoli river.

Badshahi Qila and Tapti River



Zenana Hamam

BILQUIS JAHAN

The tomb of Bilquis Jahan, or Begum Shah Shuja is barely 2 kms from Shah Nawaz's tomb because of its distinctively shaped dome, the tomb is locally known as Kharboozi ('melon-like') Gumbaz. Shah Shuja, Shah Jahan's second son, lost his beloved wife, Bilquis Jahan, in Burhanpur during childbirth, and erected this tomb in her memory.

MAHAL GULARA

Beautifully located on the banks of the Badi Utaoli river is Mahal Gulara, a Mughal pleasure retreat, 21 kms from Burhanpur on Amravati Road, north of the village of Sindhkheda.

HAZRAT SHAH BHIKARI

Very close to the tomb of Bilquis Jahan is the dargah of Hazrat Shah Bhikari also known as Hazrat Shah Nizamuddin.

DARGAH-E-HAKIMI

About 3 kms from Gandhi Chowk in Burhanpur is the village of Lodhi, said to have been founded by and hence named after a king of the Lodhi dynasty. The village houses the Dargah-e-Hakim, a sacred pilgrimage for the Dawoodi Bohra Muslims. It is the mazar of Syedi Abdulqadir Hakimuddin.

ASIRGARH

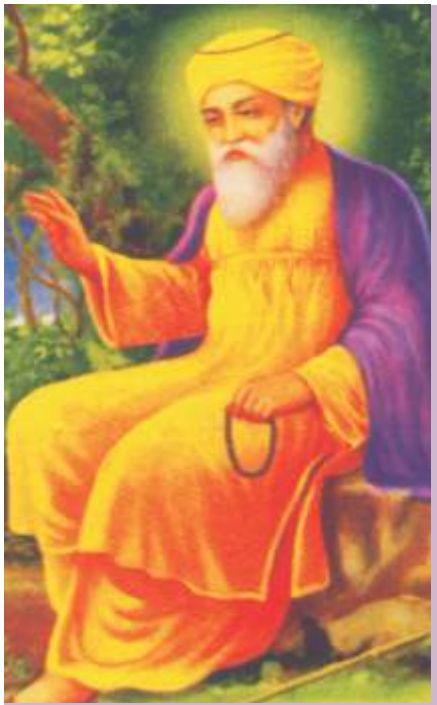
Perched high on a hill of the Satpura range just under 25 kms north of Burhanpur is one of the most magnificent forts of the region, rivaling even the great Golconda in impregnability. Alexander Cunningham attributes the origins of the fort to 'great antiquity' , going so far as to identify it with the 'Ozoabis' mentioned by Ptolemy.

Asirgarh Fort

Dargah-e-Hakimi

SHAH JAHAN & MUMTAZ MAHAL IN BURHANPUR

Of the Mughals, Shah Jahan is perhaps most closely connected to the city. His first daughter, Roshanara, was born here in 1617, When Shah Jahan was still a prince Latu, as emperor, Shah Jehan returned to Burhanpur, where he lost the wife he passionately loved, Mumtaz Mahal : She died while delivering their 14th child, also a daughter in Burhanpur.



Guru Nanak Dev

SIKHISM IN BURHANPUR

The Sikh connection in Burhanpur dates as far back as the early 16th century when Guru Nanak is said to have visited the town. (Surjit Singh Gandhi, History of the Sikh Gurus Retold 1606-1708 CE). The gathering to which he is said to have preached, on the banks of the Tapti, is commemorated by the Gurudwara Sangat Rajghat Patshali Pahili, which still stands at the site.

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KHOONI BHANDARA, BURHANPUR
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Accommodation in Burhanpur

MPT Tapti Retreat

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Facilities

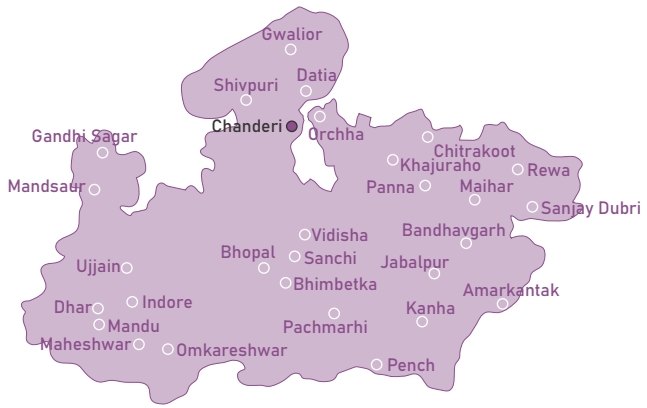
AC Rooms | Conference Hall | Restaurant | Swimming Pool

MPT Tapti Retreat by MPT Hotels & Resorts offers you impeccable service and hospitality in Burhanpur, the city famous for its legacy of medieval architecture. This hotel, aptly located 6 km from the railway station, the hotel offers conference facilities along with quality food and clean ambience. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Badal Mahal - portal to nowhere

Chanderi

The looms of Chanderi weave fabrics, history and legends.



From Kirti Pal's Fort, the view over the town is expansive. The town spreads across a valley encircled by hills. Minarets and domes rise out of fields and trees and there are occasional glimpses of the high wall that once encircled the city. (See Box: Walled Cities) In the sixteenth century it was such a thriving trade and transit city that the founder of the Mughal Empire, Babur, decided that he must acquire it. Historian Abraham Eraly, in his book The Lives and Times of the Great Mughals, describes the ensuing battle in these graphic words :-

Weaving a Chanderi Sari

WALLED CITIES

Forbidding gate to a walled city

Now, they are curiosities, tourist attractions, raw materials for new con- structions, but it hasn't always been so.

Till as recently as 150 years ago, encircling walls raised the stature of a city. The ungoverned areas between cities were, often, lawless places where bands of brig- ands preyed on travellers. Prosperous cit- ies therefore protected themselves with high walls pierced by a few well-guarded gates.

At the heart of the city, gener- ally on a knoll from where look-outs could heep a watch on the surround ing countryside, was the fortress-palace.

This was the home of the ruler who lived on the taxes collected from his subjects. In return, he ensured law and order in his city and the right to his subjects to live their lives without fear of molestation and attack. The citizens of these fortified towns were happy to pay for the certainty of being able to live and work in a secure environment.

And so, the walled cities closed their gates at sunset, admitted only carefully scrutinised people after dark, had patrols walk the town at night, and opened their great gates only when there was enough light for the look-outs to be sure that no danger lurked beyond the walls.

Such walled cities thrived all over the world. One of them was Chanderi.

When the monsoon ended, Babur set out on his campaign again, this time against Medini Rai of Chanderi in north-eastern Malwa. Here for the first time he came across the macabre Rajput rite of jauhar, in which, faced with certain defeat, women and children immolated themselves or were slaughtered by their men, who then slew each other, or rushed out naked to fight and die - to preserve their honour. The Rajputs kept their honour, Babur took the fort.

This searing event is still remembered by the people of Chanderi who point out Babur's Mosque.

BABUR'S MOSQUE

It's in ruins today, after five centuries, but one can still discern a few of the features of that old place of prayer. There is also a carving in the cursive Arabic script though it would require a scholar to read it. A shelf of land behind the mosque gives superb, though vertiginous, views of the town below.
Returning to the ruined mosque, and climbing up a tumble of stones and bricks, visitors can reach the Jauhar Monument.

JAUHAR MONUMENT

Here, apparently, Rajput families committed ritual suicide rather than face dishonour at the hands of their enemies. It was often the custom to send captive women to the harems of their conquerors and condemn children to a life of slavery.

Linked with this act of self- sacrifice is the Khuni Darwaza.

KHUNI DARWAZA

This 'Blood Gate was where, according to legend, the Rajput warriors met their enemies, and were slaughtered by them. Local guides assure visitors that, in that furious fight, the environs of the gate ran ankle-deep in blood: a gory legend worthy of any fort anywhere in the world.

From the town, with its small, tortuous, lanes and alleys, the fort walls look suitably forbidding and ominous. Once there were four gates in these protective walls but, with the passage of time and the absence of menacing armies, they serve only a decorative purpose today and one no longer exists: shops and houses occupy the space where it once stood. Nevertheless, history still asserts its presence in the midst of all the bustle of the bazaar. Hiding itself, almost as if it was averse to attention is the interesting Jama Masjid.

JAMA OR JUMA MASJID

This 15th century mosque is accessed through an impressive door opening to a short flight of steps and a large central court. There is a tree growing in the centre of this open court, presumably to offer shade to the Faithful. Islam is a congregational religion like the other two Semitic faiths of Christianity and Judaism, and such spaces are an essential feature of their places of worship. Surrounding this cour are interesting arches and domes. This mosque is, apparently, used only for Friday prayers and funerals.

Fairly close to the mosque is the mysterious Badal mahal.

BADAL MAHAL

This is a tall, slim, rather elaborate arch that leads nowhere. There is the building either in front of it or behing it. There is also no local legend that might explain its purpose. But, since it is not called a 'cloud gate' but a 'cloud mansion', a likely explanation is that it was meant to serve as the entrance to a summer resort cooled by flowing water simulating monsoon showers This, however is just informed specu- lation based on 'Badal Mahals' in other parts of India.

Not quite as mysterious but still open to interpretation are the Nizamuddin Tombs.

NIZAMUDDIN TOMBS

In a walled compound, there are a number of graves, most of them set in pavilions with beautifully carved stone lattices. Some local people believe that these are the tombs of the family of the noted 14th century Sufi saint, Hazrat Nizamuddin Ayulia. Others contend that they belong to the descendants of the 16h century Nizam-ud-Din Ahmad Bakshi. He wrote one of the best histories of India, the Tarikh-i-Nizami, and was made the Commander-in-Chief of the Mughal army in Gujarat. The second view is underscored by the fact that there is a Nizamuddin Gate in the city, an honour that could have been accorded to a C-in-C.

Also in the city is a Jain Temple.

JAIN TEMPLE

The Jaina faith is an austere and strictly non-violent one centred around their 24 spiritual guides, or Tirthankars. There are statues of all the Tirthankars in the second courtyard after the entrance. A great number of the followers of this religion are from the prosperous trading community and they often express their devotion by decorating their temples with expensive marble, glass and gold.

On the outskirts of the city, amid fields and orchards, is the Raja Shisupal's Tank.

RAJA SHISUPAL'S TANK ALSO KNOWN AS PARMESHWAR TANK

On one side of it is the white Lakshman Temple and on the other is the ochre-coloured sandstone tower of the Durjan Singh Chhatri. Neither of them are of any significant historical, architectural or mythological interest. The tank, however, is the source of an interesting legend.

Raja Shishupal's Tank

A ruler named Raja Shisupal, when out hunting, got lost. He was also very thirsty. Spotting a beautiful woman out in the wilderness he begged her to tell him where he could find water to quench his thirst. In his anxiety, he also reached out and touched her. She stepped back and said that she was a goddess and that he should not touch her. She did, however, create a pool of water in which he not only quenched his thirst, but also found himself cured of a chronic skin disease.

The pool became the Shisupal Tank. In gratitude he asked her to tell him what he could do to repay her for the great favour she had done for him.

The story goes on, but as it leads to another location, it will be completed at that spot.

Another interesting legend is con- nected with a building at the end of a causeway leading away from one side of the tank. This elevated road arrows between low-lying fields and leads to a monument. It rises out of its own high plinth that was, once, a small is- land thrusting out of marshy wetlands. The monument is called the Shahzadi Ka Rouza.

SHAHZADI KA ROUZA

According to the legend, Mehrunisa was the beautiful daughter of the ruler, Sultan Hakim Khan. She fell in love with one of the sultan's army officers. The sultan felt that the man was not high-born enough to marry his daughter and so he ordered four of his trusted men to kill the upstart officer. The condemned man tried to gallop away on his horse but the poor animal was killed under him. He leapt off and tried to run for his life but was killed. When the princess heard what had happened she was distraught. She fled from her father's palace, fell on the body of her lover, and killed herself.

Because she was a princess she was entitled to a mausoleum. But the sultan wanted to ensure that the memory of his daughter, who had brought disgrace on his family, would not be revered. This is why he had the rouza built on an outcrop of rock in a pond, so no one could get to it.

The rouza is an intriguing, but not very attractive, block-like building with snaking brackets supporting a corbel table or flat shelf between the lower floor and the upper one. It has the forbidding squatness of a tomb rather than the gran- deur of a mausoleum, clearly designed to deter visitors rather than attract them.

Far more light-filled and appealing is the Koshak Mahal.

Shahzadi ka Rouza

KOSHAK MAHAL.

It is a tall building of arches and courts and a plaque says:
Recorded in Tawarikh Ferishta that Mahmood II Khilji, Sultan of Malwar, passed through this place in A.H. 848 (A.C. 1445) and ordered that a seven storey palace should be built here. This is in the style of Mandu.

Legend is divided on the reason why only two storeys of the original stand today. One contends that the Khilji sultan lost interest before the upper five floors were completed. The other tale says that the sultan's local representatives either ran short of funds after the first two floors were built, or they embezzled the money, and so the other floors were of such shoddy construction that they collapsed before the sultan could return to Chanderi. The two floors that stand, however, have both a lightness and a permanence that seems to make the building soar.

The most impressive structures in Chanderi, however, have been cut into a golden cliff overlooking the valley. They are the caves of Khandagiri.

Koshak Mahal built in Mandu's Afghan style

KHANDAGIRI

These Jain temples were carved out of the rock about seven hundred years ago. At the start of the flight of steps, leading up, is a colossal statue of the Tirthankar, the spiritual guide, Mahavira. Shoes have to be removed at the bottom of the flight of stone stairs. More standing and seated images of the Tirthankars have been carved into the cliff and are protected by pillared and arched porticoes.

The best time to visit these cliff temples is close to sunset when the rocks seem to glow with a light of their own.

While you are on the west-facing side of the valley, you should see the unusual Kati Gate.

A colosal statue of the Jain Tirthankar Mahavir

The Kati Gate, cut into solid rock links Bundelkhand to Malwa.

KATI GATE

This man-made ravine cut into solid rock links Chanderis Bundelkhand region with that of Malwa, and beyond. According to an inscription on this dramatic gorge, the gateway was cut out on the orders of Jiman Khan in 1430 during the reign of Ghias Shah, Sultan of Malwa

The passage that leads to the gate is worth examining in some detail. The rock has been cut and smoothed t ensure that no hand-holds were left Attacking armies could not scramble up the sides, they had to face the onslaught of the defenders manning the narrow entrance. A wall was built between the smooth sides of the gorge. In it was set the arched gate with two medallions engraved above the arch. It is also very likely that there was a defensive post to let in above the gate. It has been bricked in now, but its outlines are clearly visible. Finally, to the right and left of this post are two canon ports, much like the ones they had on men-o-war and privateers' sloops. As a 15th century defensive structure, it's fascinating.

And now to complete the story about the magical origins of Raja Shishupal's Tank.

When the raja asked the beautiful woman what he could do to repay her great, thirst-quenching miracle, she asked him to build a temple with a curtained sanctum. And he should not remove the curtain for nine days. He promised to do as she asked but, being a king with many things on his mind, he kept forgetting and she kept appearing in his dreams. Eventually he did build the temple, and did install a curtain in front of the sanctum. But then he grew impatient and, after two days, drew the curtain aside. To his dismay he found that a head had formed in the sanctum, but it had not grown a body.
You can see this curious idol in the Jageshwari Temple.

JAGESHWARI TEMPLE

This is really a temple complex and, like the Jain one in Khandagiri, is built against the rock-face of a hill. Ninety steps lead to the top and after every few steps there are platforms for the weary. The steps lead past a small shrine and a large stepped tank of green water with trees around. Further on, shoes have to be removed at the gate of the group of temples built against the hill. In front of these rock-imbedded shrines, are protective porticoes. The prevailing grey of the rocks is relieved by red and yellow flags fluttering in the cool breeze of the wooded hill.

The first temple is that of Jageshwari, guarded by the statues of two lions The idol has a white face with large eyes and seems to have been mounted on a tall pedestal. It is heavily draped in red robes so no visitor can know what lies beneath those draperies. The other, lesser, shrines are also interesting, even if you are not a devotee. After visiting in this complex, your last port of call should be the Singpur Mahal

SINGPUR MAHAL

This is now the well-kept Museum of the Archaeological Survey of India. Do pause at the sculpture of Varaha, the boar incarnation of Vishnu, kept in the garden; and at a gracefully executed Ganesh. The galleries inside have slide exhibits of the Stone Age rock paintings in Madhya Pradesh, This is followed by sketches of various architectural styles, galleries devoted to Hindu sculptures from Old Chanderi and then one displaying Buddhist and Jaina sculptures. The last gallery downstairs has blown-up pictures of Mughal Miniatures including one of Babur fighting Ibrahim Lodi in Panipat in 1526; and a particularly relevant one of Babur taking Chanderi Fort in 1528.

The gallery on the first floor contains weapons, a loom, kitchen utensils and musical instruments. An information board outside the museum says, among other things:

The Bundelas were the local rulers of the Chanderi region under the Mughals. Chanderi originally belonged to Orchha. The fiefdom of Orchha was to go to the eldest son, Ram Shah, of Madhukar Shah. However (Mughal Emperor) Jehangir awarded Orchha to Bir Singh, youngest son, for fa- vours received, and gave Chanderi to Ram Shah.

Devi Singh Bundela (1645-63) grandson of Ram Shah and son of Bharat Shah, developed Chanderi. He was as well versed in Ayurveda, was a war- rior, an able administrator and a reputed courtier of (Mughal Emperor) Shah Jehan.

Much of Chanderi's prosperity had grown out of the fact that it lay on a trade route between the north and the trading port of Surat on the Arabian Sea. But when the British laid their rail lines they bypassed Chanderi, possibly because its gradients were too steep for their chugging steam locomotives. Chanderi declined. One industry, however, held its own because the value-addition it provided could not be replicated.

Even to this day, the handlooms of Chanderi create woven magic. (See Box : Chanderi Fabrics)

Varaha in the Singpur Mahal Gardens

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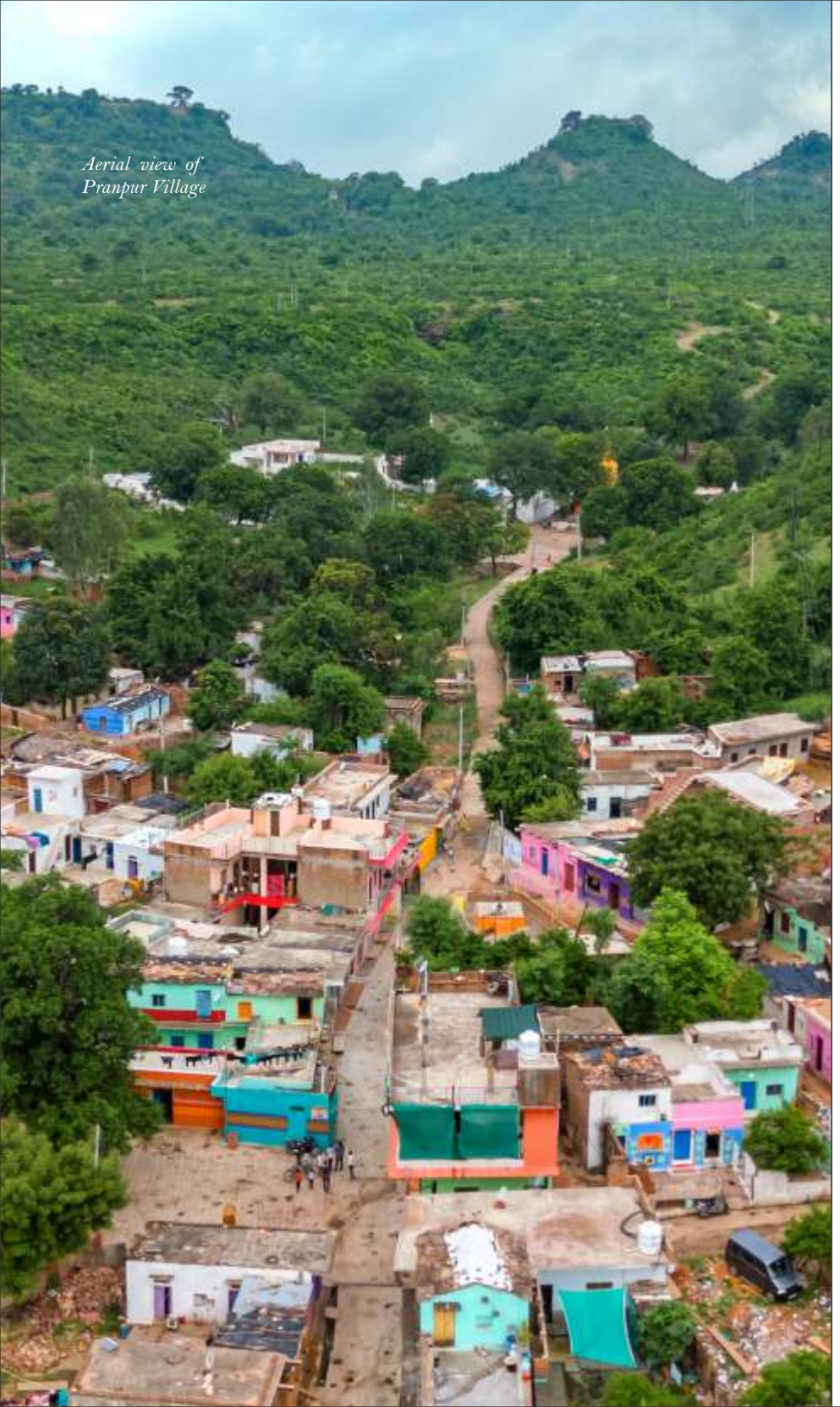
CHANDERI SAREE IN ICONIC SAREE WEAVING CLUSTERS OF INDIA
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

The Radiant Fabrics of Chanderi

The weavers mohalla, or precinct, is a place of long, narrow lanes, walled and gated houses built around courtyards visible through doors opening into the lanes, and the sound of clack-clack-clacking! looms punctuating loud filmy music from CD players. Many of the long lanes are used to stretch the silk warp that takes the cotton weft. Men cycle past carrying hanks of silk thread from Varanasi, cotton from Coim- batore and the valuable gold, and silver metal-thread from Surat.

Traditionally, the weavers used to make fine turbans and handkerchiefs for the elegant, and slightly dandified, nobil- ity. Bejewelled and perfumed men carried handkerchiefs as a style statement, often threading the end through their rings. Gradually, however, as the effete courts and their posturing courtiers passed into his tory, the weavers quickly responded to the demands of the growing ranks of fashion- conscious women who like to drape them selves in the figure-flattering saris woven on Chanderi looms.

Today there has been a further evolu- tion. Visitors can now take home curtains and table cloths created by the traditional weavers of Chanderi.



Aerial view of Pranpur Village

PRANPUR VILLAGE

Pranpur village near historic Chanderi, is a picturesque destination celebrated for its craft and handloom traditions. Home to families of weavers and artisans for generations, it offers visitors a unique glimpse into local craftsmanship. Known for handloom weaving and crafts like bamboo, wood, and stone work, Pranpur is ideal for experiencing and purchasing authentic products. The Craft Handloom Tourism Village enhances visitor experiences with amenities and showcases the area's rich cultural heritage.

Accommodation in Chanderi

MPT Kila Kothi

7004885979

kilakothi@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant

MPT Kila Kothi is meant for them who are seeking a regal hospitality in the historic city of Chanderi. This is a royal residence of the erstwhile Scindia state which has now been converted into a hotel by MPT Hotels & Resorts. The sprawling garden and restaurant and 6 AC rooms host you with full regality and class. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Chanderi

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chanderi@mpstdc.com

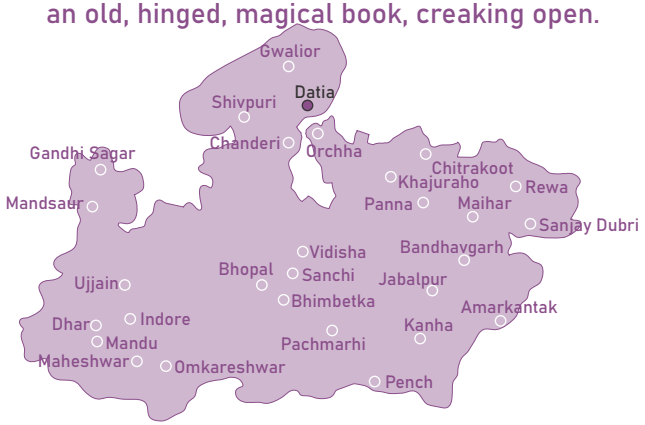
Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant

MPT Hotels & Resorts' MPT Tana Bana hosts you in the heritage city of Chanderi. Located in almost ravine like surroundings, you can behold the grand hill which houses the Chanderi Fort right from the hotel. The Chanderi Weaver's village, the Heritage sites and the bus stand - all are located within the periphery of almost 2 km, making the hotel most convenient. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

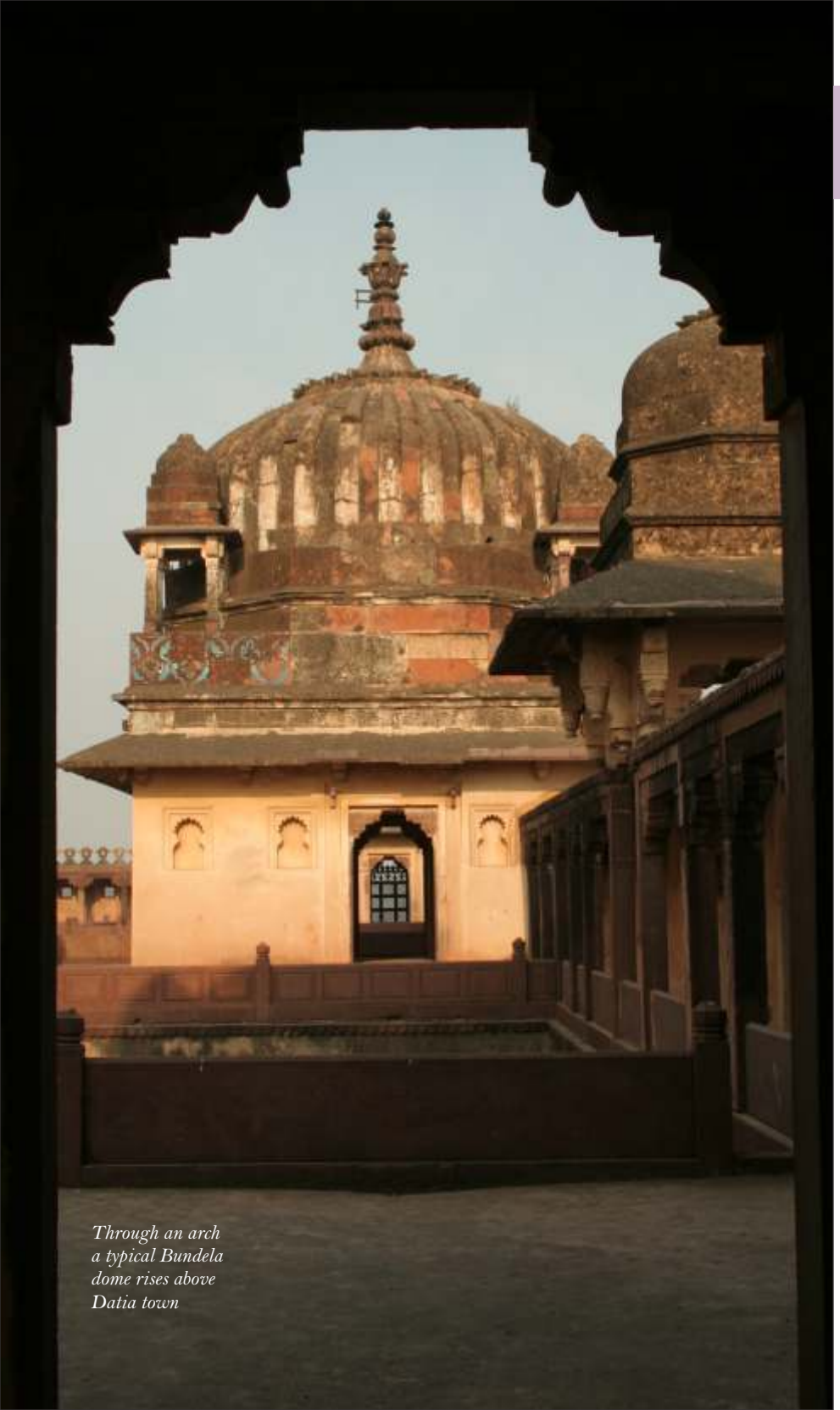
Datia

For many generations Datia allowed its gothic past to sleep, undisturbed. Now, slowly, it's stirring awake again like a spell from an old, hinged, magical book, creaking open.



Even its name is drawn from a legend of dark violence. "Datia" is the diminutive of Danta Vakra, the demon monarch who was slain by Lord Krishna. In more historic times, the old palace glowering down from a hill in Datia, was reputedly built by Bir Singh Deo, controversial king of the Bundelas. He is credited with assassinating Abul Fazl, adviser to the Mughal Emperor, and having his gory, severed head delivered to his patron, Prince Salim. There is also the blood-thirsty tale of his condemning his own son to be torn apart by savage dogs for having killed a seer in the same pitiless manner. Clearly, those were days, much

Vir Mahal crowing a scrub covered hill



Through an arch a typical Bundela dome rises above Datia town

The imposing and menacing facade of Bir Singh's Palace

like our own, perhaps when heinous crimes were condoned by beleaguered society. But for all his ruthlessness, Bir Singh was a multi-talented man and there is a belief that he had a major influence in creating the very assertive Bundela style of architecture. He was also very astute. To prevent dissensions amongst his sons, he divided his kingdom among them and gave Datia, and the Palace, to Bhagwant Rao. Datia became an independent state in 1626 and the palace, built in the 17th century and hunching over the old town like a somnolent ogre, is still known as Vir Mahal.

VIR MAHAL OR BIR SINGH'S PALACE

It is an impressive structure crowning a scrub-covered hill. When seen from below, its reflection in an ancient reservoir at its feet makes it seem as if

Decorated wall of Bir Singh's Palace

wavering illusion is emerging into reality. Massive encircling walls, heavy terraces rising to pavilions and squat cupolas, and the upward thrusting central floor growing like the bud of an ominous mushroom, give the impression of implacable and menacing authority. On a closer approach, through winding streets and to the terrace in front of the palace, the impression is gentled, but only slightly as if a glimpse of humanity is emerging from a grim face.

The main gateway rises through arches and galleries which have a certain unexpected delicacy. It is al most as if one noticed finely shaped eyebrows on the visage of a fearsome judge. Bundela architecture is full of such seemingly inconsistent touches niches with exquisite little sculptures, friezes like gem-encrusted embroidery, arches scalloped like almond icing, ceil- ings folded with all the intricacy of origami. Here, however, above the main arch there are most unusual motifs. Sinuous horned dragons pursue terrified deer who look over their shoulders in fright even as they speed away. Much of this work resembles Damascene hinting at the light touch of Persian art. Bir Singh's overlords, the Mughals, had a strong Persian orientation in their culture and mores. In fact many of the ceilings inside the palace have borders and medallions which seem to have been drawn from the rare carpets of Persia.

Do look out from the terrace in front of the palace. The old city spreads in cubistic patterns with a predominance of blue (See Box - Blue Homes) Out of them thrusts a brown Bundela palace or two, and one dominates a distant peak. Most of them, however, are still in deep hibernation awaiting the touch of sensitive restorers to bring them into our world again.

After the gothic ambience of the palace, visitors are drawn to the Chhatris.

THE CHHATRIS

All princely families, with claims to a martial blood-line, had to have cenotaphs, or chhatris, to commemorate their dead. These monuments do not, necessarily, hold the ashes of their ancestors, though many did. The princes did, however, try to decorate these elaborate memorials with incidents from the great ocean of tales, myths and legends from the scriptures. Often, too, there are illustrations of the great deeds attributed to the lives of those remembered in the cenotaphs.

A board installed just outside the perimeter wall of the chhatris says-

Cenotaphs of the Kings and Queens of Datia

Murals composed of narrative scenes for Ramayana and Mahabharat, Puranic events, scenes of royal palaces, army processions, fairs and festivals, flora and fauna... Designs are drawn over live plaster...floral motifs and small bastions built of thin mud bricks (LAKHORI) and sandstone...

... They are built in the shikara style, of North Indian temples and on the banks of a pond called KARNASAGAR

These cenotaphs were built in the 18th and 19th centuries.

This is a huge complex of chhatris, of various shapes and sizes, and enclosed by a high wall. Twenty three of these cenotaphs are in good condition and most of them have varied and decorative architectural features stone grilles, arches, niches, cupolas, medallions, pillars and even circular ceilings. Some of them are bright with murals in radiant colours and they are well worth lingering over. The murals in the chhatri of Parichhat Raja are particularly attractive.

The chhatris of Datia do much to lift the slightly ominous mood conjured by the palace on the hill.

Aerial view of
Bir Singh Palace

PEETAMBHARA PEETH

Datia is noted for its many beautiful temples, and thus referred to as Laghu Vrindaban or 'small Vrindavan'. The most popular temple in Datia town is Peetambhara Peeth. A shaktipeeth, it enshrines two of the ten Mahavidyas, Dhumavati and Baglamukhi, and is much revered by the local population. It is thronged by devotees from far and wide, especially on Saturdays. Apart from the main shrine, the complex has several smaller shrines dedicated to other deities, including Parshuram, Hanuman and Kal Bhairav. Vankhandeshwar Temple, to Lord Shiva, is believed to date back to the time of the Mahabharata.

Some of the other temples in Datia are Avadh Bihari Temple, Shivgir Temple, Vijay-Raghav Temple, and Bihariji Temple.

Peetambhara Peeth Temple and (inset) trinkets being sold outside

Another significant structure in Datia is Rajgarh Palace on top of a hill near Peetambhara Peeth. Bharatgarh Fort and Karna Sagar Tank with its ghats, ruined temples, and surrounding chhatris, are the other attractions of the town. Bharatgarh Fort, Karna sagar tank, Rajgarh palace are the other attractions of Datia. Bharat Garh was built by Maharaja Dalpat Rao (1682-1707 AD). A Ram Janki temple exists inside the imposing structure.

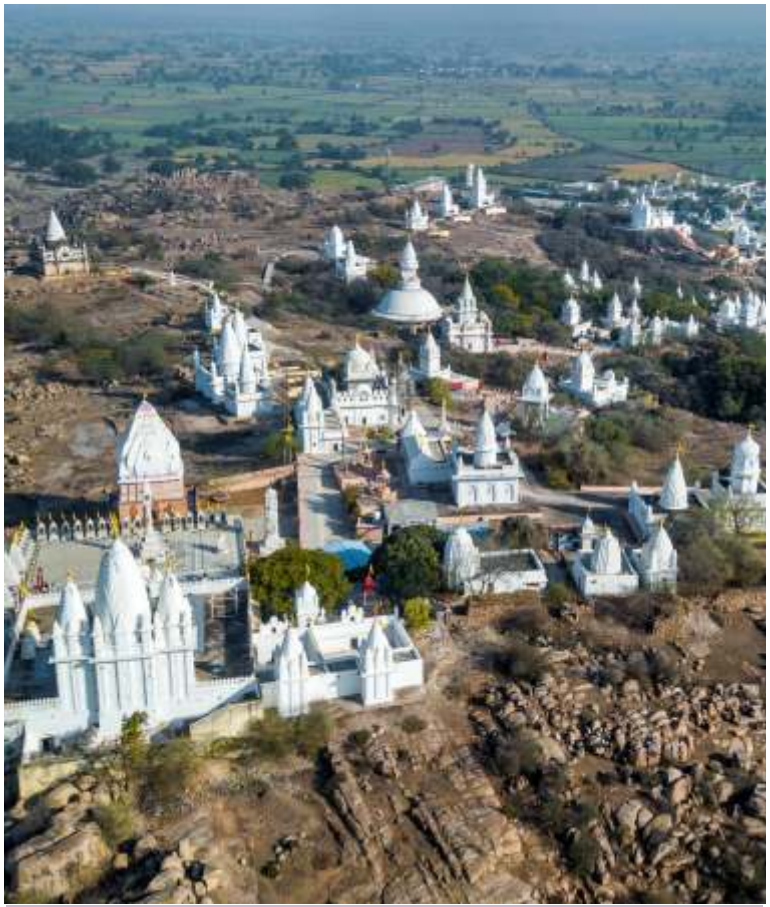
Rajgarh Palace

SONAGIRI

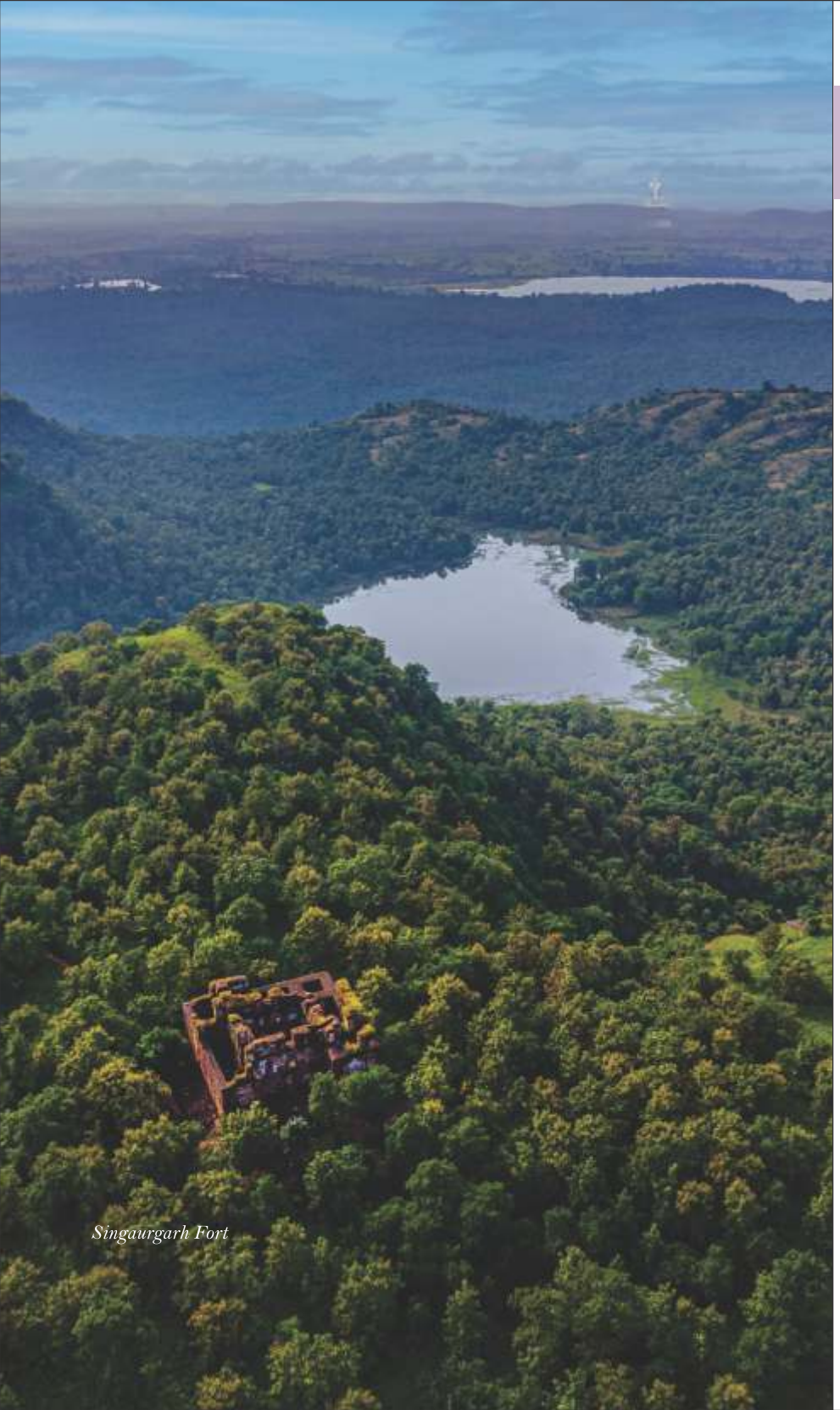
Located 15 kms from Datia, one comes across with rows of sparkling white marble-clad temples on the slopes. This is the famous Jain pilgrimage of Sonagiri (literally the 'golden mountain'). Known as Swarnagiri or Shravangiri in ancient times, it is revered by the Digambara sect of Jains.

Sonagiri has 77 temples on the hill and 26 in the village below, many of them built recently, and all of them brilliantly white. The most beautiful among these is possibly the temple dedicated to Chandranatha, the eighth of the 24 tirthankaras.

Sonagiri is also known for a large annual fair held here in the month of Chaitra (March-April), when 'thousands of pilgrims gather at this religious site set in a landscape of tranquil beauty'.



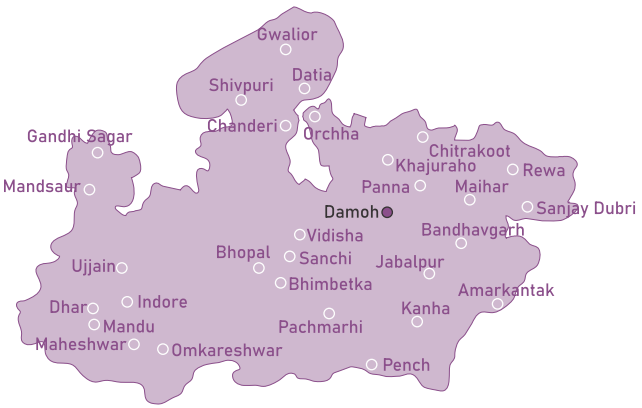
Clusters of white marble temples at Sonagiri present a stunning view



Singaurgarh Fort

Damoh

A Confluence of History, Nature and Spirituality



Located in the heart of India, Madhya Pradesh, Damoh is renowned for its ancient history, rich culture, and natural beauty. Evidence of its existence dates back to the Stone Age, as seen from the stone tools found in Singrampur. This district witnessed the emergence of human civilization millions of years ago. In the 5th century, it was part of the Gupta Empire, and the 10th-century Nohleshwar Temple, built by the Kalchuri rulers, stands as a remarkable example of architectural excellence. Damoh holds historical significance through the eras of the Mughals, Bundelas, Marathas, and the British. The bravery of Rani Durgavati and the district's contribution to India's freedom struggle have earned it a distinct place in history.

Ghanta Ghar of Damoh

Entrance of Singorgarh Fort

SINGAORGARH FORT

The Singorgarh Fort, located in the Bundelkhand region of Damoh district in Madhya Pradesh, holds immense historical and archaeological significance. Situated in Jabera Tehsil, it lies 16 kilometers from the tehsil headquarters and 42 kilometers from the district headquarters. Archaeological evidence suggests that this fort was constructed during the reign of the Kalachuri kings due to its strategic and military importance. Over time, it came under the rule of various dynasties, including the Chandels, Pratiharas/Parihars, and the Gonds. The Gond period is considered the golden era of this fort.

An inscription from 1307 CE, with eight lines, refers to this fort as "Gaj-Singh Durga," implying it was the fort of King Gaj Singh, a ruler of the Pratihara dynasty who governed the Damoh region around the 14th century. Over time, the name evolved to Singh Durga, Singhourgarh, and finally Singorgarh. The inscription mentions that a victory pillar was erected during Vijayadashami, and a nearby lake was named Vijay Sagar. Another inscription references Maharaja Putra Shri Waghdev of the Parihar dynasty.

Pathway to the fort

Hathi Gate

The Fort's Architecture and Strategic Design

The Singorgarh Fort is considered one of the prominent hill forts of Madhya Pradesh. It held significant strategic and military value during the reign of Gond Queen Rani Durgavati. From a geographical perspective, the fort was highly secure. It was protected by two massive ramparts, one of which encircles the peaks of the hill, covering an area of approximately 5 kilometers, acting as a defense against external invasions. Inside this outer fortification lies another rampart, adding an additional layer of security. To reinforce these ramparts, large bastions and wide platforms were constructed, remnants of which can still be seen today. The walls feature continuous crenellations, although many of these have been damaged over time.

The fort is constructed using unhewn stones, with mortar made of lime and brick powder. This masonry technique was implemented during the Gond period. The upper parts of the fort contain various architectural structures built during the reigns of different dynasties, many of which remain as evidence of its rich history.

Gond Dynasty and Military Planning

During the Gond period, the fort became a vital strategic stronghold. Its layout was meticulously planned to ensure it was impenetrable to attacks. The dual-layered massive ramparts testify to this meticulous military planning. The fort had three main gates for entry, of which two are still visible, while the third led to a narrow courtyard. This courtyard was strategically designed so that if enemy forces breached the main gate and entered the courtyard, they would be trapped and easily neutralized.

One of the gates is known as the "Hathi Darwaza" (Elephant Gate), believed to have been used for the movement of elephants. Steps leading up to this gate were also constructed. The inner rampart of the fort spans approximately 730 meters, while the outer rampart extends around 5 kilometers. The height from the main gate to the Queen's Palace (Rani Mahal) is 122 meters.

Rani Mahal

The Rani Mahal is the only significant structure within the fort that

Courtyard of Rani Mahal

remains relatively intact. It stands as a testament to the architectural excellence of the Gond period.

The Singorgarh Fort exemplifies the grandeur of medieval Indian architecture and strategic planning. Its dual-layered fortifications, vast ramparts, and historic structures reflect the military and cultural significance it held during the Gond dynasty. Today, it remains an invaluable monument for historians, archaeologists, and those interested in exploring India's rich heritage.

Jatashankar Temple

JATASHANKAR

Jatashankar Temple is a famous religious and scenic spot. Dedicated to Lord Shiva, it attracts visitors not only for its spiritual significance but also for its natural beauty. Devotees come here to worship and seek blessings while enjoying the serene and peaceful environment.

NOHLESHWAR TEMPLE

Known locally as Mahadev or Nohleshwar, this temple was constructed around 950-1000 CE. According to local beliefs, Queen Avni Varma of the Kalchuri dynasty commissioned its construction. The temple is an outstanding example of the 10th-century Kalchuri architecture.

Carving of Nohleshwar Temple

The Nohleshwar Temple

NAZARA VIEWPOINT

Nazara Viewpoint, built on a high hill, offers a mesmerizing view of the Rani Durgavati Wildlife Sanctuary. From here, one can enjoy the beauty of dense forests and spot the caves of wild animals, making it a must-visit location for nature lovers.

GIRIDARSHAN

Giridarshan is a picturesque spot filled with greenery and stunning landscapes, located on the Damoh-Jabalpur National Highway. This two-story rest house with a watchtower was built by the Forest Department. Visitors can reserve accommodation through the DFO office in Damoh. The sunrise and sunset views from here are a major attraction.

The Nazara View Point

The Nidan Kund

NIDAN KUND

Near Bhesa village, Nidan Kund features a waterfall that cascades from a height of 100 feet. The best time to witness its beauty is from July to August. During low water levels, it transforms into a popular picnic spot. The waterfall's step-like flow over the rocks creates a visually stunning sight.

VEERANGANA DURGAVATI TIGER RESERVE

Named after the brave queen Rani Durgavati, this sanctuary was established in 1997 and spans around 550 square kilometers. It is home to rich biodiversity, including Bengal tigers, Indian leopards, and various species of deer, as well as an array of flora and fauna. The reserve offers wildlife enthusiasts and nature lovers an opportunity to explore the beauty of the natural world.

SADBHAVANA SHIKHAR

The highest peak of the Vindhyan mountain range, Sadbhavana Shikhar stands at an altitude of 2,467 feet above sea level. The city lights at night create a spectacular view from this peak.

KATAAV DHAM

Situated 60 kilometers from Damoh, Kataav Dham is named after the unique rock formations carved by a river. The main attraction here is the Mriganath Temple, located atop a hill in Kataav Dham, offering stunning panoramic views of the surroundings.

KUNDALPUR

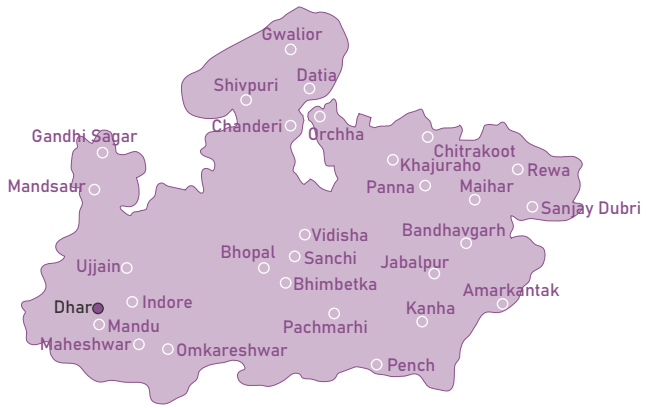
Kundalpur is a historic pilgrimage site for Jainism, located 35 kilometers from Damoh in Kundalgiri. It houses a 15-foot-tall, 1,500-year-old idol of Lord Adinath, the first Tirthankara, in a lotus position. This sacred site holds immense religious and historical significance.

Kundalpur Jain Temple

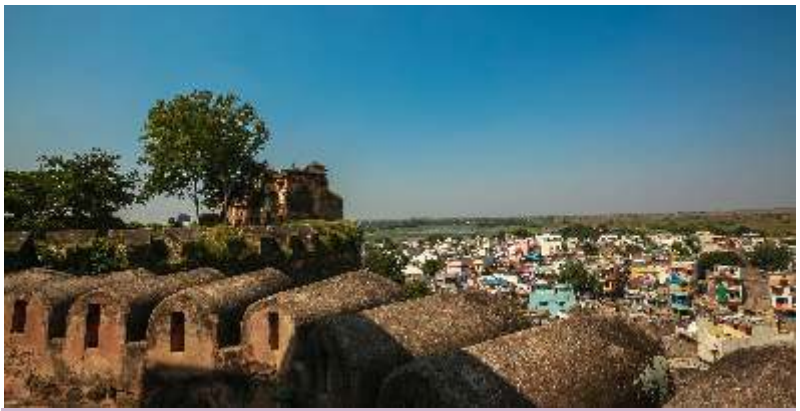
Kharbuja Mahal

Dhar

In the quiet town of Dhar, the shards of history glint like bright chips of glass in an adobe wall.



For centuries, conquerors had marched down the old caravan route that stretches through Dhar, linking Delhi to the Deccan. Here, they had rested, built their monuments, and then moved on. The people of Dhar had welcomed them, accepted their presence and their presents, and continued unperturbed with their normal way of life when the kings and their armies had departed. History records that the first great ruler of Dhar was from the Parmar dynasty: a feudal family from the Deccan who became Rajas in the 10th century after asserting their independence. Vairasinha Parmar conquered Dhar in the 10th century AD and made it his capital. The greatest of the Parmar rulers of Dhar however, was the legendary Raja Bhoj warrior, statesman, visionary and scholar who ruled from 1010 to 1055.



From the battlements, the town spreads below

According to a persistent legend, this kings, Saraswati etsin Dhar what Acasidince, a temple to the goddess of learning, Saraswati. Its known as the Bhoj-Shala.

BHOJ-SHALA

This is an attractive, and rather eclectic, monument with a large cen tral court, a pillared gallery encit. cling it, and a mihrab or prayer-niche indicating the direction of the holy Islamic city of Mecca. When Muslims recite their obligatory prayers every day they are required to face Mecca where the Prophet Mohammed received his message from God through the Angel Gabriel. The mihrab and the open courtyard, typical of a congregational religion, give the impression that it was built as a mosque. But it is, of course possible, that the original structure was a temple, then a university and finally modified to serve as a mosque.

The mihrab, inside the arch, is respected by both Hindus and Muslims

Today, the slight edge of tension that might have existed because of the temple-mosque controversy has been effectively dulled by a functional compromise. Hindus worship here on Tuesdays, placing flowers on the mihrab because there are no idols in the Bhoj-shala. Muslims say their congregational prayers in it from 1 pm to 3 pm on Fridays facing the same mihrab on which Hindus had placed their offerings of flowers earlier in the week! The carvings on the pillars display typically Hindu designs which do not, necessarily, indicate that was once either a temple or a Sansk university. They could have been carved by Hindu artisans using the motifs they were most familiar with.

Outside the Bhoj-Shala, and at right angles to it, is a beautiful Muslim tomb known as that of Kamal Maula.

KAMAL MAULA

One of the keepers of this tomb claims that the Islamic saint interred here came from the city of Multan, now in Pakistan, in 1456. This is possible but then it would be in conflict with another legend. That belief contends that the tomb was erected by Mahmud Khalji after his proclaimed victory over the Raria of Mewar in 1440. There is an inscription above the entrance of the courtyard of the tomb that states that Mahmud Khalji prostrated himself before the tomb in 1457 There is also another inscription that says "In this world nothing remains of good men except their goodness".

In the environs of the tomb there is a Muslim cemetery and a ruined, domed, mausoleum over a grave said to be that of Kamal Maula's brother. The name "Kamal Maula' is apparently, a mispronunciation of 'Kamal Malwi: Kamal of Malwa which would place him as a native of this area and not of Multan. It could, also, have been derived from Kamal Maulvi or Kamal the Orthodox Scholar, and this seems to be the most likely explanation.

Muslims played a major role in Dhar. The Parmars were succeeded by the Afghan Ghoris who made their capital in Dhar. But they, too, moved on to another place: Mandu. Neither the Parmars nor the Ghoris, however, were responsible for building the structure that dominates Dhar, The Fort.

The Islamic Tomb of Kamal Maula

THE FORT

At the gate of this imposing fortress there is a descriptive board which says On a hill previously known as Dharagiri, a fort was built by Delhi Sultan Muhammed bin Tuglakh in 1344 while returning from the south. It has three gates. The outer wall is made of red sandstone. The third gate was built in the reign of Aurangzeb. Some construction was also done in the Fort in the 15th and 16th centuries in the Mughal and Maratha periods.

Entrance of the Fort

During the Mutiny, rebels occupied the fort but were forced to leave as the British Army fired at it continuously for six days.

Nowadays, the local Police are a major presence in the fort. That,

The fascinating wall of Fort

however, should not deter visitors from walking around the only group of buildings in the fort that is of significant interest.

At one end of the fort is the Shish Mahal.

SHISH MAHAL

Literally 'The Glass Palace', it has lost all the mirrors it might once have had. Its wall and arched facade are made of slim bricks, most of them un-plastered and exposed. An internal flight of steps leads up to the first floor. a pavilion with an ice-cream pink plaster. It looks onto an unkempt garden at the battlement level of the fort, with another building in Islamic architecture at the far end. This building is double storeyed and gives an eagle's eye-view of the town.

A board at the side of the pink building reads

Shish Mahal

Dhar, the ancient capital of Malwa.

The Shish Mahal stands at the north-west part of the Fort and was built in the 14th century during the stay of Muhamad bin Tuglakh who was on his way from Daulatabad (in Maharashtra) to Delhi. He repaired the gateways and fortifications of the Parmar period.

The Shish Mahal was used as a royal residence. It is construct- ed in Tuglakh architecture, which has heavy walls sloping down. It is rectangular in shape and has an apsidal roof with small cells which have arch type doors. There are steps to- wards the south which access the second storey. This was constructed at a later date.

The *haveli*-like building at the far end of the neglected garden is called the Kharbuja Mahal.

KHARBUJA MAHAL

A 'kharbuja' is a melon and the palace got its name from its domes which looked like large melons Apart from their aesthetic appeal and conforming to a typical Islamic architectural mode, they also kept their buildings cool, allowing hot air from the rooms to rise inside the dome and away from the living spaces. There it would be radiated away from the surface of the dome.

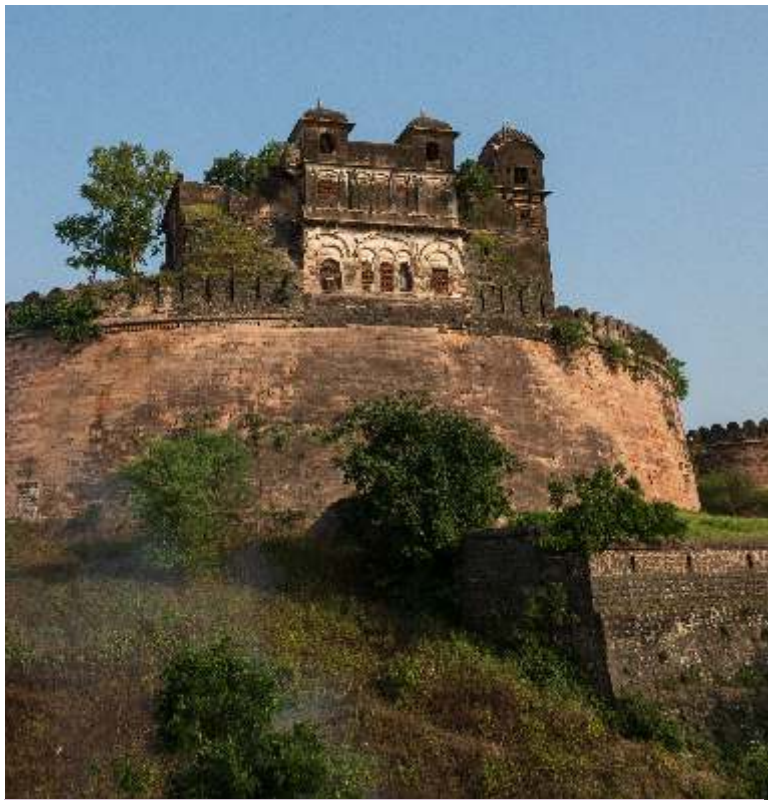
This is a double-storeyed building with seven rooms on the lower floor, presumably used for the more formal encounters, and four private rooms on the upper floor. Mughal royalty stayed here and it was probably built in the 16th century, the Mughal period.

On the Marathas succeeding the Mughals, this place was plastered and decorated with murals. When the Maratha general, Raghoba Dadon escaped from Pune, in 1778, he hid here. He was an uncle of the Peshwa ruler Mahadev Rao 1. His wife, Anandi Bai gave birth to a boy who, later on became Peshwa Baji Rao II. The Peshwas were hereditary prime min isters who assumed the powers of the Maratha Confederacy, territories tha have now been largely included in the state of Maharashtra

Though constructed in Mughal style, the Kharbuja Mahal contairs Rajput influences which are seen in the niches and windows.

From the battlements of the Fort there are superb views of the town spreading at the feet of its forbidding walls. One gets the distinct impression that the town clustered around the fort like chickens gathered around a mother hen!

And even when one is driving out of town, past the chhatri-mausoleums of its former ruling families, the for dominates the view. It is difficult to believe that this is just another way side monument built by a warrior his quest for other worlds to conquer.



An "Air-Condtioning" Melon Dome rises above the fort's walls

EXPLORER'S MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF DHAR

JHABUA

If you are not an excessively energetic type but still want to visit a place tha most other visitors have not been to, Jhabua would be a good choice. It is abou 90 kms from Dhar and its main attraction is that it is in the heart of the tribal lands of the Heart of India. It will give you an opportunity to see how the legally designated adivasis or aboriginals of India live. The majority of these people belong to the Bhil and Bhilala tribes and the most convenient way to see them is when they congregate in Jhabua for the weekly haat or fair on Sundays. It'sa teeming, colourful, event stocked with everything from chickens to terracotta pots, bead jewellery, spices, mountains of freshly cooked sweets and the dred flowers of the mahua tree used to brew their potent beer and gin-like drinks

At the weekly haat, a woman wears her Bead Jewellery

A special annual fair is also the setting for their 'official' elopements. It is known as the Bhagoriya Mela literally the Run-away Fair. There the young men, twirling their manly moustaches, and the not-so-o maidens generally in their favou rite red saris and decked out in bead jewellery, come full of enthusiasm to the fair. It's generally held in March, near the spring Holi festival and after the harvest has added to their disposable incomes. Very often the boys and girls have already chosen their partners and only wait for the Bhagoriya to get social sanction for the match

Formally, then, the young man walks up to the girl of his choice and smears gulal, red powder, on het face. If she then colours his face too. they both run off into the forest and consummate the partnership. They then return to their families and, amid much jubilation, they become man and wife.

The Bhils are a happy, pragmatic people and if, on rare occasions, 1 married woman decides to elope with another man, this too is settled amicably The deserted husband is entitled to Jhagda Torns, or Breaking the Dispute. compensation and everyone, hopefully, lives happily ever after. Or at least till the next Bhagoriya Mela.

Visitors can also, by previous arrangement, visit a Bhil village. They are generally, prosperous and very clean.

From Dhar you can also do an excursion to The Bagh Caves

THE BAGH CAVES

It is a distance of about 97 kms and its worth the drive if you are interested in seeing five famed Buddhist caves. The caves were probably natural cavities, in

a sandstone cliff, which were then enlarged and built upon by Buddhist monks in the 5th and 6th century.

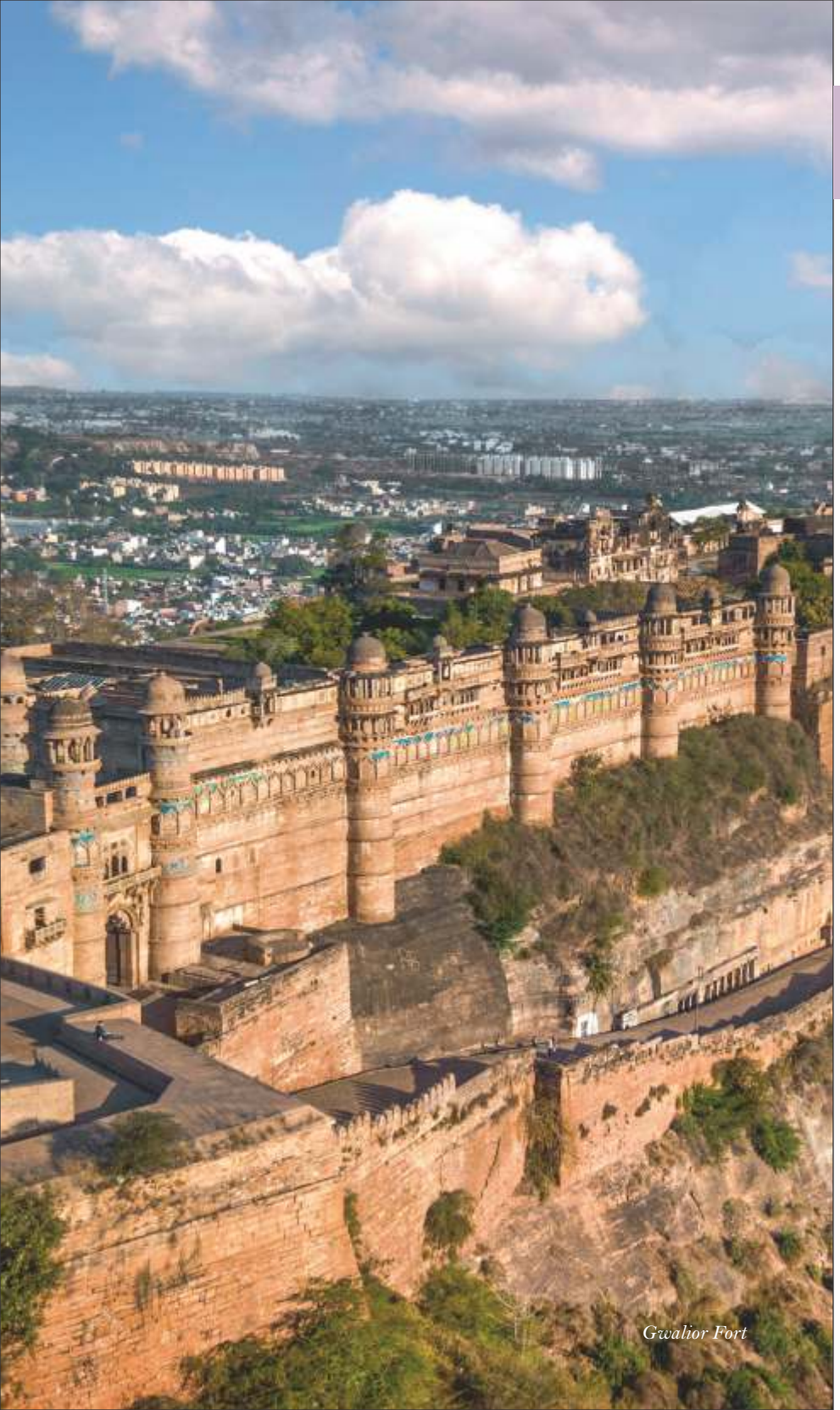
The tradition of living in caves goes back to pre-Buddhist days. Indian ascetics, like the mendicant friars of medieval Europe, served as wandering spiritual guides. They begged for their food and were, therefore not expected to stay long in any one place and become a burden to the host community. Consequently, they did not have permanent dwellings. In the rainy season, however, when the roads became impassable in India, they assembled together in monasteries. This is how the practice of living in caves came about. Caves could be abandoned during the fair-weather months and then re-occupied in the drenching monsoons. But not all caves were of a suitable size. And so they had to be enlarged, with hammer and chisel, cells and beds carved into them for the use of the monks, and central prayer halls created for their congregational activities. The caves, or sections of caves, used for living were called viharas or monasteries. The assembly halls for discussions and congregational worship became their chaityas. Naturally, in the process of excavating these caves, they were also beautified with sculpted figures and carved pillars supporting rock overhangs. And to while away the long, wet season, the talented artists amongst them even painted the walls of their caves with murals depicting the legends of their faith on the background of contemporary life.

Curiously, the Bagh caves were not cut during the reign of the Buddhist Mauryas, starting with Ashoka the Great. They were excavated during the Gupta period. The Hindu Guptas were a very tolerant dynasty and, according to the Government of India's scholarly book, 2,500 Years of Buddhism, Buddhist painting seems to have attained its maturity during this period with some of the finest specimens in the caves at Bagh. In these caves, too, the Buddhist artisan-monks had made ingenuous channels, ducts and small reservoirs to lead off rainwater and natural seepage into storage tanks for their use, and to prevent their caves from becoming damp and being damaged.

Sadly, when these monastic caves and assembly halls were abandoned with the decline of Buddhism, the dripping water found new outlets and slow erosion began. Pillars collapsed, paintings were eaten away by mildew and mould. By the time the ASI assumed charge of them it was too late to do any effective conservation. The reproductions of the paintings have, how- ever, been preserved in the Bhopal Museum and, to a lesser extent, in the Indore Museum. Having said that, if Buddhist cave architecture interests you, then there is still much in the Bagh caves to hold your attention.

A bridge across the Bagri River takes visitors to the base of the sandstone cliff in which the caves have been carved. Steps and a ramp lead one to the cave level. On this level, Cave No. 2 has worn carvings of Disciples and of the Buddha and a stupa. Between this cave and Cave No 3 there is a small alcove with a figure of Ganesh. Cave 3 was, probably, a chaitya with pillars supporting the roof. A short distance away is Cave No. 4 with the best vestiges of paintings of people, flowers and geometric designs.

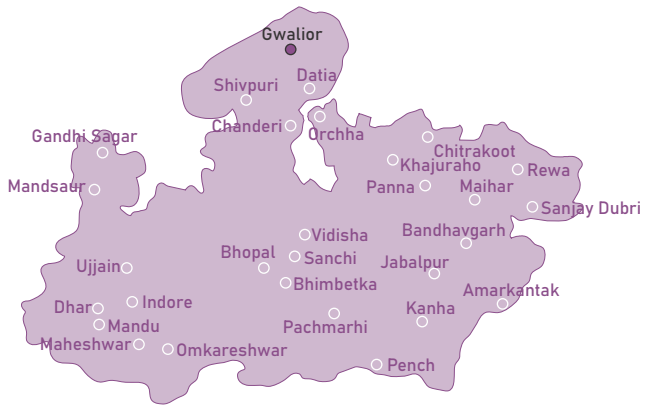
Back across the bridge is the Site Museum with reproductions of the art once held by the Bagh Caves including impressive, larger-than-life, fibre-glass figures.



Gwalior Fort

Gwalior

Gwalior began with a king, a sage, and a miracle.



Once upon a time, a king named Suraj Sen went out hunting. Outpacing his retinue, he rode through the forests of a gorge and up into the sun-hammered top of an enormous rock thrusting about 100 metres above the plain.

His hard ride had made him thirsty and so, when he spotted a hermit sit- ting on a rock, he asked him for some water. The recluse struck a rock and a cool, clear, spring gushed out. Thankfully, Suraj Sen quenched his thirst and then he bathed in the small pool that had collected below the miraculous foun- tain. To his great joy he emerged cured of a long-standing skin disease. In gratitude, the king asked the sage how he could repay him. He was told to enlarge the spring, build a tank to impound the curative waters, and make this place his capital This is exactly what he did and he named his capital Gwaliawar. a gift given by the sage Gwalipa.

The oldest monument in the fort The Teli-Ka-Mandir

Myth and history come together in an ancient inscription which proves the the hill was occupied in 525 AD. Since then it has housed successive lines of the hit that have appeared like comets, blazing briefly, ac Maghrtantlet shoes of rulets that hune Prathihars, Kacchwahs, Choris, Tomars, Mughals, the East Indu curlady and eventually the Scindias (See Box - The Scindias) before it was absorbed into the Republic of India.

You could, therefore, start your visit to Gwalior by driving up to the fort atop the rock, and walking through the high-points of its history. Or, better still, get there on a starlit night and let an excellent son-et-lumiere bring its

THE SCINDIAS

The Scindia dynasty was founded by Ranaji Scindia. His martial qualities had cought the eye of Peshwa Balan Baji Rao who authorised him to collect taxes, retain ing a percentage of it for himself. Ranoji established his headquarters in Ujjain in 1735, and it remained the capital of the Scindia's territories till Daulat Rao Scindia founded his new capital in present-day Gwalior-Lashkar in 1810.

Ranoji's third successor, Mahadji Scindia, seemed to have been destined for greatness. As a child he was found sleeping in the sun, shaded by the expanded hood of a cobra, The cobra is part of the crest of the Scindias as is the sun, an assertion of the fact that they belong to the Sun clan. Ably assisted by the greatest of the foreign military adventurers in India, general Benoit de Boigne, he had extended his territories from beyond Delhi in the north to south of the Narbada river by the end of his reign.

Mahadji's successor by adoption, in 1794, was Daulat Rao. He too had a foreign general, Jean Baptiste Filose. But though Mahadji was able to acquire some territories from his weaker Rajput neigh- bours, he also lost territories around Agra, Delhi and Aligarh because of his wars with the British. This, apparentlyly, made him see the advantage of coming to terms with the growing might of the British East India Company

The Scindia's early acceptance of realpolitik paid off. They had no hesitation in using the services of foreigners if they had the best available talents Michael Filose, the grandson of Jean Baptise Filose, was one of them. He was an architect, engineer and sound civil administrator. He accompanied Jayaji Rao Scindia to

Agra when the ruler had to flee because h army had joined the revolt against the Fay India Company.

Filose also helped to persuade the British commander of Agra, Sir Hugh Rose, to rout the revolutionaries and restore Lashkar to the Scindias.

The Scindias and the British Royal family clearly had an abiding respect for cach other. In 1906, when the Prince of Wales had to abandon a shooting trip Nepal, he chose to accept the invitation of the Scindias and spent two weeks in Shivpuri. And in 1914 and 1916 when daughter and son were born to Madhar Rao Scindia I, they were named Mary and George after the British king and queen Maharaja Sir George Jiwaji Rao Scindia Alijah Bahadur, who ascended the throne of Gwalior in 1925, was the last Scindia ruler of the state. In 1948 the forma princely states were integrated into the Republic of India and all princely titles were officially abolished.

In spite of surrendering their princeh powers, six of the Scindia family have been elected to positions of political authority by the voters in the world's largest democracy In this achievement they are unique among the former ruling families of India.

The Jai Villas Palace, designed by Sir Micheal Filose

chequered past to life (Sce Box: Son et Lumiere); and then return the next morning to stroll through one of the most legendary forts in India, at your own pace.

GWALIOR'S SON-ET-LUMIERE

This is an impressive Sound and Light Show, staged in Gwalior Fort: the first show in Hindi, the second in English. Spectators sit on stone bleachers extending from the battle- ments. The history of the Fort is dramatised with music, commentary, sound-effects and effective and shifting, coloured floodlighting of the fort and its environs. It is, in every way, a good introduction to the chequered past of the Fort and, by association, of Gwalior.

It can get appreciably colder up in the fort than in the town below. A torch or flash- light would also be useful. If you do not have your own transport do ensure that you have arranged for a pick-up from the fort and a drop to your accommodation in town oth- erwise you would have a long trudge down from the Rock of Gwalior after the show!

THE JAIN MONOLITHS

On the way up to the fort, from the town massed at its feet, the road climbs through a wooded gorge called the Urwahi valley Facing it, and carved into the soaring sandstone cliff, are the imposing Jain mono- liths. They depict the Tirthankars, or enlightened souls, who came into this world to help their fellow men 'ford the river of existence'. According to an au- thoritative historian of Gwalior, Arthur Hughes, the statues were carved in the 15th century when Gwalior was ruled by the tolerant Tomar king Dungar Singh or by his son and successor, Kirti Singh. Legend has it that the skilled creators of these giant nude sculptures worked under the patronage of a Tomar queen who was either a Jain herself, or was a great admirer of this austerely non-violent religion.

There is a parking lot at the base of these statues and a flight of steps leading up to them. If, however, you take time off to view them, make sure that you wait for the one-way traffic to flow in your chosen direction before you drive out of the parking lot.

A Jain monolith on the way up to the fort

THE GWALIOR FORT

The road becomes steeper and steeper and eventually leads through narrow acclivity before you reach the fort on the broad top of the hill Th original road, the walls rising to over 15 meters, and the man-made sheer cliffs, were fashioned over eleven centuries ago. But the weight of history seems to rest lightly on the fort today. On your left are the offices of the Archaeological Surve of India, a museum, and a water pavilion that, reputedly, was devoted to musical performances during the reign of the Mughals, many of whom prided themselves on being patrons of the arts.

The Museum has interesting exhibits, well displayed and identified. Like all the museums run by the central Archaeological Survey of India, (ASI), photography is not allowed inside. (Those under the state Archaeological Department permit photography for a small fee.) There are two particularly interesting descriptive boards inside the museum: one on the Hindu Avatars, the successive incarnations of Lord Vishnu, the Preserver, the other on the Jain Tirthankars. Both concepts deliver the reassuring message that life on earth is guided by supernal beings who manifest themselves whenever they are needed.

The Man Mandir Palace

To the front, and left, of the museum rises the massive bulk of The Man Mandir Palace.

THE MAN MANDIR PALACE

From the 13th to the 14th century, Gwalior had been ruled by the Sultans of distant Delhi, In the chaos that followed the death of the last Sultan, a warrior of the martial Rajput clan of Tomar, made himself the ruler of Gwalior and established his own dynasty. The greatest of these rulers was Raja Man Singh Tomar (1486-1516).

The palace is a magnificent structure of forbidding walls relieved by soaring towers and cupolas and glistening yellow, blue and green ceramic tiles depicting ducks, and banana trees. A long flight of steps leads from the ground to the open courts of the palace, encircled by apartments. Of particular interest are their carved pillars and brackets, fretted ceilings, and a dance hall with a grilled balcony for the ladies of the court to see performances without being seen. Deep, wavy eaves, with a curiously Chinese-Persian look, throw cool shadows inside the rooms. The beautiful perforated stone screens have such intricate designs that they could be expressed in math- ematical formulac. The two subterra- nean floors are suitably dark and were once used as naturally air-conditioned chambers to escape from the heat of summer. Later, they became dun- geons. Today, many visitors avoid them because of the terrible tales of cruelty and death associated with these underground prisons.

An open court in the Man Mandir Palace encircled by apartments

Some areas of the Palace, in a line along the edge of the cliff, have been opened to visitors but have not, as yet, been restored by the State Archaeological Department. There is the palace of Man Singh's son Vikram. It is separated from the pal- ace of Man Singh's grandfather, Ka- ran and that of the Mughal emperor Shahjehan. A little further on is the palace of the emperor Jahangir. In

the lowest storey of the Karan Mandir you might still be able to see traces of the paintings and decorations that once brightened the king's bath-house and the remains of the copper pipes that carried the royal hot water! You might also encounter some of the resident population of bats who have been, quite literally, hanging around here for many generations!

Decorative Detail on the wall of the Man Mandir Palace

GUJRI MAHAL

There is another interesting palace in the Man Singh complex though it is not attached to it. The motor road from Gwalior enters through the Urwahi Gate. The pedestrian road down from Man Singh's palace exits through the Gwalior Gate and reaches the Hindola Gate opening into the Gujri Mahal. This palace was built by Man Singh for his wife, Mrignayani. Legend has it that Man Singh, while out hunting, saw this Gujar village girl subdue a rampaging buffalo

with her bare hands. She was also very beautiful. When he married her, his other, high-caste, wives refused to accept her in the Man Mandir Palace. He then built the Gujri Mahal for her and she, in turn, helped him establish the Gwalior School of Music, or Gwalior gharana, and contributed to some of the school's well-known ragas. The Gujri Mahal is now the State Archaeological Museum, quite distinct from the one facing the Man Mandir Palace. The rarest exhibit in this is what has often been described as India's Venus de Milo though it is far more beautiful than that Hellenistic sculpture. It is the famous Salabhanjika statue which is normally kept under lock and key but can, for a fee, be photographed.

Back on top of the Rock of Gwalior are a tank or reservoir. a gurdwara, and three temples.

SURAJ KUND

This is the largest of the struc- tural tanks in the fort, and the most legendary. Legend has it that Suraj Sen was cured of his skin disease here, in the miraculous spring created by Gwalipa. People still believe that its waters have curative properties. The best view of the tank is from near the entrance of the Gurdwara Datta Bandi Chhod.

In the Jai Villas Palace: A Crystal Swing for lord Krishna

GURDWARA DATA BANDI CHHOD

This elegant, white, Sikh temple (See box: The Sikhs) is dedicated to one of the many meritorious acts of Guru Har Gobind Singh. The sixth Guru's rising popularity alarmed the Mughal Emperor Jahangir who had him arrested and imprisoned in Gwalior Fort. When Jahangir fell ill his wife, Noor Jehan, consulted a Muslim sage and was told that the emperor would be cured if he released the Sikh leader. But the Guru refused to go unless the Rajput nobles, imprisoned with him, were also set free. Jahangir said that all those who could hang onto the Guru's coat-tails could follow him out, reasoning that the proud nobles would not agree to such a humiliating condition. But the Guru had a special coat of 52 trailing tassels made: one tassel for each noble. A tassel is not a humiliating coat-tail and yet it could be interpreted as one! The Guru and his fellow prisoners walked out free.

The receptionists provide you with scarves to cover your head before you enter the gurdwara. You are expected to rinse your hands at the wash-basins outside, remove your shoes and socks, and wade through a cleansing trough at the start of the steps leading to the temple.

Like all gurdwaras, the light-filled marble spaces are devoid of idols. Pride of place is given the holy book of the Sikhs: the Guru Granth Sahib, resting on a silver divan in an alcove arched in gold. This is the sanctum of the temple: a room with flowered ceramic tiles on the walls, a display of the Guru's weapons, and a glass door heavily framed in gold. There is also a picture of the Guru. The Prasad, or sanctified offerings, are rich, sweet sooji halwa.

Across the motor road from the Gurdwara complex, but separated from it by a high wall, is the Teli-ka-Mandir.

THE SIKHS

The religion of the Sikhs, Sikhism, was founded by Guru Nanak in the late 15th century. Sikhs, literally disciples", are followers of their ten gurus or religious teachers from Guru Nanak to Guru Gobind Singh. The Mughals, who then were the par- amount power in India, began to persecute the Sikhs because they feared their disci- pline and growing strength. This compelled the Sikhs to take up arms and Guru Gobind formed a new fraternity within the Sikhs called The Khalsa (The Pure). He gave this fraternity a common surname: "Singh' (lion) for men, and 'Kaur (honess) for women. He also revised the sacred book of the Sikhs, the Adi Granth, which had been compiled by the fifth Guru, Arjun Singh. Finally, before his death, Guru Gobind Singh declared that there would be no more living Gurus after him. Sikhs revere the Adi Granth and refer to it as the Guru Granth Sahib,

Traditionally Sikhs of the Khalsa fraternity do not cut their hair and, conse-quently wear a turban and grow a beard. They also carry a comb, wear shorts, strap on a sword, and fasten a steel bracelet on the right wrist.

Sikh temples, or gurdwaras, have no idols because Sikhs believe in one god. People of all faiths can visit a gurdwara pro- vided they wash their hands and feet before entering, are barefooted, and have their heads covered. Gurdwaras are also known for the generosity of their langars, or free hitchens, offering meals to everyone who cares to accept their hospitality and is pre- pared to eat along with other diners regard- less of their status or belief.

TELI-KA-MANDIR

This monument, under the protection of the ASI is, reputedly, the oldest in the fort. It was probably built in AD 800 or thereabouts. The local legend that it was built out of donations given by an oil merchant (teli) has arisen out of a pun on its name. The other legend that it was built by a princess from Andhra (Telengana) seems more likely. Its curious shape is due to the fact that, halfway up. its rectangular form becomes a pyramid crowned by the barrel roof of Buddhist shrine. Its 24.3 metre high tower is covered in carvings. The interior is bare and the doorway is flanked by sculptures of Ganga and Jamuna and, above the door, there is s a carving of Garuda who is the living vehicle of Lord Vishnu. Curiously, there is a panel with the seated figure of Buddha. This reinforces the belief that this was a temple dedicated to Vishnu because, according to some traditions, the Buddha was his ninth incarnation.

Equally intriguing are the twin temples of Sas-Bahu.

The Sas-Bahu Temples

SAS-BAHU TEMPLES

The words 'Sas-Bahu' mean Mother-in-Law-Daughter-in-Law but this is clearly a mispronunciation of the original which could have referred to a multi-armed Vishnu idol, now missing. An inscription says that the temples were completed by a Rajput prince in 1093.

The Sas is a profusely embellished temple with circular, bangle-style, decorations on the pillars, and Brahma, Vishnu and Siva with their consorts at the entrance. The Bahu is much smaller and does not have many carved figures. They are mostly friezes of elephants, and the heads of stylised monsters often called Kirti-mukhs which some scholars believe represent creation flowing out of the mouth of Time.

Architectural historian, Karan Grover, says that both these temples were built by artisans from Gujarat. "Only the Gujarat craftsman" he contends, "with his skill in erecting columnar halls, could have conceived and built such daring structures."

There is a superb eagle's eye view, of the town, from the battlements near the Sas-Bahu temples. The last time these fortifications withstood a siege was when the army of the British East India Company attacked them in India's first War of Independence. In 1857, Indian units of the Company revolted against the humations imposed on them by their British officers. One of the great leaders of this war was the young Rani of Jhansi.

RANI OF JHANSI

The British sought to deprive this courageous queen of her kingdom by a legal subterfuge. She and her loyal soldiers held out against repeated British attacks. Then on June 18, 1858, when she found that the odds against her were too great, she mounted her horse and leapt over the battlements and into her enemy's ranks. Today, a heroic equestrian statue of the valiant Rani stands in a commemorative park on the spot where she was cremated.

Legends enrich this town, enshrined in its statues and monu- ments. Among them is the story of Tansen. This great singer of the Gwalior School of Music was one of the Nine Jewels, the Nine Living Treasures, of the court of the great Mughal Emperor Akbar. Tansen's voice was so magical that when his enemy wanted to kill Tansen he convinced the emperor to ask Tansen to sing a raga that would cause all oil lamps to ignite spontaneously. Tansen sang that melodic sequence, the wicks burst into flame, but the power of the raga made his body burn with a terrible fe- ver which no doctor could cure. Tansen's beloved, however, began to sing a raga that caused a cloud-burst and quenched his raging fever. Presumably his spiritual guide Mohmmad Ghaus was unable to help him.

A gate stands at the end of a narrow and very insignificant lane in the town.

Beyond it spread lawns, a few large trees, and a road leading to an impressive monument, with a smaller one on a platform to one side. These are the mausoleums of Mohmmad Ghaus and Tansen.

The Tomb of Mohmmad Ghaus

MAUSOLEUMS OF MOHMMAD GHAUS AND TANSEN

Mohmmad Ghaus' monumental, 16th century, tomb is a massive sandstone structure with rising towers on the four corners, crowned by cupolas, and a huge central dome. Its outer walls are made of exquisitely cut stone grilles, in varied patterns, which let speckled sunlight fall on the gal- lery surrounding the main tomb. Here lie the graves of the spiritual family of Mohmmad Ghaus. Musicians sitting on the floor of the gallery just outside the inner chamber sing semi-religious songs in the spirited style of the ghazal which involves clapping and sinuous movements of the upper body. It is considered meritorious to give a small donation to the singers. The tomb of the saint, in the inner chamber, is enclosed in another grille bright with strips of coloured cloth tied by petitioners who hope that the soul of the saint will intercede on their behalf with Allah.

Other tombs, on platforms, stand outside the main entrance to the mausoleum.

Some distance away is Tansen's mausoleum: a very simple pavilion of white marble on its own platform. On one side of the platform is a tamarind tree whose leaves, if chewed, are sup- posed to improve one's voice. It would appear as if too many hopeful sing- ers have attacked it over the years, it seems to be dying.

THE MYSTIQUE OF THE GHARANAS

Education in India was, traditionally, umparted by a renowned teacher, given the title of a guru. His pupils, called sishyas, lived with him and, virtually, became part of his family. Thus he didn't teach them just the mechanics of knowledge, such as the three Rs, but he also imparted his wisdom, his philosophy of life, his world-view. Today, the guru-sishya relationships have been largely overtaken by the demands of modern edu- cation which is, in many ways, an imper- sonal, assembly line process.

Nevertheless, it still exists in the teaching of classical music and dance.

The students of these arts proudly say that they belong to the family, the gharana, established by a particular musical genius From him, and his anointed successors, they have acquired the subtle nuances, inflexions and for want of a better word-the style of expressing their art. Indian classical music expects every singer and musician to adhere to the sequence of notes that expresses a cer tain mood. This is a raga. But then the seill of that performer is judged by the way he improvises on that in the style of his gha- rana. The nearest that western music comes to this is in the performance of Blues and Jazz musicians. They might take a tune like, 'Sweet Georgia Brown', and play it with dif ferent variations at every performance. Except that western musicians do not have the additional discipline to conform to the style of a particular gharana!

In other words, every recital of every Indian classical performer is a unique cre- ation within the parameters of the raga and of his or her gharana.

The Sas-Bahu Temples

A Tansen Music Festival is held on these grounds every year.

Gwalior is associated with its own gharana, literally 'family', of music. Gharanas are distinguished from one another by the emphasis and style of expressing the music, though the basic melodic sequences, or ragas, can not be changed. (See Box: The Mystique of Gharanas) Devoted to the Gwalior gharana, which is reputedly the old- est of the gharanas, is a beautiful little heritage mansion in the heart of town. It is The Sarod Museum.

The Sarod Ghar

THE SAROD MUSEUM

A sarod is a northern Indian musical instrument, like a lute. It is played for classical dances or as a solo instrument, either by plucking or bowing its four melody strings which cause several sympathetic strings to vibrate. The melody strings are tuned c'-f'-g'-e" starting with middle C. And it came to us from a mountainous land.

About four centuries ago, an Afghan herdsman named Mohammed Hashmi Khan Bangesh travelled to India carrying an instrument called rahab. This was developed into the first recognised Sarod by his son Ghulam Ali Khan Bangesh in order to play the more sophisticated music developed in India.

The Sarod Museum has excellently mounted displays of the original instruments showing how they evolved over the years at the hands of generations of the Bangesh family. The house is still owned by the family and the current master of the sarod is Amjad Ali Khan. His sons, Aman and Ayan, have reverted to the family surname of Bangesh.

To any Indian, this is a house sanctified by four centuries of classical music. To those who are not familiar with Indian Classical music it is like being in the place where the Italians developed the violin out of the medieval rebec. Except that the violin was developed by many unrelated people. The sarod has been developed by only one living family and four generations of them were born in this house.

Over the years that the violin and the sarod were being evolved, the rulers of the Gwalior Fort had changed. In 1777, the ruler of the martial Marathas ordered it to be passed to the first Scindia ruler: Mahadji Scindia. The Scindias are still held in very high esteem by the people of the former Gwalior state and departed members of the Princely family have been commemorated in The Scindia Chhatris.

THE SCINDIA CHHATRIS

By tradition, many former ruling families in northern India have chhatris built in their memory. Chhatris, literally 'umbrellas', are cenotaphs in which the ashes of the late princes and princesses are enshrined. The more recent, and

imposing, chhartis of the Scindias are in a dedicated memorial park in Gwalior. The great gate of the park leads to a long road flanked by trees and grassy lawns. The well-kept grounds hold three temples made of coffee coloured sandstone, quite distinct from the white marble chhatris. These cenotaphs, raised on marble plinths, resemble shrines which, in may ways, they are. Inside them the ashes of the revered Prince or Princess have been interred and a statue of the person installed. It is only after the ceremonial installation of the statue that a flag is hoisted at the chhatri.

The chhatri that first catches the eye, at the end of the road leading from the gate, is that of Gajraraje. Her great-great-grandson would have been the ruler of Gwalior, in time, if the era of the Princes had not come to an end.

The cenotaph to the left, down another avenue, is that of Jivaji Rao, son of Gajraraje. The one to the right, also at the end of an avenue, is the chhatri of Vijayaraje, daughter-in-law of Jivaji Rao.

The sandstone temples are dedicated to Radha-Krishna, on the left, Ram on the right, and Vishnu in the centre. The temple to Lord Vishnu looks a bit like a squat, Byzantine, orthodox church and the marble fountain in front of it has a certain stylised, Victorian formality about it. Even the grounds have a restful quality as if peace had been ordained by royal decree.

The epitome of formal regality, however, is the sprawling white elegance of the Jai Vilas Palace.

JAI VILAS PALACE

This elegant white sprawling building, completed in 1874 when Britain's Queen Victoria was at the height of her power as the Empress of India, took nine years to build. It was designed by a remarkable polymath and genius, named Sir Michael Filose. He had been born in Gwalior, had been a playmate of the prince who became the ruler of the state, and was a man of remarkabh eclectic tastes able to encompass the best of the pomp and grandeur of both Indian and European palaces. He chose as his inspiration the architectural idiom of Tuscany: possibly because there, too, the warmth of the east had blended with the precision of the west.

The long drive, leading to the Jai Vilas Palace, has royal rail cars parked on either side, once used for the Prince's guests. There is also an interesting little model of a palace on the right of the main entrance. It has much the same ritualistic significance as a foundation stone though it carries a greater religious aura

An appreciable part of the Jai Vilas Palace has become the H.H. Maharaja Sir Jiwaji Rao Scindia Museum.

H.H. MAHARAJA SIR JIWAJI RAO SCINDIA MUSEUM

This wing gives an interesting insight into the lifestyle of a powerful princely family. Portraits of the family, its family tree and its flags and insignia, dominate the foyer atop the flight of steps from the entrance. The personal flag of the Scindias shows two black cobras, with their hoods spread, against a deep orang background below a sun radiating light. Legend has it that the founder of the dynasty, when a child, was protected from the heat of the sun by a cobra with its hood expanded. This was interpreted as an omen of future greatness for the sleeping child. On this floor there are also trophies of the Princes' hunting parties and a gallery of old sculptures.

At the other end of the foyer, a stairway leads up past an indoor swit ming pool to halls with a private breakfast room, dining rooms, offices, rooms with Chippendale furniture, carved blackwood furniture and the living wing of the tiny Chinkoo Raja a Maharanı who was only four feet two inches tall and so had everything scaled down to her size including a crystal swing for a religious festival. There is a Chi nese room, another with an intricate stained-glass window. A descending flight of stairs leads to a court with a crystal fountain and the royal coaches. 3 Another section holds the formal western-style dining room where a sil- ver coach and carriages once wound around the table offering port, sherry, liquors and cigars. Then there's the formal Indian-style dining room where guests sat on low stools and a pandit sat at one end facing a statue of Lord Krishna. In a foyer with huge mirrors there is a red chandelier with 100 bulbs illuminating staircases sweeping up to the first floor of this wing. There, above, is an enormous reception area with a coffered and painted ceiling, two huge crystal chandeliers weighing three and a half tons each. To make certain that the roof could take their weight, a one kilometre ramp was built so that eight elephants could amble up and stand on the roof above. The roof held: the chandeliers were hung!

And on the furniture, the mouldings, the decorations on the coffered ceilings, picture frames, everywhere where good-taste dictated that it could be used, gold glittered. Five hundred and sixty kilograms of gold leaf were used in this Palace

It was a different age with different perceptions. People felt secure and protected by rich and powerful princes and they expected their rulers to lead rich and powerful lifestyles. That was their noblesse oblige, the obligations of their position. As the people of another nation continue to express it, the ruler has to live a "happy and glorious" life. The Scindias, clearly, lived both happily and gloriously in Jai Vilas Palace, Gwalior.

The resplendent first floor Reception Room

UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITE

GWALIOR FORT
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

EXPLORER'S
MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF GWALIOR

BATESHWAR

After driving for about 37 kms, much of it on a fairly rugged road the stretches through villages and scrublands, explorers pass the fortress-like ruins of Padhavali on the left and then, a further kilometre brings one to the fing evidence of old, ruined, structures covered in earth, scrub and trees. A line further on, a barbed wire fence demarcates the grounds of Bateshwar, also known as Bhuteswara. Much of it still under excavation and conservation by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI). Even though our archaeologists are working on it, Bateshwar has emerged as an amazing complex of carved blocks a few shrines, some stone ponds and a very unlikely fort made later from stones taken from the ruins. The ASI estimates that it was once a religious complex of one hundred temples of which the archaeologists have restored eight, and also worked on an old tank or reservoir which is a necessary feature of all traditional

The impressive ruins of Bateshwar

temples. Pilgrims are expected to have a ritual bath before entering such religious places.

Do pick your way through the ruins with great care: if you should slip and have an accident here it will be a long and painful drive back to Gwalior

Of special interest, in the reconstructed temples, are stone door jambs with carvings of Ganga and Jumna. Gangas vehicle or vahana is a crocodile, Jumnas is a tortoise and they are usually depicted beneath the Images of these two river-goddesses. Other striking sculptures are the marriage of Shivand Parvati; a beautiful dancing Ganesh, the ten successive Incarnations of Vishnu, a cluster of five Shivlings, Agni, the god of fire, with his vahana, a goat, and a pillar showing typical Pratihara features.

The Pratihara dynasty is known, more formally, as the Gurjara- Pratiharas, and they ruled from the 8th century to the beginning of the 11th century, The

Pratiharas are historically the most important of the four 'Fire born" clans of the martial Rajputs. These were Pawar also known as Paramara, Parihar aka Pratihara, Chauhan aka Chahumana and Solanki aka Chaulukya. The term 'Fire born' has been interpreted by some historians as inferring that these tribes were, originally, foreigners who had entered India with the Huns and then been accepted into the Hindu fold by a fire-rite of purgation conducted by the seer Vasishtha in Rajasthan.

The small fort overlooking the temples, which have been built on the slopes of a range, was clearly constructed long after the temples. The fort, and the temple complex, look down onto the flat, green, fields of a fertile valley This valley must have been a very prosperous one, and its rich inhabitants worshipped in, and supported, Bateshwar's many excellently carved temples.

The temple on top of a high platform

PADHAVALI OR PARAVALI

Driving back about a kilometre, the explorer should stop at the fenced-in grounds of Padhavali. Today it looks like a fortified hillock enclosing a temple. Archaeologists believe that, in the early 19th century, the Rana, or Prince, of Dholpur, converted a ruined temple atop a mound, into a small fort or garhi. He used dressed stones, said to be the remains of the old town of Dharon, to erect defensive towers for his fort, and many such stones still lie scattered around the grounds of Paravali. A flight of stone steps, guarded by two stone lions, lead up to the ruins of the temple within the walls of the garhi.

The explorer can still visualise the majesty of the temple as it would have been in its heyday. In a paved court, the remains of the old structure stand: atop a carved plinth sixteen sculpted pillars supporting a flat roof. There are intricately carved panels on the stone beams between the pillars. They depict the divinities Surya, Kali, Siva, Vishnu and Brahma, and friezes drawn from the great epics of India. To one side of the temple is a barrack-like building that the Rana had apparently, made as his temporary 'palace'.

Drive down another 4 kms, on a fairly rugged, rural road, through villages, to the base of a second hillock. Leave your car outside the village, trek up a rising path till you come to a flight of 95 steps. It takes about ten to fifteen minutes to complete the walk. At the far end of the steps the top of the hillock spreads in a surface of flat rocks which seem to have been superficially dressed. You have arrived in Mitaoli.

An intricately carved arch and ceiling of Padhavali Temple

MITAOLI

Ahead of you is a huge, circular, building which resembles our Houses of Parliament in Delhi. To your right, on a raised outcrop of rock, is a built-up platform holding a small, square, shrine. This shrine is not of great significance, the circular structure is important.

All around its outer wall it has small alcoves carrying carvings of Siva and Parvati interspersed with carvings of a diamond-shaped motif. Inside this huge doughnut-shaped building, open to the sky, there is a gallery divided by pillars into sixty-four segments. In the centre of this paved court is another circular building raised on its own plinth. There are two shivlings inside this inner shrine.

The entire structure is locally known as Ekottarso Mahadeva Mandir or The Temple of 101 Shivlings. Nevertheless, there can be little doubt that this was, originally, a Chausath Yogini Temple dedicated to the 64 aspects of the Mother Goddess Parvati, and, eminent scholar of Indian Art and Architecture, Krishna Deva, has specifically identified this as one of the Chausath Yogini temples of Central India. There are, however, no yogini figures left in any of the alcoves. The yogini cult has always been identified with Siva, accounting for the presence of shivlings in this temple, because Parvati is the consort and shakti, or Power, of Siva.

The outer doughnut-shaped enclosure protects an inner gallery and shrine on a platform

The inner shrine holds two shivlings. Mitaoli was, apparently, a temple of the Yogini cult of the Mother Goddesses

Accommodation in Gwalior

MPT Tansen Residency

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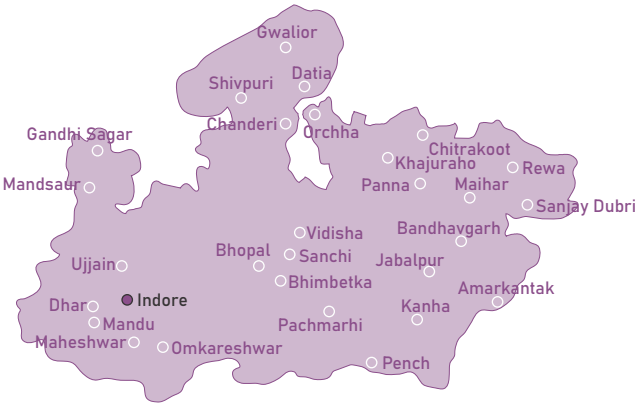
Tuning with the grandeur of the city of Gwalior, MPT Tansen Residency is an assurance of excellence in service and comfort for leisure as well as business travelers alike. It's conference facilities, vantage location and flawless service by the efficient MICE team, make it one of the best MICE hotels of the city. ISO 22000:2018 FSMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Sarafa Bazaar

Indore

A cheerful, hard-headed pragmatism is the leitmotif of the people and the town of Indore.



The tone for this was set in 1818 when the Holkar rulers of this former princely state decided to move their capital to the village of Indore. (See Box: The Origin of the Holkars.) This was, clearly, a brilliant decision. According to the official gazetteer

This city, within the short space of three years (1818-21), changed from a desolate town to a flourishing capital. Indore began to grow as a centre of commerce and industries owing to its increasing wealth and population.

The old Rajwada Palace in the hear of town

THE ORIGIN OF THE HOLKARS

Malhar Rao, the founder of the dynasty, was a shepherd in Hol, a small village near Pune. The suffix 'kar' means 'belonging to Legend has it that, when he was having a siesta, certain auspicious signs appeared around him. These were interpreted as an omen that the boy had a great future ahead of him. He was, thus, sent into the service of a Maratha chieftain.

Malhar Rao soon proved that he was both a natural leader of men and a born tactician in the battle field. His prowess earned him the respect of the Peshwa, overlord of this region, and he was given command of 500 horsemen.

All the major military routes to the Deccan, that is between north and south India, passed through Malwa The Mughals had protected this important link but, with the decline of the Mughal power, there was a vacuum in this strategic area. The Peshwa and his Marathas moved in.

In 1727. Malhar Rao Holkar was given a grant of land in Malwa After many battles and skirmishes, Holkar finally established his hold over vast territories in this rich and important area. His son had been killed during the siege of a fort in 1754. Malhar Rao died in 1766 and his grandson Male Rao, suffering from incipient insanity, died a year later. He was succeeded by his mother, and the daughter-in-law of Malhar Rao, Ahilyabai.

The Holkars ruled their state for almost 220 years. On the 16th of June 1948, the state merged with the independent Union of India and the long rule of the Holkar dynasty ended.

THE HOLKAR'S COAT OF ARMS

The extraordinary level-headedness of the Holkars comes out clearly in their crest. No mythological lions or unicorns for them. Their coat of arms tells the whole story. A prancing horse, a lance and a sword depicting the martial prowess of the Holkars. The sun representing their deity Malhari Martand. The crown to indicate that they were vassals of the British crown. A bull and wheat emphasising their strong pastoral and agricultural base. And a poppy. Opium, extracted from the capsules of the poppy, may be a politically incorrect produd today; but in the 18th and 19th centuries it was as valuable a commodity 25 tobacco became in the 20th. The British East India Company, the overlords of India till 1858, encouraged the opium trade from India to both West and East Asia and, possibly, also to England. The Encyclopaedia Asiatica, published in 1858 says: *"Opium is largely manufactured in the fertile table-land of Malwa, in Central India..."* and the compiler of the Encyclopaedia, senior administrator Edward Balfour, goes on to say *".. In the fens of England, a whole population use opium as a prophylactic against age."*

This coat of arms appears in a stained glass window in the lobby of The Lalbagh Palace.

THE LALBAGH PALACE

After the British crown took over the possessions of the East India Company, in 1858, it became increasingly fashionable for the Indian princes to show their appreciation of Western culture. Architecture, in particular, took on a European orientation. The Lalbagh palace, grew in the reigns of three princes. Tukoji Rao II (1844-1886) started it, Shivaji Rao (1886-1903) continued it; and Tukoji Rao III (1903-1926) loved the palace so much that, even though he abdicated in 1926, he stayed on till his death in 1978. It almost seems as if every extravagant style, every new whim of European architects, was

The Lal Bagh Palace

incorporated in the palace and its furnishings. Thus, a walk around Lal Bagh could become a lesson, for students of Design, in the variations of decor and form that Europeans evolved for their homes over many decades. If technical terms are of interest to the visitor, then the architecture is a blend of Renaissance, Palladian and Baroque. There are Rococo and Neo-classical influences in the furniture and the decoration relies heavily on stucco and marble. Pillars rise in the three classic styles: Doric, Ionian and Corinthian. The cultured English gentleman had to have a knowledge of Greek and Latin and be familiar with their myths. In the palace they would have been delighted to see sculptures and paintings of Poseidon and Demeter, Helios and Hephaistos along with naiads, griffins and cherubs floating across the painted ceilings. And, naturally, there are chandeliers, expensive drapes, and huge mirrors to replicate all this exuberance over and over again.

To the visitor who is not interested in the technicalities of art and architecture, it will all seem rather grand and dazzling. Much like a Bollywood set awaiting the director's call for "Lights! Camera! Action!"

A reflection of elegant European tastes in the Lalbagh Palace

But for all the shimmer of its gold, the sheen of its marble and the glitter of its chandeliers, it does not seem to be over-stated. This is the way our princes were expected to live to uphold the prestige of their people. In much the same way, the poor of medieval Europe prided themselves on the excessive decorations of their cathedrals glorifying their King of Kings!

Do also look at the Indian dining room made for more traditional ban FA quets. Notice that there is the grave of a Muslim saint just off a long verandah As its ceremonial covering and offer ings of flowers show, it is still being paid all the marks of respect due to such a revered shrine.

Before you leave, visit the statue of Queen Victoria, standing, in all her buxom majesty, alone and not very revered, in the grounds of Lalbagh Palace Before the Lalbagh was built, the Holkars lived in the Rajwada Palace.

RAJWADA PALACE

Unlike the Lalbagh, that stands aloof in the midst of extensive grounds. the Rajwada stands in the heart of the busiest part of the town. Facing it is a garden with a statue of the great queen Ahilyabai. The façade which encloses the gateway of the Rajwada Palace gives the impression of a rather forbidding wizard's castle. The three lower storeys have been painted a dark brown. The three floors rising above them have their windows outlined in white giving the impression of multiple eyes gazing down at one from a well-defended fortress.

The Rajwada Palace

This ominous look is very deceptive.

Walking through the main gate one enters a bright, sunlit, quadran- gle surrounded by galleries and deli- cate arches of great elegance. There is something very welcoming about this place as if the earlier Holkars had followed the example of their great queen, Ahilyabai, and been accessi- ble to the humblest of their subjects. And then they had taken a leaf from the pages of their British masters and decided to be distant and aloof from their common subjects.

Today the Rajwada houses offices and a small shrine.

Not far from the old Rajwada Pal- ace are The Royal Chhatris.

THE ROYAL CHHATRIS

Rose are beautiful monuments with soaring towers and their wall decorated with sculptures. All of them have wide and deep pavilion decoratably made to

Krishnapura-Ki-Chhatri

shelter pilgrims. Since there has the Khan River greatly depleted today they attract students, mendicants and assorted vendors Catering to visitors The rather crowded environs of back yonotaphs tend detract from their powerful presence. But if you stand back you will notice the intricate workmanship that has gone into creating these temple-like memorials to former Holkars.

The largest one is a memorial to Krishnabai who died in 1849. The one with a Ganesh on it is to Tukoji Rao (1844-86). The least impressive was built in honour of Shivaji Rao Holkat who died in 1903.

Also in the heart of the town is the unusual Kanch Mandir.

KANCH MANDIR

Its name means 'The Glass Temple and that is exactly what it is. Every centimetre of its interior is covered in tiles made of Belgian glass: floors,

The Kanch Mandir

ceilings, pillars, alcoves holding images, lamps. It was built by a millionaire cotton merchant, Sir Hukum Chand, about ninety years ago. There is also a legend that a soothsayer had told the Indian knight that work on the Kanch Mahal must never cease. Clearly he was a very far-sighted man. When one builds with tiny glass tiles, and opens the building to streams of worshippers and visitors, little bits of glass ate bound to get damaged. And then they have to be replaced. So the building of the temple will never cease!

This is a temple of the Dig amber sect of the Jains. They are, predominantly a trading community and were probably attracted to In- dore because it is, essentially, a trad- ing town.

One enters a foyer glittering with glass and even the two murals of guards, or dwarapalas, are made in mosaics of glass. The room beyond is a sort of ante-room with a small statue in the centre of the far wall. This is, really, the rear of the sanctum lying on the other side of the wall.

Around the walls of the sanc- tum are glass pictures depicting the tenets of Jainism, and indicat- ing the punishments that await all who transgress these teachings. More precepts of this non-theistic faith are displayed in pictures in the hall to the side of the sanctum There is a black marble statue of the Tirthankar Shantinath, flanked by white marble statues of two other Tirthankars: Adinath and Chandr- aprabhu. The pillars here look as if they had been encased in bangles of multi-coloured glass.

Traditionally, traders set great store by Lord Ganesh, the benevo- lent and wise, elephant-headed, son of Lord Siva. He has an impressive shrine known as the Bada Ganapati.

BADA GANAPATI

Ganapati is another name for Ganesh in his role as the leader of his father's goblin hordes: the Ganas. Here, he is worshipped as an eight metre high scarlet idol, decorated with jewellery. According to the attendant priest, the idol was built by a devotee named Narain Dadsich. He also claimed that it was the tallest Ganesh in India.

The clay idol has, apparently, been held together by a mixture of jaggery or molasses, methi or fenugreek and other secret ingredients all mixed together with the water of seven sacred rivers.

Devotees also visit the unusual Temple of Annapurna.

The Bada Ganapati claimed to be the tallest in India

TEMPLE OF ANNAPURNA

The name of this goddess has been interpreted as 'She who fills with food', normally

depicted with a rice bowl in one hand and a spoon in the other to stir the boiling rice. This temple is unusual because it is built in the southern or Dravidian style. It has a towering, and richly embellished gopuram or gate-tower, guarded by two huge statues of elephants.

In her very colourful sanctum, Annapurna is flanked by the fearsome goddess Kali and the benign goddess Gayatri. All goddesses are aspects, or forms, of the great Mother Goddess.

Many people believe that Annapurna wards off all famines from Indore.

The non-Semitic faiths of India, excluding Sikhism, have a rich pantheon of divine and semi-divine beings. Indian artists have sculpted and painted them for thousands of years. A fair idea of this long-standing tradition can be had by a visit to the Central Museum, Indore.

CENTRAL MUSEUM, INDORE

The gardens of this museum are full of antiad witues. A state The wandel when it is consecrated and went of the damaged, and no longer revered as an embodiment of the deity, it reverts to pre-consecrated status as a statue. Exhibits in museums are called statues. Of particular interest in the front garden is a red-brick model of a temple is Vishnu, the Preserver of the Brahmanical Trinity, and an excellent 13th century sculpture of the Jain Tirthankar Adinath. Depictions of the Tirthankars are often mistaken for Buddhist images. There are many, rather subtle, distinguishing features but the easiest is to look for an identifying emblem at the base of the statue. The Tirthankar images have it; the Buddha images do not. There is also a canopy from the 11th century, sculpted in great detail.

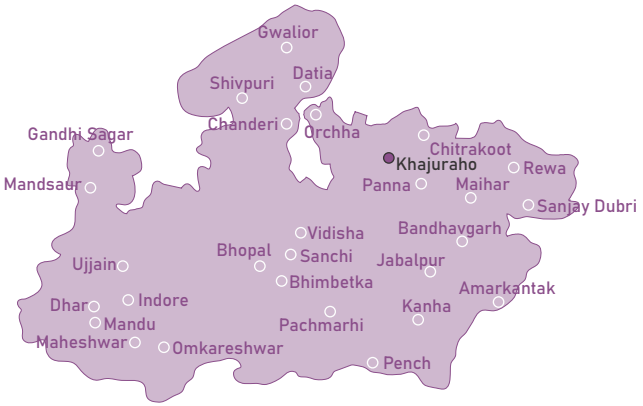
Inside the museum there are a number of galleries but, if you are running short of time, do visit the Weapons Gallery and the one showing reproductions of the Buddhist paintings in the Bagh Caves. The originals of these old paintings have been destroyed by the seepage of rain water.

In the rear garden there are more exhibits including one of the bout incarnation of Vishnu: Varaha, who drew the world out of the great abyss of water. Presumably, this sculpture will not be damaged by being exposed to the elements.

The 1000 year sculptures of Khajuraho have a timeless grace and fludity

Khajuraho

One thousand years ago, Khajuraho had the world's most liberal civilization.



Today, we still stand in awe at the grace and fluidity of its sculptures. T They depict themes that no one would dare to exhibit even in our most avant-garde studios. In Khajuraho they were carved into the outer walls of temples for everyone to see, and appreciate. Clearly, in that distant age, such sculptures were accepted as a natural and meaningful part of everyday life.

THE CHANDELLAS

But in spite of the courage of their artistic convictions, we are not sure who these people were. They called themselves the Chandellas: virtually a title that they had given to themselves to perpetuate a status-enhancing myth. (See box : Son of the

Khajuraho captivates travelers from around the globe

SON OF THE MOON

This icon is commonly referred to as the 'Chandella Lion'

The Chandellas based their claim to noble Rajput descent on the tale of the amo- rous Moon-god.

Once upon a time, they said, the beautiful daughter of a high caste Brahmin felt overcome by the heat of a summer's night in Khajuraho. Silently she left the home of her devout father and tiptoed down to a forest pool. There, in the silver light of a full moon, she undressed, walked into the inviting water, and began to bathe. Just then, Chandra, the moon god, spied her. Overcome with passion, he transformed himself into a handsome young man, descended to earth, stepped into the pool, and turning on his irresistible charm, seduced the girl.

In the magical manner of divine conceptions, the girl knew that she was pregnant and she sobbed to her lover that he had put an indelible mark of shame on her. Consoling her, Chandra said that their son would grow into a manly and coura- geous ruler and start the Chandella dynasty whose fame would stretch to the far corners of the earth and be remembered long after the city had been abandoned and covered by the jungle.

Moon) This, they believed, gave them, the right to assert that they were Chandravanshis with blood ties to powerful Rajput clans who claimed descent from the Moon God, Chandra.

In all likelihood, however, the Chandellas were related to the aboriginal tribes of this part of Madhya Pradesh: the Bhars and the Gonds. This is borne out by the fact that the Chandellas' titular deity was Maniya Devi, a tribal deity of the Bhars and the Gonds. Maniya Devi is a Mother Goddess who, like Mother Goddesses all over the world, assumes many terrifying forms. Significantly, the oldest temple in Khajuraho, dating to the last quarter of the 9th century, is the seldom-visited Chausath Yogini. This unroofed, and now bare, shrine was dedicated to the 64 aspects of the Mother Goddess. Her worship reputedly called for fertility rites to be performed by her devotees under the open sky These were, consequently, rituals accepted by the public as a form of worship The depictions of these erotically explicit ceremonies would have been treated as a natural expression of religious feelings suitable for depiction on the walls of their temples. Moreover, it is likely that the aura of the Chausath Yogini temple, and its powerful Yogini cult, had exercised such a magnetic hold on the tribal sensitivities of the Chandellas that they believed that this was the ordained spot in which to construct their religious capital.

It is also clear that the Chandellas had acquired a great reputation as warriors,

skilled in realpolitik. In the middle of the 7th century, much of northern India was ruled by the imperial Pratiharas. The Chandellas convinced the Pratiharas to accept them as their feudatories and thereby acquired a princely status. From there the Chandellas grew in power, resisted invaders and, eventually, threw off the yoke of the Pratiharas. They built-forts in Mahoba, Kalinjar and Ajaygarh and were said to have established their capital in Khajuraho, reputedly named after the two golden date palms, or khajurs, that decorated their main gate.

WAS KHAJURAHO A LAKE AND TEMPLE TOWN?

Oddly, however, though the fortifications in Mahoba, Kalilnjar and Ajaygarh still stand, there isn't a single secular structure standing, or in ruins, in Khajuraho. Either they had been abandoned and had crumbled, or Khajuraho had always been the Chandellas religious capital, a town of magnificent temples. Their secular capital could have been tucked in the security of one of their huge forts.

If Khjuraho was, primarily, a religious lake-town, this would account for the fact that its temples have no perimeter walls to protect them and also that they stand on high plinths, rising above their natural moats. Possibly they were built on granite outcrops, or islands, rising above the wetlands. The renowned traveller Ibn Batuta, who came to India in the 14th century, said that there was a huge pond in Khajuraho, about a mile in length, dotted with temples. Local tradition has it that, at the height of its power, Khajuraho had 85 temples. (See Box: The Once and Future Temple). Today this legendary stretch of water has been reduced to the Shiv-Sagar Tank, and one or two less significant ones that are often dry, and a small stream. And only 25 temples have survived.

The great temple-building boom in Khajuraho began with the first politically powerful Chandella prince, Harsha, who ruled from AD 900 to 925. The last important Chandella raja was Paramadin who was defeated by his enemies in 1202. But even with the loss of the Chandellas' political power, Khajuraho continued to shine as a religious beacon. More than 100 years later, in 1335, it was famed for its resident hermits with remarkable medical abilities. But then, it faded from human memory, was abandoned, and the wilderness took over. Five centuries later, in 1838 a British engineer named T.S. Burt was told about 'the wonders of a place called Khajrao' by a porter carrying his palanquin.

The green spaces could once have been lakes

He rediscovered this magnificent ghost town in the forest.

It is surprising how remarkably well the soaring sandstone structures, and their superb carvings, have survived five hundred years of weathering and the choking invasion of the jungle.

All this is brought out evocatively in the Son-et-Lumiere presented in the Western Group of Temples every evening. The first show is in Hindi, the second in English.

BEFORE YOU START YOUR TOUR

If you want to do justice to the temples, budget the whole morning for the important Western Group; wear a hat; carry a bottle of water though you can get refreshments in the complex from the 'Canteen' in a grove of trees to the left before you get to the Kandariya Mahadeva; and make sure that you can slip in and out of your shoes easily: you will have to take off your shoes before you enter the temples though you can wear them on the platforms of the temples affording excellent views of the sculptures.

THE WESTERN GROUP

The temples have been divided into the Western, Eastern and Southern groups with most of the important shrines being encircled by the perimeter wall of the Western Group. This is in the bustling market area of Khajuraho. It is also where visitors buy tickets to visit the monuments, purchase the Archaeological Survey of India's (ASI) excellent guide book on the monuments of Khajuraho in their World Heritage Series, and hire the services of trained guides or recorded audio-guides. The monuments are well sign-posted. The plaque on the right, just after the entrance of the Western Group gives a brief introduction to the history of Khajuraho, a capsule description of its temples and the names of the important ones.

Standing at this spot, and looking across the well-maintained grounds of the complex, the temples can be divided into five sets. To the left, where 9 would be on the face of a clock, are the Varaha and Lakshmana temples. At 12 o'clock, dead ahead, are the Kandariya Mahadeva and Jagadambi temples. Between 1 and 2 o'clock is the Chitragupta temple. And at 3 o'clock are the Parvati, Vishwanath

THE ONCE AND FUTURE TEMPLE

The ASI has discovered 18 mounds dotted around the existing temples. All of them could hold the remains of temples. One of them, the Bijamandal mound, has been excavated enough to reveal the presence of the largest temple in Khajuraho: four meters longer than the Kandariya-Mahadeva.

Atop the mound there was a large marble Shivling, once worshipped by itinerant sadhus (religious mendicants) who had built a brick hut for themselves at the back of the mound. Much of the mound has now been opened to expose a large sandstone platform richly decorated with stone friezes. This rises to what could have been the sanctum or garba griha.

From the images imbedded in the mound, and lying around, it has been estimated that this was probably con structed in the latter part of the 10th century or the early part of the 11th. This would place it among the early temples to be built in Khajuraho, but, for some strange reason, it does not seem to have been completed. It does, however, contain erotic sculptures which bolster the belief that the temples were inspired by the fer- tility cults of the Yoginis.

Clearly, Khjuraho still holds many secrets of its extraordinarily liberal past.

Varaha intricately carved

and Nandi temples. Start your tour by walking down to the Varaha Temple.

VARAHA TEMPLE

This is a shrine rather than a temple. Inside its oblong pavilion, rising on a high plinth, is a superbly carved monolithic image of the third incarnation of the Preserver of the Hindu trinity: Varaha the boar. The sculpture is 2.5 meters long and 1.5 meters high and its sandstone has been polished to a jewel-like lustre. On the body of this yellow sandstone image are carved 674 figures of gods and goddesses in relief. In fact a folklorist would, quite literally, take a lifetime telling all the tales associated with the images carved on this greatly revered incarnation. According to Hindu cosmology, Varaha rescued Mother

Earth by lifting her from the abyss that had engulfed her. This shrine was probably made during the rule of the first, significant, Chandella prince: Harsha. It is dated to 900-925 AD.

In front of the Varaha temple rise the steps that access the platform of the Lakshmana Temple.

LAKSHMANA TEMPLE

This, the earliest of the temples dating to 930-50, was built in the evolved Khajuraho style with its curvilinear tower rising like a great mountain peak There is a wonderful processional frieze on the facade of the platform capturing hunting and battle scenes. A panel which often shocks visitors also seems to have dismayed an onlooker captured on the panel. He is covering his eyes but there is also an acceptance nce of the generally offensive deed of his companion. Even in our 21st century soldiers have been guilty of worse deeds to relieve their tensions.

The erotica, however, form only a small part of the sculptures in Khajuraho. In another platform frieze, men and women disciples listen to a Tantric preacher sitting in a chair, a line of religious musicians dances in ecstasy, and there is an impressive frieze showing elephants and their keepers, including a

The Laxmana Temple

woman.

The temples are so richly decorated with carvings that even the professional guides who visit the temples ever day have assured us that they still find something new to comment on.

The largest and tallest of the temples, and the one with the most carvings is the Kandariya Mahadeva Temple.

KANDARIYA MAHADEVA TEMPLE

This temple was built between 1025 and 1050 and it rises in successive towers like a range of mountains. Quite apart from its profusion of carvings visitors often ask questions about the scrolled arch above the entrance. The generic name for this is torana and it could have evolved from the ceremonial gateways at the cardinal points of Buddhist stupas. More specifically, this particular type of torana is called makara torana and in Khajuraho they have been preserved only in the Lakshmana, the Kandariya Mahadeva and the Javari. An imaginative interpretation of the makara, the monster head, is that it represents the maw of Time with creation pouring out of it.

The lintel has a four-armed Siva flanked by Brahma and Vishnu: the Destroyer with the Creator on one side and the Preserver on the other.

On the same platform as the Kandariya Mahadeva is the temple of Jagadambi.

JAGADAMBI

This temple seems to have changed its dedication possibly with a change of the faith of its ruler. Jagadambi is another name for Parvati, the consort of Siva. But the lintel of the sanctum has a four-armed Vishnu. The sculptures of the gods have been wrought with particular finesse and the images of the sura-sundaris, or celestial maidens, are particularly appealing.

In between the two temples, and sharing the same platform, is a small pavilion. This is the portico of a Siva shrine: the rest of the shrine has fallen.

There is an interesting sculpture in this pavilion. It is a sardula: a fabulous, heraldic creature represented as a rampant, horned lion though the horns on this sardula seemed to have been shed.

Coming down from the large platform of the temples you will have to walk some distance to get to the base of the Chitragupta Temple.

CHITRAGUPTA TEMPLE

This is one of the few temples in India dedicated to the Sun God, Surya. He

DISCOVERING MADHYA PRADESH

Kandariya Mahadeva Temple

drives his chariot, drawn by the seven horses of the days of the week, across the sky. He is also the only Hindu god who wears boots. There is an eleven headed and eight armed Vishnu in a niche in the south. In the west there is another unusual sculpture: a three-headed and eight armed Surya.

The most interesting feature of this greatly-restored temple is the series of divine couples shown one below the other: Brahma-Brahmani, Siva-Parvati Lakshmi-Narayana and Bhairava-Bhairavi

When you come down from the Chitragupta Temple, continue down the path that would eventually lead you to the gate of the Western Group. To your right, now, will be the Parvati Temple.

PARVATI TEMPLE

All that is left of the original temple is an undecorated tower crowned by an amalaka: a fluted, melon-shaped structure. Inside the temple is an image of Parvati manifested as Gauri. Visually, this is not an interesting shrine.

Nearby is a white temple built by a local maharaja about a century ago. Its architecture is a strange melange of idioms, completely alien to the graceful Khajuraho style.

This will bring you to the last shrine in the Western Group, the Vishwanath Temple.

VISHWANATH TEMPLE

This is among the finest examples of the developed Khajuraho temple style. It once had four subsidiary shrines at the four corners of the high platform on which it stands and so is called a panchayatana temple, though now only two of these subsidiary shrines stand.

Particularly noteworthy are two sura-sundaris: one plucking a thorn from the sole of her foot with an extremely graceful depiction of feminine curves, and another celestial maiden playing a flute.

The architectural style of this temple indicates that it was built just before the Kandariya. From an inscription found in this temple it is clear that this was originally dedicated to Siva Marakatesvara built by the Chandella ruler Dhanga in 1002. Of the two lingas that had been installed here, at that time, only the stone one remains. The far more valuable one has disappeared. It was made of emerald.

Facing the shrine of this temple, and in its own pavilion, is a massive Nandi: the bull vahan, or vehicle, of Lord Siva.

Just outside the perimeter fence of the Western Group is the Matangesvara Temple.

MATANGESVARA TEMPLE

This is a living Siva temple built between 900 to 925 AD. Installed in it is a polished stone lingam, 2.5 metres high and a metre in diameter. It is very popular with devotees and their colourful flow, up and down the steps of the temple, the sound of conches and bells, and the fragrance of incense conjures up visions of what the monumental temples of Khajuraho must have been like when the were living places of worship.

Down the main road from the Western Group, and leaving the Matangesvara Temple to your right, stands the ASI Museum.

Shiv ling of Matengeswara Temple

Matangeswara Temple

ASI MUSEUM

Open from 10 am to 5 pm and closed on Fridays, the Museum has some exquisite sculptures and they are well displayed. In the foyer is the most beautiful dancing Ganesh we have ever seen. To the left is the Jaina Gallery with an 11th-12th century statue of Sambhava Nath. Beyond is the Vaishnava Gallery displaying the 10th-12 century Varaha with six heads. There is also a very attractive celestial nymph of the 11th-12th century. To the right of the foyer is the Miscellaneous Gallery with a statue of a king and queen of the 11th-12th century. The Siva Galley beyond has a huge statue of Paravati and a six-headed statue of Siva called Sada-Siva, both dating back to the 11th-12th century. Ask the Museum attendants to show you the three stone images taken from the Chausath-Yogini Temple of Khajuraho: Brahmani, Maheshvari and Mahishasuramardini.

CHAUSATH-YOGINI TEMPLE

To the south-west of Khajuraho's Shiv-Sagar Tank, a road leads to an outcrop crowned by the rectangular granite temple of the Chausath Yoginis or sixty-four aspects of the Mother Goddess. It has no roof and there are a number of cells built into the inner surface of the wall. These, once, contained images of the Yoginis of which the last three were moved to the Museum. This is the oldest temple in Khajuraho and the oldest Yogini temple in India dating to c.875 AD. According to Krishna Deva, the retired Director General of the ASI, when writing about the Yogini cult: "Khajuraho was one of its important centres in the early medieval age."

The ruins of the Chausath-Yogini Temple, the oldest temple in Khajuraho

More temples of the great medieval age of Khjuraho stand outside the focal Western Group. For easy reference, the ASI has classified them as the temples of the Eastern Group and those of the Southern Group.

THE EASTERN GROUP

The temples of the Eastern Group are near a water-body, often dry, known as the Ninora Tal (also called the Khajuraho Sagar) that once irrigated the farms of the present Khajuraho Village. These temples are to the east of the Western Group and are the Vamana, Javari, Brahma and Ghantai; and the Jaina temples of Adinatha and Parsvanatha, in their own walled compound. Right at the end of the road is the Vamana Temple.

VAMANA TEMPLE

This temple is dedicated to the fifth incarnation of Vishnu: the dwarf Vamana. If the ten incarnations of the Preserver are taken to represent a pre-emption of the Theory of Evolution, then Vamana would represent the proto-human Pithecines. Judging from its style, this temple was built in 1050-75 continuing the architectural modes of the Kandariya. Curiously, there are very few erotic carvings here. There is a four-armed standing Vishnu on its lintel.

The Vamana Temple dedicated to the fifth incarnation of Lord Vishnu

Here, better than anywhere else, the visitor can see how the village of Khajuraho has been integrated with its temples. Just beyond the protecting walls of the grounds of the temple, farmers still tend to their fields as their ancestors did a thousand years ago.

A short distance down the road, towards the village, is the Javari Temple.

JAVARI TEMPLE

This is a little gem of a temple, built between 1075 and 1100. It has all the features of a larger, developed Khajuraho temple. It stands on a high plinth and has a delicate, soaring shikara or tower. Its beautifully sculpted makara torana arch is an excellent example of the skill of those old stone carvers. In fact the carvers who worked here showed their expertise again when they also placed such toranas as canopies over the niches housing sculptures of the many godsof the Hindu pantheon. Look for them in the lower row of the jangha, literally the thigh, the central portion of the temple.

In the village, and to the right of the road, stands the rather forlorn Brahma Temple.

BRAHMA TEMPLE

Being in such an easily accessible public place, the temple is often locked. And it has been wrongly called a Brahma Temple because the four-faced linga in its sanctum was mistaken for the four-faced idol of the Creator, Brahma. Though the linga would indicate that it is a Siva temple this could not have been its original dedication. There is an image of Vishnu, the Preserver, carved on the lintel of the doorway of the sanctum. Shrines all over the world change their character as their protectors shift from one faith to another. And this

Brahma Temple

temple could have been subjected to such changes of belief for many centuries. It was probably built in about AD 900 when the magnificent Varaha was being carved and placed facing the Lakshmana Temple in the Western Group.

Also rendered humanly inaccessible by the protective ASI because it would otherwise been too accessible to vandals, is that beautiful shell of a once great shrine, the Ghantai Temple.

GHANTAI TEMPLE

Ghantai, which means 'bell', is the local name for these ruins because of the carvings of bells on its slim pillars. All that stands, now - behind a vandal-excluding fence is the remains of the entrance porch and its maha-mandap or assembly hall. The carvings inscribed on the main beam, on top of the door are the sixteen auspicious signs seen in a dream by Lord Mahavira's mother. Devotees of the Jaina religion believe that Lord Mahavira

was the last Tirthankar, or liberated spiritual guide, to walk the earth. (See Box: The Jains) There is, therefore, every reason to believe that this was a Jaina temple and it was probably larger than the one that lies ahead, the Parsvanatha Temple.

PARSVANATHA TEMPLE

This stands in a cul-de-sac ending in a walled enclosure surrounding two ancient Jaina temples and some living ones, Sellers of souvenirs, metal icons and bric-a-brac mass around the parking area in front of the complex. There is also an interesting book-shop, in the entrance porch, selling literature on the Jaina religion.

The Parsvanatha Temple is one of the two old temples and has been made of honey-coloured sandstone.

It was built about the same time as the Lakshmana, probably in 950-70, and is the larger of the unaltered Jaina temples: the others having been covered in white plaster. The absence of this plaster allows visitors to see that, in spite of being a Jaina temple, it holds many images related to the Vaishnava faith in which Lord Vishnu is the principal deity. It also holds some of the most graceful sura-sundari figures. On the south façade one celestial maiden is shown putting eye-liner, another puts make-up on her feet. On the north façade a sura-sundari attaches bells to her anklets.

All this is in marked contrast with the austere images installed in the two sanctums: one of polished black marble, the other of sandstone.

The other unaltered Jaina temple, and adjacent to the Parsvanatha, is the Adinatha Temple.

ADINATHA TEMPLE

It is smaller than the Parsvanatha and, in many ways resembles the Vamana. But, clearly, it shows a later development of the Vamana model. For one thing it is not as squat as the Vamana. For another, whereas the top row of the outer wall of the Vamana has diamonds in niches, here there is a band of flying celestials carrying garlands, playing musical instruments or brandishing weapons. The other two rows show gods, goddesses and mythical lions. It was probably built round about AD 1100, a little after the Vamana.

Of the original temple that once stood here, only the vestibule and the shikara tower above the sanctum have survived. The image installed in the sanctum is that of the first evolved spiritual leader of the Jainas, Adinatha.

Closest to the entrance to this complex is the living Santinatha Temple.

SANTINATHA TEMPLE

Though there is reason to believe that this temple was built in AD 102728, all that remains unaltered is the oblong enclosure of small shrines and displays of ancient sculptures the most striking of which are the twin seated sculptures of the parents of an evolved spiritual guide.

It would be convenient now to head due south for the third lot of temples, the Southern Group.

SOUTHERN GROUP

Here there are just two conserved temples: the Duladeo and the Chaturbhuja.

These are among the last temples to be built by the sculptors of Khajuraho and there are many experts who believe that when these were being built and carved, the artistic dynamism of Khajuraho was dying down. But, as in all matters of art, the opinion of experts is always open to question as beauty lies in the eye of the beholder.

Chronologically, the last temple to be built in the Khajuraho style is the first one to be encountered on this southern road. It is the Duladeo Temple.

DULADEO TEMPLE

The most impressive features of this temple are the flying celestials on the uppermost row of the shikara tower. Their movements have been excellently captured as they soar through the sky. The jewellery on its female figures has

Duladeo Temple

been carved with great intricacy. This temple was probably built between 1100 and 1150.

About this time too, though perhaps a shade earlier, the masons of Khajuraho built the Chaturbhuja Temple.

CHATURBHUJA TEMPLE

It stands all by itself at the end of the road. It is the only temple in Khajuraho that does not have a single erotic sculpture. Possibly, by that late date, the driving impetus imparted by the zestful worship of the Mother Goddesses of the Chausath Yogini temple, was dying down. And with its decline, the creative urge also diminished. The images seem to be stereotyped as if they were being routinely replicated rather than the result of original inspiration. At the entrance are the well-known figures of Ganga and Jamuna.

But, in spite of all this, there is one brilliant burst of creativity. The 2.7 metre-high, standing image of Vishnu is so vibrant that it is almost seems as if the Preserver is about to step out and greet his devotees. We got the distinct impression that when the image's face is viewed from three different angles it takes on three distinctly different expressions.

The Chaturbhuja Temple is an unusual south-facing one.

Very unusually, this is a south-facing image, best seen at sunset when the dying sun lances in and illuminates the statue in an orange glow. This is when the visitor feels that the world's most liberal civilization is not dead: it is only sleeping.

This feeling is reinforced by the exhibits of the Tribal and Folk Art Museum.

TRIBAL AND FOLK ART MUSEUM

There is something exquisitely unsophisticated, or supremely sophisticated, about the artistic expressions of the Tribal people of Madhya Pradesh. And the tribal museum captures it in all its extraordinary vitality. Picasso and Brancusi, and Paul Klee all tried to draw on the wellsprings of their inspiration with varying degrees of success. Here, in the Tribal and Folk Art Museum, however, are expressions of the very origins of human art.

In the lobby is a single roomed hut with a tiled roof. Pottery birds and walls painted with finger designs brighten this simple dwelling. Then there is a metal tree of life known as the Karma Tree. Terracotta horses and elephants stand under two dimensional paintings capturing the rhythm of village life. Simple household equipment become objects of great ingenuity. We filled a ball-like terracotta lamp with oil, lit its wick, and then swung it as villagers do when they walk down their dark paths at night. The flame remained alight and not a drop of oil spilled out.

A millennium ago, when these tribal artists and artisans met the outside world, something incredible happened. The wonder of Khajuraho was born. Local masons drawing on their own inspiration and using local materials created the miracles of this ancient temple-town.

THE JAINS

The followers of this determinedly non-violent religion believe in the sanctity of all life. They are strict vegetarians, will not eat after dark for fear of inadver- tently ingesting insects. Their monks and nuns wear muslin mouth-and-nose masks for the same reason, and sweep the path before them to brush little creatures out of harm's way.

Jains are divided into two principal sects: the Digambara, whose spiritually advanced male ascetics wear no clothes, and the Svetmbara whose evolved renunciates wear scanty, unstitched, white garments.

Jains refute the commonly held belief that they are an offshoot of either Hinduism or Buddhism. They claim that their faith is older than these two religions and was the religion of the ancient Indus Valley people. Jains do not believe in a Creator god but in a divinity that includes all the spiritually advanced souls who have shed all attachments and are 'conquerors of self or Jinas. Only human souls can rise to this level. Those advanced souls who have deliberately deferred their ascension to divinity in order to help mankind are the Tirthankars, the spiritual guides who help humans to ford the river of existence.

According to Jain teachings, since the dawn of mankind, there have been 24 Tirthankars. The last Tirthankar was Mahavira who was a contemporary of the Buddha in the 6th century BC.

WATERFALLS

There are two attractive waterfalls where rivers, cascading off escarpments, wind through natural amphitheatres and gorges like settings from a fantasy movie. They are great for unwinding picnics after tramping around monuments.

Rane. A half hour drive from Khajuraho, on a road that plunges through protected forests where wild animals live free, in the Ken Gharial Sanctuary, is a Visitors' Centre. From here a stepped and tiled path leads down to broad viewing platforms. Here, visitors stand at the edge of a gorge cut by the Ken River, flowing jade green, through tow- ering cliffs of grey and rose, black, magenta, pink and pale blue.

Cliffs like these were quarried by hand,
hefted, carried on creaking bullocks carts, and placed before the masons of Khajuraho. Slowly, wondrously, the temples began to grow...

Pandav Thirty two kilometres away from Khajuraho there is a natural bow! scooped out of the wooded mountains by an ancient land subsidence, smoothed by a river that plunges down one side of it. The cliffs around this amphitheatre hold a number of caves that are the occasional homes of wild creatures and anchorite religious mendicants with saffron robes and matted hair

With a little bit of determination, and a fair sense of balance, one can clamber down to the cool, green-and-silver bottom of the bowl... It is a wonderful way to get lost to the world.

EXPLORER'S MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF KHAJURAHO

AJAYGARH

Eighty kilometres out of Khajuraho, along the highway to Panna, and then through village roads, the explorer reaches the small town of Ajaygarh. The vehicle has to be parked here and there is a fairly strenuous trek ahead. This leads through a gap between a line of shops to a short, black-topped, road stretching between houses for a little more than 30 metres. A wooded hill rises ahead with the fortress wall snaking on top, far above. The goal on this excursion lies beyond that distant wall. This is when the explorer must decide either to press on, or to turn back.

If the decision is to forge ahead, there will first be a rough track cut through the sub-montane terrain for about three metres. After that the stone steps begin, winding sinuously up the scrub. You have to trudge up 456 of them before you come to the first tall gateway of the old fort. Pause here because this is only the beginning of your trek and there's a fair amount of climbing ahead of you

The view from here is interesting but not spectacular. You are not likely to see much wild-life, perhaps an inquisitive mongoose at best. But if you're a birder, do carry a pair of small binoculars: the sightings might be worth while.

If you are an ordinary trekker who wants to get in a little exercise in the great outdoors and you are not an aspiring decathlon champion you should have got your second wind and be eager to carry on. You still have another 170 steps

The Ajaygarh Fort

The Rang Mahal in the mountain fort of The Chandellas

to climb before you cross into the inner wall of the fort's defences. Do be especially careful because these are the old steps the then earlier ones had been renovated. And though the treads of these steps are broader than the new ones, they are worn, cracked and broken in places.

You can't afford to stumble and slip here: you're not likely to have any Search and Rescue teams land in a helicopter and whisk you away with paramedics in attendance! You should pause and look at the way the walls have been constructed with large. dressed, stones and no visible mortar.

Leaving the wall on your right you walk through a second gate, and pause. On your right, carved out of the living rock, is a most unusual flying Ganesh, bearing a snake aloft and carrying an axe. This normally be- nign deity had clearly been installed here as a guardian to ensure that anyone who crossed his path had the best of intentions - or else!

There are more carvings on the rocks at the side of the steps before you reach the main gate of the fort. The gate might be locked but there is likely to be a panel missing giving access through it as if it was a wicket gate! You are now in the fort: overgrown with trees and shrubs and a path winding through them. Follow this path to give you an eagle's eyes view of the town massed in the valley, far below.

If you continue on this path you will come to a plateau reasonably clear of trees and start descending a bit. Finally, in a clearing, you will come across two carved temples known as the Rang Mahal. One of the temples has the remnants of a stone tower, or shikara. The other one has standing pillars but is unroofed. Look for carvings inside the first one and on the outside of the second. They have been finely cut and look almost like engravings. There is a third temple but, in its present state, it looks as if enormous children had been playing with building blocks and abandoned them when their attention was diverted!

This fort was built by the Chandellas who were also responsible for creating the superbly embellished temples of Khajuraho.

Accommodation in Khajuraho

MPT Payal

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Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant | Wifi | Conference Hall

Swimming Pool

Soak in the mesmerizing wonders of Khajuraho while staying in the classy MPT Payal. Ideally located - very close to the Western group of Temples, MPT Payal is a popular MICE hotel with 25 AC rooms & conference facility, swimming pool. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

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Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant | Wifi | Conference Hall

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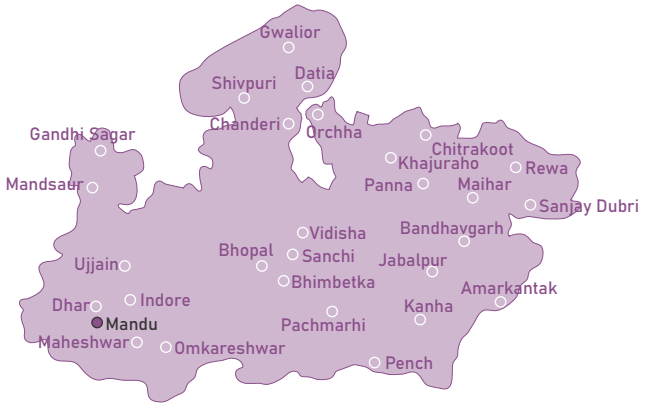
Your host in the World Heritage Site Khajuraho, MPT Jhankar of 'MPT Hotels & Resorts' is a leisure cum business hotel. The spacious layout, remarkable hospitality and best food in the town, makes it like no other. The clean ambience and its location make it the best choice of the town. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

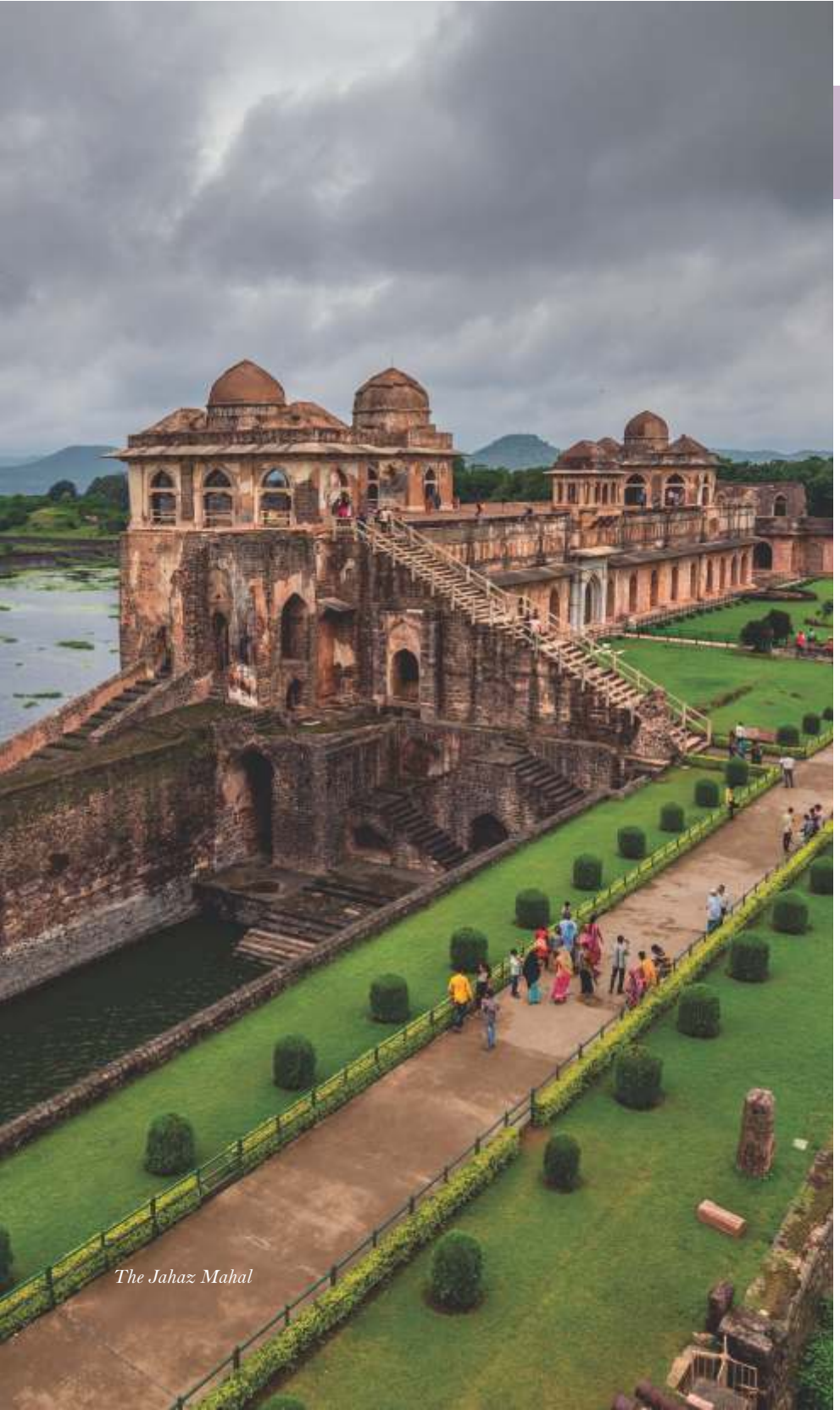
Mandu

The Afghans built themselves a pleasure-fortress atop the rugged plateau of Mandu.



Their ancestors had stormed down from the high and dusty mountains of Afghanistan, in the 12th century, and conquered much of northern India. Three hundred years later, possibly in Mandu, they had intermar- ried with Turko-Afghans. (See Box-the Ghori-Khaljis). The striking monuments of Mandu consequently combine the virile assertion of the Afghan mode with the great cultural heritage of the Turkish people. Like most eclectic creations, that borrow the best from two cultures, Mandu is uniquely impressive.

The formidable natural moat



The Jahaz Mahal

THE GHORI-KHALJIS

Mohammad of Ghor was a 12th century Afghan invader who established the powerful Ghorn dynasty in India. His descendant, Dilawar Khan Ghort, was appointed governor under the Turko-In- dian Tughlak dynasty. Dilawar's province included Mandu. In 1401, he set himself up as an independent ruler of the area under the regal title of Sultan Shihabud-Din Ghori. He died in 1406, probably poisoned by his eldest son, who ascended the throne as Hoshang Shah. He ruled for 29 years and was succeeded, in 1435, by his eldest son, Mohammad Shah. Historians believe that he was a worthless debauchee and was poisoned by his brother-in-law, Mahmud Khan Khalji who set up the Khalji dynasty of Malwa in 1436.

Poison seemed to play a significant role in the royal successions in Mandu. Ghi- yathud-Din Khalji was probably poisoned by his son Nasirud-Din Khalji who, in 1510; was also poisoned. He was succeeded by the last Khalji ruler of Mandu, Mahmud Shah Khalji II who was executed by the invading king of Gujarat in 1531.

The impression begins as visitors start driving, through the small villages and scrubby sub-montane lands, on the rising road to Mandu. On both sides of the road, overgrown by bushes and strangler figs, are domed structures. These were the guard-and-staging posts of the armies of Mandu. Though not all of them survive, it is believed that they were placed at multiples of 55 metres apart depending on the terrain. Up in Mandu, there is one of these domed structures between Echo Point and Reva Kund.

There is another domed monu- ment, visible from the road. A board identifies it as Jali Mahal but says nothing more about it. There is a second Jali Mahal in Mandu that resembles this one. According to the Archaeological Survey of India's Guide, "It is square in plan with three arched openings on each side...it is really a tomb of some noble." This Jali Mahal probably served the same purpose. There were many noblemen in the court at Mandu.

After leaving the lower Jali Mahal, the visitor gets a first glimpse of the

One of Mandu's strategic gates

formidable natural and man-made Defences of Mandu.

DEFENCES OF MANDU

The great encircling walls of the plateau, that now begin to appear, seem to be a secondary defence. The first is the deep irregular ravine of the Kakra Khoh entwining around the fortress on the west, north and east with a slim tongue projecting deep into the plateau from the east. It is, virtually, a natural moat. On the rim of this ravine are the walls winding around for about 45 kms. They have 12 imposing gates. The road passes through the Alamgir and Bhangi Darwazas. Both are bastions built at an angle and against the line of the wall to allow the defenders of Mandu to wreak havoc on the attackers massed below. As an additional precaution, the military engineers had sacrificed a man so that his restless spirit would haunt the enemy. To this day, offerings of flowers are laid on the memorial to this unfortunate victim to ensure that his soul rests in peace. This gate pre-dates the occupation of Mandu by the Ghoris.

In fact, because of its strong defensive topography, Mandu has been occupied, off and on, since the sixth century AD. At that time it was known as Mandapa-Durga. This could be interpreted as the Pavilion of the powerful Hindu Mother Goddess, Durga. Its Islamic rulers renamed it as Shadiabad, the City of Joy, in the 14th century.

Today, it is not a city; it is not even a town. It can be best called The Village of Mandu.

THE VILLAGE OF MANDU

Roads meander past huts, open-fronted shops, and spreading fields. Vendors push their carts laden with vegetables and fruit including the unusual fruit of the bizarre baobab tree (See Box - The Upside-down Tree) Children drive plodding herds of cattle and a resplendently- dressed band blares strident music to proclaim the procession of an equestrian groom on his way to his bride's house. A very ordinary Indian village scene in a very ordinary Indian village.

But what is so extraordinary about this village are the magnificent monuments that rise above the winding roads. Mandu's past glitters in incongruous splendour like diadems on a farm boy. And the most magnificent of these monuments is the Jami Masjid.

Aerial View of Mandu

JAMI MASJID

There is an austere simplicity about this enormous structure. It stands on a 4.6 m high plinth accessed by an impressive flight of steps. The whole mosque covers an area of 97.4 sq m and its porch, atop the flight of steps, is dominated by a 16.8 m dome. As demanded by congregational religions, beyond the porch is the great open court surrounded by arched colonnades. On the far side of the court is the Prayer Hall with its pulpit atop a flight of steps, and arches extending away to the right and left. The blue in the panels, still glittering after all these centuries, are inlays of the semi-precious stone lapis lazuli. Do devote a little time to the construction of the ceiling crowned by three large domes and fifty eight smaller ones.

Muslims pray facing Mecca, and the direction of that holy city is indicated by a recessed panel called a mihrab. The seventeen mihrabs here, to cater to large numbers of the faithful, are the most decorated features in this huge mosque. White stone, chiselled with the delicacy of metal filigree, stands out against their polished black backgrounds.

While there is no official explanation for the presence of the fifty-eight small domes along with the three large ones, it seems fairly obvious why they were installed. Long before Thomas Alva Edison invented the microphone in 1877, Mandu's architects had designed the domes as sound amplifying devices to carry the words of the, often feeble and old, preacher to the entire congregation. The Jami Masjid, said to have been patterned on the great mosque in Damascus, was started by Hoshang Shah and completed by Mahmud Khalji in 1454.

Mahmud Khalji was Mandu's ruler in the middle years of the 15th century He was the son-in-law of the great Hoshang Shah who ruled in the early 1400's. Adjacent to the Jami Masjid is Hoshang Shah's Tomb.

HOSHANG SHAH'S TOMB

The magnificent white mausoleum can generally be reached from the road that passes to one side of it. Visitors entering the grounds from the road have to walk around to the door of the tomb, on the other side. The square tomb, rising on its plinth, is crowned by a large dome with small cupolas at the corners. There is a certain eclectic harmony about this monument. The corridors encircling the grounds have red sandstone pillars with brackets in Hindu architectural style: the artisans were, clearly, given a free hand to carve them in the manner that they were most familiar with. The round Afghan dome, as distinct from the onion-shaped Mughal dome, is surmounted by a crescent which, according to the Archaeological Survey of India, is a feature which seems to have been imported to Mandu direct from Mesopotamia or Persia.

Hoshang Shah's tomb lies inside the mausoleum along with other tombs believed to be those of his wife, three sons and a daughter. The tombs of the men are identified by a carving of an inkpot and a reed pen; those of the women have only an inkpot.

There is an interesting inscription on the right jamb of the door. It says that the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan sent four of his architects, led by Ustad Hamid, to visit Hoshang Shah's tomb in 1659. Shjah Jahan was, at that time, deeply involved in creating the Taj Mahal in Agra in memory of his beloved wife, Mumtaz Mahal. Local scholars believe that, till the Tomb of Hoshang Shah was built, Islamic tombs were made of sandstone. This was the first to be made of marble. The Taj Mahal followed.

The mosque and the mausoleum convey only two aspects of the charac- ter of Mandu when the Afghans ruled. In these two monuments there is cer- tainly

DISCOVERING MADHYA PRADESH

The enormous Jami Masjid

Hoshang Shah's Tomb:
pre-empting The Taj Mahal?

no aspect of the light-heartedness that should be associated with a 'City of Joy'. It would appear that up to the reign of Mahmud Shah Khalji 1, Mandu was very much like London during the reign of the Germanic George II: unsmiling, self-righteous and with a disciplined military mindset. In contrast, Mahmud Shah's son, Ghiyathud-Din Khalji, was a fun-loving hedonist. His monuments reveal his outgoing and pleasure-loving nature.

After leaving the tomb of Hoshang Shah, and driving left down the road, the visitor will come to the gate of the Palace Complex, and its ticket booth, giving entry to a number of interesting buildings. The first of them is the Jahaz Mahal.

JAHAZ MAHAL

Although this is called the Ship Palace, it bears as much resemblance to a water craft as a rhinoceros did to the mythical unicorn: though the legendary one-horned horse was inspired by travellers' tales of the Indian Rhino. But then the Afghans were never known for their sea-faring skills. They probably gave their pleasure palace its fanciful name because ships conjure up images of uninhibited fun away from the prying eyes of the mainlanders! The fact that the Jahaz Mahal had two large lakes on either side of it, added to the Afghans' illusion that it resembled a ship.

It is clear that this palace, in spite of its size, was never meant to be lived in, lts ground floor has three large halls with corridors in between, and narrow rooms at the far ends. From the halls pavilions project over the Munj tank. These halls were lounges and the pavilions were places for people to enjoy the cool breeze that blew off the lake. The narrow rooms at the far ends were changing rooms for those who wanted to swim in the pillared pool at the northern end.

The terrace above was for festive parties, with superb views of the lake in front. It, too, had a smaller swimming pool at one end and pavilions for more intimate conversations. In fact, years later, the Mughal Emperor Jehangir describes just such a party hosted by his beautiful wife Noor Jehan at which a great entertainment took place and the drunkards indulged themselves to excess.

Such mass revels were necessary, Ghiyathud-Din, the creator of the Jahaz Mahal, had to find ways to keep his dependants occupied. According to the ASI.

It is said he had at one time 15,000 women of various classes and professions in his seraglio. Five hundred beautiful and young Turkish females in men's clothes and an equal number of Abyssinian females, all in uniform and armed, used to stand as guards to his right and left sides respectively.

Ghiyathud-Din's extravagant lifestyle, during his early years, seems to have palled on him as he grew older. This is apparent from the design of the Hindola Mahal.

HINDOLA MAHAL

This audience hall has sloping walls that resemble the trestles of a swing 'hindola' means swing. For all its massive bulk it is aesthetically austere as a monastic shrine with soaring windows filled with stone grilles. The external pillars aligned with the sloping walls are buttresses to counteract the thrust of the arches that once supported the high roof. Only the arches now remain to show where the roof once covered the great hall. In spite of Ghiyathud-Din's apparent change of lifestyle, he could not abandon the women of his court. They wouldn't know where to go to if he died. The transverse projection to the far end of the hall seems to have been meant to provide safe access to the hall for

The arched interior of the Hindola Mahal

the king and his women: a flight of sloping stages allowed women to be carried up in palanquins, or to ride up on horses and elephants.

Most of the women lived with the Sultans, the rulers, in a complex of buildings a little away from the Hindola Mahal. These are now ruins standing on the right bank of the lake as seen from the Jahaz Mahal. Visitors should tread with care when exploring these buildings because many of them are subterranean and at lake level. Their passages have been ingeniously aligned to trap cool winds blowing off the lake and into a step-well, or baoli. It is called the Champa Baoli because its water was said to have had the fragrance of the Champak, or Magnolia, flower. It seems to have lost its perfume with the decline of Mandu. Such wells, and the labyrinths of rooms and passages leading off them, were designed to provide cool, slightly damp, retreats from the hot, dry winds of summer. There is also a hamam, or bath-house, in this living complex. It has apertures like stars cut into its ceiling.

Beyond this living area, and at right angles to it, so that it faces the Jahaz Mahal across the lake, is the Jal Mahal.

JAL MAHAL

This water palace has two halls with vaulted ceilings and seems to have been meant for the use of its rulers. Its marble walls, with medallions of blue and yellow with inscriptions, give it a certain regal air. But though it has not been dated it is likely that it was constructed after the Khalji era. It was probably built to offer a private escape for royal couples. Walking out of the Palace Complex, along the road that stretches between
the Jahaz Mahal on the right and the Kapoor Tank on the left, pause to lo across, past the lone, spreading tree on your left, before you get to the tank. The in the middle ground, are the ruins of a building controversially referred to as Gada Shah's Shop and House.

GADA SHAH'S SHOP AND HOUSE

One story has it that Gada Shah was a trader who got extremely rich dealin in saffron and musk. He acquired so much authority that he demanded, and w

given permission, to build his shop and house in the royal precinct. He was al- allowed to enter by the Royal Gate. If this is true, then he is likely to have acquire his powerful status by lending money to a spendthrift monarch and demandir privileges in return for writing off the ruler's debts.

The other tale is based on an interpretation of the name Gada Shah: literall 'Beggar Master'. During the reign of Mahmud Shah Khalji II, the Rajput chie Medini Ray, is said to have entered the service of the Sultan as a servant. Befor long, however, he had become the unofficial ruler of the kingdom. This seems to be a more likely explanation than the trader tale.

On the way out to the gate of the Palace Complex, stop over at the ASI Museum.

ASI MUSEUM

It has some interesting exhibits found in Mandu. Most of them are Hindu sculptures of the 11th and 12th century but there is also a large statue of a Jaina Tirthankar. About 10% of the exhibits are devoted to Islamic calligraphy: Islamic tradition forbids the depiction of humans.

On the way back, towards the Jami Masjid, from where this section of the tour had started, stop in front of the great Mosque. Facing the mosque, across the road, is a ruined structure atop a high flight of steps. This is the Madrasa or Ashrafi Mahal.

MADRASA OR ASHRAFI MAHAL

This is all that remains of two ambitious projects that came to naught. It was first planned as a college attached to the great mosque that it faces and was, like the Jami Masjid, built around a huge courtyard surrounded by arcades giving access to small cells for the students. It was planned by Hoshang Shah and completed by Mahmud Khalji 1.

Shortly after it was completed, however, Mahmud Khalji had a change of heart. He filled up the courtyard to provide a platform for his tomb in the centre of a grand mausoleum which would have rivalled the great mosque. In addition, he raised a seven-storey tower to commemorate his victory in a battle against the Rana of Mewar. Ironically, the Rana also raised a great tower in honour of his victory over the Sultan in the same battle. Together, the mausoleum and the Victory Tower of the Sultan would have been the most magnificent buildings in Mandu. But, a few generations after the Sultan had indulged himself in these

The Madarsa or Ashrafi Mahal

Champa Baoli & Hamam

ostentatious works, they collapsed.

Later, legend has it that Ghiyathud-Din, who did not like stout women, forced his 15,000 ladies to run up and down those steps taking each step in a single stride. Decades after that mass exercise, when the Mughal Emperor Jehangir was in Mandu, he often climbed to the top to enjoy that elevated view. But his beautiful wife, Noor Jehan, did not like the trudge up. To encourage her to follow him, he placed a gold coin on each step as an incentive. It worked; and then she distributed the coins to the poor. This, however, seems an unlikely tale. Noor Jehan could have had all the gold coins she wanted for the asking: the Emperor and his wife were very much in love. Besides, what was the point of pick- ing up the coins and then giving them to charity? It seems sad, though, that this impressive flight of steps was eventually used as a treadmill for corpulent females!

Continuing down the road which ends in Rupamati's Palace, visitors come to Darya Khan's Group of Monuments.

DARYA KHAN'S GROUP OF MONUMENTS

These are a little off the road, to the left. All that we know of Darya Khan is that he was an officer in the court of Sultan Mahmud II who ruled from 1519 to 1526. The monuments have been spaced around a large tank now called the Somvati Kund.

Before the visitor reaches the steps leading down to the masonry tank, there is an interesting ruined mosque to the left. It does not have a descriptive board to identify it but its builders had, clearly, used materials from Hindu monuments when constructing it. Its three domes have a rather haphazard look about them as if they were added as an after-thought.

On the other side of the tank there is a large, squat, sandstone tomb and to the left of the tank there is a smaller domed structure. Both have been identified as Darya Khan's tomb. Since he could not have been buried at two places, the smaller mausoleum probably refers to a relative, perhaps a younger brother.

Some distance to the right of the tank, opposite the smaller domed structure, is a ruined caravanserai, an inn for caravans. This is an interesting relic of a bygone age but as there is a much better preserved caravanserai in Mandu, there is no need to spend much time in this one.

There is a strange replication of themes between the Darya Khan's group of monuments and those of the Sagar Talao Group.

SAGAR TALAO GROUP

Here, too, the monuments are near a tank, in this case the Sagar Talao, though they are separated from it by a road. And here, too, the mosque has been constructed out of material taken from Hindu structures.

The principal monument in this group is Malik Mughith's Mosque built by the father of the man who became the first Khalji ruler of Mandu, Mahmud Shah Khalji I. When this mosque was built, in 1432, Hoshang Shah still sat on the throne and the virile Afghan architecture of the plateau had not matured Many of the buildings of the pre-Islamic Hindu era lay in ruins after repeated onslaughts on the fort. In the early years of the Islamic period of Mandu, therefore, builders made extensive use of the remnants of earlier buildings lying abandoned and scattered. Consequently, this large mosque has many features associated with Hindu architecture particularly in its carved pillars. If time permits, this monument is worth pottering around, particularly to spot the eclectic fusion of Hindu and Islamic motifs. In particular, the structure of the unusual porch does not conform to orthodox mosque design and is more like the vestibule of a temple. The mihrabs, or prayer niches, in the western wall, however, are typically Islamic.

Opposite the mosque is a fascinating Caravansarai.

CARAVANSARAI

This is a specific, purpose-built structure unique to the age of caravans Not many of them have survived the onrush of progress, for when the caravans were ousted by the railways, the caravanserais fell quickly into disuse. No other monument, however, better captures the slow, plodding romance of that distant age than such transporters' hostelries. (See Box - Caravanserais).

A road between these two monuments leads to a building with the very unusual name of Dai ki Chhoti Bahen ka Mahal.

DAI KI CHHOTI BAHEN KA MAHAL

This is, literally, The-Mansion-of-the-Younger-Sister-of-the-Wet-Nurse. Presumably her sister had suckled a Very Important Baby or else she wouldn't have been entitled to a mansion! No one, however, knows who that hungry baby was but outsourcing nursing was a common occurrence among VIP mothers who either wanted to regain their figures after childbirth or did not produce enough milk to satisfy her baby's appetite.

This monument is really a mausoleum, as is another near it called the Dai ka Mahal.

DAI KA MAHAL

Some architects believe that both these mausoleums could once have been

CARAVANSERAIS

The presence of caravanserais in Mandu testify to its old association with West Asia aka 'the Middle East'. The word 'caravan' is the European version of the Persian word 'karvan'. It describes a group of traders, pilgrims or travellers journeying together for mutual protection in an age when lawlessness and brigand age prevailed in the regions between the great walled and fortified cities.

Caravanserais were buildings for sheltering caravans. They were large, quadrangular structures enclosed with a massive wall with small windows and air-holes. They usually had only one entrance protected by a strong gate, high enough to admit laden camels, and with rooms in the gate-house for the guards.

The central court was spacious enough to accommodate a large number of camels and other pack animals, and was open to the sky. In the heart of the court was a fountain with a basin to water the animals and provide for the domestic needs of the caravanners.

In the caravanserais of Mandu there are both storerooms for goods and living quarters of various sizes on the ground floor, built against the walls and facing inwards. Food was not provided by the owners of the caravanserais, but it could be cooked in the corners of the quadrangle.

Unlike the traditional caravanserais in West Asia, there was no accommodation on the first floor though, in the hot weather, people probably slept on the terrace above the rooms and under the stars.

Caravanserais were not the equivalent of the Coaching Inns of medieval England and Europe. The inns also pro- vided food and drink along with shelter Such establishments in West Asia were known as Khans.

mansions for the wet-nurse and her sister. There are traces of a formal Mughal garden nearby and the remains of an attractive mosque. The strong Hindu elements in the architecture of these two monuments, such as the balustrades and the elephant-tusk brackets, along with the elongated neck of the dome, suggest that these two nurses could have come from further south, possibly Hyderabad. Alternatively, these architectural features might have reflected a personal preference without pointing to a regional origin.

Returning to the road that leads to the southern edge of the escarpment, pause when you come to a sign reading Echo Point.

ECHO POINT

This place seems to be popular with both drivers and guides and so they will probably stop there even if you do not ask them to. Step out and look slightly to the left, and shout. A single echo will return. Turn a little to the right and shout again. You will be rewarded by two echoes. Your voice has bounced off monuments across a little ravine. You can now move on to encounter one of the more romantic legends of Mandu at the Rewa Kund Group.

REWA KUND GROUP

The Rewa Kund tank, with masonry steps leading down to the water, was probably used as a swimming pool, at one time, with changing rooms and lounges which have been altered over the years. It once also supplied water to the monument now known as Baz Bahadur's Palace.

The Rewa Kund

BAZ BAHADUR'S PALACE

The entrance to this double-storeyed palace has tall, slim arches on the left. Atop these once ran an aqueduct, carrying water lifted by animal-powered Persian wheels from Rewa Kund to the pool that is virtually a courtyard of the palace. Other courts lined with colonnades serving airy rooms make this monument an elegant and cool place even today when it is no longer filled with the nobles, their ladies, and their soft-footed servants waving peacock fans and spraying rose-water. It was built by Sultan Nasirud-Din Khalji in 1508-9.

In a short span of 50 years, Mandu changed hands a number of times from the Khaljis, to the rulers of Gujarat, to the Mughals, to Sher Shah Suri an

The Baz Bahadur Palace

Afghan warrior, to the governor appointed by Sher Shah, Shujaat Khan, to his son Malik Bayazid who crowned himself as the ruler under the title of Sultan Baz Bahadur.

Baz Bahadur did not seem to have the qualities required of a ruler. When he was soundly defeated by the warrior queen of the tribal Gonds, Rani Durgavati, he said he would not fight any more and retreated to his palace to devote himself to music. He also found a soul-mate in the very talented, and loving, princess Roopmati.

A short distance away from Baz Bahadur's Palace is a building standing right at the edge of the 366 m escarpment falling to the Nimar Plains. It is called Roopmati's Pavilion.

ROOPMATI'S PAVILION

Clearly, however, it was not built as a pavilion but as a look-out post for sentries. Later, a number of additions were made including a large reservoir to store rainwater. On the terrace at the top of the building are pavilions that give a superb view over the valley. These are now associated with Roopmati, a beautiful princess of Sarangapur.

Legend has it that she came here every day to glimpse her beloved Narmada River as a glistening streak on the hori- zon. On the days that mist obscured the view, she would refuse to eat. Then, the story goes on to say, the goddess Narmada appeared to her and said that she had merged herself with the waters of the Rewa Kund so that Roopmati could see her even when mist clothed the horizon.

Roopmati's end was tragic. When Baz Bahadur was defeated, in a battle with the Mughal forces, he fled leaving Roopmati behind. She, however, remained faithful to him and rather than fall into the hands of the enemy, she committed suicide.

Leaving the sad tale of Roopmati, visitors should drive back along the road, leaving the Sagar Talao tank on the left, past Malik Mughith's Mosque, and turn right, off the main road, down a small lane between fields and a village to reach the Hathi Mahal.

The Roopmati's Pavilion

HATHI MAHAL

This is a massive building with enormously broad pillars that give it its name: the Elephant Palace. It is crowned by a huge dome. Judging from its design it seems to have been planned as a summer house or belvedere, a place designed to catch the slightest breeze and cool its occupants in the heat of the summer. It was then converted into a mausoleum, because it holds a tomb, a detached caravanserai, and a mosque nearby. No one seems to know who was buried in the tomb, who built this monument, or when.

Back on the main road, heading past Darya Khan's tomb on the right, there is a fork in the road. The left fork leads past another unidentified tomb and mosque and a barrack-like ruin, called Chor Kot, which could have been a prison. At the end of the road, down a flight of sixty-one steps is what is now known as the Nilakantha Palace.

NILAKANTHA PALACE

This beautiful princely residence was built in the 16th century by the governor of the fort, Shah Budagh Khan. It is a most unusual building set against a cutaway section of the hillside. The three sides, thrusting into the hill and facing the valley, have high walls, with Islamic arches and alcoves and little lamp niches. A lofty platform leads to a large room with an arched and open front. Water once gushed down an artificial cascade foaming like a white shawl or chhadar. It poured into a concrete pool and then flowed down the hillside into the valley. With its uninterrupted views of the valley, this grotto of a palace must have been a cool, green, serene escape all through the year.

Today it has been converted into a temple dedicated to Lord Siva of the Blue Throat, Nilakantha.

There are still, however, some inscriptions of verses from the time of the great Mughal Emperor, Akbar. One of them could be freely translated as:

In the balcony of Shirwan Shah
A dawn owl hooted a warning

The Nilkantha Palace

Revel in your Pomp and Glory now;
It will flee as the night pales to morning.
It could have been predicting the fate of the many monarchs of Mandu.

THE UPSIDE-DOWN TREE

The rocky landscape of Mandu is dot- ted with the bizarre looking Baobab trees (Adansonia digitata) They have bulbous trunks that could grow to a diameter of nine metres and a height of 18 metres. Their cu nous shapes have given rise to a legend. In its native Africa, they say that the Devil was enraged and uprooted all the original Bao- bab trees and planted them upside-down with their branches in the earth and their roots in the air.

Peddlers in Mandu sell the gourd-like fruit, after they have ripened in February.

They assure their customers that its pulp has the power of warding off thirst and this is why it was brought to Mandu by African slave traders. The slaves, apparently, had to trek for long distances across deserts and were given this fruit to sustain them. The pulp, when chewed, probably does induce salivation which gives the illusion of producing water.

It is also believed that coffins made of baobab wood preserve the interred corpses and prevent their decomposition. No one in Mandu has, apparently, put this to the test.

A vendor sells Baobab fruit

UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITE

GROUP OF MONUMENTS AT MANDU
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

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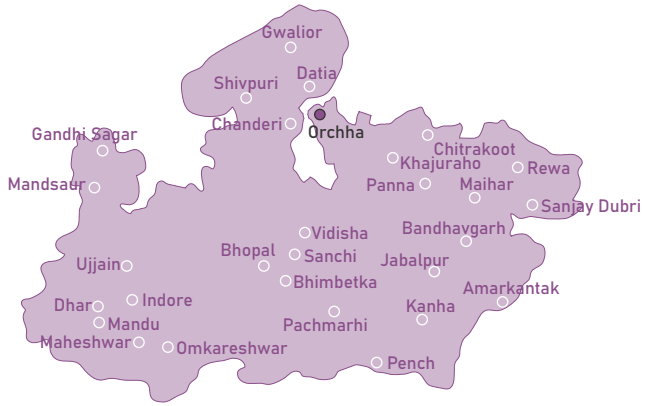
The Jehangir Mahal

Orchha

Orchha enthrals by its medieval mysteries and monuments.



This old walled town, in a scrub-dotted valley of the Betwa river, grew T in the swirling cross-currents of history. Back in 1539, a chief of the warrior clan of Bundela Rajputs (See Box - The Bundelas) made Orchha the capital of his domains. His name was Bharti Chand and many generations of his ancestors had, gradually, expanded their territories in this part of central India. At that time, much of India was ruled by the Mughals. The growing affluence of Orchha annoyed them and they marched against this prosperous town in 1577. Sadly, in the prolonged uncertainty that followed that invasion, the four surviving grandsons of Bharti Chand fought amongst

The Cenotaphs on the banks of Betwa River

themselves and plunged the state into chaos. The most devious of the brothers was Bir Singh Deo. By a blatant exercise of realpolitik, he became the king of Orchha in 1605 and held onto the throne for the next 22 years. In spite of his unscrupulous methods, he is recognised as the most famous ruler of Orchha. He was a great warrior, acquired considerable.

wealth and became an inspired builder. He was the person most responsible for creating The Bundela Style.

THE BUNDELA STYLE

Bir Singh Deo was, clearly, a visionary who did not hesitate to borrow from the best of many styles of architecture. Drawing from the simple structure of the village huts of the Bundel region, Bir Singh Deo added scalloped Mughal arches, domes from the Sultans of Delhi, delicate stone screens from the palaces of the Rajputs, the elongated spires of the Jains, and even the tall dastagir wind towers from Persia though it is possible that these were conceived by his father Madhukar Shah.

And yet this eclectic choice of styles has been blended together so harmoniously in the Bundela Style that even the British, of the very imperialistic early 20th century, borrowed from it. The 21st century's Madhukar Shah, a direct descendant of the 16th century ruler of the same name, told us that "Lutyens, the architect of New Delhi, used these palaces as his inspiration for his New Delhi buildings." The so-called 'Indo-Saracenic' style of the buildings of India's federal capital could as well have been called the 'Anglo-Bundela' style!

The archetypal buildings in the Bundela style rise in the citadel.

THE CITADEL

Bir Singh's grandfather, Rudra Pratap, started building the citadel on a riverine island, but it was his son, Bharti Chand, who completed it and shifted the capital to Orchha from Garh Kundar about 56 kms away. Its final shape was given by Madhukar Shah, Bir Singh's father.

To get to the island fort, visitors have to cross Bir Singh's Bridge.

BIR SINGH'S BRIDGE

This amazing triumph of engineering rises from a granite platform washed by the Betwa river. From the platform, narrow arches ascend to high parapets. The wide causeway that the bridge supports has been in use for 500 years. That really is quite remarkable when one realises that the oldest London Bridge in use, Blackfriars, was built more than 150 years after Bir Singh's Bridge.

The bridge leads to a gateway accessing a winding, rising road. It would have been very easy to repel attackers from here because not only would the slope of the road have slowed them down, but every turn would have given the defenders the opportunity to mow down invaders on both sides of the turn from a single defensive position. Moreover, the initial rise of the road is overseen by the Raj Mahal Palace.

RAJ MAHAL PALACE

This was Bir Singh Deo's main palace and is sometimes referred to as The Raja Mahal. It is a solid, square structure and, since it is built on a hillock, two wings have five storeys on three sides and four storeys on one side. The Halls of Private Audience and of Public Audience are imposing. To the right of the Hall of Private Audience are the bedrooms of four ranis. The rooms to the left were occupied by three more ranis. The king's chamber, in front, is on the same level as the sanctum of the Chatturbhuj temple, opposite, offering a private view of

The Raj Mahal

the idol enshrined within it. Look up when you enter the royal chambers. Their ceilings have been delicately painted. There are other paintings on the walls, some illustrating scenes from the epic Ramayana, others capturing the pomp and glory of the Bundela court. Do notice the system of natural lighting down angled shafts. These ensure privacy while allowing sunlight to illuminate the rooms. So, too, do the beautifully cut stone-work grilles.

The Raj Mahal acts as a sort of giant curtain, concealing the Jehangir Mahal.

Frescoes in the Rani's bedchamber in the Raj Mahal

JEHANGIR MAHAL

This massive palace was, apparently, built by Bir Singh Deo for the Mughal Emperor Jehangir though it is not certain if he ever stayed in it. It is, in every way, more powerful, more richly endowed with architectural embellishments, and far more beautiful than the Raj Mahal. Some architects believe that this is the epitome of Indo-Islamic architec- ture though it veers, in many ways, from the Islamic style. Its domes, for instance, have external ribs where- as the

THE BUNDELAS

Power vacuums are soon filled. In the second half of the 10th century there was such a vacuum and a new dynasty moved in: the Gahadvalas or Gaharwars (The Roman alphabet does not have a letter to represent a hard 'R' which is a cross between a 'D' and an 'R' and so it has to make do with 'R') They claimed to be members of the warrior clan of Suryavanshi Rajputs, descended from the Sun.

There are interesting stories to account for their sub-clan, the Bundelas. One of the princes of this family fell foul of his brothers for some unspecified offence. It could have been jealousy as in the Biblical tale of Joseph and his coat of many colours. The prince's name was Hamkaran and, in desperation, he sought the help of the pow- erful goddess Vindhyavasini. As a gift to the goddess, he offered five human heads, presumably decapitated in fights with those who had attacked him during his exile. The name 'Bundela' was, according to this story, derived from 'Vindhyela' 'Those Who Belong to Vindhya'

Shifting through the matrix of myth and legend, scholars believe that Sohanpal (1231-59) was the first historical member of this dynasty. The Rajput squires gathered around his banner and, with their help, he captured enough territory to give himself the title of Raja, or ruler. His third successor was Prithi Raj (130739), a man who was strong enough to discourage his feuding relatives from setting up their own little states and weld them into a single kingdom under his rule.

United, the Bundelas became a power to be reckoned with in the heart of India. But by 1501, when Rudra Pratap ascended to the gaddi of Bundelkhand- the throne of the Bundelas a power vacuum had begun to build up again. The Mughals were trying to establish their supremacy in northern India and the future of the land looked uncertain. The Mughal Emperor, Babur, decided to appoint Rudra Pratap as his viceroy thus putting his imperial seal of approval on the Bundela's rule! Clearly, however, the canny Rudra Pratap was not very happy with the smile on the face of Babur, the Tiger. In May 1531, he decided to build a fortified palace in the strategic location of Orchha But he did not live to rule from his new palace: before the year ended he tried to rescue a cow being attached by a tiger, and was killed by the ferocious carnivore.

Eight years later, his son and successor Bharti Chand moved the court of the Bundelas from Garh Kundar to Orchha.

Bharti Chand had no children. He was succeeded by his Brother Madhu- har Shah in 1554. Madhuhar was an extremely courageous man and he refused to accept the Mughal Emperor's demands for his Hindu subjects to abandon their religious emblems. Very wisely, Madhukar Shah gave territories to all his eight sons but when he was defeated and forced into exile in the mountains, where he died, his most famous son, Bir Singh, conspired with the Mughal Prince and, eventually, had Ram Shah... the ruler of Orchha and his own brother... moved to Chanderi.
Bir Singh became the ruler of Orchha.

His son Bhagwant Rao took over Datia in 1626 and, from then on, it became a separate state.

Bir Singh died in 1627 and was suc- ceeded by his son Jujhar Singh: a weak individual easily influenced by evil counsel and rumours. He had his virtuous young brother, Hardaul, poisoned because he was influenced to suspect his integrity.

Over the next 150 years, the fortunes of Orchha, and the Bundelas, waned. Bands of Marathas attached the state repeat- edly till, in 1783, Vikramjit Singh moved his capital to Tehri. Two years later he re-named it Tikamgarh because he was a devotee of Lord Krishna and Tikamjee is one of Krishna's names.

One hundred and sixty five years after moving to Tikamgarh, Maharaja Bir Singh Deo II merged his state with the independent Union of India. The year was 1948 and the Bundela dynasty had ruled their state for over seven hundred years.

The Courtyard of Jehangir Mahal

Islamic domes have internal ribs. Large open courts let in light and air and, at one time, virtually all the rooms had murals: only a few remain now. Many of the brackets show the wavy style of Jain architecture. Interestingly, however, the main door is on the east-facing side of the palace. It is high, wide, and impressive and is decorated with bright ceramic tiles. It would almost seem as if Bir Singh wanted his tribute to Jehangir to turn its back to the Raj Mahal built largely by his family. Many would say that Bir Singh had not adhered to the Rajput code of chivalry and honour in order to ingratiate himself with a powerful prince. Others would argue that since the Mughals were antagonists, if not open enemies of the Bundela Rajputs, anything that weakened the Mughal empire was an honourable strategy. Judge for yourself when you hear the legend of Bir Singh and Afzal Khan.

THE LEGEND OF BIR SINGH AND AFZAL KHAN

The great Mughal, Akbar, was estranged from his wayward heir- apparent, Prince Salim. The Crown Prince believed that behind this friction was his father's most trusted adviser, Afzal Khan. But if he dared to assassinate Afzal Khan himself most of the Empire would rise against him: or so he believed.

So, in a plot reminiscent of a Star Wars episode, he persuaded Bir Singh to do his dirty work. Bir Singh invited Afzal Khan to Orchha offering to negotiate a lasting end to their mutual suspicion. But when the unsuspecting emissary from the Mughal court came here, he was killed, beheaded, and his severed head was delivered to Prince Salim in a place called Kara-Manikpur. In spite of this black deed, however, the Emperor forgave his son and endorsed his succession to the throne. When Prince Salim became the Emperor Jehangir, he rewarded Bir Singh by removing his brother, Ram Shah, from the throne and sending him to Chanderi. Bir Singh was made the ruler of Orchha. This is why, historians reason, he built a palace to welcome his patron and emperor and called it, after him, Jehangir Mahal.

From the Jehangir Mahal there is an excellent view down a green slope to the tall, slim, camel stables, the heavy and broad elephant stables, and the hamam or bath-house. It is fairly easy to identify the hot-bath warmed by a furnace, the chill pool, the steam room and the massage platforms. Such facilities

originated in colder climates and were brought by the Mughals when they invaded India in the 16th century.

Between the Raj Mahal and the Jehangir Mahal is the Sheesh Mahal.

SHEESH MAHAL

It was built by the ruler Udait Singh in the 18th century as his personal rest house. It is a double-storeyed building, virtually an annexe of the Jehangir Mahal, full of stairways winding through the thick walls accessing curious little rooms, a couple of courts and a few large rooms. One of them had mirror chips in the ceiling and a strategically-placed, full-length, cheval mirror which, from the enormous double bed, gave uninterrupted views of the huge stone tub in the bathroom. Very sybaritic. It has been taken over by the MP Tourism Development Corporation and is run as a hotel and restaurant.

From here there are excellent views of the Rai Praveen Mahal.

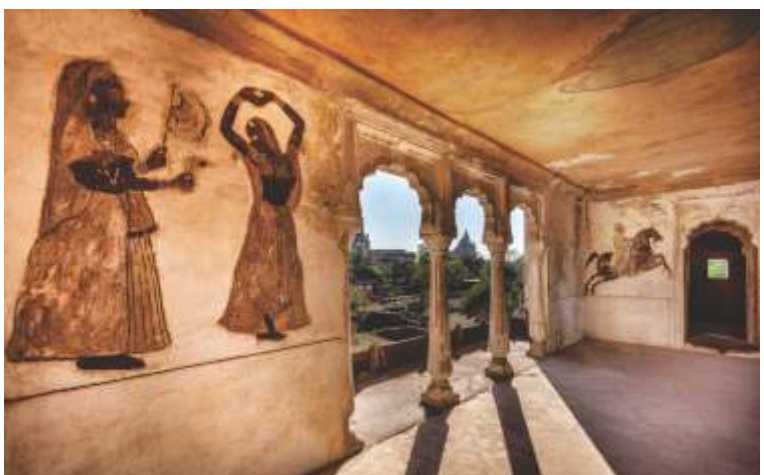
RAI PRAVEEN MAHAL

Rai Praveen was the favourite mistress of Raja Indramani (1672-75) when the Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb was on the throne. This elegant, double-storeyed, brick building seems to be more Mughal than Bundela. It has a main hall, terraces overlooking its formal gardens, little chambers, and is filled with light and air. Rai Praveen was a skilled dancer, singer, musician and a poetess who was associated with the great Hindi poet Keshav Dass.

It is interesting to visit the mansion of this remarkable woman and to imagine what it must have been like with oil-lamps flickering in the jasmine-scented darkness, stringed instruments playing softly, and the enchanted voice of Rai Praveen casting a loving spell around her king. We don't know if anyone has ever made a ballad about The Legend of Rai Praveen.

THE LEGEND OF RAI PRAVEEN

There is a mystery woven around her. Legend has it that stories of her beauty, and her other skills, came to the attention of the Emperor Aurangzeb. He sent a message to his vassal, Indramani, that he wanted Rai Praveen to join his harem in Delhi. Since a summons from the Emperor could not be refused, Rai Praveen went. There, however, she penned a poem to the Emperor. We have



Inside of Rai Praveen Mahal

translated it in our own words as:

Dogs and crows and the scavenging crew
Dine on the leavings of others
Tell me my Emperor, and tell me true,
Which of these three pariah creatures are you?

She returned triumphant to Orchha. In her jubilant entry into Orchha there is every likelihood that she stopped, on the other side of the bridge, and worshiped in the towering Chatturbhuj Temple.

CHATTURBHUJ TEMPLE

This curiously designed temple dominates the town of Orchha. It has a central smooth, not ribbed, dome much like that of a mosque. But it also has rising towers resembling the chhatris or cenotaphs of the Bundelas. Again, like a mosque, it has a court open to the sky: a feature required by a congregational religion like Islam, but then it also has a sanctum as in all temples. There are many other unusual features in this temple, pointed out by the experts of the School of Architecture and Planning of Delhi. They say:

The layout of the temple is peculiar in that it reflects a basilica in plan and the Antarala (the chamber in front of the shrine) and the Garbagriha (the sanctum) are of almost the same size. The Mahamandapa (large assem- bly hall) is not aligned with the Antrala. But is at right angles to it, equally divided on both sides. The absence of any carving or ornamentation, the loftiness of the ceilings, and the arrangement of its sanctuary are unusual features in a Hindu temple.

The most logical interpretation that can be put to these intriguing features is that Bir Singh Deo employed Muslim architects to design this temple dedicated to the four armed, Chatturbhuj, Vishnu. It stands on a high pedestal, is accessed by a flight of steps and gazes down on a vibrant market set on a terrace at its base. On it are vendors of colourful powders used in worship, metal icons, and refreshments for the weary pilgrim.

Down a flight of steps, from this terrace, and left through a gate, brings visitors to the large, open, court in front of the next unusual temple in Orchha: The Ram Raja Temple.

The Chaturbhuj Temple

The Ram Raja Temple, once a Palace

THE RAM RAJA TEMPLE

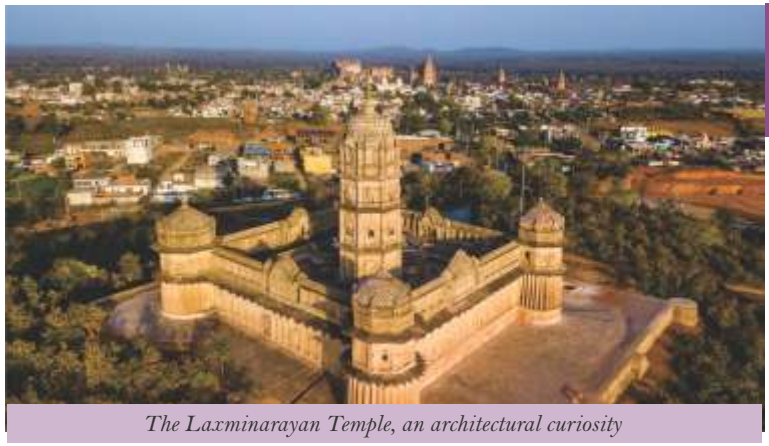
This was built by Madhukar Shah in the 16th century, as a Palace for his principal Queen. Legend has it that she went to a distant place and brought back a sacred idol of Lord Ram, the seventh incarnation of the Preserver, with the intention of installing it in the Chatturbhuj Temple. But the temple was not ready to receive the idol so she kept it in her palace. However, when the time came to install it in the temple, it refused to budge and no force could get it to move. So it was left here, the palace became a temple, and Lord Ram is worshipped as a king enthroned in the palace of his choosing. He wears the turban of royalty. His queen, Sita wears a crown, and his loyal brother Lakshman is dressed as a prince. The silver door in front of the sanctum is decorated with two elephant heads. On the lintel of the door is a silver Ganesh and above this icon is the silver emblem of the sun. Lord Ram is believed to have been descended from the Sun.

But this is not the last of the mysterious shrines of Orchha. If you want a draught of cool, fresh, air before continuing with your explorations in the town, drive to the top of a hillock, some distance outside the town. On it is the strange Laxminarayan Temple.

LAXMINARAYAN TEMPLE

Built by Bir Singh in 1622 it is a square structure with the main entrance at one of its diagonals. The walls are blank on the outside but they have battlements on top. There are squat towers rising on the four corners and a taller tower in the centre. There are galleries running abound the inner walls surrounding the courtyard, which is open to the sky. In the centre of this courtyard is an octagonal sanctum with a hall in front of it. The most eye-catching feature of the Laxminarayan Temple are the paintings adorning the walls of its galleries and its vaulted roof.

The subjects of the paintings are particularly unusual. While some of them illustrate episodes from the sacred epic, the Ramayana, and of Lord Krishna the eighth incarnation of the Preserver, others depict mythical, martial and secular scenes. There is an interesting painting of the legendary 'Chungi Chirya the



The Laxminarayan Temple, an architectural curiosity

monstrous bird that could fly away with elephants captured in its talons. This could have inspired the Roc of the Arabian Sinbad stories. Then there are paintings of the siege of Jhansi Fort by the forces of the British East India Com- pany. A very unusual panel shows two European soldiers drinking at a table. These paintings span the developed phase of the Bundelkhand School of Art from the 17th to the 19th centuries. They are not, strictly speaking, 'murals' and even the plastered brick walls on which they have been executed are special. (See Wall Paintings and Lakhori Bricks)

According to the experts of New Delhi's School of Planning and Architecture (The Laxminarayan Temple) is an architectural curiosity, and much research could be done on the inspiration and motivation behind it.

Returning to the town, there are three other fascinating buildings: Phul Bagh, the Dastagirs, and Hardaul ka Baithaka. Closest to the Ram Raja Temple is Madhukar Shah's Phul Bagh.

The painting in the Laxminarayan Temple depicts an event of Ramayana

Tourists visiting the Bundela Chhatris

RAFTING ON THE BETWA

Though you can get fairly good views of the chhatris from the land, the best views can be had from the river.

Using unsinkable, inflatable rafts and crewed by boatmen trained in white water sports and rescue, this thrilling facility is run by the state's Tourism Development Corporation. It starts from the river bank in front of the chhatris. This is where visi- tors wear their helmets and life jackets and sign a waiver.

Rafts are paddled upstream to hit the first mild rapids. This gives newcomers a feel of what white-water is like. From here there is also a good view of Bir Singh's chhatri. The rafts are then turned around and, after a short while, the paddlers stop and the rafts float down on the currents of the river. After passing the chhatris the rafts bob under a bridge and the paddlers duck!

Then there is the jouncing, swirling, excitement of a strong rapid before hitting calm water again. On the left bank of the river the Chhaturbhuj Temple looms up in the distance as does the Citadel complex. Then the rafts spin and bounce in another rapid before they float gently on currents of the river, reach the confluence of the Betwa and the Jami, and then brave two more rapids, including the most challenging one, before landing on the banks in front of the Bundela Riverside Retreat.

This rafting trip covers three kilometres and takes approximately forty-five minutes. Even the ghostly horsemen, who are sometimes reported to visit the hamlet, could not have had a more exciting experience of magical Orchha.

Rafting on Betwa River

WALL PAINTINGS AND LAKHORI BRICKS

The red and white paintings on the walls at the entrance of the Laxminarayan Temple, and in the galleries around the central open court art, actually, semi- engraved paintings. Sea shells are ground into powder and then made into a paste which is applied on the surface that is to be painted. This is then polished, by rubbing, till u acquires the sheen of marble Using an extract made from the red flow ets of the palas tree the prepared surface is then painted When the painting is dry the pattern is etched on it so that the white under-surface is revealed. The paintings at the entrance and the two drinking Europeans and their deg have been done using this technique. This type of wall painting dates back to the 19th century.

The Laxminarayan Temple has been constructed of thin Lakhori bricks, stone and lime mortar Lakhori bricks are made of brick powder called surkhi, lime, jaggery, an edible lemad seed called urad dal, wood apple fruit called bel, fenugreek seeds called methi, pate fibre, and sand. All these are mixed in a stone grinder. This mixture is then moulded and fired in the normal way. Lakhori bricks are, reputedly, lighter, stronger and far more durable than normal bricks.

The Dastagir Ventilation Towers

DASTAGIRS

These towers originated in Persia and are, reputedly, the only ones of their kind in India. Wind blowing across the tops of the towers creates an up-welling draught that sucks out hot air from the chambers below them. As the hot air is exhausted, cool subterranean air is drawn in keeping the basements at a pleasantly low temperature.

You might have to get special permission from the authorities to venture into these naturally air-conditioned chambers. In our troubled times, such hidden places have to be secured against disgruntled and violent people.

Next door to the Dastagirs, and the Phul Bagh is the unusual Hardaul ka Baithaka.

HARDAUL KA BAITHAKA

The very honourable Hardaul was the younger brother of Jujhar Singh who ruled from 1627 to 1635. Even as a young man he had built up such a high reputation for sagacity and kindness that streams of people used to bring their problems to him and accept the advice he gave them. He dispensed his wisdom from a platform in a pa- vilion set in a formal garden of octagonal beds and stone-paved paths. This has now become a shrine where a priest officiates and religious mendicants sit in the garden and receive alms in his memory, now hallowed by The Legend of Hardaul.

THE LEGEND OF HARDAUL

People believe that Hardaul had lost his mother at a very early age and had been brought up by the wife of his brother, Jujhar Singh. Hardaul's growing popularity got the Mughal court worried that he might lead a re- volt against their emperor Shah Jahan. Insiduously, they filled the mind of Jujhar Singh with lies about his wife's affair with Hardaul. When the weak Jujhar confronted his wife with his suspicions she was distraught. "How can you even think that?" she cried.

"He's like my son" But Jujhar Singh insisted that he would be convinced of her innocence only if she poisoned Hardaul's food herself, and took it to him. She did so, but when she gave him the dish, he noticed that she had tears in her eyes. He asked her why she was crying when usually she sat and fanned his food. She broke down and told him what had happened. Hardaul's reply was typical of the man. He said "If I don't eat this food there'll be distrust between husbands and wives all over Bundelkhand" He ate the food and died and became a folk hero. Even today, all weddings in Bundelkhand have him as their first invitee.

Though Hardaul's memory is enshrined in a very special way, the other members of the princely family of Bundelkhand have been honoured by an imposing group of pinecone-shaped cenotaphs know as the Bundela chhatris.

BUNDELA CHHATRIS

There are fifteen cenotaphs of the Bundela rulers and members of their family standing proudly on the southern, the right, bank of the Betwa river. The chhatris rise on a square platform and the sanctum is also square. The sanctums hold the ashes of the cremated princes and princesses. The first chhatri has a marble statue of Madhukar Shah and his wife with a painted canopy over them. The last chhatri seen from the river-side (See Box Rafting on the Betwa) is a square one and it is dedicated to Bir Singh Deo.

Bundela Chhatris rise on the banks of the Betwa

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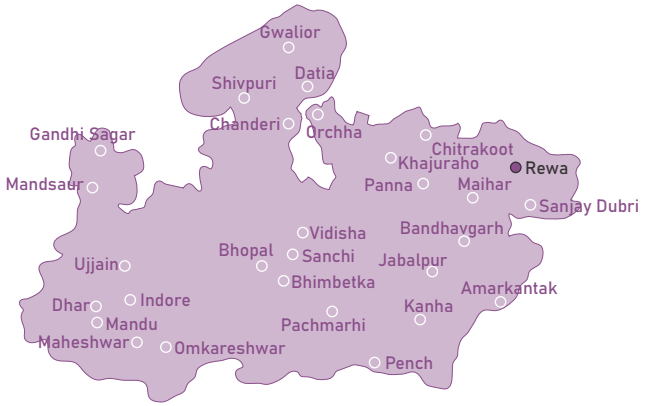
Rewa

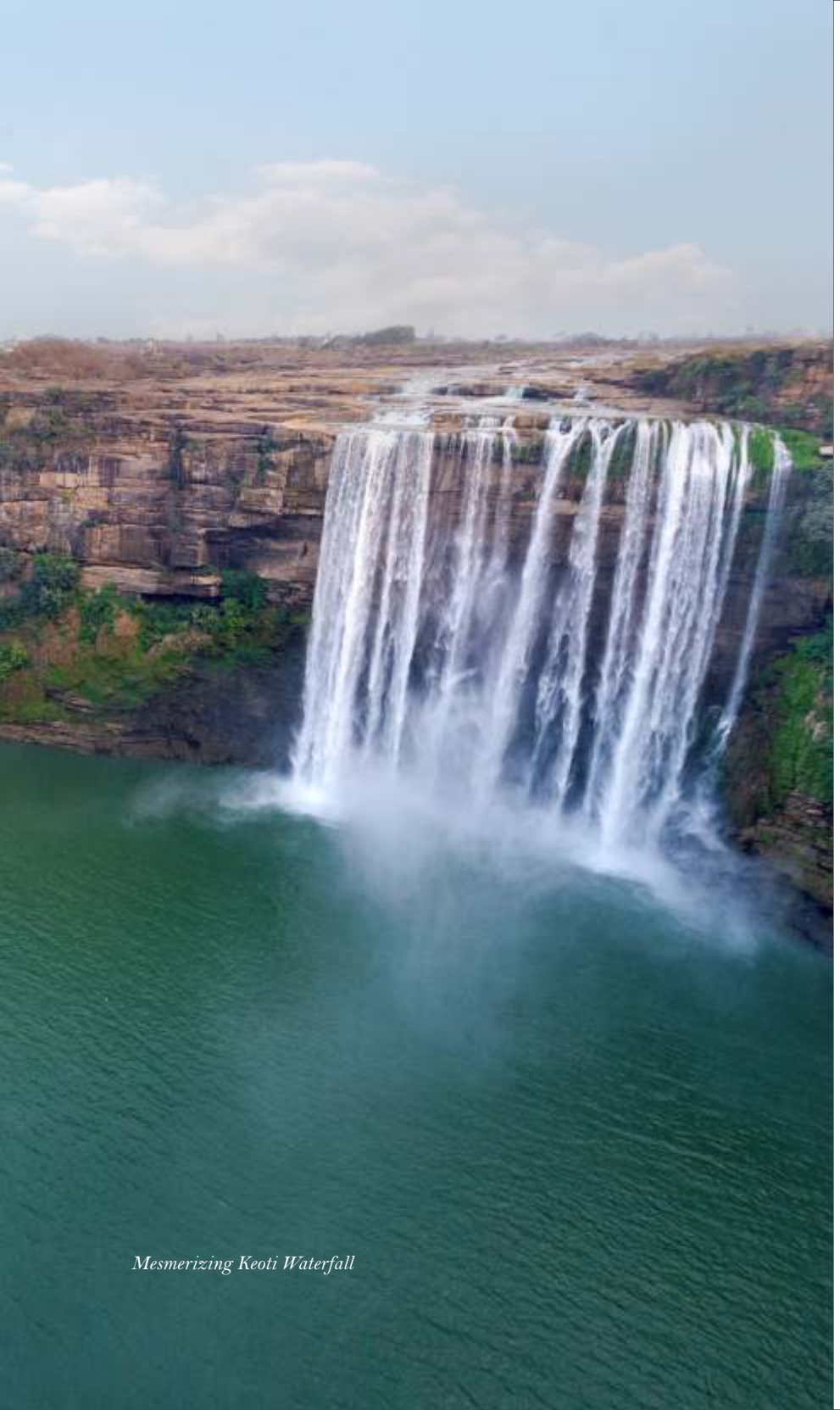
An Amalgam of Natural and Archeological Beauty



Nestled in the north western side of Madhya Pradesh, Rewa is a place synonymous with natural beauty and archaeological treasure trove such as cave paintings, Buddhist stupas and Kalchuri period riches of sculpture. Under Bhaghela rulers, Rewa reached at a zenith in the field of music and literature. It was due to the love for environment and wildlife of the erstwhile Maharaja Martand Singh Ju Dev, that the rare white tiger was brought to the notice of the world. Furthermore, Rewa contributed immensely in the freedom struggle

The Baghel Museum

Aerial view of Ginnorgarh Fort



Mesmerizing Keoti Waterfall

between 1857-1942. Many a waterfalls around Rewa, lend a surreal appeal, making it a must watch destination amongst the leisure travellers.

WATERFALLS

A number of mesmerizing waterfalls are seen around Rewa, viz, 30 km from Rewa district head quarters is Keoti waterfalls, 31 km away on Semariya road is Purva waterfall, Chachai and Bahuti waterfall in Sirmour (71 kms from Rewa) development block. Bahuti waterfall with a height of 142 m is the highest fall of the region. Tamas River along with its tributaries Beehar and Mahanadi forms the Purva waterfall.

REWA FORT

Salim Shah (Jalal Khan) son of Shershah (Afgan) initiated the construction of a fort on the north bank of junction of river Biher and Bichhiya in 1539 A.D after the death of his father Shershah in Kalinjar fort in 1544 A.D. However, he left Rewa and went to Delhi and never came back to Rewa again.Raja Vikramaditya of Baghel dynasty came to Ranbahadur Ganj from Bandhargarh in 1617 A.D. on a hunting expedition and noticed the half built fort and got it completed it. He is credited with the construction of the fortification wall, bastions, doors and palaces. A colony was revalidated in side the fort which is called upper hatti.

BHAIRAV, KHAMDEEH

This place is 25 km on the right of the Rewa-Gurh Road. This four-armed Bhairav is monolithic in structure and one of the unique depictions of lord Bhairav. This idol is 31 feet tall and 3.07 metres wide. In the upper left hand of Bhairav is a trishul and in the lower left hand a rudraksh mala. In the upper right hand he holds a snake with three tongues and in the lower right hand he holds a kalash. A rudraksh mala adorns his neck and a snake twines along with. This idol is unique due to its size and has been declared as a protected monument by State Archaeology.

The Bhairav, Khamdeeh

The Govindgarh Palace

GOVINDGARH PALACE, GOVINDGARH

Lying 19 kms from Rewa in the Hazoor tahsil, Govindgarh Palace is a magnificent building on the bank of a picturesque lake. Maharaja Vishavnath Singh of Rewa built the Rama Govind temple, This palace was subsequently expanded by Maharaja Raghuraj Singh and Maharaja Gulab Singh. The sub-sections of this beautiful palace are known as Raghav mahal, Badal mahal and Ulta mahal. The noteworthy monuments are the Anandgarh and Dariya mahal (constructed by Gulam Singh) and the Darbar Hall and the adjoining marble temple (built by Raghuraj Singh). Govindgarh is also famous as the place where the first White Tiger was seen.

BAGHELA MUSEUM

The museum exhibits the prosperous history of the royal house of Rewa. It consist of a weapon gallery, stone gallery and a collection of rare pictures and written material. A gallery dedicated to the life of Rewa's white tiger 'Mohan' exhibits the history of whiter tigers of the region.

The Rani Talab

RANI KA TALAB

A Shiva temple exists in the centre of Rani Talab. The lake is surrounded by Chhatris. Another Shiva temple is situated towards the bank of the lake which is lined with six chhatris . These provide a fascinating view. At some distance from the lake there is a huge temple, which is called Rani Ka Mandir,dedicated to lord Ram and Sita . According to the priest the temple was built by Raja Vishwanath

The Vyankat Bhawan

Singh and Rani Subhadra Kumari. Several kalachuri period images have been pasted on the boundary wall, which include those of Balram, dikpala and other deities.

VYANKAT BHAWAN

This magnificent palace houses a tunnel 25ft below its foundation which opens in the Fort. The central hall is known for its exquisite splendour of golden colour carvings. The State Museum run in the premises has a display of many 1000 years old statues belonging to Kulchuri period. This is a protected monument under State Archaeology.

DEUR KOTHAR

Situated on Rewa-Allahabad highway near Katra, remains of Buddhist

Stupas of Deur Kothar

Stupas belonging to Mauryan age (3rd to 2nd Cent. BC) have been found. It is situated on the ancient trade route between Bharhut and Sarnath stupas. The excavation also yielded an Ashokan inscription. The monument is protected by ASI.

WHITE TIGER SAFARI, MUKUNDPUR ZOO

One of its kind in the world, the White Tiger Safari in Mukundpur, Govindgarh is an exciting opportunity to behold the rare, beautiful white big cat. This is the place where Rewa's former ruler Maharaja Martand Singh Ji had first spotted the White Tiger. A White Tiger breeding center in the proximity has been named after the Maharaj.

Indrahaar

WHAT TO DO

Tourists may taste the local cuisine like Indrahaar, Khurchan, Chaat etc. Local craft include toys and artifacts carved on betel nut (Supari).

Craftsman making artifacts of betel nut

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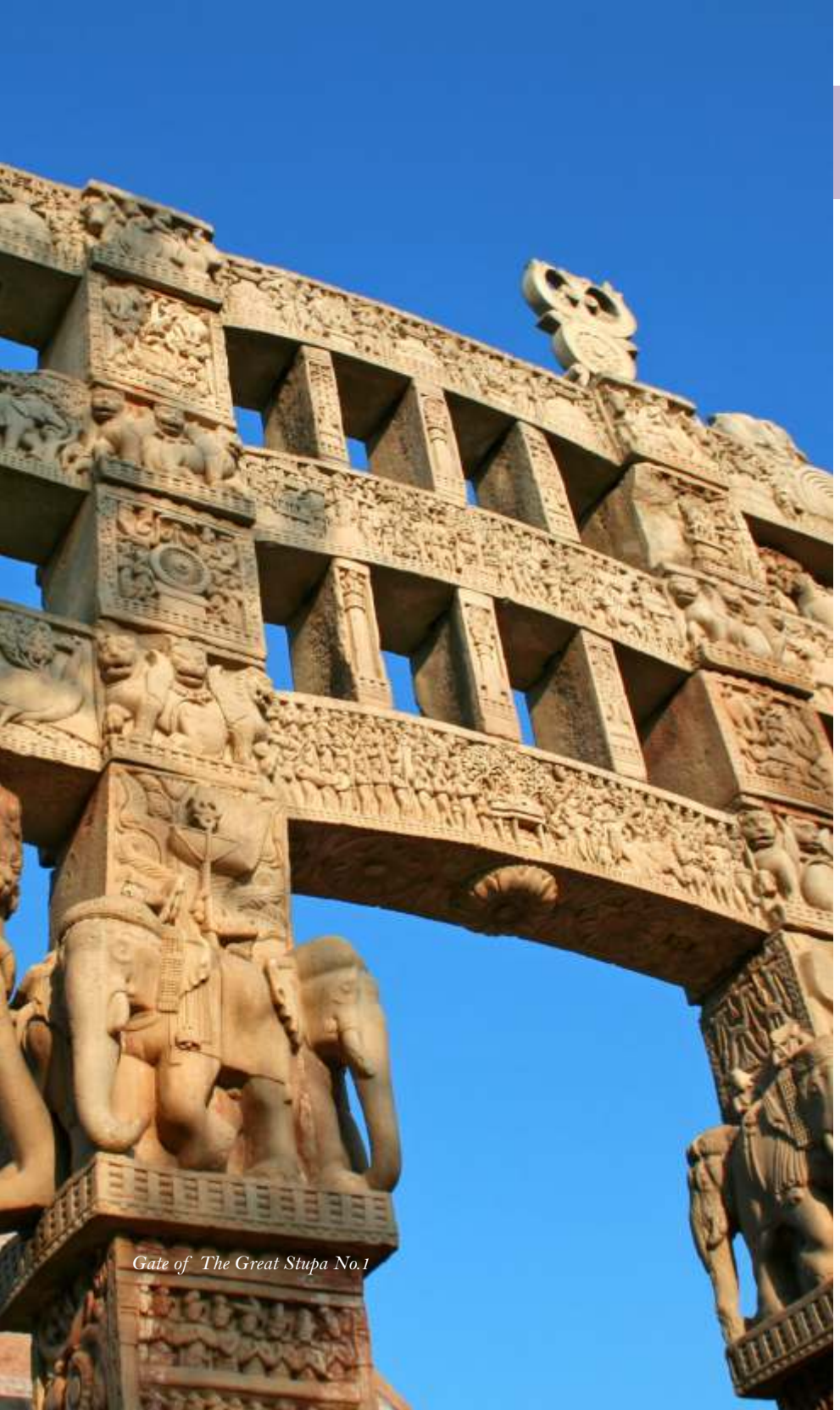
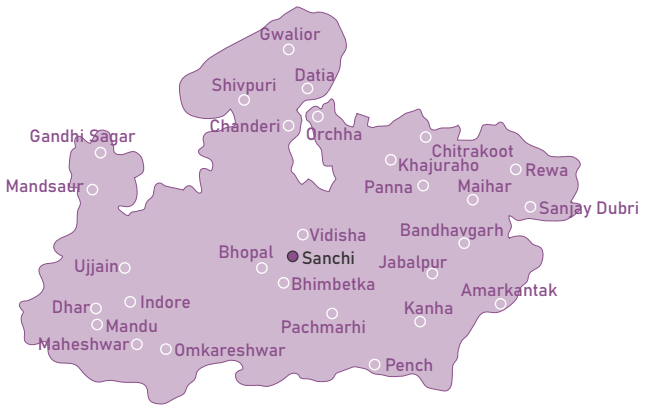


Gate of The Great Stupa No.1

Sanchi

Sanchi is a monumental record of the rise and fall, and resurgence, of Buddhism in India.



The drive from the fertile farm-lands of present-day Vidisha, and up the T road winding through the scrub-covered hillock of Sanchi, covers a span of twenty-six centuries. The first building that catches the eye, as the car coasts into the parking lot near the gate of the Buddhist complex, is the Mahabodhi Temple. It looks like a great man-'o-war cresting a high wave. The land on which it stands was donated by Independent India's first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru; its cost of construction was borne by the Islamic ruler of Bhopal State, Nawab Hamidulla Khan, and it was built by the Buddhist Mahabodhi Society of Sri Lanka. Buddhism had been born in India, had thrived and spread from its shores, had had its influence eroded, and was now reasserting its presence.

From the gate, a path rises up through manicured lawns to the huge dome of the Great Stupa No 1.

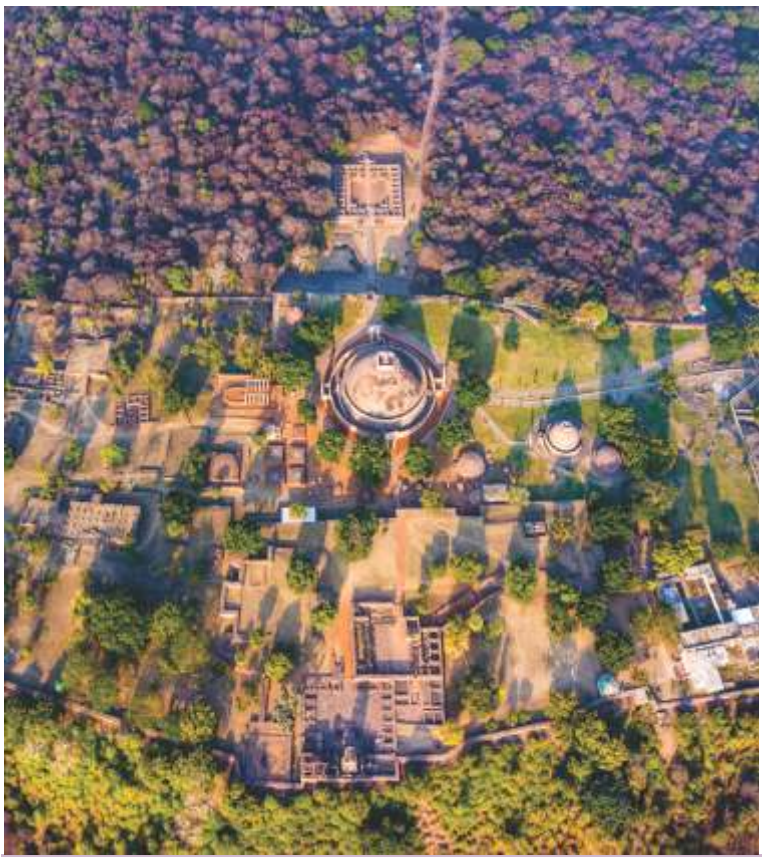
The Great Stupa at Sanchi

From the base of the Mahabodhi Temple, a flight of broad steps descends to the main gate and ticket booth of the complex. To one side of it is a fig tree. Gautama Siddhartha became the Buddha, under a Pipal Tree known botanically as Ficus reli- giosa but in Buddhist circles it is called the Bodhi or Bo tree: literally 'The Tree of Wisdom'. A sapling of the original tree was planted here in 1952, jointly by the Prime Ministers of India and Sri Lanka. People seeking boons tie bits of cloth on the railings surrounding the tree: a practice common to many religions all over the world.

An image of the Buddha in The Pradakshina around The Great Stupa

GREAT STUPA NO 1

Scholars believe that this was the first monument to be erected in Sanchi in the third century BC. The popular belief is that it was raised by one of the most



Aerial view of Stupa's premises

THE BUILDING OF THE GREAT STUPA

This was originally a brick mound 21 m. in diameter

The Buddhist artisans of Sanchi had learnt how to carve and polish stone from contemporary Persian craftsmen in the ancient university city of Taxila. Using these skills, local sculptors proceeded to embellish the gateway pillars and cross beams with graphic bas-reliefs drawn from the tales of the Buddha's life against the background of their every-day experiences.

Work on the Great Stupa project did not extend over a few months, or even a few years. It stretched over a century. It was a labour of love and dedication; a meritorious work that would earn enormous spiritual benefits for all involved in it. Generation after generation of artists, artisans and craftspeople came here with their families, their children were born here and studied under the watchful eyes of their fathers and grandfathers. Unquestioningly, sons were apprenticed to their fathers, learnt how to transform rough blocks of stone, rolled off creaking bullock-carts, into dressed slabs. They stood in admiration of their elder brothers as they softened slabs of stone with water, cut it using hand-saws and chisels.

They watched intently as the silver-haired Masters used charcoal to sketch the outlines of the carvings on the dressed slabs, stepped back as the dust and the chips from the chis- els flew and the pictures grew magically out of the stone, centimetre by intricate centi-metre.

In those days there were no 'efficiency experts' to make time-motion studies or frown at cost-over-runs! The merchant princes who had sponsored the Great Stupa project, paid occasional visits on their caparisoned horses, decorated palanquins, trotting bullock-carts. They examined the progress of the work, spoke to the Greek guards protecting the work-site, returned to Vidisha and impressed upon their fami-lies the fact that they had a sacred duty to see this pious work through to its comple-tion, regardless of how many generations it would involve.

In a future age, Sanchi would have been a contractual job: quickly completed, corners cut. In the days of the sponsoring plutocrats of Vidisha it became a religious and timeless work of art.

Domesticated elephants Circa second century BC

powerful rulers of India: the Mauryan emperor Ashoka. In fact Ashoka had built a brick mound about 21 m in diameter. In the 2nd century BC the prosperous Buddhist traders of Vidisha enlarged it to its present size of 36.5 m in diameter and 16.4 m in height, and faced it with stone. (See Box- The Building of the Great Stupa). Those rich merchants continued to remain fervent Buddhists even after the non-Buddhists sungas came to power in 185 BC; and the burghers of Vidisha continued to make Sanchi a haven for Buddhist monks who feared persecution by the new rulers of the land.

For a hundred years, Vidisha's wealthy elite poured money into Sanchi. Among the many other structures they erected was Stupa 3, soaring monolithic pillars crowned with capitals of four lions, and the social edicts of Ashoka engraved in stone. Much of their loving attention, however, was concentrated on embellishing the Great Stupa. They added an elevated circular path to it, presumably reserved for the clergy: the ground level walkway being for ordinary pilgrims. Their designers also flattened the huge dome to hold a platform protected by a low, stone fence. In the middle of this platform they installed a three-tier stone umbrella. Around the base of the dome they erected a stone vedika railing with four torana gateways. Interestingly, both the fence and the gateways replicated, in stone, the wooden ones used to protect the villages of their precursors: the pastoral Aryans. Moreover, because the gateways were carved to illustrate the legends and myths of the Buddha's life, even the backgrounds of these carvings in stone are of great interest. They show, in careful detail, scenes from the second century BC when the traditions of the old ways of the Aryans were still being adhered to This gives a very special significance to the toranas of the Great Stupa.

THE TORANAS OF THE GREAT STUPA

The torana facing the entrance to the complex is the northern one. At the back of one of its pillars people are shown venerating a stupa accompanied by a wind and percussion orchestra. The conical head-dresses of one of the devotees shown in profile and also that of at least one of the musicians seems to indicate that they were Persians. In a different place, on the same torana, is a stylistic

The columns could indicate the Greek influence on Buddhist architecture

depiction of the Buddha's feet. In the early years of the faith, the Buddha was always depicted by symbols, never in human form. Since the religion preached by him was a non-theistic one, he did not want his followers to worship him as a god. It was only much later, when Buddhist leaders decided to project him as the ninth incarnation of the Hindu God Vishnu, that images of a human Buddha began to appear in Buddhist iconography.

On the torana of the eastern gate, walking clockwise around the stupa which is the accepted way to circumambulate religious places, there is a particularly sensuous celestial maiden, or apsara, carved as a bracket figure. There are also elephants supporting the cross-beams on their backs. Indians were, probably, the first people in the world to train elephants for domestic work and for war. The invading armies of Alexander the Great were, reputedly, dismayed by the huge war elephants used by the Indian prince, Porus. Also on this pillar, is a graphic scene of a street procession. The urban street is on two levels and, on the second level, a man rides an elephant and holds an ankus prod. Spectators lining the balconies of the double- storeyed houses gaze down at the procession. The roofs of the houses have the curved domical shape easily made of bent bamboo. Even after the Buddhists began using stone and brick, they still adhered to the traditional shapes dictated by the original timber dwellings. Finally. another carving on this gateway captures another symbol of the Buddha: the Bodhi Tree. Here, too, a

Worship of Stupa Pillar, North Gateway

North Gateway, Inner View

domical roof has been shown behind the forked trunk of the sacred tree.

The front of the southern gatepost carries possibly the depiction of the National Emblem of independent India: the Lion Capital of Ashoka. The four lions of which only three are visible as in this cary- ing replaced the Imperial Crown of Britain when India became a Republic on 26th January, 1950. The Dharma Chakra, or Wheel of the Law, appears in the centre of our National Flag on which it also represents the Charka or spinning wheel. The transposition of the 'k' and 'r' convey subtly differ- ent meanings! The Dharma Chakra indicates the implacability of natural justice regardless of the social status of people. The charka, on the oth- er hand, is a symbol of Mahatma Gandhi who broke the exploitive monopoly of the British by mak- ing his own cotton thread on a spin- ning wheel. This weakened Britain's attempt to impose a monopoly on the manufacture of cotton cloth.

Finally, there are two foreign influences depicted on the western gateway. At the very top of the pillars are carvings of winged lions. Such winged lion griffins are found in one of the palaces of Darius the Great, King of Persia in the 5th century BC. It was a symbol of fierce majesty and was probably inspired by the Persian mentors of Indian stone carvers to represent the power and majesty of the Mauryas. Then there is the lone figure of a standing warrior with a spear. He has been identified as a Greek sentry and was probably modelled on the guards of Sanchi who were either for- eigners or of foreign origin but born in one of the many Greek colonies in India. There were extensive political, commercial and cultural contacts be- tween the Greeks and Indians during the age of the Mauryas.

A monument as large as the Great Stupa clearly called for a supporting establishment of multi-tasked priests. Stupas are not hollow structures. They are reliquaries holding the bones of revered Buddhists: the relics of the foremost disciples of the Buddha, Sariputra and Maudgalyayana, were found inside Stupa No. 3. No one could live inside stupas. This is why they also built the vihara.

THE VIHARA

Leading down from the level on which the Great Stupa dominates Sanchi

Tourists understanding the Jataka Stories depicted on Torans

The Vihara or Monastery

hill is a flight of steps that accesses the ruins of the monastery, or vihara. Individual cells for the monks opened onto a central unroofed courtyard. It had been built of timber frames and brick walls, austere as befits a monastic establishment, and without any of the decorations that embellished the Great Stupa. Over the years, and embroidered by the imaginations of the guides, legends have grown around this monastery. There's one about how the son and daughter of Ashoka were educated here before they took Buddhism, and a sapling of the Bo Tree, to Sri Lanka. It is an attractive tale but all that we know for sure is that Buddhist monks studied here, not who they were.

Then, for their community worship, the monks needed assembly halls. They called these their chaityas.

CHAITYAS

Since the stupa was, in those days, the only symbol that Buddhists were permitted to venerate, and the monks could not hold their religious ceremonies outside the Great Stupa, they built smaller stupas and enclosed them at the end of rectangular halls. These halls had the typical barrel vaulted roof of timber, timber pillars and brick walls. Here, too, however, the timber supports collapsed over the seven centuries when Sanchi was abandoned. All that is left of the oldest chaitya, dating back to the time of the Great Stupa, are ruins identified as Temple 40. In all likelihood this chaitya conformed strictly to the original precept of Buddhist architecture that there should be no human depictions of the Lord.

In course of time, however, the dilution of the original non-theistic Buddhist creed became inevitable. Most of the monuments in Sanchi were built much after Buddhism had ceased to be the religion of the rulers. Sanchi was, in fact, an island of Buddhism depend- ent on the generosity of the merchants of Vidisha. But merchants cannot thrive in opposition to the beliefs of the ruling power for long. They have to compromise.

Such a compromise first appeared in the 4th century AD. Superb figures of a seated Buddha were installed around the base of the Great Stupa. Also from the 4th century AD is a sculpture of a Snake Goddess, a Nagina, standing a little away from Stupa No.3 Then, from the 7th or 8th century terracotta figures of the Buddha appear on the floor of the second chaitya hall, Temple 18. In the 10th or 11th century, carved door-jambs were added. One of these jambs, now exhibited in the Site Mu- seum, shows figures of the Hindu God- dess Ganga with her attendants. At this time, possibly, the last vestige of Buddhist veneration was removed: there is no trace of the stupa that must have occupied pride of place when it was a chaitya.

The faith of the now predominantly Brahmanical population lapped like a

Worshipers of the Buddha, North Gateway

rising tide around the hillock of Sanchi. Temple 17, near Temple 9, is unique. According to architectural historian Satish Grover, this is the earliest extant Brahmanical structural temple. The fifth century architects of this temple took their inspiration from cave shrines like those found in a sandstone hillock not far from Vidisha. Since this temple was inspired by such a cave shrine, it has a single, dark cell. The four pillars at the entrance are squat versions of Ashoka columns crowned by the familiar inverted bell and carvings of animals. Moreover, as the walls of caves did not have any embellishments, here, too, the outer surface of this masonry temple has no decorations. Curiously, when Captain FG. Maisey visited this temple in the nineteenth century, he remarked that it held the lower portion of an image of the Buddha seated on a lotus throne with the Buddhist creed inscribed on it. There is no image in the temple now so it is impossible to say when it was installed in this temple dating back to the age of the Brahmanical Guptas. Facts tend to get blurred when there is a conflict of interests.

In another response to pressures to adjust to the prevailing religion of the rulers, Buddhism reacted by evolving the eclectic system of Vajrayana. It accepted many of the icons of the rulers' religion but fitted them neatly into their own belief system. Thus Goddesses became embodiments of spiritual powers, the Buddha was regarded as the most advanced of a number of spiritual mentors and, soon, the pantheon of Vajrayana Buddhism became as rich and varied as that of their rulers' religion. They even built a temple in Sanchi dedicated to their interpreta- tion of Buddhism. It is in ruins now and is known as Temple and Monastery 45.

TEMPLE AND MONASTERY 45

It stands at the eastern extremity of the Sanchi complex, gazing over the carved and fallen blocks of its monastery. This temple was built in two phas- es. The earlier one was raised in the seventh or eighth century, the second one was built in the 9th or 10th century AD. Behind the mesh screen of the locked gate there is a seated statue of the Buddha. On the door-jam outside there are carvings of the Goddesses Ganga and Yamuna and, above them, mildly erotic

panels. Vajrayana has reached considerable heights of development in Tibet and our Himalayan states and is often, though inaccurately, referred to as Lamaism. The tantric practices of Vajryana are diametrically different to those of the non- Buddhist faiths. Lamaism is the aspect of Buddhism that seems to attract an in- creasing number of devotees all over the world and is leading to a virtual resur- gence of this ancient religion, globally (See Box - The Buddha and his Creed).

The plateau that holds the monuments of Sanchi measures about 380 metres north to south and 200 metres east to west and it holds an estimated 50 monuments. Only determined scholars decide to visit them all, including the small stupa bases probably marking the burial sites of revered monks. However, even an overall view of this religious complex is enough to bring home the fact that, in its heyday, it must have been an extremely powerful religious centre, particularly as it preached a faith that started as a reformation movement. But the initial zeal to reform is weakened over time and it becomes easier to conform and, eventually, to accept the ideas that the reformation movement opposed in the first place!

No one knows why Sanchi was abandoned: possibly successive generations of Vidishas plutocracy cut down their support. We do know that the Archaeological Survey of India has not identified any Buddhist monument to the 13th century. Some carved slabs showing the Brahmanical deities Vishnu, Ganesh and the Goddess Mahishasuramardini, from the 13th century, were excavated from Sanchi. These have been exhibited in the Site Museum. From the 14th century, however, Sanchi lay slowly crumbling in the sun, abandoned to trees and scrub. Half a millennium later, in 1818, it was 'discovered', by a British army officer General Taylor. Amateur archaeologists and treasure hunters flocked and did considerable damage to the monuments. Serious conservation work on Sanchi began only in 1912 when Sir John Marshall, Director General of Archaeology in India, took up excavation and conservation in a scientific way. planned and

Many of the antiquities unearthed in Sanchi are on display in the Site Museum.

Temple & Monastery 45

THE BUDDHA AND HIS CREED

In 623 BC, the Buddha was born Prince Siddhartha of the state of Kapilavastu on the Indo-Nepal border. In his early years he was cosseted, surrounded by luxuries and protected from the harsh reali- ties of life. He was married to the beautiful Yashodhara and had a son, Rahula. But on the four occasions he went out of the palace he saw an old man, a sick man, a corpse and an ascetic who seemed to be at peace with himself and the world. Disturbed by these encounters, he wondered why age, ailments and death afflict human beings. He felt that, perhaps, the ascetic had found the answer. Bidding his sleeping wife and son goodbye, he left the palace and went in quest of a solution to the eternal Problem of Pain.

During his quest stretching over six years, he met many, so-called, wise men; subjected himself to all sorts of austerities and almost starved himself to death. But he was still unhappy. He realised that such harsh mortifications would not lead him to the answers he was seeking. He abandoned this extreme course, bathed in a river, and

accepted easily digestible rice gruel from Sujata, a rich merchant's daughter. He then ate and slept in moderation till he had recovered his health. Then, in a forest in Gaya, in the present state of Bihar, he sat under a fig tree in deep meditation for seven weeks. The night before his birthday, he dis- covered the Law of Causation. He summed this up as The Four Noble Truths:

All existence is full of suffering

Suffering is caused by selfish desire

There is a way to overcome such desire

The way is the Noble eightfold Path

The Way, also known as The Middle Path, consists of:

The Right View: depend on your own powers of reasoning

The Right Mental Resolve: follow the logic of the Right View

The Right Speech: speak truthfully with the Right Resolve

The Right Action: be compassionate to everything

The Right Livelihood: your profession should not cause suffering to others

The Right Effort: keep examining yourself to prevent relapse into error

The Right Mindfulness: make Right Effort into an unchanging mindset

The Right Concentration: cultivate the ability to avoid distraction

THE BUDDHA AND HIS CREED

The Buddha opposed the excessive rit- ualism, cults of sacrifice, and the institution of a priesthood as the self-proclaimed inter- mediaries between God and man: in fact he did not preach the existence of a God.

He asked his followers to lead simple lives, to beg for their daily food- in Sanchi there is a huge bowl sculpted from a single boulder, into which the faithful placed their daily offerings of food for the monks to go in separate directions to spread his message of peace, and to rest in a monastic community during the monsoon months when torrential rains made the roads impassable

The Buddha began his mission at the age of 36 and died in Kushinagar, in today's Uttar Pradesh at the age of 80. His death is normally referred to as parinirvana: the state of eternal ecstasy when his conscious being leaves this world and is merged with the Oversoul like a drop of water merging with the Ocean. Nirvana happens only after the burden of all the guilt acquired after successive rebirths has been completely obliter- ated by meritorious deeds.

Buddhism, today, is divided into the Hinayana or the discipline of the Little Vehicle, which is the most traditional and often the most austere form of the religion, the Mahayana or Great Vehicle which has accepted occasional inputs from other faiths through the years and is, therefore, the most eclectic; and the Vajrayana or Way of the Thunderbolt which is the most esoteric and is the Buddhist discipline most widely practiced in the Himalayas. His Holiness the Dalai Lama is an exponent of Vajrayana. This is also the most publicised discipline today and has attracted many adherents from Europe and the USA and also considerable misrepresentation in books and movies!

A nagini image shows the evolution of Buddhism

THE SITE MUSEUM

It stands at the bottom of the Sanchi campus, fenced in and protected by the Archaeological Survey of India. In its lobby is the capital of an Ashokan Pillar, four lions facing the four cardinal directions. Other particularly eye- catching exhibits are a Nagaraja, or Snake King, dating back to the 2nd Cen- tury BC's Sunga Period; a very serene Buddha in Meditation from the 7th Century AD; and a Gajalaxmi, the Goddess of Wealth, from the 10th century. Of some interest is the fact that many of the sculptures and carvings from the post Buddhist Brahmanical period are exhibited here. There are also displays of iron implements virtually all of which resemble ones being used in many of our homes today.

The lion capital that once topped the Ashoka Pillar

Accommodation in Sanchi

MPT Gateway Retreat

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Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant | Bar | Wifi | Conference Hall

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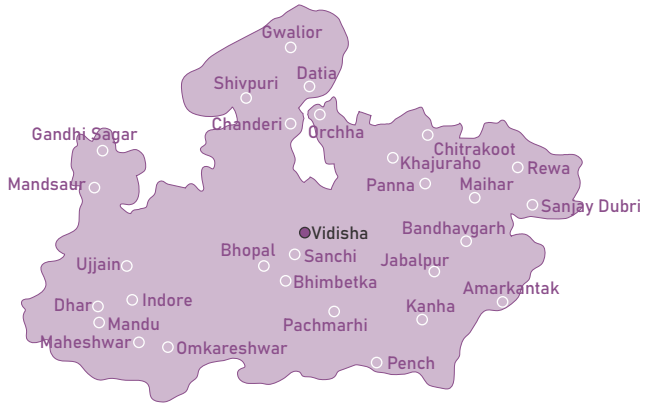
*MPT Gateway Retreat in the World Heritage Site, Sanchi, offers best in hospitality services. Facilities include gym and conference hall, which makes it a much sought after MICE destination in the proximity of Bhopal. The spacious layout and best quality food makes it the first choice for events like weddings and corporate events.ISO 9001:2015 **QMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.*

The Pillar of Heliodorus worshiped as Khamb Baba

Vidisha

In the 7th century, the prosperous town of Vidisha, suddenly, pulled up its roots and shifted to the far bank of the great river Betwa.



It was an inexplicable migration because there is no doubt that the old Vidisha was one of the richest cities in India and was closely associated with Sanchi and the Emperor who erected the first monument in that Buddhist centre (See Box - The Mauryas). Much of Vidisha's continuing prosperity arose from the fact that it

The Udaygiri cliffs on the Vidisha Caravan Trail

THE MAURYAS

India's most powerful dynasty began life as a family of peacock breeders. Now protected as India's National Bird, peafowl were treated as domestic poultry in circa 350 BC. But though his origin, in a village of poultry farmers, was humble, Chan dragupta Maurya was a man of exceptional ability and determination. He also, very clearly, had a talent for picking the right advisers. He chose as his friend, philosopher and guide, the wily strategist Chanakya, also known as Kautalya, author of the clas- sic treatise on governance and the convo- luted byways of realpolitik: Arthashastra, it is as relevant today as it was when it was written.

By 305 BC, Chandragupta ruled over a vast empire that extended from the Hin- du-Kush in the mountainous north-west to Mysore in the south. His successor and son, Bindusara, was crowned in 298 but he has no significant achievement to his credit. In fact, there was a revolt in the town of Taxila when his eldest son, Sumana, was viceroy, Bindusara had to send his second son, the viceroy of Ujjain, to quell the Taxila revolt. This son's name was Ashoka.

On quelling the revolt, the 18 year old Ashoka was returning to Ujjain when, while passing through Vidisha, he fell in love with and married the beautiful Devi. She was a rich merchant's daughter and a Sakya of the same clan as Lord Buddha. There are a number of conflicting legends about how Ashoka succeeded to his father's throne round about 269-270 BC but the fact remains that he was the most competent of Bindusara's sons with both military and administrative experience.

Eight years after he was crowned, Ashoka came to a turning point in his life After a bloody victory over the eastern kingdom of Kalinga, Ashoka trudged through the gory battle field. Men and animals lay dead, dismembered, their blood soaking red into the ground. Vultures circled and flapped down even as the piteous cries of the wounded rent the air. Instead of inspiring him to conquer the lands of the deep south, Kal- inga made Ashoka turn his face away from war and violence. He resolved to dedicate his life to spreading compassion among all the citizens of his empire, and for all living crea- tures. As a result of that catharsis, Ashoka became a Buddhist and ruled for 36 years as one of the greatest kings of history.

Under him India achieved heights of material and moral progress that were unri- valled and set standards for governance that no nation has ever equalled, either before or after. No empire of the size and strength of Ashoka's had, or has, renounced aggression and expansion as the Mauryan one did under this emperor. According to historian Anil Chandra Banerjee, Ashoka hept his Empire immune from foreign invasions.

"... and internal rebellions and pro- vided it with an administration which harmonised efficiency with benevolence … his missions to foreign lands were amongst the greatest civilizing influences in the history of the world".

Though he was a staunch Buddhist, and sent his son and daughter, the monk Mahendra and the nun Sanghamitra, to Sri Lanka to spread the message of the Buddha and carry a sapling of the Bo Tree, he never mentioned Budddhism in any of his 36 different inscriptions on rocks and pillars erected all over India. He founded hospi- tals for men and animals, planted roadside trees and groves, dug wells and constructed watering sheds and rest-houses.

His philosophy is summed up in one of his quotations. He said:
"All men are my children. As for my own children I desire that they may be pro- vided with all the welfare and happiness of this world and of the next, so do I desire for all men as well"

From all historical accounts, Ashoka was able to fulfil his desire in a far greater measure than any other ruler has ever done.

Varaha lifts the Earth from the Abyss

was both on the river Betwa and that it straddled two important trade routes. One linked the weaving town of Paithan, to the ancient capital of Ujjain, then through Vidisha and on to the Buddhist pilgrim centre of Kausambi. The other one started from the Arabian Sea port of Bharuch passed through Vidisha, and led to the holy city of Mathura. A branch of this road stretched out from Vidisha through the valley of the Betwa river to the Mauryan capital of Pataliputra. India's Milton, the poet Kalidas, described Vidisha as a place where everybody could become as rich as his heart desired.

At first people thought that the relocation tale was just a myth. Then, a few years ago and fourteen centuries later - new evidence emerged, quite literally. A civic official, intending to increase the depth of the Narmada's bed, to control its annual flooding, was confronted with a bonanza of antiquities dredged from the river. It was such an amazingly rich find that, to this day, they have had to be stacked in its open yard and have not, as yet, been classified. Every visit to Vidisha should start with a walk around its Vidisha District Museum.

VIDISHA DISTRICT MUSEUM

It is a small museum with striking exhibits, some displayed in the garden. They testify to the continual cultural wealth of the area, even after the great town relocated. From the 9th-10th century is a Bhairavnath the Hunter with his dog. From the same century comes a panel of Jain Tirthankers: the spiritual guides of a predominantly trading community. A century later, the artists of this affluent place created a superb reclining Vishnu, Brahmanical god of Preservation, lying on the coils of the great serpent Sheshshayi said to represent the power of the ocean.

Inside, at the entrance to the museum, is a towering Yaksha, one of the protectors of the God of Wealth, Kubera. This is from the 2nd century before the town changed its moorings. There is also a beautiful sculpture of a nag and nagini: semi-divine beings with human faces, the tails of serpents, and the expanded hoods of cobras; they live in great splendour in patala, the regions below the earth. This antiquity is from the 11th century. There are also a number of other striking sculptures testifying to the unbroken artistic activity of the Vidisha region and, by inference, to its virtually unbroken prosperity. Artists sur- vive on the support of wealthy patrons. And their patrons continued to be rich through successive dynasties of rulers: their kings changed but the power of their wealth remained!

Even when the Parmars ruled in the eleventh century the area was affluent enough to support the building of the monument now called the Bijamandal.

BIJAMANDAL

Today it is a very impressive platform, richly carved. This, apparently, was the base of a soaring Brahmanical temple dedicated to the Goddess Charchika also known as Vijaya. It has been attributed to the Parmara King Naravarmar who ruled from 1094 to 1133. Legend has it that the great temple was 35 m high and 39 m wide; that it was demolished on the orders of the Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb in 1682; and that the existing mosque was, then, erected on its platform. The pillars of the mosque had, clearly, been taken from the temple Fascinating carvings from the temple lie arrayed on the grounds, awaiting classification and display in a museum. Particularly striking are those of Maheshmardini, the goddess who killed the buffalo of ignorance; a standing eight-armed Ganesh, God of Good Beginnings, and the dancing seven materna figures, the Sapta Matrikas. Against the wall of a storage shed there is a superbly carved Makra, a mythical sea monster that some iconographers contend depicts creation emerging out of the maw of time. At the far end of the grounds there is also a baoli or step-well with intricately carved pillars.

Leaving the Bijmandal, and winding through the narrow streets of the town, visitors can reach the Gumbaz-ka-Maqbara.

Bijamandal

GUMBAZ-KA-MAQBARA

The historical significance of this domed tomb is not clear. It holds two Muslim graves, one dated to 1487. The gazetteer says, cryptically.

The inmate of this tomb was a big merchant.

Presumably this citizen was par- ticularly rich and powerful, in a town of rich and powerful traders, to warrant the honour of an archaeologically protected tomb.

Leaving the fourteen hundred year old 'new' town of Vidisha, visitors should head out, cross the Betwa, and reach the earlier town, now known as Besnagar.

BESNAGAR

When the old town was abandoned in the 7th century, and much of its building materials carted across the river to build the new town, the original Vidisha gradually became the hamlet that it is today. It is sur- rounded by fertile fields that contrib- ute to Vidisha's image as a major grain market. The major monument, recall- ing the old town's past glory is Heli- odorus' Pillar.

HELIODORUS' PILLAR

Helidorus was the son of Dion, very likely a nobleman in the court of the Greek king Antialcidas of Taxila. The king sent Heliodorus as his personal ambassador to the Sunga court at Vidisha. Here, Heliodorus became a devotee of the Brahmanical god, Vishnu whose vahan, or vehicle, is the eagle Garuda. Heliodorus erected a pillar crowned by a Garuda in honour of his devotion, This is now a protected monument in its own walled grounds.

The descriptive board erected in the grounds says:

This column is locally called Kham Baba and is worshipped especially by fishermen. There are two inscriptions in Brahmi characters and the

Heliodorus' Pillar

Prakrit language..... This is dated to approximately 150 BC."

The Brahmi script is the ancestor of the vast majority of Indian scripts and was drawn from Aramaic. It was probably introduced to Indian traders, by their Semitic contacts, in the 8th or 7th century BC. Prakrit was an Indo-Aryan language that developed as regional dialects of classic Sanskrit and then evolved into distinct literary languages identified by regional names. In much the same manner, the so-called Queen's English, is evolving into Hinglish (Hindi-Eng- lish) and Chinglish (Chinese-English).

After Heliodorus Pillar, there is one more place of considerable interest in the old Vidisha. It is a sand- stone range about a kilometre long and rising to a height of 110 metres. It has 20 rock-cut cave-shrines and is known as Udaygiri.

UDAYGIRI

The caves are protected by mesh gates and guards are in attendance. A motor road runs along the base of the range and two caves are accessible just off the road. Visitors who want to see the other caves will have to wind their way up rock-cut steps and along paths cut into the rocks of the range. Cave No.1, which is of archaeological significance, and Cave No.2 which is not very noteworthy, are on the hillock behind the other caves.

The first cave that the visitor encounters, driving into Udaygiri, is Cave19. This is known as the Amrit Cave after the carving around the entrance. It shows the churning of the ocean by gods and demons, out of which emerged a number of precious things like the Nectar of Immortality, or amrit. The imagery is, clearly, taken from the churning of milk to make butter: the Aryans were a pastoral people. This cave has a pillared portico built in front of its mouth. Inside there is a shivling, em- blem of Lord Siva, and Siva's vehicle, the bull Nandi.

On the rock-face adjoining the cave is a finely wrought medallion of the Siva Family: Lord Siva, his consort Parvati, their sons Kartik and Ganesh, and Nandi.

Some distance down the road are other important caves and the rock-cut steps accessing them.

The first cave is the Varaha Cave, Cave 5. Varaha is the third incarnation of the preserver, Lord Vishnu. (See Box - The Avatars) He is credited with raising the earth out of the abyss. This is depicted graphically on the face of this rock-shelter: it is not, really, a cave. On a surface of 6.5m x 4m, Varaha has been carved as a heroic boar, standing in the ocean, lifting the beautiful woman, Earth known as Prithvi or Bhoo-Devi, who hangs on to his tusks. His heroic rescue is applauded by celestial beings gazing down at him from the sky.

The cave on the same rock-face has nothing in it. The entrance to the cave is flanked by guards or dwara-palas, Vishnu, Ganesh and the Mother Goddess in her aspect as Mahesha- suramardini slaying the Buffalo of Ignorance.

From here the visitor, climbing up the rock-cut steps, and turning left about a third of the way up, reaches Cave No7.This has a lotus carved on the ceiling and was made on the orders of a Minister of Chandragupt. Since the majority of these caves have been dated to the Gupta dynasty, it is likely that the 'Chandragupt' referred to here was of that era and was not the great Emperor Chandragupta Maurya.

After this there is a slightly hazardous scramble over rocks, on the left, to reach Cave No.4. This is a cave, not a rock-shelter. It holds a very unusual shivling with the face of Parvati carved on it.

Adjoining this is Cave No. 3 with a standing figure of Siva's son, the warrior-god Kartik but without his vehicle, a peacock.

THE AVATARS

Indian savants pre-empted Darwin's Theory of Evolution by many thousands of years. They expressed it in the doctrine of the avatars or Reincarnations of the Pre- server, Lord Vishnu.

In a slim religious textbook of the virtue of duty, called the Bhagvat Gita, Lord Vishnu says:

"Age after Age I come
To redeem the sin of the sinner
And to restore Righteousness."

According to Brahmanical doctrine, these reincarnations of the Preserver take forms suitable to the age. The most widely accepted Ten Incarnations, or Dus Avatar, are:

Matsya, the fish
Kurma, the tortoise
Varaha, the boar
Narasimha, the beast man
Vaman, the dwarf
Parusuram, the forest dweller
Ram, the ideal ruler
Krishna, the social man
Buddha, the philosophical man
Kalki, an equestrian which is a futuristic symbolic representation.

Many of the Brahmanical beliefs are couched in allegories, awaiting interpretation when mankind's knowledge has advanced sufficiently. In this case, it seems clear that the Brahmanical seers had realised that life emerged in the sea, had crawled out of the blood-warm waters as a tortoise does, stepped onto the swamps of early earth as a wild boar does, evolved into a giant Neanderthal ape-man, then into our first proto-human the tiny Rama pithecus.

From there humans advanced socially into forest dwellers whose ideal is Parusuram or Rama-of-the-Axe, the law-abiding inhab- itants of great kingdoms as Lord Ram the Prince of Ayodhya was, the citizens of lib- eral societies patterned on Lord Krishna, on to thinkers and international citizens of the questing Information Age exemplified in Lord Buddha. And finally, into the Bionic Man in which the mind and will of man will be housed in an imperishable silicon body. To the Brahamanical futurologists this last step in mankind's evolution could best be conveyed by depicting a sort of man-animal hybrid, a centaur form which is a combina- tion of a man and his vehicle. That is how the last avatar, the avatar to come, Kalki, has been depicted in Brahmanical iconography.

Maheshasuramardini slays the Buffalo of Ignorance

Back on the rock-cut steps, and after a short ascent, lies the rock-shelter Cave No. 13 with a large carving of the Preserver Vishnu reclining on the coils of the serpent Sheshshayi.

Climbing to the top of the rock-cut steps, and walking across a flat area, the visitor will reach a hill rising at the back. It should not take more then ten minutes to reach the hill. On this hill lies Cave No. 1: a pillared portico built in front of a cave. According to architectural historian Satish Grover:

The oldest shrines of the Hindu religion, true to the national genius, are

In Udaygiri the preserve rests on the primeval ocean

once again a group of caves carved out of a mountain side at Udaigiri.

The gazetteer adds:

Architecturally, Cave No. 1 is of considerable interest as it represents the earliest phase in the development of tem- ple architecture in India planned as it is with a small shrine and a simple porch in front. The enshrined figure was originally hewn out of the solid rock at the back of the temple

It seems to have been chiselled off but the outline remains. It would appear to have been a depiction of the Brahmanical Sun God, Surya. Near it is a newly installed image of a Jain Tirthankar. It could be a statue of the Tirthankar Sitalnath because he was said to have been born in this area.

Visitors are discouraged from going to the hazardous Jaina caves further up the hill rising from the motor road.

In Cave No. 4 : Parvati carved on a shivling

EXPLORER'S MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF VIDISHA

UDAYAPUR

This is for those explorers who are interested in old architecture.

The town, today, is a very sad reflection of what it must have been when it was founded by the Paramar king Udayaditya in the lat- ter half of the 11th century. It is 55 kms from Vidisha and the visi- tor will have to drive through nar- row, winding lanes to get to Uday- apur's greatest attraction: the soaring Neelkantheshwar Temple.

Neelkantheshwar Temple

It was constructed between the years 1059 and 1080. Like the famed temples of Khajuraho, Neelkantheshwar is covered in carvings. Even though many of them have been defaced by vandals and iconoclasts, there are enough of them left to hold the visitor's interest for a long time. Do, in particular, look carefully at the three entrance porches. And do not miss raising you eyes to examine their ceilings: they have been exquisitely carved like enormous, exotic, unfolding flowers. So too are the pillars and ceiling of the vestibule, where a large Nandi bull - the vehicle of Lord Siva - faces the sanctum. In the sanctum the idol is a huge shivling, covered in brass, with the crowned head of Siva on it. It was presented to the temple by a general of Mahadji Scindia in 1775. This is illuminated by the rising sun every morning. Behind the shivling is an idol of a black Parvati draped in a red sari.

There are four small standing shrines around the main temple and an unusual havan pavilion. A havan is a sacred fire ritual undertaken by worshipers seeking a favour.

The richly carved Neelkantheshwar Temple

Very unusually, the architect has had his own image placed high up in the tower as if he were surveying his own handiwork!

Between 1336 and 1338, Muhammed Tughlaq, had a mosque built to the left of the entrance to the grounds of the temple.

Out of the temple, then, and down a narrow lane, stands the oddly-named Pisanhari Temple.

Pisanhari Temple

It is a single-celled temple with a tower and a flat-roofed porch. Inside is a black shivling, a small idol of Parvati in a red sari standing in an alcove to one side and, as always, Nandi in the portico gazing into the idol of his Lord.

The story is that the raja donated this temple in honour of the woman who ground spices and wheat for the court. Pisan means to grind.

From here, down more narrow lanes, is the Pillared Shahi Mosque.

Shahi Mosque

Reputedly commenced in the reign of Jehangir and completed in that of Shah Jehan in 1632, this is a simple, long, pillared structure in the unostentatious style of early Mughal buildings. Within sight of this living mosque are the walls of the old fort.

On the way out of Udayapur, are the remains of the Barakhambi.

Barakhambi

It is a pillared hall standing alone in a scrub-covered wilderness: all that remains of a large temple built in the 11th century. If you want to walk across to have a closer look, do watch your step or else you might stumble or twist your ankle.

Another destination with a number of architectural monuments, and 31 kms from Vidisha, is Gyaraspur.

GYARASPUR

Historians and archaeologists believe that this was a very important city in the medieval age. The large number of ruins dotted around indicate that it came under the influence of Buddhism, Brahmanism and Jainism. In fact the beautiful Shalbhanjika, which is often regarded as being more beautiful than the Venus de Milo, was found here. It is now housed in the Gujari Mahal, State Archaeological Museum, in Gwalior.

Among the more important monuments in this historic place - many believe that it is the most important monument in Gyaraspur Bajramath Temple.

Bajramath Temple

It is certainly very accessible, standing, as it does, adjacent to the town's playing field where amateur cricketers hone their skills.

It is clearly a Brahmanical temple standing on a high plinth with three shrines, or cells, placed abreast: rather unusual. The carvings on the doorways, and above them, are particularly attractive. The descriptive board in the temple's grounds says

Originally a triple-shrined Brahmanical temple dedicated to Surya, Vishnu and Shiva. This temple contains three shrines in a row now occupied by Jaina figures. It is assignable to about the 10th century AD.

If the explorer is lucky, there might be a colourful weekly fair, or haat, in progress just off the road that leads to the Athakhambe and Chaukhambe.

The torana gate and the ruins of a great temple

Athakhambe and Chaukhambe

These names merely describe a monument with Eight Pillars, and another with Four Pillars. They are, according to archaeologists, all that remains of two temples dating to the 9th and 10th centuries. Judging from the beautifully carved pillars, the temples must have been imposing structures before they fell to the ravages of time, or vandals.

From here, halfway up the hill that rises above the town, are the even more fascinating pillars called the Hindola Torana.

Hindola Torana

This is, literally, the Swing En- trance because the most elaborately carved pillars resemble the trestles on which swings hang.

This was once the entrance to a large temple dedicated either to Vishnu or to the Trimurthi - the Brahmanical trinity of Brahma, the Creator, Vishnu, the Preserver, and Siva, the Destroyer. All around them are dressed stones from the destroyed structure. A descriptive board reads.

This ornamental gateway was the entrance to a magnificent Brahmanical Temple of which only the plinth re- mains. And four central pillars of the mandapa. The torana has the ten incar- nations of Vishnu and is assignable to about the 10th century AD.

A torana is a welcoming arch or ceremonial gateway. A mandapa is a pavilion for ceremonies or in which

pilgrims can rest.

Driving on a winding road up the hill, stop at the highest point. The view of the valley at your feet is beautiful and stretches all the way to the horizon. There are small clusters of villages, the bright patchwork of fields, silver ribbons of irrigation ditches, the shimmering blue spread of a reservoir held back by the earthwork of a dam. It looks as unreal as the setting of an animation film.

From here it's a short walk over the crest of the hill to the Mala Devi Temple.

Mala Devi Temple

In front of the temple is a descriptive board that claims

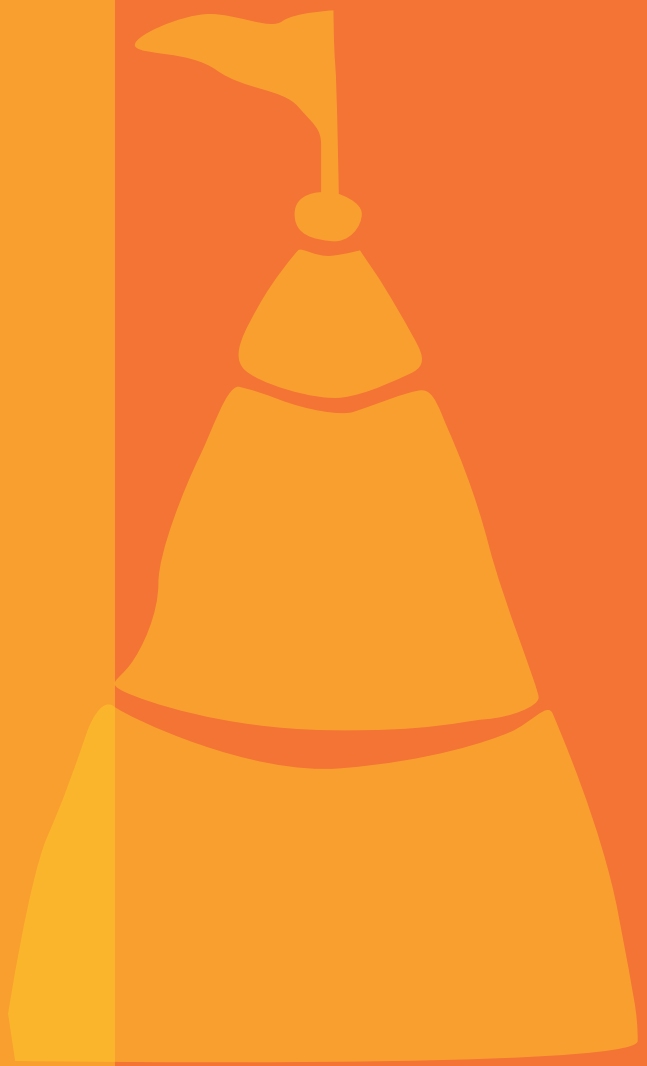
This is a Jain temple, a richly carved magnificent edifice comprising an entrance porch, a hall and a sanctum which is partly rock-cut and is surrounded by an ambula- tory and crowned by a lofty shikara. It is assignable to about the 9th century AD.

That is the official opinion and to the left, in the hall, there is a Jaina statue about 2.5 to 3.5 metres tall. But, in the sanctum, there is a statue which could be that of a Jaina Trithankar because of the groin-covering position of the hands. But it carries neither the diamond-shaped heart-emblem nor the identifying symbol unique to each of the 24 Thirthankars, so it could also be a statue of a Buddha. Outside, there are carvings of female figures which are common to Brahmanical, Buddhist and Jaina temples. And then there is the name: Mala Devi. This would, normally, give a strong impression that it is a Brahmanical temple. While Brahmanical tradition forbids the worship of damaged idols, such a prohibition does not apply to the Jaina faith. Buddhists, however, have not been known to take over the abandoned shrines of other faiths. On assessment, therefore, the identity of this temple would seem to remain an open question till some dedicated explorer uncovers convincing evidence one way or another.

The Mala Devi Temple

Pilgrim Centres

Amarkantak
Chitrakoot
Maheshwar
Maihar
Mandsaur
Omkareshwar
Ujjain



DISCOVERING MADHYA PRADESH

Pilgrimage

Religion plays a very important role in the lives of most Indians, often in marked contrast to their public image.
In his famous work, "The Pilgrim's Progress", John Bunyan wrote:

I'll fear not what men say
I'll labour night and day
To be a pilgrim.

In marked contrast to the attitude of the English of those days, Indian society has always been far more tolerant of a person's personal beliefs. And pilgrimages continue to play a significant, and accepted, role in the socio-cultural life of many people.

Pilgrimages are voyages powered by faith. A pilgrim journeys because he believes in the spiritual rewards that such an endeavour will shower on him. This belief is reinforced by the experiences of other like-minded souls who feel that they, too, have benefited by their pilgrimage.
But though pilgrim spots might have grown around something so intangi- ble as faith, there are very substantial spin-offs from the burgeoning streams of pilgrims who pour in. The destination grows, shrines arise drawing on the inexhaustible treasures of religious literature, traditions and folklore. The hallowed place becomes a virtual repository of the myriad facets of an ancient, living faith.
Amarkantak glitters with the web of beliefs associated with a powerful, sa- cred river that has flowed through the racial memories of farming communi- ties for many millennia. Chitrakoot reverberates with the cadence of the world's longest epic of intrigue, betrayal, exile and triumph: much of it happened here, according to the faithful. Maheshwar enshrines the memory of a diminutive but steel-willed queen whose reign was so just and benevolent that she has been dei-fied. She also created a famed weave of fabrics that has captured the imaginations of 21st century designers and couturiers.
Maihar is a hill-top shrine dedicated to the Mother Goddess. Reputedly very ancient, its popularity is growing as pilgrims carry back tales of the changes it has wrought in their stressed 21st century lives. Omkareshwar, the island shaped like the primordial sound OM, is dotted with temples associated with Siva, the Destroyer of evil and ignorance, the blue-throated Lord who will bring about the dissolution of Creation and then, after the dark night of nothingness, restore it by his Cosmic Dance. He also rules over Ujjain as The Lord of Time. This city, with incredibly complex roots deep into India's kaleidoscopic past, touches the childhood of the divine hero, Krishna; glows with the terrifying tale of Siva's devastating dance; holds one of the four immortal wish fulfilling trees, and is the home of two scholars in whose skills lie the predicted futures of countless mil- lions of people in India and abroad.
When you walk through the pilgrim centres of Madhya Pradesh you im- merse yourself in the scintillating ocean of beliefs that sustain the wonder that is our land, and our people.

The devotee in the Narmada Udgam

Amarkantak

When Brahma, the Creator, wept, two rivers emerged in Amarkantak.

From the tear of his right eye was born the great Narmada: one of the seven sacred rivers of India. It flowed across our land to the west and south to merge with the Arabian Sea. The tear from his left eye became the Sone, coursing north and east till it met the holy Ganga, the Ganges, on the plains of Bihar. There it joined that mighty flood to water the great mangrove delta of the Sundarbans and pour into the Bay of Bengal. That's the legend of their birth, capturing the life-enriching qualities of these two great rivers. And Amarkantak has benefited greatly by their presence.

A complex of white shrines sparkling in the sun

THE STONE-AGE GALLERY

The revered source of the great Narmada

From its source in Amarkantak, the river flows for 1,300 kms and enters the Arabian Sea Gulf of Cambay through a 27 kms broad estuary below Broach.

The government's official publication, the Gazetteer, says that the Narmada is not mentioned in the ancient scripture of the Aryans called the Rig Veda since the first wave of Aryan migrants into Northern India had not probably penetrated far into the peninsula beyond the Iodo-Gangetic plain.

Apart from the legend that the river sprang from a tear of the Creator, Lord Brahma, another legend says that the river was created in the form of a lovely dam- sel whose beauty captivated the gods and brought them all to her feet. Shiva laughed when he saw the enamoured gods and named her Narmada, or 'delight-giving'.

In Central India, the Narmada is held to be far more sacred than any other stream, so much so that even the Ganga is supposed to come and dip in it once a year. She comes in the form of a coal-black cow and returns home pure white free from all sins. The mere sight of the Narmada is equivalent to a bath in the Ganga, and such are its virtues that all the sins of a person who sees or dips into it are removed.

This ancient pilgrim town in the Maikal Range, is green with forests, gentled with soft wetlands and streams, and serene with temples and shrines.

There is a certain laid-back atmosphere about this place, curiously free of the hustle and bustle associated with most other pilgrim towns. It almost feels as if the rivers, forests and mountains have imposed their own age-spanning world-view on Amarkantak, setting a measured, unhurried pace which absorbs anxiety and stress, attunes one to the heart-beat of nature.

Even the mighty Narmada, that roars and fumes in the great Dhuandhar Falls in distant Bhedaghat, is a tiny trickle of water in a white shrine

in the most important temple in Amarkantak, the Narmada Udgam.

NARMADA UDGAM

This is, in fact, a walled complex of white shrines sparkling in the sunlight, grouped around two tanks. The Narmada is born in the basement of a single celled temple. (See Box: The Narmada) On the wall behind this seemingly insignificant little spring, is an image of the beautiful Goddess, Narmada Devi.

Devotees step down to the level of the small pond at the base of the spring, scoop up water in their hands, and sprinkle it on the image of the goddess. The water from this tank flows into a larger tank around the main group of temples, then into a smaller tank. From there it is led under the road from where it pours out through the traditional Gao Mukh (Cow's Mouth) spout into the largest tank served by the steps of a ghat. From these steps pilgrims have their religious baths, purifying themselves in the cleansing waters of the holy river.

From there the Narmada flows on, gathering strength from the many lit- tle streams fed by the wetlands of Amarkantak. It is best to follow the further course of the river after you have seen the other interesting places in the town and its environs.

Some idea of the age of this town can be had from the complex of old ASI Protected Temples.

THE KALACHURIS

The name Kalachuri does not appear to be Sanskritic, and has been connected with the Turkish word Kuluchur indicat- ing an officer of high rank. This, if cor- rect, would point to a foreign origin for the dynasty and they may have entered India with the Hunas and Gujaras. The Kala- churi kings used an era, called Chedi or Kalachuri samvat, according to which the reckoning commenced from September 25 in AD 249,

The early Kalachuris rose into prominence in the sixth century AD. A branch of this celebrated dynasty was then ruling a fairly extensive territory comprising portions of Gujarat, Khandesh and Malwa They were an aggressive dynasty, fighting with their neighbours, annexing their territories to their own. But they were also attacked as often and had to surrender parts of their domains.

In spite of the fact that their kingdom grew and shrank in size frequently, the Kalachuris remained a force to be reckoned with for six centuries. Then they ceased to exist. The last acceptable inscription to mention the Kalachuris is from AD 1240. No one knows why they vanished. In all likelihood it was because of internal weak- nesses and the rise of new powers.

The Kalachuris had appeared unheralded on the bright stage of history. And they disappeared as mysteriously into the darkness.

ASI PROTECTED TEMPLES

These monuments are no longer living temples and are under the protection of the Archaeological Survey of India. The oldest group of temples, on the left of the entrance to the complex, was built in the 10th century by the Kalachuri dynasty. (See Box: Kalachuris) From the temple on the extreme left a beautiful Vishnu statue was stolen by an art smuggler, but it was recovered and is now displayed in the safety of the ASI Museum at Rewa. There is another Vishnu statue in its original place but it is now protected by a heavy mesh.

To the right, and behind a small tank, are more recent temples built by a later dynasty of rulers. They are about 200 years old.

The ground of this temple complex rises up to two temples built in the curvilinear style of the eastern state of Orissa. They have been cleaned and restored by ASI experts.

Returning on the road that leads past the main Narmada Udgam temple, visitors come to the Gayatri Sarova.

GAYATRI SAROVA

This was built by the state's Tourism Department and when a favourable monsoon fills it, visitors could be offered relaxing boat rides.

There is an interesting temple still being built, which seems to be called by two distinct names Karna Math Mandir aka Maha Meru Sri Yantra Mandir of Tripur Sundari.

KARNA MATH MANDIR AKA MAHA MERU SRI YANTRA MANDIR OF TRIPUR SUNDARI

Even before it has been completed, it is rich with intriguing icons. The gate is crowned by four enormous faces of the Mother Goddess. Statues of the 64 yoginis, varied aspects of the Mother Goddess, embellish its walls. The spire of the temple rises in the form of a stylised Mount Meru. Enormous snakes form the balustrades and encircle the base of the temple. The idealised Mount Meru could represent the continental masses which rest on the slowly coiling currents of molten rock known as Magma: graphically conjuring up the coils of a giant serpent!

Mother goddesses play a significant role in Hindu iconography. Most rivers are represented by goddesses including the Narmada. The Sone is an exception. Some distance away from the temple to the Mother Goddess, and towards the edge of the escarpment, is a tiny shrine under a mango tree. This is called the Sone Bhadra Maharaj.

The Karna Math Mandir

The Kalchuri Temple eleven centuries old

SONE BHADRA MAHARAJ

Here, again, the river starts as a trickle but it rapidly gathers strength. The trickle is collected in a small tank and it then flows into a larger tank. Now it pours through a buried pipe to become a chortling, gushing, mountain stream with a flight of 130 steps on one of its banks. Clearly more wetland water flows into it, even on this short course, because the trickle that emerges from the Sone Bhadra Maharaj could not possibly have created this gush of water. At the far end, the stream that is the Sone, tumbles down the cliff in a waterfall. This is the start of its long north-eastern journey to its confluence with the Ganga.

From the Sone there is a pleasant drive around the hill and through beautiful forests of the hardwood saal (that's how it's pronounced, though it's usually spelt sal). This leads to a curious place called the Mai ka Bagicha.

MAI KA BAGICHA

This Garden of the Mother has two small shrines: one with a small idol of the Goddess Narmada; the other with the idols of both Narmada and Parvati, the consort of Siva. The most significant part of Mai ka Bagicha is a small wetland in which white lilies stand. Devotees believe that these plants grow only here and nowhere else in the world. In fact they are Ginger Lilies that are cultivated as garden plants in the Himalayas.

There is also a belief that the Narmada actually starts in this small marsh, disappears underground, and re-appears in the Narmada Udgam. Faith often establishes links that evade the cold eye of logic.

About 6 km from the source of the Narmada, and on the way down from Amarkantak, there are attractive waterfalls known as the Kapil Dhara and the Dugdh Dhara.

KAPIL DHARA AND THE DUGDH DHARA

The Kapil Dhara is associated with the legendary sage Kapil or Kapila: he reputedly spent 12 years here deeply immersed in meditative austerities. Here, too, the young Narmada pours down the escarpment in a gushing waterfall and depressions in the water-worn rocks, before the cascade, are said to be the footprints of that powerful seer. The base of the falls, on the rocky banks of the brisk, blue stream that is the Narmada, is a favoured picnic spot with visi- tors. Those who are a shade more adventurous often opt to trek for a further one kilometre or so to the next Narmada falls: the Dugdh Dhara. In both spots people delight in the fact that this pilgrimage to Amarkantak, unlike many oth- ers, has been a happy combination of religious duty and relaxation in a gentle, green environment.

View Point

The Narmada's Dugdhdhara Falls

Accommodation in Amarkantak

MPT Holiday Homes

9111401044

hhamarkantak@mpstdc.com

Facilities

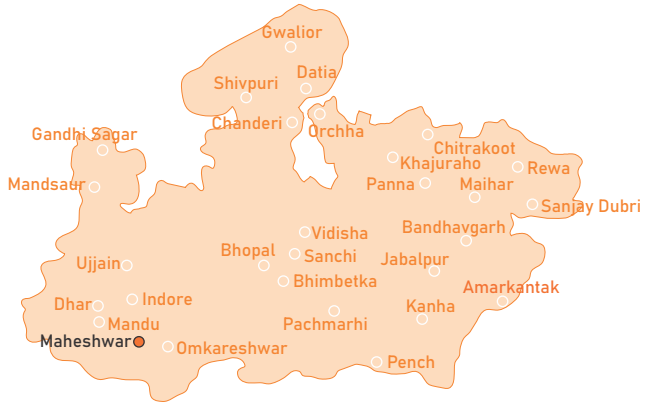
AC Rooms | Conference Hall | Restaurant | Wifi

Transport

MPT Holiday Homes of 'MPT Hotels & Resorts' hosts you while you are in Amarkantak, the city of the birth of the holy river Narmada. A 10 min walk will take you to Narmada Udgam temple. Its quality food, clean ambience and location make it an ideal family as well as business hotel. Its exceptional guest service make it the best hotel of the pilgrim town. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Maheshwar

The memory of one remarkable woman dominates Maheshwar: the diminutive but powerful Queen Ahilyabai.



To this day, more than 210 years after her death, Ahilyabai's reign is still a reality in the quiet town that was her capital for almost three decades. It's there in the impressive ghats, or riverine landings, rising from the broad flow of the Narmada. One can see it in soaring temples and cenotaphs. It's in the sound of clacking looms creating the old weaves of the famed Maheshwari hand-woven fabrics. It is in the smile of a woman vending fruit: "Of course I'm happy. Everyone is happy when Ahilyabai Devi watches over us!" Devi is a title reserved for a goddess. The reverence in which the people of Maheshwar hold her has deified Ahilyabai (See Box - The Greatly Revered Ahilyabai)

An array of Maheshwari saris

The Ahilya Fort

THE GREATLY REVERED AHILYABAI

Great achievers are magnets for legends and it is not easy to winnow fact from adulation. There is, for instance, the oft-repeated tale that when Rani Ahilyabai sat in court, even birds would not fly overhead! A more plausible legend speaks of her induction into the Holkar family.

According to the story, Ahilyabai was a child of eight when Malhar Rao Holkar, military governor of the Malwa region, stopped at Chondi village on his way to his ruler's capital in Pune. He was impressed by the way this little girl conducted herself at a temple service. He brought the child to his mansion and had her groomed to be a bride for his son Khande Rao.

In those days, child marriages were common, all over the world, so were arranged marriages with parents actively involved in seeking 'suitable matches' for their children, Besides, women did not have much say in the conduct of their lives: which is all the more reason to admire Ahilyabai's outstanding success in a male-dominated world.

She was widowed when she was just 29 and, if she had followed the tradition of those days, should have thrown herself on her husband's funeral pyre, and died in a socially sanctioned rite called sati. Most unusually, her father-in-law prevented her from taking this extreme step. Legend has it that Malhar Rao Holkar had trained her in both administrative work and military affairs. She excelled in both.

Once, when a neighbour wanted to seize her territories on the death of Malhar Rao, legend has it that she sent turbans to all the other chieftains and asked them to come to the aid of their 'sister'. They appeared with their armies on her borders, scaring her would-be attacker.

Besides, everyone realised that this physi- cally small woman had the unquestioning loyalty of both her troops and her people.

And also the protection of all the gods in the pantheon as well as the powerful Brahmins she had given generously to charity and for the building and restoration of temples. The powers ranged behind her were formidable!

Ahilyabai's wise and just reign came to an end with her death in 1795. But there has been a lasting consequence of her send- ing turbans to the other Maratha chieftains.

When their wives met her they said, according to legend. "You've given turbans to our husbands, but what have you given to us?" Ahilyabai gave an order, immediately, for the weavers of Surat who had made the turbans, to create a special weave for the saris she intended to present to the women of her supporting chieftains. In fact, she went further than that. She invited the weavers to bring their looms and their families and to relocate themselves in her capital. This, according to a strong local belief. was the beginning of the weaving industry in Maheshwar.

The best view of Ahilyabai's heritage is from a boat sailing down the Narmada. The spires of temples rise like the ones near the memorial to Yeshvanti Rao Fanse, followed by the Vittaleshwar Temple also known as the Pandhari Nath Temple. All temples are wreathed with legends, often conflicting. For these two temples it's best to get them from the temple authorities and the guides, and then decide which is more interesting! Flights of steps descend from these temples to the water, they are alive with people bathing in the Narmada or worshipping it with flowers, incense, bells, chants and oil-lamps.

A more elaborate worship is carried out during the Narmada Festival.

NARMADA FESTIVAL

Its formal name is the Narmada Jayanti. Donations are collected from all who want to celebrate this festival and an order is placed with weavers in Surat, in Gujarat, to make a 1,000 m long cotton sari. When sufficient funds have been collected, the date is set between 15th November and 15th December. The sari is stretched across the river as an offering. Coconuts are thrown into the river and people tear off small pieces of the now-consecrated sari and place it on their altars at home. No one knows when, or how, this unique ritual started in honour of the sacred river.

The Narmada at Maheshwar seems to be deepest a little after the ghats - guides insist that it is appreciably more than 80 m to the bottom but it gets shallower towards the middle where green reed-beds break the surface. Here, on a small island, is the lonely Baneshwar Temple.

BANESHWAR TEMPLE

This single-celled shrine, rising atop a short flight of steps from the water's edge, was built by Anand Raj Parmar in the 5th century. Outside, there is a panel depicting a man on elephant-back fighting a curious monster with a long

The Baneshwar Temple in the middle of the Narmada

The Ghat

reptilian neck and a lion's mouth. The story that this represents a monster that lurks in the river, is just not true. There is a shivling inside the Baneshwar Temple and it seems to be very popular. When the river is in spate, it could be completely submerged.

The river's high-water flood level has been marked in the forecourt that leads to the gate of the huge cenotaph of Ahilyabai.

After visiting the island-temple, head back across the river to the vast fan-sweep of the Royal Ghats.

ROYAL GHATS

These are really very imposing and were created by Ahilyabai's daughter-in law because she did not find the queen's original cenotaph impressive enough. If you disembark at the foot of the Royal Ghats, with the fan of steps rising in front of you, head left. There you will find the single-celled, very insignificant, original chhatri, or cenotaph, of Ahilyabai. It has a stepped roof and stands on a platformí. It is an unassuming structure. Clearly the queen was not only very great, she was also very humble.

On her death, in 1795, her daughter-in-law, Krishnabai, decided to erect a more fitting cenotaph of Ahilyabai.

CENOTAPH OF AHILYABAI

She started by having some of the old, river-fronting, retaining wall of the fort that encloses the palace torn down. It was then stepped back from the banks of the river as far as it could without endangering the royal complex.
She also commissioned two artisans from Rajasthan, the brothers Bhujdar and Gajdar, to redesign and construct both the retaining wall and the new cenotaph. They went about their job with considerable flair.

In place of the bare retaining wall they created a Rajasthani palace wall with arches, balconies and oriel windows. Into it they let a fortress gate atop a flight of steps that fanned out like the terminal moraine of a glacier. On top of the gate they sculpted the figures of men playing most of the traditional musical instruments of India. The gate accesses a court.

In the middle of this court is a rather Islamic-looking domed structure,

The Queen's cenotaph,

profusely decorated. This is the cenotaph, or chhatri of Vithoji Rao. This Holkar prince turned brigand out of frustration that he could not ascend to the throne. He was caught and the irate Peshwa had Vithoji Rao chained to an elephant's foot and dragged around till he died in great agony. His ashes were brought back to Maheshwar and placed in this cenotaph.

Facing Vithoji Rao's chhatri across the court, is a short flight of steps leading to Ahilyabai's cenotaph built by her daughter-in law. It is a powerful structure, resembling a temple: a black curvilinear tower rising from a white lower floor, and clearly visible from the river.

Before you leave the court, do notice the flood-level mark inscribed at the side of the steps. As in all agricultural countries, from the days of the rising of the Nile in ancient Egypt, flooding rivers have been both a bane and a boon: they cause tremendous destruction to towns and settlements along their banks, but they also lay down rich silt that renews the fertility of the fields.

At the head of the steps, and turning left, another long flight of steps leads past the Maheshwar weaving centre, under the sponsorship of the Holkar family (See Box - The Maheshwari Weaves) and up to a court in front of the Palace Complex.

THE MAHESHWARI WEAVES

A Maheshwari weaver at his loom

The Holkar family continues to support the handloom weavers of Mahesh war. According to handicrafts expert Kamaladevi Chattopadyay, the first Maheshwari sari was designed by Ahi- lyabai herself. The pattern of the weaves range from plain to variations of checks and stripes. The plain ones are called mid- night blue or Chandrakala, and Baigaini (or brinjals also known as aubergines) Chandrakala has a deep violet warp and a chocolate weft. The moon-and-star design, or Chandratara, has four stripes of one shade alternating with one stripe of another shade. The Beli is described as "lengthwise stripes of six dents of two shades, two dents of one, and four of another. Parbi is a chequered counterpart of Beli" There are, in fact, about 100 origi- nal designs, including Hansa, Chatti and Meena. The original design was Bugdi, and it was reversible.

The warp of these saris, that is the threads that are stretched on the loom, are silk. The weft, created by the action of the shuttle through the warp, is cotton. Nowadays the weavers also create chunni- scarves, the over-shirt and pyjamas known as salwar kameezes or 'suits', and shawls of light wool and silk.

The craft inspired by Ahilyabai's gift to the ladies of her allies has thus blossomed into a thriving cottage industry famed for the quality of its fabrics.

PALACE COMPLEX

From the court, the old palace does not look very impressive: a long, double-storeyed building, very plain and bare of any carvings or decorations normally associated with palaces in our land. The part of the palace still in the possession of the Holkars is, visually at least, far more palatial. That part, however, is not open to casual visitors. This section is, and it is from here that Ahilyabai administered justice.

In deference to the memory of 'Ahilyabai Devi' this wing of the palace is accorded much of the respect given to a shrine. Visitors have to remove their footwear at the gate. Inside is a shaded forecourt with a statue of Lord Krishna, and another of Parvati and Ganesh. Beyond is the gallery from where Ahilyabai dispensed justice from her gaddi, a throne-like divan. It holds a sitting statue of the queen.

A board says that she ruled from 1765 to 1795. It asserts that she rebuilt the Vishvanath Temple in Varanasi and that she treated her Muslim and Hindu subjects 'on par'. It goes on to say

Her living quarters were on the first floor and administrative offices on the ground floor... She wanted to commit sati when her husband died but her father-in- law persuaded her not to as he had need of her help in administering his domains.

Because of that far-seeing decision, the memory of the little queen continues to permeate old Maheshwar.

Facing the Narmada from Fort

The River Narmada

Accommodation in Maheshwar

MPT Narmada Resort

8349994783

maheshwar@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Conference Hall | Restaurant | Parking

Swimming Pool

MPT Narmada Resort is located right on the lap of the holy Narmada. One can behold the grand expanse of the river right from our hotel. With this auspicious view and the best food in the town, MPT Narmada Resort is a perfect place stay while you are holidaying in this erstwhile Holkar stronghold. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

The temple crowns a wooden hill

Maihar

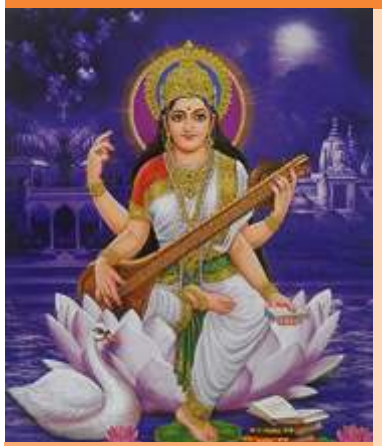
It is a Temple of the Arts, Sciences, Speech and Music; but the complex of Maihar, sitting atop a wooded hill, has no faculty, no school, college, or university. It does not even award any degrees, diplomas or certificates. And yet it attracts thousands of people to its hallowed portals every year.

The long streams of pilgrims who pour into Maihar everyday, their eyes fixed fervently on the white shrine atop a wooded hill, are driven by a single desire. They want to have a darshan, a merit-enhancing sight, of the sacred idol of Sharda Mata: 'Mother Sharda'. (See Box - Saraswati)

Cars have to park in a lot outside the main shopping area at the foot of the hill.

Devotees enjoying the scenic view from temple

SARASWATI



Saraswati, the goddess of learning and the Arts, the personification of an ancient river

Saraswati is the beautiful, white, god- dess of an ancient river. Folklorists believe that this river was one of the boundaries of Brahmavarta, the home of the early Ary- ans, as the Ganga, the Ganges, became the boundary of their descendants. In those early days it flowed, white and clear, from the Himalayas to the sea and bestowed fertility, fatness and wealth to the people who had built their settlements on her banks Earth movements and climate change, interpreted as the wrath of semi-divine beings, made her vanish underground and emerge as a mysterious, subterranean, stream under the visible confluence of the Ganga and Jamuna also called the Yamuna.

In the Brahmanical pantheon Saraswati is the wife of Brahma, the Cre- ator, the goddess of speech and learning, and the divine being who gave the world the meticulously structured Sanskrit language and its phonetically accurate Devnagri script. The grammar of the language and the pronunciation of the Devnagri alphabet are so unvaryingly specific that they could serve as a mathematically accurate and universal computer language.

Saraswati is depicted as a fair woman in a sari, riding a swan, playing a vina or lute, and holding a book or manuscript. There is a curious trans- continental simi- larity between her and the White Goddess of Inspiration of ancient European mystic lore written about by poet Robert Graves. The many aspects of Saraswati could however, vary in appearance, as do the many aspects of the Christian Virgin Mary depending on the perceptions of her devotees. Saraswati is also identified with Vach, the goddess of speech. Her other names are Bharati, Brahmi, Put- kari, Vagiswari and Sarada.

In Maihar, she is worshipped as Sar- ada or Sharda

An exception is made for those who have reservations in the Surbahar hotel run by the Madhya Pradesh Tourism Development Corporation. It has parking space in its walled grounds beyond the traffic barrier. From here there are two ways of getting up to the temple. One can either walk up 1,152 steps; or one can hire one of the shuttle-service taxis run by the temple authorities which start from the base of the hill, where the market ends.

On the grounds in front of the double-arched gateways leading to the pedestrian path up the hill, is the market. It is as kaleidoscopic as a teeming, vibrant fair. Brightly dressed pilgrims shop for religious scarves, coconuts, coloured powder, brass oil lamps, trinkets, toys and photographs of Sharda Mata. There is a constant ebb and flow of people, the buzz of conversation, the importuning of beggars sequestered in their own area behind fences, and the sound of religious chants amplified through loud-speakers.

Statues of a golden lion and lioness stand atop the gateway on either side of

Devotees in the premises of Maa Sharda Devi Temple

a small image of Sharda Mata. Two more statues of guards, painted bright red, stand against the side pillars of the arch; the central pillar is guarded by a red Hanuman. This plethora of images probably owes as much to the legends woven around the goddess as it does to the princely family of martial Rajputs who once ruled this area. Beyond the ornate gateway rises the wooded hill on which the white temple stands. And, as a backdrop to this stand-alone hill, hunches the green Kaimore Range.

The tarred motor road starts from one side of the pedestrian complex fronting the gateway, and winds up the hill. At the upper end of this soaring road, a flight of 194 canopied steps, with protective railings, zig-zags up to the temple. Atop the steps is a flat, paved, area with a tree shading a shivling. Beyond the shivling and at the end of the paved yard, a short flight of steps rises to the railed queues stretching past the sanctum holding the revered idol of Sharda Mata.

The sanctum glitters with embossed silver. The idol is in the cen- tre of the silver sanctum and is covered in garlands so that only her black face. and the silver crown are visible. Her eyes are almond-shaped and glisten in a manner that is a feature of most idols of tribal, and not necessarily Brahmanical, deities. Like many old religions, Hinduism has absorbed the traditions of faiths pre-dating the worship of Brahmanical deities in an unquestioningly tolerant and

eclectic way. It is the custom here for the pujari, the officiating priest, to receive the offerings made by devotees, touch them to the idol in symbolical acceptance, and then give them back.

Leaving the sanctum to its right, the queue moves forward, turning right at an idol of Hanuman, leaving it to the left. On the right, now, is an idol of Narsingh also known as Narasimha: the man-lion. He is the fourth incarnation of the Preserver, Vishnu: the earlier three are the fish, the tortoise and the boar. Those who believe that Brahmanical seers pre-empted Darwin, contend that this avatara, or incarnation, represents Neanderthal man. After passing the idol of Narsingh, there is an idol of Kali Ma, literally the Black Mother, against the wall ahead. She is one of the most fearsome aspects of the Mother Goddess and

Cable car to reach to the temple

her mission is to destroy the dark monster of Ignorance and Evil. Leaving Narsingh on the right and Kali on the left, the queue walks out of the sanctum and into a tree-shaded, paved, open court with benches. On the right of this runs a platform with four small shrines and pujaris in attendance: your last opportunity to make offerings to the temple of Sharda Mata before starting down the sacred hill.

Devotees believe that when they have the intense experience of a spiritual encounter with this powerful aspect of the Goddess, their natural mental faculties and talents will be significantly enhanced. And, as in most metaphysical experiences, the belief moulds reality.

Pilgrims wrap red threads around a tree when asking for boons from the goddess

Accommodation in Maihar

MPT Surbahar

7880108591

maihar@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

MPT Surbahar offers a comfortable stay in the pilgrim city of Maihar. You can actually get a view of the temple of Sharda Devi from its restaurant and garden. Located at a walking distance from the Temple, this hotel is known for its fresh, hygienic food, clean ambience and remarkably hospitality. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

The Pashupatinath Temple

Mandsaur

The land of timeless treasures

Mandsaur district is the richest archaeological terrain in the north-western Malwa region. The district has highways cut through the low foot-hills of the Aravali and Vindhya ranges. Its rich black soil is ideal for growing wheat and coriander, while its forest are vast tracts of shrubs and elegant supple Dhawda trees. The Imperial Gazetteer of Mandsaur describes it as 'a place of considerable antiquity and of historical and archaeological importance'. Indeed, the region's past finds its roots in the realms of mythology. It is here that King Dashratha is said to have accidently killed Shravankumar, in the Ramayana.

Garbh Greh of Pashupatinath Temple

PASHUPATINATH TEMPLE

Picturesquely located on the banks of the Shivna river, stands the Pashupatinath temple. The river is also the home to a variety of migratory birds during winters. The Pashupatinath temple houses an eight faced shivalinga which belongs to the Gupta period. Crafted in red stone and polished, it shines like marble. The shivlinga weighs 4600 kgs and is almost 3.5 meters tall. Having lain on Shivna's river bed for centuries, the impressive image was discovered in 1940 and was installed in this shrine in 1961. The eight faces are carved upon the linga in two rows, and depict Shiva as Bhava, Pashupati, Mahadeva, Ishaan, Rudra, Sharva, Ugra and Ashani.

Part of the Pashupatinath temple complex is a small Hanuman temple and a shrine dedicated to Shri Janaki Nath.

Four Faced Shivling in the Museum

YASHODHARMAN ARCHAEOLOGICAL MUSEUM

Located on the southern edge of Mandsaur Town on SH-31 is the Yashodharman archaeological museum. Arranged simply but painstakingly on 2 floors, the museum has four sculpture galleries, dedicated to Shiva, Vishnu and numerous goddesses which have been gathered from across the district, including Hinglajgarh Fort. The sculptures displayed in the museum have been dated between the Gupta period 5th-6th century AD and 14th century.

DASHAPURA FORT

Most of the sources agree that credit for its construction goes to Hoshang Shah, who ruled over Malwa in the 15th century. This Fort is legendary in many ways – it has close associations to the legendary battle fought between Humayun and Bahadur Shah, it is the place where Akbar settled the headquarters of the Mandsaur government after capturing the Malwa region; and it is also the place where a treaty between Sir John Malcolm and Malwa's Holkar rulers 'settled' the region firmly in British hands in the year 1818.

CHATURBHUJNATH NALA ROCK SHELTERS

Rock shelters of Chaturbhuj Nala has been added in tentative list of UNESCO World Heritage Site

Bhanpura, a small township in Mandsaur district holds a wealth of heritage and natural beauty away from the hustle and bustle of city life. Around 30 kms from the town are the rock shelters called Chaturbhujnath Nala or Chaturbhuj Nala stretched over the 5 km long trail with thousands of ancient rock paintings on the wall. Situated within the Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary, it encompasses the spectacular views of sprawling landscape and splendid water bodies.

The discovery of Chaturbhuj nala rock shelters

Belonging to the pre-pastoral (over 6,000-12,000 years old) to the early medieval age (10th century), the Chaturbhuj nala rock shelters are often compared to the UNESCO approved Bhimbetka rock shelters. Named after a nearby Chaturbhujnath temple, the site was discovered in 1977 by a local school teacher Ramesh Kumar Pancholi and his friends. Since then, these rock canvases have gained many international tourists and travellers who come to spend fun weekends.

The first 700m of the site is accessible to the visitors which are painted in the shades of red, ochre, white and black. It is alleged that hundreds of designs were also created on the outer walls of the shelters which might have been erased by sunlight and rain. These early paintings depict the instances of ancient lifestyle such as men riding cattle, women dancing, warriors marching and hunting scenes portraying rhino, hump-less cattle, and deer being chased and hunted with arrows.

Other ancient sites near Chaturbhujnath nala rock shelters

Just 5 kms from Bhanpura is a hill known as "Dar Ki Chattan". The site features almost 560 man-made cupules marked on the walls. It is supposed to be the earliest efforts of artistic expression by the human. According to many archaeologists and scholars, these cup marks are anywhere between 1,00,000 to 2,00,000 years old. Other rock-art sites in the region that existed in the ancient times and used by ancient humans are Chiber Nala, Sita Khardi and Modi. But, the most prominent and well protected till date is the site of Chaturbhujnala.

It is always enthralling for travellers to go on an impromptu voyage to places that are just off the map. Chaturbhujnala shelters in one such wonder including the Hinglajgarh Fort, Hinglaj Mata Temple, Chaturbhujnala Temple and Gandhi Sagar Reservoirs in the nearby regions of prolific Bhanpura which will leave you awestruck with its richness and glory.

EXPLORER'S MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF MANDSAUR

RATLAM

Located about 75 kms northwest of Ujjain, the bustling town of Ratlam is a busy railway junction. One can visit the beautiful 11th century temple in Bilpank or drive to Sailana, home to a stunning Cactus Garden or pray at the Hussain Tekri shrine or buy the purest gold for which Ratlam is known for. For the curious traveller, Ratlam also reserves unexpected sojourns into history.

NEEMUCH

Neemuch is about 176 km from Ujjain. Perched on a barren basaltic ridge, the town of Neemuch is located on the border of two historically active regions – Rajputana and Malwa. From Neemuch, one can visit the feudal, fortified township of Rampura and the intricately carved temple of Khor or wander into lovingly preserved havelis.

Sitamau Palace

SITAMAU

30 kms east of Mandsaur is Sitamau, which houses the Sitamau palace, still in a fair state of preservation. The walls that enclosed the palace are still partly extant, as is a temple, dedicated to the Sitamau rulers' kul devi, Amba, its domed roof artfully carved in a lotus pattern.

Laduna - Part of the Sitamau estate is Laduna, 4 kms south of Sitamau. Located on the banks of a large lake, Laduna palace was built as an alternative to Sitamau in case the latter succumbed to Maratha attacks – a routine phenomenon in this region at that time.

TEMPLE OF DHARMARAJESHWAR

100 kms from Mandsaur and 60 kms north-east of Sitamau, is situated the magnificent rock–cut temple of Dharmarajeshwar. Miraculously preserved ancient Buddhist caves can also be seen on the same hill. It bears some

The Rang Mahal in the mountain fort of The Chandellas

similarities to the rock-cut marvels of Ellora. This site is protected by Archaeological Survey of India.

The main shrine in the Dharmarajeshwar Temple complex was originally dedicated to both Vishnu and Shiva, and an image of Harihara is found in the garbhagriha of the temple. However, it later became a Shiva temple, so the garbhagriha also houses a shivalinga. Today, Mahashivratri is the main festival celebrated here. There are five smaller shrines within the temple complex, one of which is empty. The others are dedicated to Panch Devi, Chote Vishnu, Bade Vishnu and Dasavtaras.

BUDDHIST CAVES

A few minutes' walk from the Dharmarajeshwar temple, carved into the rough laterite rock of the hill-face are a series of Buddhist caves, which date back to the 5th century AD. However, only 14 caves are open for the visitors.

GANDHI SAGAR DAM

The Gandhi Sagar dam is one of the first of the four dams built on the

Buddhist Caves of Dhamnaar

EXPLORER'S MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF MANDSAUR

Gandhi Sagar Dam

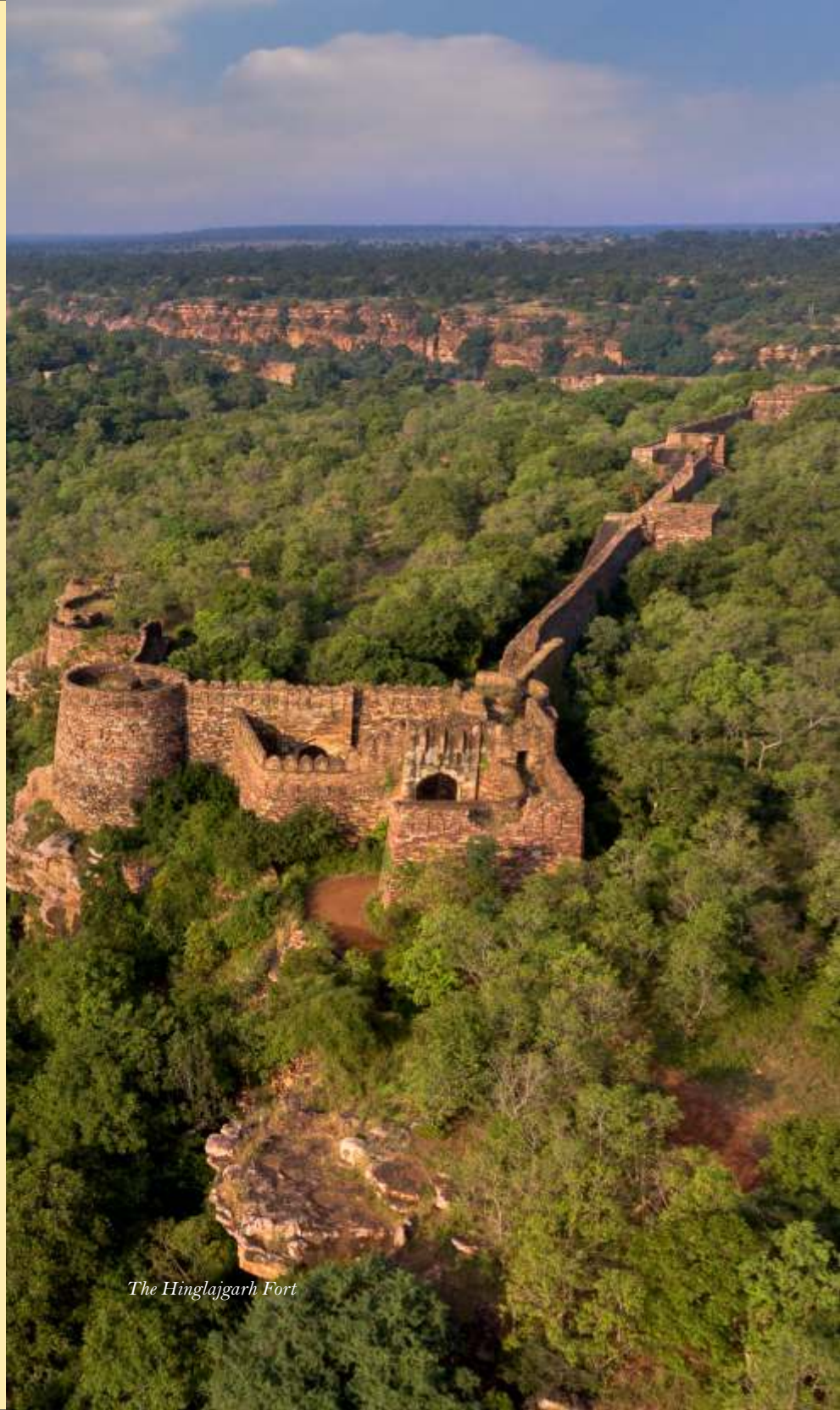
Chambal River. The construction of this dam started in 1954 and was completed in 1970. The height of the dam rises upto 62.20 meters. The Gandhi Sagar Power Station now supplies electricity throughout the Mandsaur district. Besides meeting the power requirements in the district, electricity from this power house is also supplied to many other areas in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan.

HINGLAJGARH FORT

Nestled deep inside the untamed forests of Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary, the historic Hinglajgarh fort lies atop a hill at a distance of just 39 km from the Gandhi Sagar forest retreat. The ruins of once a majestic fort stand as a testament to the rich historical significance of the city, serving as an intriguing site for history lovers.

Note: You can opt to explore this ancient fort while you book a safari in the Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary.

The Chambal River



The Hinglajgarh Fort

THE HISTORIC ENSEMBLE OF DHAMNAR
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

ROCK ART OF CHAMBAL VALLEY REGION
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

Accommodation in Mandsaur

MPT Highway Treat, Mandsaur

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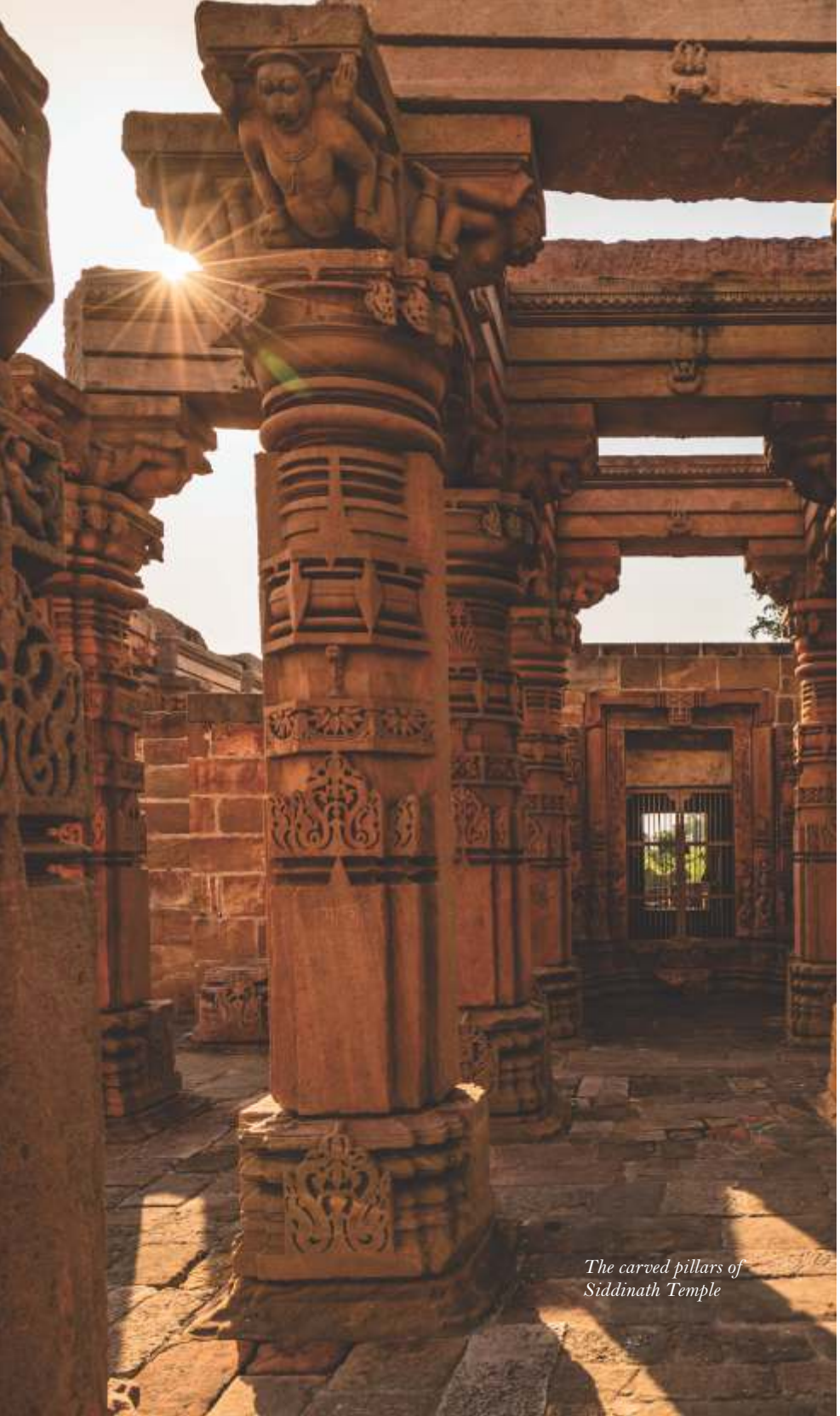
Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Conference Hall

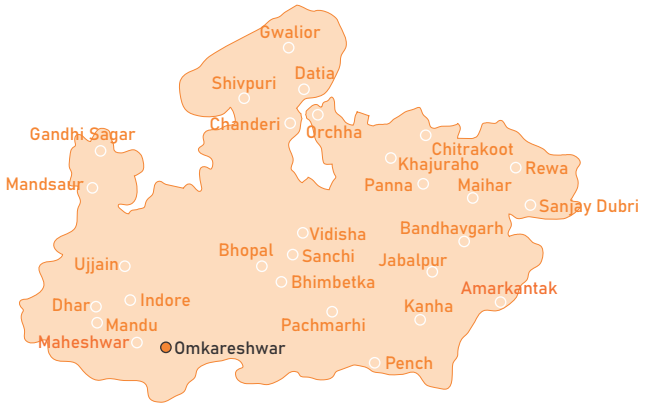
Experience the charm of MPT Highway Treat in Mandsaur, conveniently situated along the Indore-Neemuch road to Rajasthan via Chittorgarh, a mere 7 km from Mandsaur. Whether you're in need of a rejuvenating break during your journey or planning a delightful overnight stay with your family, our location caters to both. With conference hall facilities available, it's an ideal venue for corporate meetings, strategically positioned between Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. Additionally, nearby attractions include the revered Pashupatinath Temple and the Dharmrajeshwar Temple, both offering cultural and spiritual experiences. Visitors can also explore the scenic beauty of Gandhi Sagar Dam, providing a serene environment for relaxation and sightseeing. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.



The carved pillars of Siddinath Temple

Omkareshwar

The shape of the holy island determined the sanctity of the name, Omkareshwar.



Seen from high above, and through the eyes of faith, the two hillocks on this riverine island, separated by a gentle lowland, assume the form of the sacred syllable OM. The word 'Omkar' is literally the enunciation of Om or the Om sound. (See Box - The Mystic Sound).

THE LEGEND

The rivers that embrace this island are the local Kaveri, to the north, and the sacred Narmada, to the south. At Omkareshwar they flow in a valley between The Vindhya range to the north and the Satpura range to the south. According to a

On the far bank of the Narmada, an island shaped like a sacred sound

THE MYSTIC SOUND - OM

Also spelt AUM, this is considered to be the sacred sound of God and is often uttered as an invocation. It is also inscribed as an auspicious sign on buildings and at the head of a book. Written as a single character, it is believed that it is most effective if it is uttered as a single syl- lable for at least ten seconds: the Ah for one second, followed by the Oo for one second, and then the Mmmm vibrating deep in the chest and resonating in the head for eight seconds.

Many mystic interpretations have been given for this sound. One is that it represents the three sacred books of the Vedas. Another contends that Ah represents Vishnu, Oo is for Shiva and Mmm for Brahma: the great gods of the Brahmanical Trinity of Preserver, Destroyer and Creator respectively. According to Madame Blavatsky of the 19th century's Theosophical Society, the sound stands for the three elements of Fire, Water and Air.

In Buddhism the syllable Om occurs in the sacred formula Om Mane Padme Hum which literally means 'Hail to the Jewel in the Lotus, Amen' but this, in turn, has been given various levels of mystic interpretation.

The most recent explanation for the universality of Om is that this is the sound that everything in the universe vibrates to, like an enormous tuning fork, after the ini- tial impetus given to it by the Big Bang of cosmic creation. There will, undoubtedly, be many more explanations for Om as Sci- ence and Mysticism progress on their path of convergence.

legend, when Narad, the great seer, paid a visit to the deity of the Vindhya mountains, he was angry to find that there was no dwelling here suitable for Lord Siva. Dismayed at this, the deity of these mountains subjected himself to very severe austerities. Lord Siva was so pleased with this that he said he would make Omkareshwar one of his homes. The other eleven Jyotirlingas were also the result of similar austerities performed by still other devotees of the Great Lord. (See Box - The Jyotirlingas)

All this happened in legendary times, long before the first historian wrote the first history of Omkareshwar. Its history, however, is as interesting as its legends.

HISTORY

Back in the 12h century, Omkareshwar was ruled by the Bhil kings: monarchs of a martial tribal people. All went well till Bhil king Natthu made the mistake of falling out with a powerful priest, Daryo Gosai. The slighted prelate asked the raja of Jaipur for help and, soon, the raja's brother, Bharatsingh Chauhan was at Natthu's door eager to put the, reportedly, arrogant Bhil in his place. But Natthu, so the story goes, was a shrewd man with a beauti- ful and talented daughter. The conflict was settled when Bharatsingh married Natthu's only daughter and many of Bharatsingh's men also entered into wedlock to use a medieval term for a medieval time... with many other comely Bhil damsels. They then settled down to domestic bliss in Omkareshwar in 1165. The descendants of this happy example of inter-racial bonding became the Bhilala people who, after a thousand years, still retain their identity.

VIEW OF THE HOLY ISLAND

Even today, Bhilala's homeland is an attractive place. The best view of the island can be had from the terraces of the rooms of the Narmada Resort.

Boat ferry visitors to the sacred island

It is perched atop a wooded rise looking down on the swift flow of the Narmada river, and the sacred island on the far bank. The double-humped island is about 4 kms long and 2 kms wide. A great dam rises on the far right, its spillway gushing in frothy cascades into the river. After a short spell of initial turbulence and white-water, the river calms and deepens and colourful ferries across and criss-cross from the mainland to the island and back. Pedestrians, however, can walk across a suspension bridge linking the main- land with the island.

From the south bank, the forbidding, cliff-like, walls of the main Omkar Mandhata Temple, and the palace-fortress on the rise of the hillock above it,

THE JYOTIRLINGAS

These ancient places of pilgrimage are sacred to Lord Siva. He is said to have appeared in them as a beam of light: the word 'jyoti' means 'light'. The twelve Jyotirlingas are:-

- *Kedarnath in the Garhwal Himalayas of Uttarakhand.*
- *Vishwanath in Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh*
- *Somnath near the town of Veraval in Gujarat*
- *Mahakaleshwar in Ujjain in Madhya Pradesh*
- *Omkar Mandhata in the island of Omkareshwar in Madhya Pradesh*
- *Rameshwar on the island of Rameshwaram in Tamil Nadu*
- *Mallikarjuna in Srisailem in Andhra Pradesh*
- *Trayambakeshwar about 20 kms from the city of Nasik in Maharashtra*
- *Bhimashankar a fair distance from the city of Pune in Maharashtra*
- *Nageshwar not far from Dwarka in Gujarat*
- *Baijnath also known as Vaidyanath in Devghar in Bihar*
- *Grishneshwar near the famed Ellora caves in Maharashtra.*

A shaft of light is a symbol common to many old religions indicating divine intervention. A shaft, whether of stone or wood - as in the Maypole - has been a primal emblem of creativity from the time humans first felt the need to represent the self-renewing power of nature.

give the impression of the island being a Forbidden Land. But this is quite deceptive. It does not deter the hundreds of pilgrims who make their way across the bridge and by ferry; and then do the obligatory parikrama, or circumambulation, of the island and its many shrines netted with glittering legends.

Traditionally the parikrama starts from the Omkar Mandhata Temple, but for those staying on the mainland, it would be most convenient to visit the Mamleshwar Temple.

MAMLESHWAR TEMPLE

Built in the 10th century, this ancient temple is under the protection of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI). It is, in fact, a small complex of temples. In its heyday it must have had two large shrines and a number of smaller ones. Nowadays, only one large shrine seems to be open to worshippers. The carvings in this complex are well worth lingering over. There is a particularly impressive one of a god in a very martial stance. From the image's conical crown many visitors believe that it depicts Vishnu, the Preserver, but this deity is not usually represented in a warlike stance which makes this sculpture slightly controversial. There are also some interesting smaller carvings on the door-posts of a minor shrine. This is a living temple and, because it is a fairly small one, the rituals of worship, or pujas, can be observed from outside. Visitors should be wary of the large number of semi-wild rhesus monkeys who have been known to help themselves to cameras, hand-bags and hats: they are not aggressive, just skilfully light-fingered! The Mamleshwar temple is on the south bank of the Narmada. The sacred island of Omkareshwar lies across the river. One can walk across a bridge, drive to the Koti Teerth ghats of the main temple, or ride a ferry. When you reach the island you are expected to do the parikrama, or at least as much of it as you can. The full circumambulation should take between three and four hours of reasonably brisk walking - and climbing up steps - provided one does not get too involved with the rituals of worship at every shrine!

In front of the Koti Teerth's main ghat is a raised platform holding two, single-celled, red temples. One of these is said to be the temple of the great Hindu philosopher and missionary: Adi Shankaracharya. He did much to

Puja in the Mamleshwar Temple

restore the primacy of a monotheistic line of Brahmanical philosophy after the great Buddhist wave encouraged by the Mauryan Emperor Ashoka.

A short distance beyond these small temples, are the steps leading up to the main temple. They are lined by women selling flowers and other offerings traditionally made in the temple.

On the first landing, after the initial flight of steps, stairs lead down to a cave associated with Adi Shankaracharya. Religious teachers of all faiths, all through time, have sought the solitude of caves before embarking on their missions.

Continuing up the steps, visitors come to a shrine of a five-headed Ganesh. One of the most benign and loved deities in the Hindu pantheon, this elephant-headed god is the Lord of Good Beginnings and one of the two sons of Siva and Parvati. Multiple heads, in Hindu iconography, represent enhanced mental abilities as multiple arms indicate omnipotence. Elephants are regarded as the epitome of sagacity. The mouse, Ganesh's vehicle, captures the god's ability to be aware of the most labyrinthian intricacies of a problem in much the same way as a computer operator uses a mouse to surf the net!

Another short flight of steps leads to the carved, pillared hall of the Omkar Mandhata Temple.

OMKAR MANDHATA TEMPLE

Omkar Mandhata Temple

To the right of this hall is the sanctum holding the greatly revered Jyotirlinga The antiquity of this idol is borne out by the fact that it stands in a shrine roofed with overlapping stone slabs, not dressed stones. There is every reason to believe that this was, originally, a stand-alone shrine, perched at the edge of a steep cliff cut by the Narmada. When the worship of this idol grew, so did the temple extending away from the cliff. This is why the sanctum is not in front of the main door of the temple, nor is it directly below the soaring temple tower or shikhara.

The greatly revered idol, whose enormous influence has been responsible for the growing power of the holy island, is not a titanic or awesome monolith. It is, in fact, a small shivling rising out of a shallow pit, protected by a broad silver frame. But the authority it exercises over devotees all over the world is stupendous. Appropriately, behind Omkar Mandhata stands the shakti, or dynamic power, of Siva: an idol of Parvati clothed in red and wearing a silver crown. This idol, too, is surrounded by a broad, embossed, silver frame. Three pujas are held here in the morning, noon and night.

From here, a flight of steps rises to the Mahakaleshwar Temple.

MAHAKALESHWAR TEMPLE

Here, Lord Siva is worshipped as the Lord of Time. The idol is in a glass-fronted alcove and the pillars on both sides of the alcove hold carvings of women who have probably been drawn from the rich array of Hinduism's semi-divine entities.

Above the Mahakaleshwar temple are three more floors, each dedicated to a different aspect of Siva.

The exit from the temple leads down a corridor bright with shops selling the varied products used in the ceremonies of worship both in temples and at home: tiny idols, oil-lamps, images, bright mounds of coloured powder, beads, incense, coconuts - which are said to resemble both human heads and wombs and cassettes and CDs of religious chants and hymns. Such shops selling religious objects are fascinating reminders of the continuing relevance of rituals that are thousands of years old.

Leaving the corridor of shops, a path runs parallel to the ghats of the Narmada flowing below you. This is the Parikrama path.

PARIKRAMA PATH

It accesses many places of reverence like the Omkar Math, Ananda Mai Temple and the Ramakrishna Mission among others. At the point where the path takes a sharp turn to the right, and begins to ascend the hill, is the sacred Sangam.

SANGAM

This is the confluence of the Narmada and the Kaveri and there is an interesting tale associated with the merging of these two streams of water. The Narmada is one of the most sacred rivers of our land: some people regard it as even holier than the Ganga, the great Ganges. The stream called the Kaveri is a comparatively insignificant rivulet that, geographically, is a tributary of the Narmada. But legend has given it a strong and self-willed personality of its own. According to the story, the little Kaveri came down to meet the mighty Narmada but she was distressed at the cold reception given to her. And so, in a fit of anjustifiable pique, she refused to merge her waters with those of the greater river. She flowed to the north of the island, cupped its east, and even though she joined the Narmada at their south-eastern confluence, her waters continued to maintain their identity. In fact, sharp-eyed boatmen claim that they can see the two streams flowing along the same bed but refusing to merge. The Narmada then, apparently, realised that it was incumbent on the mightier river to bend a bit. And so, when the northern flow of the Kaveri meets the southern stream of the Narmada-Kaveri at the south-western tip of the island, they merge in reconciliation and flow on as one!

From this south-western tip, the Parikrama path winds up the island, past the Rinamukteshwar Temple to the Gauri Somnath Temple.

GAURI SOMNATH TEMPLE

This is also at the top of a flight of 270 steps, that rises up from the ghats, for those who want to do a half-parikrama. The temple has a curious resemblance to the temples of Khajuraho, with only a rising curvilinear tower atop a high plat- form. Inside is an enormous black shivling.

Legend has it that this monolithic idol once had a mirror-bright surface Anyone who looked into it saw his, or her, next incarnation. The Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb, the legend says, gazed into it. To his horror he saw a filthy animal looking back at him. Enraged with the lingam's prediction he tried to burn it. Ever since then it has lost its reflective, and predictive, abilities and has

assumed its present colour. At the back of the shivling is an idol of Siva's consort and shakti, Parvati. Curiously, her eyes glitter in the manner of many tribal deities, hinting at its great age. This temple is under the protection of the ASI.

From here, and a little after shops selling refreshments and religious goods is the Patali Hanuman.

PATALI HANUMAN

In a pavilion, out of which a tree grows, is a three meter long idol of Hanuman, the powerful and greatly loved, monkey god who is a great devotee of Lord Ram. He and his horde helped rescue Sita, the consort of Ram, from the palace of the evil Ravana in Sri Lanka. They also built the boulder bridge linking India with Sri Lanka across the Palk Strait, according to devotees.

Here, Hanuman is shown sleeping, his enormous mace by his side. Both the pavilion and the idol are painted a brilliant scarlet, the colour of strength and power.

Leaving the shops and pavilion, the hall-parikrama path is cemented and winds through scrub-land with occasional trees and religious establish- ments. There must have been a number of temples here, once, because there are numerous carvings strewn around. The path dips, then rises again and leads to the Chand-Suraj Gate.

CHAND-SURAJ GATE

This Moon-Sun Gate, which is what Chand-Suraj means, is set in massive walls of dressed stone with carved corbel projections to support the topping stones. It seems likely that this is all that remains of an old temple because there are sculptures of the fearsome goddess Chamunda and another of the benign Ganesh.

The road passes through the gate and continues till it comes to a fork. The right fork leads to the Ashapuri Temple.

The Holy Narmada River

ASHAPURI TEMPLE

It is a rather insignificant temple with a white image of the Goddess of Hope: the deity of the Bhil tribal people and of the former ruling family. The erstwhile princes were known as the Raos. A fair is held here in the presence of the former princely family and a sacred fire, or havan, is lit.

Retrace your steps back to the fork and take the left road. A little short of the new Gauri Temple, bear right and descend on the path to the Siddinath Temple.

SIDDINATH TEMPLE

Many visitors find this ruined temple the most impressive one on the island. Its unroofed pillars rise from a plinth richly sculpted with a frieze of elephants and equestrian warriors. The pillars are worth examining for their intricate carvings and corbels showing beautiful women supporting the weight of the capitals on their backs. Lying fallen on the ground is an amalaka: a stone carved like a fluted disk and representing a holy fruit, usually placed at the top of the shikhara tower.

The road continues down to come to the Arjun-Bhim Gateway

ARJUN-BHIM GATEWAY

This is a massive gateway set in thick walls, largely ruined now, with sculptures of two warriors of the epic Mahabharat War, the Pandav brothers Arjun and Bhim. It is difficult to explain the presence of this gate unless one believes that the whole of the upper part of the island was once fortified. Or, perhaps, this led to a great temple, now destroyed. A flight of over 200 steps winds down from this gate to the ghats.

Pilgrims will then return to the Omkareshwar Temple to complete their parikrama, having walked around all the significant shrines and temples on the holy island. If they have done the complete parikrama they will, in effect, have walked an enormous OM. This must, surely, have earned for them considerable reserves of merit.

A shop catering to pilgrims fascinates a visitor

Siddnath Temple

EKATMA DHAM, OMKARESHWAR

In the heart of India, within the sacred land of Omkareshwar, a profound spiritual and cultural revolution is unfolding. Omkareshwar, a place of great significance for seekers of truth and wisdom, is witnessing the development of the Ekatma Dham project. This monumental endeavour is dedicated to preserving and celebrating the timeless message of Advaita Vedanta.

A Journey of Oneness

Ekatma Dham, standing tall above the holy Omkareshwar, serves as a beacon of unity and oneness, echoing the teachings of the great Adi Shankaracharya. It is a living embodiment of Advaita Vedanta philosophy, which proclaims the oneness of the individual soul (Atman) with the ultimate reality (Brahman). Under the guidance of the Acharya Shankar Sanskritik Ekta Nyas, this sacred space revives and celebrates the ancient wisdom of Vedic Dharma (Sanatana Dharma), spreading the noble teachings of Acharya Shankara.

A Vision of Unity

The Ekatma Dham project is a significant effort to promote Advaita Vedanta and honour Adi Shankaracharya's life and teachings. It features a massive 108-ft Statue of Oneness in Omkareshwar, unveiled on September 21, 2023. In a world often filled with stress and despair, this project aims to symbolise spiritual and cultural unity in India and offer hope for a better, more harmonious world.

Projects at Omkareshwar: 'Jnana Bhumi'

Nestled on a sacred island, Omkareshwar is a holy site and home to one of the revered 12 jyotirlingas. Its spiritual history is evident in the numerous Shaivaite, Vaisnavite and Jain temples that dot its landscapes. A pilgrimage to Omkareshwar is a profound journey for devout Hindus, offering a chance to connect with the divine and pay homage to Lord Shiva. The ancient temple, adorned with intricate carvings, stands as a symbol of enduring faith, drawing seekers of blessings and solace. It is also the place where Acharya Shankara met his Guru Ji, Govinda Bhagwatapada to attain enlightenment. In order to mark this achievement, the Department of Culture, through the Acharya Shankar Sanskritik Ekta Nyas, has undertaken a series of ambitious projects at Omkareshwar. It holds a great significance in the history of Advaita Vedanta, and it is a place of spiritual growth and enlightenment.

A Statue of Adi Shankaracharya and the Advaita Lok Museum

One of the highlights of the project is the installation of a multi-metal 108-ft statue of Adi Shankaracharya atop Mandhata Parvat hill, facing south towards the Narmada River. This statue will be accompanied by the Advaita Lok Museum, which will showcase the life and philosophy of Acharya Shankara through immersive exhibits and interactive displays.

The museum will feature a 3D hologram projection gallery, nine exhibition galleries, an indoor widescreen theatre, and a cultural boat ride called Advaita Narmada Vihar. This boat ride will take visitors on an audio-visual journey through the profound teachings of Adi Shankaracharya and other Indian preceptors of Advaita.

The Acharya Shankar International Institute of Advaita Vedanta

With the motive of promoting the study and understanding of Advaita Vedanta, Ekatma Dham will also have the Acharya Shankar International Institute of Advaita Vedanta. This institute will house seven centres dedicated to different aspects of Advaita Vedanta, including philosophy, science, social sciences, literature, music, and arts.

The project will also feature a library called the Maharshi Vedavyasa Advaita Library, that will serve as a comprehensive resource centre for scholars working in fields related to Advaita Vedanta philosophy. An extension centre, the Acharya Gaudapada Advaita Extension Centre, will work towards popularising the content developed by the institute's various centres, based on Advaita Vedanta. The Acharya Govind Bhagavatpada Gurukulam will offer residential training in Indian spirituality and Advaita Vedanta.

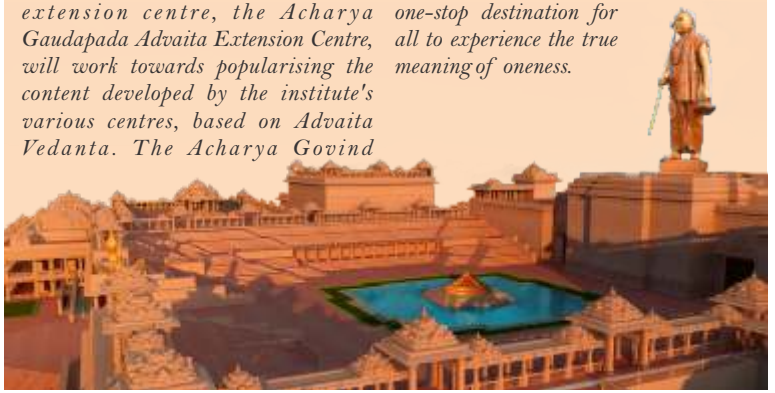
A Journey Through Adi Shankaracharya's Legacy

In the land of Omkareshwar, the legacy of Adi Shankaracharya, the great philosopher and exponent of Advaita Vedanta, will continue to inspire and guide seekers of truth and enlightenment. The teachings of Adi Shankaracharya, rooted in the oneness of the individual soul and the ultimate reality, resonate through ages, leaving an enduring impact on Indian society, culture, and spirituality.

Ekatma Dham is not just a monumental project; it's a spiritual journey through time, a tribute to the timeless wisdom of Adi Shankaracharya, and a celebration of unity and oneness. It stands as a testament to the power of philosophy, spirituality, and culture to transform and unite a nation.

As we reflect on this remarkable initiative, we are reminded of the profound words of Adi Shankaracharya: "Brahma Satyam Jaganmithyaa Jeevo Brahmaiva Naaparah" - Brahman is true, the world is unreal, the jeeva (soul), individual existence is none other than Brahman.

When in the heart of Madhya Pradesh, plan a visit to Ekatma Dham, a living testament to the wisdom of Adi Shankaracharya and a one-stop destination for all to experience the true meaning of oneness.



MPT Temple View

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Facilities

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Perched atop a small hill, MPT Temple View provides a breathtaking panorama of the sacred Narmada River, the revered Jyotirlinga Temple, and the Statue of Oneness. A brief 15-minute stroll from our establishment brings you to the temple grounds, ensuring convenience for our guests. Renowned for exceptional guest service, delectable vegetarian cuisine, and pristine surroundings, MPT Temple View promises an enriching stay. Explore the divine and relish top-notch hospitality at our idyllic retreat. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

MPT Sailani Island Resort

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Facilities

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MPT Sailani Island Resort is a water & adventure tourism destination of Madhya Pradesh and offers activities like Jet Skii and Motor Boat. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. Note: Buses/ tempo travellers with seating capacity of more than 15 pax are not allowed. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

The hallowed ghats of Chitrakoot

Chitrakoot

A great epic has sanctified the riverine town of Chitrakoot.

As most Indians know, the Ramayana (See Box: The Ramayana) describes the birth, marriage, exile and return of the Prince of Ayodhya: Ram. Due to a palace intrigue, he was banished from his kingdom for fourteen years. He spent twelve of those deprived years,, along with his wife Sita and his brother Lakshman, in the forests of Chitrakoot, following the advice of the sage Bharadwaj. The Ramayana, as translated by scholar and the first Indian to become Governor-General of India, Chakravarti Rajagopalchari, describes the exiles arrival at Chitrakoot in his own words:

The Mandakini : "The water is clear and sweet"

THE RAMAYANA

Ancient Indian scholars wrote two of the longest epic poems in world literature: the Mahabharat, with about 100,000 cou- plets, and the Ramayana with about 24,000: many times larger than the Greek Iliad and Odyssey combined. There are conflicting claims about the time of the composition of the Ramayana by the poet Valmiki but it is generally accepted that it is a description of actual events that took place many centu- ries earlier, certainly not later than 1,000 BC. These descriptions were elaborated to convey a number of moral lessons that have served as a bedrock for an ethical system that has governed countless generations of Indians across the land and wherever the Indian diaspora has spread.

Enterprising Indian traders carned the epic all across Southeast Asia, particularly to Cambodia, Indonesia and Thailand To this day, tales from the Ramayana are featured in the traditional theatre, dance and shadow-puppets of Java and Bali. Thus, events that occurred three thousand years ago, still come alive through the enactment of The Romance of Rama.

Then they saw at a distance the Chitrakoota hill. They were glad and began to walk briskly towards it. "How beautiful this region is" exclaimed Raama.

"The forest here has fine edible roots and fruits. The water is clear and sweet. Rishis dwell in aashramas in this forest and we may most certainly live happily here in their holy company." They proceeded to put up an aashrama there for themselves. Lakshmana was a clever workman. He soon constructed a strong hut, which was weather-proof and made it comfortable and convenient. Single-handed, he completed the mud hut with windows, and doors all made of bamboos and jungle material.

A lot of what is described in the Ramayana is relevant today. A wooded hill still dominates the Chitrakoot landscape and is a major part of the mystique of the area. Much of this region is typical Deccan Trap country: undulating plains made of ancient lava fields. (See Box: The Deccan Traps) But there are also large patches of beautiful forest, well-watered with streams and rivers. Thriving shrines stand on the sites of legendary ashrams. And there is a temple reputedly marking the spot where Lakshman had built the first hut, the Param Kutir, for the three of them. In fact a walk through Chitrakoot, and its environs, is a fascinating tour of the locations of many of the well-known episodes of the great epic.

And, apart from beliefs associated with Ram, Lakshman and Sita, Chitrakoot has links with other, older, legends. One of these is the story of Kamadgiri.

Idol of Kamadgiri Temple

KAMADGIRI

This is the 'Chitrakoot Hill" mentioned in the Ramayana. A pedestrian path leads round the base

THE DECCAN TRAPS

About 65 million years ago, a strange phenomena changed the face of India. Long, narrow, cracks developed in the earth's surface. Lava began to well out through them, spreading slowly like hot and molten chocolate, cooling, forming the base of more lava oozing out of the earth. This went on for centuries, layer upon layer of lava being laid down, one atop the other. The rivers of lava spread out like flat, horizontal sheets, filling the hollows of the terrain over which they flowed. Eventually they covered the whole of Central India including virtually all of Madhya Pradesh. When the lava from these fissure eruptions cooled they formed flat-topped plateau-like structures. Some of these rivers of super-heated lava spread for more than 100 kilometres before they solidi- fied, each flow varying between 12 and 29 metres inilackness. The total thickness of the successive flows were from 60 meters to an incredible 2,000 meters.

Generally, the lava flows were laid down horizontally, in a series of enormous terraces or steps: trap is a Scandinavian word for step. The rock formed from such cooled lava is called basalt: it is dark and very hard. Sometimes, however, the basalt covered softer rocks which, in course of time, were eroded and leached away by underground water. This gave rise to caves, often enclosing subterranean ponds and lakes, occasionally being threaded by dark, underground, rivers that become a source of great wonder when they emerge out of the earth.

Legends grow around such wonders.

The Kamadgiri Mountain

of the forested hill and many barefooted pilgrims do this circumambulation believing that it is a meritorious act. Not many of them are aware that the hill is believed by some people to be hollow, enclosing a huge, warm, subterranean, lake illuminated by a sustaining blue light. Around the lake sit immortal sages who oversee the destinies of mankind, and of the world. There is a secret entrance to this hidden domain, but only evolved souls can pass through it. Those who believe in this story add that, when it rains, 24 springs gush out of the hill at the same time. This can only happen, they argue, if percolating rain water fills the lake and it begins to spill over its banks, gushing out of its

Aarti at Ram Ghat

overflow ducts which become springs.

The most permanent flow of water in Chitrakoot, however, is the river Mandakini. It washes the very colourful Ram Ghats.

RAM GHATS

This is the living heart of Chitrakoot. Beliei blesses it as the favoured bathing place of Ram, Lakshman and Sita. When the river is burnished with dawn, devotees stand in the flowing water and do their surya namaskar salutation to the sun. All through the day there is a kaleidoscope of activities here: decorated boats crossing and rowing down the river; priests assisting fami- lies to perform the rituals and prayers for the repose of the souls of their dear departed, a child having his first haircut in the auspicious mundan ceremony; women pouring ablutions on a shivling, visitors gazing up at the bust

Bharat Milap Mandir

of the poet who composed his own, vernacular, translation of the Ramayana at the Tulsidas Chabutra; vendors peddling fruit and warding off hordes of determined monkeys, and a row of shops bright with trinkets, souvenirs, and flowers and colourful powder used in religious ceremonies. All the while, there is the compulsive beat of bhajans pouring out of CD players. Greatly revered tradition has gone hi-tech.

In the evening, when lights cast bright spears in the dark water, bells ring and devotees gather around for the swirling oil-lamp ritual of aarti, worshipping the life-giving river with flowers, fire and incense.

Steep flights of steps lead up from Ram Ghat to a number of important temples including the Bharat Mandir.

BHARAT MANDIR

Ram's half-brother, Bharat, was his successor to the throne of Ayodhya. But he felt that he had no right to sit on it because his brother had been exiled by a shameful ruse. He, therefore, took a large retinue with him, found the three exiles, assembled his glittering court in Chitrakoot and tried to persuade Ram to return to Ayodhya and rule as the rightful king.

This great assembly has been replicated in miniature in the Bharat Mandir. The priest repeated the story and said that Ram had refused to return till the period of his exile had ended. Bharat then took Ram's wooden clogs, placed them on his head, and marched back to Ayodhya where he enthroned the wooden slippers and ruled as his brother's regent.

The officiating priest places a pair of clogs on devotees' heads as a blessing.

Visitors have to descend to the ghats and then climb up another flight of steps to the scalloped entrance of a gate house. Beyond is the forecourt of the Yagya Vedi.

Yagya Vedi

YAGYA VEDI

Here, a small domed shrine faces a well. This pit, apparently, is all that remains of the original 108 in which the creator, Brahma, lit his invocatory fires before he created the world. In the sanctum of the small domed shrine is another replica of Bharat's durbar. Possibly, the royal assemblage was so big that it occupied two terraces: the lower one and this.

From the Yagya Vedi one can walk through an opening in the right wall to get to the Param Kutir.

Idol of Hanuman

PARAM KUTIR

On this site, it is believed, Lakshman built a hut for the three exiles. In place of the original wattle-and-daub structure there is a beautiful domed shrine with a pillared verandah in front. Visitors should, however, carry a stick to ward off the hordes of aggressive monkeys that infest this temple. Idols of Rama, Sita and Lakshman have been installed in the shrine.

From here, there is an excellent view of the ghats rising on the far side of the Mandikini, including that of the towering, and comparatively new, statue of Hanuman.

The premier shrine of Hanuman, the great warrior, is atop a hill called Hanuman Dhara.

HANUMAN DHARA

When the three exiles were in the forest, Sita was kidnapped by Ravana and taken to his kingdom in Sri Lanka. Hanuman went there as a royal messenger from Rama but was caught, bound, and had his tail set on fire. Hanuman freed himself from his bonds, and then, according to the Ramayana.

He jumped from mansion to man- sion, setting fire to them. In a little while a strong breeze began to blow and the whole city was in flames.

Flushed with triumph, Hanuman returned to Rama, presumably still in Chitrakoot, and told him how he had laid waste to the capital of Ravana.

Local tradition adds a detail that the Ramayana does not relate. Rama saw that his faithful messenger was still filled with anger, He, therefore, shot an arrow into a rock and a spring of cold water gushed out. Hanuman bathed in this divine fountain and cooled his anger. This is what is commemorated atop Hanuman Dhara.

It is, however, a long and fairly arduous haul up.

Starting with the Hanuman shrine at the bottom of the 787 steps winding up the hill, there are six more Hanuman shrines at various levels. Some are in little pavilions, others are carved on rock faces, and they're all painted bright

Sati Anusuya Temple

orange. There are plenty of monkeys here, all black-faced langurs, and they all behave as if they are masters of all they survey.
A particularly audacious one reached into the pocket of a visitor in search of a snack!

The first long orange building houses the idol of Hanuman on which the rage-cooling spring used to drip. The water has been channelled into a pipe, away from the image, and Hanuman has been arrayed in rich garments.

Devotees then go out, down some steps, and cross a bridge spanning a pool backed by a rock-face on which a blue Hanuman has been painted. There is still a fairly long way to go, past more shrines, open-fronted stalls, a small temple holding a Shivling, a passage leading to another building and, finally, Sita's Kitch- en or rasoi with the images of five rishis sitting down to enjoy Sita's hospitality. There are many references in the Ramayana to the seers and their hermitages in the forests where the three exiles spent their banishment. This shrine captures the friendship that grew between Rama, Sita and Laksliman and the hermits who had chosen a lonely and contemplative life in the jungle.

One of these hermits lived in an ashram, 15 kms out of Chitrakoot town. It is called Sati Anasuya.

SATI ANASUYA

In those distant days the hermitage must have been a very rustic hut of bamboo, branches and thatch. The Ramayana says that Rama, Sita and Lakshman visited this ashram and were welcomed by the very virtuous wife of Sage Atri. She is known as Sati Anasuya. This devoted wife's virtue had acquired such power that she caused the Mandakini River to gush out of the earth and flow past their ashram. Deciding to test her purity, three powerful deities disguised themselves as hermits and, when her husband was away on a cliff lost in meditation, they visited her ashram and demanded food. Such a demand could not be refused, nor could the conditions that the three 'hermits' imposed to accept her food. They would do so, they said, only if she was naked when she served them. So great was the strength of her resolve, however, that the three gods were transformed into three babies whom she suckled at her breasts. She thus fulfilled both their demands and still retained her virtue.

Another, more recent, version of the same powerful legend says that Atri and Anasuya had triplets with all the virtues of the three gods.

Today, a large and glittering temple stands where the Atri-Anasuya

hermitage once, reputedly, did. But the Mandakini still flows past it with all the sparking beauty of the forest stream that was born in untarnished virtue.

Pilgrims bathe in it and large fish come up to the surface fearlessly asking for food sold by vendors.

A little beyond the modern temple are older shrines and below them is a huge rock with powerful, primitive images of Shiva carved into them.

Further along the course of the Mandakini is a beautiful spot, down a flight of steps. It is the Janaki Kund.

JANAKI KUND

Sita was the daughter of Janaka, king of Mithila. She was, therefore, also known as Janaki. This spot, on the Mandikini, was the legendary place where Sita preferred to bathe in the morning, and in privacy. Presumably because the more public ghats, in those days, attracted the rishis, their wives and their disciples.

Here, on the banks of this rippling stream, there is a small pavilion where, often, a scholar reads the Ramayana written in Khari Boli, the local dialect rather than in Sanskrit or other literary languages.

Continuing down the course of the Mandikini is another attractive riverside shrine known as the Sphatik Shila.

SPHATIK SHILA

According to a touching legend, Rama had plucked some wild flowers and was decorating Sita's hair with them. They were both seated on a rock on the banks of the river. Unhappy with this cameo of domestic bliss, Jayant, the mischievous son of one of the gods, turned himself into a crow, flew down and pecked Sita's feet. This enraged the vigilant Lakshman who fired an arrow at the intruding bird, and pierced one of its eyes. This is why crows, to this day, tilt their heads to examine anything!

There is a pavilion that enshrines footprints, recalling these legendary events on the banks of the Mandakini river.

Water, because of its cleansing properties, plays a very important role in

Sphatik Shila

Gupt Godavari

most of the old religions. Rivers, with their life-giving flow, have always been important to the agricultural economy of our land.

Eighteen kilometres away from Chitrakoot are two caves through which a stream flows. These are known as the Gupt Godavari.

GUPT GODAVARI

From the parking area in the village below, a stepped path leads, past a ticket booth and a manned footwear rack, to the fairly narrow mouth of the upper cave. The mouth opens out into a large cavern with two interesting features. One is an outcrop of black rock protruding from the paler roof of the cave.

According to legend, this is all that remains of the peeping-tom monster: Mayank. He dared to spy on Sita while she was bathing in a pool in the cave. The enraged Lakshman petrified him and stuck him onto the roof.

Then there is Sita Kund, the small pond in which Sita was bathing when Mayank peeped at her.

Going out from this cave there is an entrance to the lower one through which a stream flows. The stream, which extends for about 100 meters, appears to have its source in a number of little springs gushing and trickling out of the mountain. Pilgrims seeking spiritual benefits, wade knee-deep through this stream and emerge out through the mouth of the lower cave.

The descriptive board at Gupt Godavari says:

This cave was formed natu- rally by water and dates back to 9.50 lakh years. (That's 950,000 years ago) It is said that in order to have a glimpse of Lord Ram, the river (Godavari) came here secretly from Nasik. It is said that this place was visited by Ram, Sita and Laxman.

After emerging from the cave the Gupt, or Hidden Godavari, flows into a pond and then vanishes, presumably underground. The legendary source of this important river is in the temple of Trimbakeshwar in the western state of Maharashtra. That is at least 800 kms as a crow flies, very much more as a subterranean river flows!

But then, epics have their own magical logic...

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Ujjain

Time is, quite literally, the essence of Ujjain.

According to Hindu belief, the Lord of Time resides here. It was, also, a great centre of Buddhism and Jainism during the lifetimes of both the Buddha and that of the last of the Jain's spiritual guides, the 24th Tirthankar, Lord Mahavira. All this happened many hundreds of years Before Christ. But quite apart from being a major religious hub, the prosperity and technological achievements of Ujjain lured ambitious rulers to dominate this rich land. (See Box-The City's Fabled Past).

In the 3rd century BC, Ashoka took over as the viceroy of Ujjain. During his rule, according to historian Dr. Kalyan Kumar Chakravarty, Ashoka's *"... son*

The famed ghats of Ujjain

The impressive Mahakaleshwar Temple

THE CITY'S FABLED PAST

Devotees taking bath on River Shipra

For centuries, the town stood centred in the cross-hairs of history, the focused target of conqueror after conqueror. They came, drawn by tales of its prosperity stretching back to 2015 B.C.

In that distant age, migrants from the beleaguered civilization of the Harappans had probably settled here, bringing their manufacturing skills with them. These mys- terious people could have been merchant- adventurers from the Mediterranean who had sailed up western India's navigable rivers and established walled colonies in present-day Gujarat. There they had cre- ated their sophisticated cities and manufac- tured ceramic and metallurgical wonders for export to the ancient Egyptians and the Biblical people of Ur, home of the great Semitic father-figure, the prophet Abraham. Sadly, over-exploitation of their land, and attacks by fierce pastoral tribes, had led to a frightened exodus of the Harappans to the fastnesses of the rugged mountains of the north and to the well-watered plains of the south and east. One of their new settlements was in Kayatha, 24 kms east of Ujjain.

Here, over successive generations, they had honed their inherited skills. By 700 BC, the settlements of the original Harap- pan people had grown into the first recognizable City of Ujjain.

It was, clearly, a very rich and powerful city. Archaeologists have unearthed a blacksmith's furnace from its 500 BC - 200 BC period. Armed by the arrow-heads, spear-heads, knives and blades, the settlers in Ujjain wiped out the copper-age, Chalco- lithic people around them. They built cam- bered roads varying from 6 m to 12 m in width and, on them, 1.8 m wide cart tracks have been found. Buddhist literature indi- cates that Ujjain was a major trade centre on the South-west North-east caravan route linking the famed Mauryan capital of Pataliputra, in present-day Bihar, with the ports of the west coast on the Arabian Sea.

Continued prosperity gives peace, scholarship, tolerance and a spirit of pride to the citizens of a city. In spite of the devastation wrought by some invaders, the people of Ujjain rebuilt their city The Mughal emperors Akbar and Bahadur Shah had their silver coins minted in Ujjain drawing on its long tradition of metallurgical expertise. Its long-standing reputation as a centre of astronomical studies caused Mughal Governor, and ruler of Jaipur, Jai Singh, to create his Observatory here: it still gives remarkably accurate observa- tions. All this led to an attitude of tolerance and open-mindedness. From Eastern Iran, filtering through Ujjain, came the sun cult of the legendary Magi savants. In 1580, the first Christian Mission from Goa passed through Ujjain. Here, too, sects that were often reviled in more orthodox cities estab- lished their centres without fear of persecu- tion. The Naths, the Kapalikas and even the often-feared Aghoris lived undisturbed in Ujjain. And in the heart of the old city, the Islamic Bohras, whose ancestors had sailed in from Yemen, still thrive in harmony with people who do not subscribe to their tenets; and they have lived so for centuries.

To this day, the citizens of Ujjain feel that their liberal attitude is the bedrock of both their creativity and their prosperity. They tend to believe that their counterpoint is the ancient town of Varanasi, or Banaras, which is the bastion of tradition and ortho- doxy and, therefore, averse to innovation. This is, clearly, an expression of the pride that the Ujjainis have in their city as, indeed, many inhabitants of historic cities have!

THE CITY'S FABLED PAST

The deepstambhs or light-towers stand tall in the Harsiddhi Ma Temple

Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra invented the missionary cult and carried the message of Buddha from Ujjain to Ceylon"

The successors to Ashoka's Mauryan Empire, were the Sakas. They had invaded India from the north and were of Scythian-Parthian-Iranian origin. When they conquered Ujjain they absorbed local customs so rapidly that, apart from introducing the cult of Sun- worship, they gave a major boost to traditional astronomical studies. Ujjain also became such a prosperous centre of trade that even the Egyptian geogra- pher Ptolemy wrote a glowing account of its affluence and power. He called it Ozein. American Author Lyman Frank

Baum could have been influenced by this when he wrote about the wonder- ful land of Oz, and its wizard!

But the wonder of Oz, or Ozein, did not ensnare everyone. Roaring iconoclasm, wreaking destruction with fire and sword, came the Turk- ish Sultan of Delhi, Iltutmish, and his savage hordes seeking rapine and pillage. They destroyed temples and idols believing that they contained for- tunes of gold and jewels. The ancient temple of Mahakaleshwar, the Lord of Time, fell to their vicious greed. When they left, the city was as ravaged as if it had been devastated by a plague of locusts. But even they could not weaken the spirit of Ujjain and, swiftly, it reasserted itself. The metropolis once again became the vibrant nucleus of trade and culture in northern India.

When Akbar, the greatest of the Great Mughals came here, he assessed its inherent strengths and set up his silver mint in Ujjain. The coins of the Mughal Empire poured out of the furnaces and metal presses of Ujjain. His descendant, the Emperor Mohammed Shah, astutely appointed the Prince of Jaipur, the savant Maharaja Jai Singh, as his governor in Ujjain. This princely polymath built on the ancient astronomical inheritance of Ujjain and estab lished his redoubtable masonry observatory here in the first half of the 18th century. It is still used to create the star-charts on which the astrological fore. casts of millions of people are cast. By that reckoning it is the most influential observatory in the world.

The Mughal Empire then began to crumble, burdened by age, weakness and attacks by ambitious rivals. A vacuum was building up in Ujjain and was soon filled by the strong Maratha general, Ranoji Scindia, who made this his capital in 1735. During the reign of the Scindias, an official of the dynasty Ramachandra Baba Shenvi, had the Mahakal Temple rebuilt on the site of the old one.

Travellers to Ujjain generally start their tour of this historic city by visiting the Mahakaleshwar Temple.

THE MAHAKALESHWAR TEMPLE

The spire of the temple, crowned with a gold kalash, dominates the city. Crowds of pilgrims wait to deposit their footwear in the manned racks outside. A corridor leads into a partially-covered yard built around the temple tank. In this covered space there are small shrines. The first one is dedicated to Ram, Sita and Lakshman; the second holds a shivling named Koteshwar Mahadev; the third is one to the goddess Annapurna, 'She Who Fills with Food'.

From here, a silver door accesses a short flight of steps leading down to the sanctum of the great temple. It is a small chamber, often very crowded with worshippers. In the centre of the floor, encircled by a pear-shaped yoni, a protective golden fence, and

The Shrangaar of Mahakal

rising from a silver lotus, stands the Mahakaleshwar shivling. It is guarded by a hooded snake sculpted in silver and a pot, suspended above, drips water to cool the meter-high shivling. In an alcove in the wall behind is an image of Parvati.

Up a few steps, visitors enter a large hall with a silver Nandi gazing down at his master. Devotees often whisper their wishes into the ear of this revered atull. Out of the hall and keeping the temple on your left, you will come to the shrine of Omkareshwar Siva. The idol is a small black shivling in a brass yoni On either side of the idol are marble images of Ganesh, Brahma and Vishnu along with their consorts. On the floor outside the sanctum is a peep-hole giving a view of the Mahakaleshwar idol, below. There is another floor above this but its shrine to Nagchandreshwar, a serpent idol, is open for veneration only one day in the year so most visitors have not seen it.

Back towards the exit from the grounds of the temple is a shrine to the nine 'planets'. These are the seven astrologically significant ones and the ascending and descending nodes which are treated as planets when calculating horoscopes.

Around the corner from Mahakaleshwar, and near the Rudrasagar tank is the Bade Ganesh ka Mandir.

BADE GANESH KA MANDIR

This temple enshrines a huge, red Ganesh in the foyer, flanked by his two wives. Inside the shrine is a bronzed idol of a five-faced, panchmukhi, Hanuman. If you do a parikrama, or circumambulatory, walk leaving the Hanuman idol to your right, you will come to an idol of the baby Krishna in the arms of his mother Yashodhara with a background of black serpents with extended hoods. Next there is a red Hanuman with five heads and Lord Ram's name inscribed on his heart. He is reputed to be a great devo- tee of Lord Ram and Hanuman and his monkey army helped Ram build the land bridge to Sri Lanka. A line of rocks still thrusts out of the sea between the southern tip of India and the north-eastern shores of Sri Lanka. After the idol of Hanuman is an unusual one of a Black God- dess, riding on her lion vehicle. The Black Goddess, or Kali, is the vengeful aspect of the powerful yellow goddess Durga who is the enemy of evil and ignorance. This idol seems to be a composite of both aspects of the Mother Goddess. Finally, at the end of the parikrama, visitors pass a silver swing holding an image of Baby Krishna. It is customary for devotees to give the swing a slight push and set it into motion.

The Bada Ganesh

Continuing down the road, visitors come to the Harsiddhi Ma Temple.

HARSIDDHI MA TEMPLE

The most visually striking feature of this complex of temples are the two

The Harsiddhi Ma temple complex

deepstambhs or 'light pillars': cone-shaped pillars imbedded with a number oil-lamps designed to hold flaming wicks. This is an architectural element of Maratha temples and was constructed when the Marathas renovated this place of worship. The temple is on an elevated plinth and the idol of Harsiddhi Ma has been painted bright red, the colour of power and strength. There is an interesting belief woven around the goddess.

When Siva and Parvati were in ecstatic union, in Siva's palace on Mount Kailas, two demons, Chand and Prachand, disturbed them. Siva called upon the goddess Chandni to destroy them. She did so. In gratitude Siva gave her the title of 'Harsiddhi', or The One Who Vanquishes All.

The ceiling of the sanctum is rich with murals, the most important of which is the Shri Yantra. This is a geometric figure of nine interlocking triangles, five pointing down to represent the female principle and four pointing up to depict the male principle. When meditated upon, this diagram conjures up the interplay of the dynamic and static forces of the universe held in the equipoise that is represented by the bindu, or dot, in the centre of the yantra. Many devotees who have concentrated on the Sri Yantra say that, after a while, the yantra seems to rotate, faster and faster, drawing the mind into a vortex s the bindu enlarges and fills the entire consciousness, obliterating all sense impressions received from the world around the meditator.

To the right of the Harsiddhi Ma temple is the shrine of Karkokeshwar Mahadev.

KARKOKESHWAR MAHADEV

Mahadev, or Great God, is one of the many names of Siva. This single celled temple, on a raised plinth, holds an image of Nandi looking at a small multi-faceted Shivling.

Roughly in between, but in front of, the Harsiddhi and Karkokeshwar temples, is the red, sunken, shrine revered as a Shakti Peeth.

SHAKTI PEETH

There are three peep-holes for visitors to look down into the shrine. The idol is draped in red and an eternal flame burns to one side. The idol is worshipped as the elbow of the goddess Sati, fallen from the skies after her body

was dismembered to avert the destruction of the universe (See Box-The Shakti Peeths)

The universe, and the movements of the planets in our solar system. have been a special field of study in Ujjain for centuries. This continues to be practiced today using the masonry instruments of the Vedha Shala.

VEDHA SHALA OR THE OBSERVATORY

Popularly known as the Jantar Mantar, this is one of five observatories built by Jai Singh, Maharaja of Jaipur, who was also the Mughal governor of Ujjain It was constructed between 1725 and 1730 and is the only one of the threr surviving observatories of Jai Singh still in use. The Samrat Yantra, or the Supreme Instrument, is an enormous sundial indicating solar time with the accuracy of a few seconds. Another instrument looks like a high, red wall with two white arcs crossing it. According to the experts in the Observatory, this is their Transit Instrument. Using these two, and three other static instruments. the specialists in the observatory calculate the ephemeris, or table giving the predicted positions of celestial bodies for a year. Their tables influence the Courses of millions of lives all over India and in many other parts of the world.

Unlike conventional Observatories, this complex is not interested in stars in general. Their focus is on the movements and positions of Mercury, Venus, the Moon, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, the ascending and descending nodes which are treated as planets, and the Sun. The observers here treat the Sun as a planet. They are not concerned with the composition of these heavenly bodies and if a Mars-lander found silicon life on the red planet, it would not change their perceptions in any way. When they have prepared their accurate ephemeris tables, printed them and distributed them they have completed their allotted task. Then it is up to astrologers all over India to use those tables to predict how those positions will effect the courses of, literally, tens of millions of lives in every situation: births, marriages, deaths, sickness, health, wealth, business, travel. The most valued astrological predictions are person-specific: they are not the sort of vague statements made by syndicated astrologers in newspapers.

And while many self-styled rationalists sneer at the idea that such celestial objects can affect the course of human lives, it's interesting to note that the writers of the Bible believed in this. The Three Wise Men associated the Christmas Star with the birth of the Christ Child. And when a star is linked to

The Vedh Shala

an event in a human life then it is astrology, not astronomy!

The Vedha Shala is set in a pleasant garden with steps leading down to the Shipra River. On the far side of the river stretch some of the lush, green fields of this ancient city.

Visitors have to cross the river to get to a shrine of contentment. Ujjainis believe that their continued lack of anxiety is due, to a great extent, to the presence of the Chintamani Ganesh.

THE SHAKTI PEETHS

'Shakti' is strength or power, a 'Peeth' is a place where the shakti resides. The power of gods lies static within them. It is only when they interact with their consorts, the goddesses or Shaktis, that their power becomes dynamic.

There is a complex body of legends accounting for the existence of the Shakti Peeths. The essence of all the legends, however, is that Siva's father-in-law Daksha did not approve of him. Daksha was a son of the Creator, Brahma and therefore of both immortal and royal descent. Siva, with the unkempt appearance of a mendicant was, according to Daksha, unworthy to marry his daughter. He, therefore, neither invited Siva nor his daughter when he had a great fire sacrifice. When he saw that his daughter had gate-crashed the sacrifice, any way, the proud Diksha insulted her and also her hus. band. Deeply humiliated, his daughter threw herself into the sacrificial fire.

When Siva learnt of this, he stormed into Daksha's palace, laid waste to the ritual, decapitated his father-in-law and grafted a goat's head onto Daksha's body. In his anger, Siva then picked up his consort's corpse and began his terrible Dance of Destruction.

Fearing that the whole of creation would be turned to ashes, the gods appealed to Lord Vishnu. The Preserver threw his dis- cus, the invincible Sudarshan Chakra, and sliced the corpse of Siva's consort into small pieces which scattered over the earth. Wher- ever a bit of her body, or her jewellery, fell it became a hallowed spot: a Shakti Peeth. There are fifty-one Shakti Peethas in India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Tibet and Sri Lanka.

Siva's consort has many names: Uma, Dakshayani and Durga among them but she is usually referred to as Parvati. In the Shakti Peethas her idol is generally accom- panied by Bhairava who is then considered to be an aspect of Siva.

Some rationalists contend that this is the memory of an ancient asteroid which shattered under the force of earth's gravity and the heat of atmospheric friction before it could destroy earth. There are other more fabulous theories. Faith, however, does not demand an explanation; only acceptance.

CHINTAMANI GANESH

The word 'chintamani' means 'free of worry' and this, according to his devotees, is what is guaranteed by the red idol worshipped in this temple. This is a rather unusual temple. Its tower and domes crown a gallery of beautifully carved pillars belonging to the Parmar period, many centuries old. From here steps lead down to a small sanctum. The idol of Ganesh, with his wives Riddhi and Siddhi, is honoured as a self-formed, or swayambhu, one. This generally means that it was not fashioned by human hands and was worshipped long before the temple was built around it.

The Chintamani Ganesh temple is on the south-western outskirts of town A journey far to the south-eastern edge, back across the river, then to the right,

and to the right again down the long Lal Bahadur Shastri Marg, will bring visitors to the confluence of the Shipra and Khan Rivers. Here is the Navgraha Mandir.

NAVGRAHA MANDIR

Literally the Temple of the Nine Planetary Houses, this is an unimpressive structure architecturally: a single-storeyed, pavilion-like building surmounted by onion-shaped domes and fluttering flags. From a platform around a peepul tree a red-robed woman dispenses blessings and advice, empowered by small red idols.

According to a descriptive board, the temple is about 150 years old and is on the triveni ghat, or confluence of three rivers. The mysterious, and unseen, Saraswati is also supposed to mingle with the waters of the Shipra and Khan, here. Crowds of devotees assemble in the Navgraha Mandir when Saturdays fall on amavasya, or the dark New Moon nights.

The main entrance to the temple faces the river and the prime deity is Shani or Saturn. Moving clockwise around the other cells off the verandah, devotees can worship the idols of Ketu, Guru, Budh, Surya, Shukul, Chandra, Mangal and Rahu: the Ascending Node, Jupiter, Mercury, Sun, Venus, Moon, Mars and the Descending Node, respectively. The idols are rather formless and red, their basic features painted in silver, with white eyes and black pupils. They give the impression of being ancient, rural deities who have been absorbed into a more sophisticated pantheon.

Heading back into the crowded heart of the town, the visitor should stop at the large, white Shri Gopal Temple.

SHRI GOPAL TEMPLE

"Gopal' is another name for Lord Krishna and this temple, dedicated to his worship, was built 250 years ago by Maharani Baijabai Scindia. Built in the Maratha style which was strongly influenced by the Rajasthani form of architecture, the temple has balconies with curved domes and an entrance with a scalloped arch. Extensive use of silver makes the interior of the temple radiant and glittering. The idol is a dark-faced Krishna enshrined in an alcove atop a massive, silver altar.

Interestingly, there are two mosques a short distance down the road and

The Shri Gopal temple in heart of the town

directly in front of the Shri Gopal Temple.

From here, a long walk down the narrow crowded and rather Arabian-Night-ish alleys, will bring visitors to the immaculately clean and very beautiful Mazar-e-Najmi.

MAZAR-E-NAJMI

Here are the white marble tombs, or mazars, with silver doors, of the 39th, 40th and 47th Syednas, or spiritual heads, of the prosperous trading community of Bohra Muslims. The Syednas names were Ibrahim Vajiuddin, Hebtullah Moayyed Saheb, and Abdul Qadir Najmuddin. Such Spiritual leaders reside wherever the interests of the community are strongest. Bohra women may wear colourful burkhas and need not veil their faces. Such social traditions generally have a long history and these ones probably go back to the time the first Islamic traders sailed from the Gulf, bound for the rich shores of India.

The Bohras came, originally, from Yemen and, on either side of the mazar doors, two sailing ships have been inlaid in black.

Also in the heart of the town is a small Chausath Yogini Temple.

CHAUSATH YOGINI TEMPLE

Dedicated to the 64 aspects of the Mother Goddess, this temple de- picts them in a largely non-representational form: 64 red faces, most of them virtually indistinguishable from each other.

Entering through an arched doorway, the visitor steps into a small square courtyard in the centre of which is a pillared temple on a plinth. In the sanctum only five of the faces have individual features, the rest are little more than mounds emerging from a matrix as if they were being conjured up by a mind locked in deep meditation. In all old, and developed faiths, religiou icons often serve as focal points in a personal search for a reality that is as abstract as a concept in quantum mechanics. Eastern mysticism and cutting-edge physics seem to be converging.

There are recognisable male images on the left and right of the door. way opening to the sanctum. They are King Vikramaditiya of Ujjain and King Jagder of Dhar. People believe that King Vikrmaditiya cut off his head and

The Mangalnath Temple

offered it to the Goddess ten times, and on all ten occasions she restored it on his body. The King of Dhar made this sacrifice only once, and his head, too, was grafted back. Facing the sanctum, is an image of a lion, the vehicle of the Mother Goddess.

It would be most convenient now for visitors to head north-east along the Mangalnath Marg to the Mangalnath Temple.

MANGALNATH TEMPLE

'Mangal' is the planet Mars, worshipped on Tuesdays. Devotees throng this temple on the third day of the week, climb up the long flight of steps, reach the base of the plinth of the temple, walk clockwise around it, then stop to look up at the image of a ram, vehicle of Mangal. All temples dedicated to any of the celestial bodies are, essentially, Siva temples, as this one is. Even though this is known as the Temple of Mars, the principal idol is that of Siva and it is directly in front of the flight of steps leading up the plinth, past Nandi gazing into the sanctum. Mars is enshrined in a subsidiary shrine to one side of the sanctum.

From the base of the steps accessing the plinth, there is an impressive view of the Shipra River flowing below. Devotees often assure visitors that this temple gives an excellent view of the red planet, Mars. This, however, seems to be more a matter of faith than observation.

Back down the Mangalnath Marg road, the visitor will come to the popular Sandipani Ashram.

SANDIPANI ASHRAM

This small complex of buildings set in a garden has a legendary history. The faithful believes that this is where the seer Sandipani taught Lord Krishna, his brother Balram, and their friend Sudama.

The place where the ashram, or hermitage, of Sandipani once stood is now a temple dedicated to the great teacher. He sits on an elevated platform facing the images of his three seated pupils. The central image is believed to be the only seated image of Krishna in the world. The head priest who officiates in this complex is Rupam Vyas, the 202nd direct descendant of Guru Sandipani The priest assures visitors that Lord Krishna was a genius: he memorised the four

The Idols in Sandipani Ashram

The Sandipani Ahsram

Vedas in four days, and the other sixty essential books of instruction in just sixty more days.

Facing the temple to Guru Sandipani is an old temple enshrining a shivling. The more curious visitors sometimes ask why a religious complex dedicated to the second person of the Brahmanical Trinity, Vishnu - of whom Krishna is an incarnation - holds a temple to the third person of the Trinity, Siva. The devotees of Vishnu and those of Siva were, traditionally, as opposed to each other as Catholics and Protestants were in Christianity. In Brahmanism, however, there was a great reconciliation of beliefs in the composite idol ist Hari another name for Vishnu - and Har - one of the appellations of Siva The unified god is known as Harihara. This, apparently, is why the Nandi, bull steed of Siva, shown in all other Siva temples as a sitting image, is here depicted standing in honour of Krishna, the cowherd prince. It is, probably, the world's only standing Nandi.

Behind this temple, across the grounds, is a single-celled shrine with a black shivling encircled by the image of a stone serpent. When Siva is depicted in human form, he has a hooded serpent coiled around his neck. This temple is known as Serveshwar Mahadev. The faithful believes that this shivling was worshipped by the student Krishna.

There is also a stepped tank in this complex. It was, according to legend, created by Krishna for his guru, Sandipani, who came from Mathura, in Uttar Pradesh, on the banks of the River Gomti. Krishna fired an arrow into the earth and the waters of the Gomti miraculously bubbled into the tank so that the guru could bathe in the waters of his preferred river. One of the names of this tank is Gomti Kund: the tank of Gomti. And since Krishna also washed his slate in this pond, it is also called Ankpat.

Leaving the Sandipani Ashram move west-wards, through a truly rural landscape of fields and villages, till a walled compound appears ahead. This is the Gadkalika Mandir.

GADKALIKA MANDIR

A descriptive board outside this temple says

This is the temple where Kalidas worshipped (Kalidas, who lived in A.D. 400, is often considered to be the Shake. speare of India; those who have read his works in the original, often claim that this comparison is an insult to Ka. lidas!)

The ancient idol of Kalika

The plinth is of the first century BC, the Sunga period, while bricks and other pieces recovered from the basement belong to the fourth century, Gupta period, and the tenth and twelfth centuries, Parmar period. Emperor Harshvardhan had the temple renovated in the seventh century. It was rebuilt in modern times by the Gwalior state.

The temple sits on a plinth in the centre of a small courtyard with rooms all around. A golden lion gazes into the sanctum of this single-celled temple. The idol of Kalika is a red head wearing a silver crown. Legend has it that the genius of Kalidas blossomed only after he worshipped in this temple.

An unusual feature of this temple is that its tower has red-and-white candy stripes painted horizontally on it. It also has a masonry Light Tower or deepstambh, presumably built when the Scindias renovated the temple.

Further west from here, atop a knoll overlooking the Shipra, is the very simple tomb of Peer Matsyendra Nath.

PIR OR PEER MATSYENDRA NATH

The tomb has a very Islamic look with an arched doorway, a domed roof, and four small towers at the corners. The fact that it is referred as being that of a 'Pir', a title usually applied to a Muslim saint, underscores the impression that it is a mazaar of a follower of the Prophet Mohammed. But then one notices that the grave is covered in a saffron sheet and not a green one, and that saffron flags fly on its plinth, giving it a distinctly Hindu bias.

In fact it is the tomb of a great spiritual leader of a Hindu monastic sect who refer to their spiritual leaders as Pirs. The sect call themselves the Naths. which means 'Master' or 'Lord'. The names of their nine traditional leaders all ended in 'Nath'

According to generally available information the Naths strive to trans-form their bodies into immortal spiritual beings by practices and beliefs drawn from Buddhism, Saivism - the worship of Siva - and the physical discipline of yoga. This kaya-sadhana, or culture of the body, involves control of the breath, semen, and thought, to first achieve sahaja or detachment from the conflicts of life.

The original nine Nathas, according to the belief of some of this monastic

The Matsyendra Nath's Tomb

order, live semi-divine lives in the Himalayas.

Matsyendranath was the first of the human gurus of the sect. Some Hindus identify him as Lord Siva, Buddhists as the Buddha Vajrasattva, and in Nepal he is considered to be the Bodhisattva, or future Buddha Avalokitesvara His Holiness, the Dalai Lama, is considered to be the human manifestation of Avalokitesvara.

Matsyendranath is, therefore, worshipped by orthodox Hindus, Buddhists and, in a tangential way, by the Vajaryana sect of Tibetan Buddhists. And, of course, by the Naths.

The Naths are a living sect and one of their monasteries still guards the Bhartrihari Caves.

BHARTRIHARI CAVES

There is a descriptive board in front of these caves which says, in effect, that the caves are the remains of a double-storeyed monastery of the 10th century, Parmar Period. They have been named after the ascetic brother of King Vikramaditiya of Ujjain who used them as his hermitage. Bhartrihari abdicated the throne in favour of his brother and devoted himself to spirituality. He is also known for the exquisite meter of his Sanskrit verses. Centuries later, by the 14th and 15th century, these caves had become an important centre of the monastic Naths. Local belief associates these caves with Goraknath and Matsyendranath: both were influential leaders of the sect.

From the car-park, visitors have to descend a long flight of steps to a flat stretch of ground on the banks of the Shipra River. From here, queue rails lead to a few steps accessing another terrace to the left of which is a cave shrine with an image of Bhartrihari. It faces a shivling across the terrace. More steps then pierce a wall running along one side of this terrace, leading to a third terrace from where one can enter the east cave on the right and the west cave on the left.

At the entrance of the east cave is a pillared hall with carved temple pillars. On its right wall is a carving of Siva dancing between two pillars. The skull-topped mace he carries gives the impression that this temple could have been used by one of the more extreme sects of mendicants. A narrow opening on the right leads one to another chamber with a statue of Bhartrihari, reputedly marking the spot where he meditated for 25 years. Through a further passage, on the right, the visitor comes to a shivling with one of the Nath sadhus in attendance. When the Naths have been accepted as full-fledged members of their monastic order, their guru pierces their ears and inserts a heavy iron ear-ring. They often wear yellow turbans.

Out of the east cave, turning right along the caves' outer wall, the visitor comes to the mouth of the west cave. A metal staircase winds down to a lower level, then through a gap in the cave wall to the right and into a small shrine with a black idol of Bhartrihari wearing the identifying ear-ring of the Naths. Another Nath sadhu sits in attendance here. On the wall. opposite the idol is an arched aperture which once, apparently, led to 'the Char Dhams'. It is most unlikely that a tunnel led for hundreds of kilometres to the Char Dham temples in the High Himalayas of Uttarakhand. It is more likely that this refers to a Char Dham among the many temples of Ujjain. All this, however, is just so much speculation: the tunnel, if there ever was one had been blocked to prevent over-enthusiastic but inexperienced tourists from getting lost underground.

Leaving the caves and heading north one can reach the Temple of Kalbhairav.

TEMPLE OF KALBHAIRAV

This dark and fearsome huntsman's-deity is sometimes considered to be an

The idol of Kalbhairav

aspect of Siva but is, more correctly, identified as the leader of eight awesome semi-divine beings of the jungle and wilderness named the Bhairavs.

Interestingly, at the bottom of the steps leading to the temple are 1 number of shops selling bottles of alcohol. Liquor is one of the authorised offerings given to this unusual Hindu god. A descriptive board says that the worshippers of Siva also revere the eight Bhairavs and this temple has been mentioned in one of the old scriptures of Hinduism. Traditionally, the followers of both the Kapalika and Aghora sects worship Kal Bhairav. These mendicants practice extreme austerities: the Aghoras, in particular, live in cremation grounds and their lifestyles are regarded as repulsive and very anti-social by most people.

The temple is built a bit like a fortress with steps leading to a nail-studded gate, set in a gate-house in the wall encircling the temple. In the grounds, there is a large, black, light-tower and both this, and the architecture of the temple, show the influence of the Marathas. Historically, however, the temple is believed to have been built by an obscure king named Bhadrasen. Here too, with many other idols in Ujjain, the deity is a large red head with eyes, a silver forehead and crown. A very special feature about this head is the thin opening of its mouth. Liquor poured onto a flat plate is, gradually, tippled by the idol with the help of an attendant priest. Devotees say that no one knows where the alcohol goes to.

From here, the Siddhavat Marg, arrowing north, will join the Kaliadeh Mahal Marg, cross an old bridge and a weir and stop below the Kaliadeh Palace.

KALIADEH PALACE

The rather stolid, solid palace is just above the road and not in a very good state of repair. Below the road is an interesting group of pavilions, ter good ponds and flowing water-courses. Today it is more than likely that the terraces will have the festive look of patchwork quilts as local folk spread laundered saris to dry. It was not always so, if the descriptive board is to be believed. It says

The Kaliadeh Palace was built by Mahmud Khilji in 1458, while the tanks around were built by Sultan Nasirud-Din Khilji (in the 16th century)to help reduce the heat of his body as he was in the habit of taking mercury, which is very heating The Palace was damaged by the Pindaris (freebooting marauders from the disbanded Mughal army) and restored by Madhav Rao Scindia in 1920.

According to two Persian inscriptions in one of its long corridors, the

The Kaliadeh Palace

Mughal Emperors Akbar and Jehangir were said to have visited the palace. Returning down the Kaliadeh Mahal road, visitors will come to the unusual Siddhavat.

SIDDHAVAT

Here, at the edge of a terrace rising from the banks of the Shipra River, stands a reputedly immortal banyan, Ficus religiosa, tree. A descriptive board says much about the significance of this greatly revered fig:

According to mythology, the Siddhavat here, the Assahayvat in Prayag, the Boudhvat in Gaya and the Bansivat in Mathura - these four trees are immortal and worshipped as Kalpavriksh. According to the Skandpurana, the tree was sown by Parvati.

In the Deva-Asura War, the Asura Emperor Tarkasur was killed by Kartik, who was appointed the Commander-in-Chief of the Devas under this tree. The power used by Kartik to kill the Asura in the middle of the Shipra was known as 'Shakti Bedh'

According to history, King Vikramaditya, after austerities here, obtained the power to control the Betal (vampire).

Mahendra and Sanghamitra, the children of Ashoka worshipped here and then travelled to Sri Lanka.

The Mughals cut the tree and enclosed its roots in 7 round plates of metal but after a great storm it got green again.

A pilgrimage here is good for prosperity, children and salvation.

For fulfilment of desires-

(1) a thread is tied here,

(2) an opposite swastika is made to obtain a child and after getting a child, offer a coconut,

(3) for the peace of forefathers it is necessary to pour milk pooja on branches

Special fairs are held here.

The other three immortal trees are in Prayag in Uttar Pradesh's Allahabad where the Ganga and the Jumna rivers meet the invisible Saraswati; in Bihari Gaya where the Buddha realised the cause of pain and suffering, and in Mathura, in Uttar Pradesh, closely associated with the life of Lord Krishna. A Kalpavriksh is a legendary wish-fulfilling tree. The Skandpurana is a scripture said to have been written by Skanda also known as Kartik, a son of Lord Siva and Parvati, is held in particular reverence by the worshippers of Lord Siva.

Since the roots of the tree reputedly reach down to the netherworld, people come here to perform rituals for the repose of the souls of the dead. They sit in small groups in front of priests and perform ceremonies that could date back to the earliest days of their ancient faith. This is, truly, a memorable facet of Immortal India.

After leaving the Siddhavat, visitors interested in handicrafts should head south to visit Bhairogarh.

BHAIROGARH: THE BATIK VILLAGE

Happily, this is still a village where they create bright wonders in the old traditional ways.

Yellow-and-black patterned fabrics lie drying on wasteland. Through the open door of a small cottage visitors can see men drawing patterns with pen dipped in bubbling wax which wafts the fat, hot aroma of candles in an old church. In a large shed, with rays of sunlight shafting in from high skylights more wax bubbles, vats of dye glimmer, master artists sketch designs on cloth stretched on waist high tables, more artists fill in these designs with war Bare-bodied men dip the fabrics into vats of dye, draw them out dripping colour, hang them on metal drying rods. Water streams like red, black yellow blood across the dyeing floor, merges in fluid patterns, flows into drains Bollywood music blares through speakers. The shed is vibrant with sound colour, activity, the aroma of melted wax sliced by the chemical sharpness, the dyes, billows of hot steam rising in clouds.

Wax the areas from which the subsequent colours must be excluded. Crack

The Batik Print

the dry wax to get the typical veins of batik. Dye. Melt the wax in hot water. Dry, wax in the next excluded colours. Crack. Dye. Melt. Dry. Wax. Crack. Dyer.

Slowly, creatively, like emulsions emerging from a colour film, the pattern appears…

Then, for those eager to take away these cottage creations, there is a sales outlet: a shop offering the rainbow-bright fabrics of Bhairogarh. There is just one, final, encounter, with Ujjain's radiant past. The Ram Ghat.

RAM GHAT

The Ram Ghat, where flights of steps lead down to the lapping waters of the sacred river, is where the great Kumbh Bathing Festival is held once in twelve years. It commemorates an epochal event when the primal ocean was churned and treasures floated to the top like butter in a cream churner. One of these treasures was the pot, or kumbh, filled with amrit, the nectar of immortality. In the tussle between the two great churning parties, the Devas and the Asuras, some of this precious liquid fell to earth. One of the places was Ujjain, and when the earth crosses the auspicious sign of the zodiac for Ujjain, the great festival is held. Thousands of believers congregate at Ram Ghat and then all try to enter the river to bathe at the most appropriate moment to secure the greatest benefit for themselves. It is, undoubtedly, the greatest mass spiritual cleansing festival in the world. And its origins have been lost in the distant mists of legend.

There is also a daily festival at Ram Ghat and though it is not as awesome as the Kumbh it is, in many ways more touching, more beautiful. It is called The Aarti.

This is conducted every evening where a lone priest standing on the west bank of the Shipra, opposite the Ram Ghat, worships the river with flowers, incense and oil lamps, and his actions are replicated by a number of priests standing on the Ram Ghat. It is best seen from the west bank ghat below the Monastery of the Dutta Akhada, the place where the lone priest officiates.

At dusk, when the faint gilding of the sunset sky is dusted with pink, touching the towers and steps of the Ram Ghat, creating shimmering reflections like watered silk, the lights blink on like fireflies dancing. And the ceremony begins.

The hand-held aarti oil lamp is lit. So are the ones on the far bank. Drums beat, cymbals clash, a conch echoes like the haunting voice of divinity over the

Ram Ghat

Aarti of Shipra River at Ram Ghat

waters. The priest raises the flaming oil lamp, lowers it, circles it. The priests on the Ram Ghat match his moves thrusting moving spears of golden reflections into the flowing river. And all the while the metal drums increase their tempo, the clashing cymbals clang, the tympanic orchestra on the far bank follows and so do the flaming lamps.

It is an incredibly perfect synchronising of lights, sound and the flowing, dark river embroidered by red and gold reflections. This is, in every way, a fabulous encounter with an ageless ritual that strikes chords deep in the hearts of all enchanted spectators.

MAHAKAL LOK CORRIDOR

The Mahakal Corridor in Ujjain has been constructed in a very grand and beautiful way. The main reason of this corridor was to expand the premises of Mahakal temple and disperse the crowd across the city. The Mahakal lok consists of 200 statues, 80 sculptures and 52 murals. All these tell the story of Lord Shiva.

MPT Shipra Residency

7342551495

shipra@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Conference Hall

Bar | Transport

MPT Shipra Residency is a premium residency hotel located in the heart of Ujjain. A tasteful place for leisure and business travellers alike, it is also a perfect place to host conferences, corporate events and weddings. ISO 22000:2018 FSMS Certified. What people love the most about this property is its great location and hospitality. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property. Check in Time: 2 PM Check out Time: 12 PM.

MPT Avantika

7342980111

avantika@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

Situated in the middle of holy city of Ujjain, MPT Avantika is a cosy hotel offering comfortable accommodation and a peaceful stay. All guests are advised to carry a copy of their COVID-19 vaccination certificates & present the same at the time of check in. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Ujjain

MPT Ujjaini,

734255687

ujjaini@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Conference Hall

Wifi | Gym

Located near Near madhav club, MPT Ujjaini is the favourite location of corporates for holding their business meetings and conferences with 2 Conference halls. An adjoining ground with capacity of 1000 persons is perfect for marriages, yoga retreats or any event that requires huge sitting facilities.ISO 9001:2015 QMS CertifiedAll guests are advised to carry a copy of their COVID-19 vaccination certificates & present the same at the time of check in. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Wildlife Parks

Bandhavgarh
Kanha
Panna
Pench
Sanjay Dubri
Satpura

Wild Havens

If you are looking for tigers, Madhya Pradesh is where you should look.

MP holds 20% of India's tiger population, and India has about half of all the tigers in the world. Most of these magnificent big cats live in a network of 10862 sq kms of Protected Areas: 25 Wildlife Sanctuaries and 9 National Parks. That is approximately 15.5 sq kms of forest per tiger. Since visitors can not drive all over those fifteen and half square kilometres of jungle, but have to stay on the jungle paths, it would seem that the chances of spotting a tiger are about as bright as finding the proverbial needle in a haystack. To increase your odds of spotting a tiger you should concentrate on four specific National Parks. These are Bandhav- garh, Kanha, Panna and Pench. Apart from being National Parks these are also Tiger Reserves where this superb animal is especially protected and its habitat is nurtured.

Such forest management goes down to the grassroots level, literally. The growth of edible grasses is carefully fostered so that deer and other prey-species of the tiger thrive. Given enough prey species, a tiger spends only an hour or two, every day, hunting for its food. Like any other self-respecting feline, it would much rather devote its time to grooming itself or to sleeping!

In other words, the better a Tiger Sanctuary is managed the better your chances of spotting a tiger in the wild.

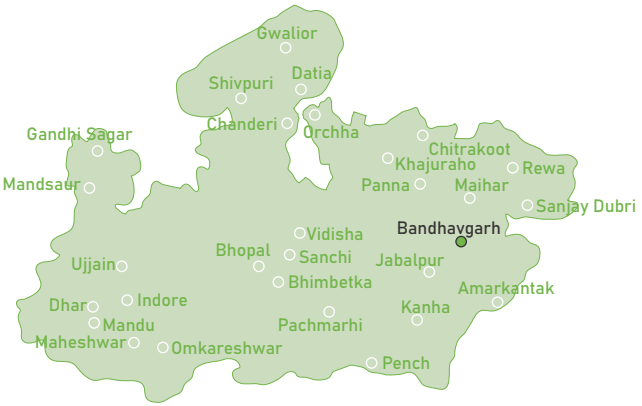
Remember

- Sanctuaries are generally closed from 1st July to 30th September
- Book your vehicle well in advance and make sure it is what you want: covered or open, seats one behind the other or along the sides.
- Ensure that your forest guide or driver gets the right tickets: for Indians or Foreigners, still or camcorders or professional movie cameras.
- The forest has its own micro-climate, generally colder and damper than outside: be suitably clad
- Be alert: tell the driver that you will grip his shoulder when you want him to stop rather than shout at him and chase away the animal!
- Carry spare batteries/film/memory-stick for your digital: you are likely to shoot much more than you usually do.
- If you decide to stand in your open-top vehicle, watch out for branches whipping past: you could get badly cut and scraped.
- Find out If your chosen Sanctuary has a Centre Point. Centre Points have Comfort Stations of a sort, coffee/mineral water/tea/colas/snacks, and a radio-linked information post in touch with elephant- mounted watchers to tell you if and where a tiger has been spotted.
- There is an extra charge to mount an elephant to get close to a tiger. Sometimes you have to climb a ladder held against the elephant to get up,alternatively you might be asked to use your vehicle as a mounting platform. It is amazing how the thought of seeing a tiger makes the most ungainly person become as agile as a Chinese gymnast.

Jungle of Bandhavgarh

Bandhavgarh

This is where the white tigers originated.



190 kms from Jabalpur, 120 kms from Satna. Area approximately: 1162 sq kms. This is the original home of all the white tigers alive today. (See Box- Tigers International) Bandhavgarh was the hunting preserve of the Maharajas of Rewa: their old fort still dominates a hill rising out of the forest. The ruined fort is not open to visitors, nowadays. The terrain is inter- estingly varied: hills, valleys, meadows, wetlands, five perennial streams and the Charanganga River. The vegetation is tropical moist deciduous consisting of saal, assorted jungle trees and grassland. Tigers often rest in the bamboo thickets that occur throughout the forested areas.

A reclining Vishnu and a jungle spring.

Tigers have the right of way

Do carry sandwiches with you when you set off on your morning round. Driving in the cool, fresh air of the jungle seems to burn calories and you don't want your hunger-growling stomach to be mistaken for a tiger in the bushes!

Though tigers have a territory of about 25 square kilometres, your guide with a little help from the Forest Guards, should be able to increase your chances of spotting one. If a tiger has made a kill the night before, it will generally rest in a bamboo clump near the remains of its dinner, dozing but alert to drive away unwelcome scavengers attracted by the scent of the carcase. If you don't give the impression of being an unwelcome guest, the Tiger will probably allow you to get close enough to get a good picture. But do not, ever, try to persuade your elephant driver, you mahawat, to get closer than he would like too. The Tigers of Bandhavgarh could carry the genes of the late charger. A ferocious charging tiger is the stuff of which nightmares are made.

Do not be tiger-fixated. Try to spot the other animals listed in Bandhavgarh: chital, barking deer, chausaingha, chinkara, nilgai, wolf, hyena, jackal, wild-boar, wild dog, jungle cat, fox, sloth bear, langur and rhesus monkeys, and leopards.

There are also 242 species of birds and the most commonly seen are peafowl, egrets, crow pheasant, red jungle fowl, common teal, red wattled lapwing, grey hornbill, kingfisher and the serpent eagle. The serpent eagle does not look like a snake, it eats them, and you might, if you are lucky, see this powerful feathered predator sitting on a branch with its meal dangling out of his mouth like a strand of thick spaghetti

While on the subjects of serpents, there is an interesting monolithic carving of a reclining Vishnu on the semi-divine serpent Shesha. A spring flows over his feet. Elsewhere, there are caves once used by hermits.

Herd of Deers

TIGERS INTERNATIONAL

The Royal Bengal tiger still prowls in Madhya Pradesh

Probably originating in Central and Northern Asia, tigers then seemed to have migrated southwards, avoiding Tibet and the northern slopes of the Himalayas, reaching Mongolia, Manchuria, and Korea, and in the south-west from the Russo-Afghan boundary to the north of the Hindu-Kush through the Elburz mountains, south of the Caspian, as far as the eastern portions of the Caucasus. From Manchuria tigers spread southwards as far as Bali. And in the sub-continent they roamed through Bhutan and Nepal, as far west as Gujarat and south to KanyaKumari. They arrived in the tip of India when the land-bridge to Sri Lanka had already been submerged. Tigers never reached Sri Lanka. The Hindu Kush and the desert areas of Iran and Bal- uchistan prevented the west-Asian tigers from migrating into north-western India or else there might have been two distinct sub- species in India. The tigers of the Caspian area had coats with a slightly richer colour than their Indian cousins and in winter the fringes on the sides of the face and along the belly were very long. The White Tigers are albinos of the Royal Bengal tigers: they are not a separate sub-species.

The Royal Bengal is found in India, Bangladesh, Bhutan and Nepal; the Amur or Siberian is a native of Russia, China and North Korea, the Amoy or South China is from South-Central China; the Sumatran lives in Sumatra, the Indo-Chinese prowls in the forests of Cambodia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Thailand and Vietnam. Three sub-species have, however, been wiped out: the Bali, Javan and Caspian tigers. Hope- fully, the Royal Bengal has been saved from this fate.

Accommodation in Bandhavgarh

MPT White Tiger Forest Lodge

7627265406
wtfl@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Bar | Parking
Transport | Conference Hall | Gym | Swimming Pool

Named after the fabled White Tigers, found Bandhavgarh in the mid-50s, the property is located very close to the Tala gate of Bandhavgarh forests. The natural splendour of the lodge exquisitely woven with the placid ambience and the lush green beauty of the landscape makes it an ideal place for residential conferences, meetings, team building programs and meditation camps. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property. For Jungle Safari Booking Visit: forest.mponline.gov.in

Accommodation in Bandhavgarh

MPT Sarsi Island Resort

8698751908
sarsi@mpstdc.in

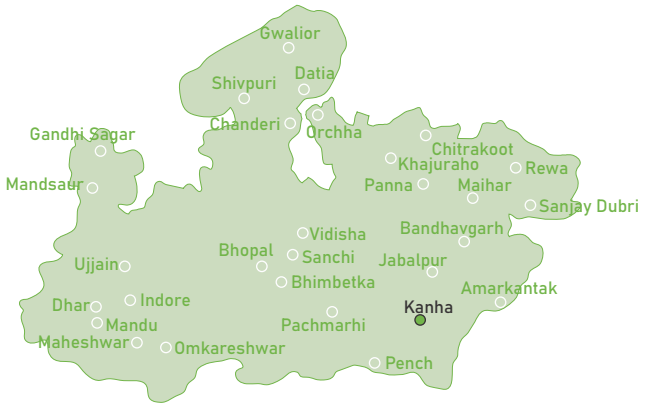
Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant

MPT Sarsi Island Resort is a serene getaway located on a picturesque island, offering a peaceful retreat surrounded by nature. Accessible only by boat, the resort provides a unique and tranquil experience away from the hustle and bustle. To reach the resort, guests must take a scenic boat ride, with the service available until 5:30 pm. We recommend planning your arrival accordingly to ensure a smooth transition to the island. With its stunning views and relaxing atmosphere, MPT Sarsi Island Resort is perfect for those looking to unwind in a secluded paradise.

Kanha

Kanha is a conservation success story.



There are two entrances: the Khatia entrance is 68 kms from Mandla and 165 kms from Jabalpur; the Mukki entrance is 82 kms from Balaghat. Area approximately: 2060 sq kms It was in this park that the Central Indian Barasingha, also known as the hardground barasingha, was brought back from the virtual edge of extinction.

The terrain consists of plateaus and flat-bottomed valleys that tend to become clayey and are locally known as kanhar: this could account for the park's name. The vegetation is the same as at Bandhavgarh: tropical moist deciduous consisting of saal, assorted trees and grasslands. It is watered by its two principal rivers, the Banjar and Halon.

Visitors on a forest round

Barasingha

Wolf in Jungle of Kanha

Spotting wild animals is always a matter of luck but Kanha is so rich in wildlife that the odds are tilted in your favour. First-time visitors, keen to spot the larger animals, often overlook the smaller ones. There is, in fact, a resident population of Monkeys in the wooded grounds of Kisli, the tourist complex in Kahna. Here, visitors live in log huts raised above ground level on short, stumpy, stilts. Don not be too disturbed if, at night, you see eyes shining out of the darkness surrounding your log hut. They probably belong to wild chital, spotted deer who visit the Kisli complex every evening. They sleep in the grove just beyond the log huts because they feel safe from predators in this human settlement! They leave for their breakfast grazing only when the morning sun begins to shaft through the jungle mist.

It would be best if you start your morning trip at 6 a.m. Kanha's famed maidans were once fields before the villages were moved out of the National Park. Here you are likely to see great herds of spotted deer with smaller herds of the beautiful antelope, blackbuck. You might also see the timorous Barking deer: its snapping yap! warns the other denizens of the forest that there is a predator around. There is also a very strong possibility that you will see the rare Barasingha: the swamp deer. Once there were only sixty-six of these in Kanha but careful conservation and management had raised the Barasingha population to over 400 when we last visited the Park. As for tigers: we have visited Kanha six times and have seen Tigers on five occasions.

The other animals recorded in Kanha are langur monkeys (See Box - Early Warning Systems) sambar, mouse deer, nilgai, chausingha, gaur wild dog, jungle cat, leopard cat and leopards. About three hundred species of birds have been sighted in the Park. The most commonly seen are peafowl, doves, babblers, tree-pies, mynahs, green pigeons, partridges, owls, woodpeckers, eagles and the bold and inquisitive tree-pies.

There are some impressive termite castles with their millions of dedicated workers devoted to their queen, tending their edible fungus farms, opening and closing the ventilation shafts, pouring out to repel any invasion, rushing up to repair any damage with a plaster of mud and saliva that sets as hard as concrete. There is also a most interesting museum with a particularly fascinating tiger gallery which also gives details of the many sub- species of tigers.

EARLY WARNING SYSTEMS

The creatures of the jungle have found co-operative ways to survive. Most animals are keenly aware of the alarm calls, and other danger signals of other species. One of the most alert denizens of the jungles according to India's late doyen of ornithologists, Dr. Salim Ali, is the red-wattled lapwing. This bird "Is uncannily and ceaselessly vigilant, day or night, and foremost to detect intrusion and raise the alarm: a loud, penetrating 'Did-he-do-it? or 'Pity-to- do-it?" repeatedly placidly or frantically as the occasion demands."

Deer, as the most popular prey species, have developed their own alarm calls from the distinctive bark of the barking deer to the foot-stamping cough of the frightened sambar. The delicate spotted deer seem to have developed a mutual benefit association with tribes of langur monkeys. Langurs are wasteful feeders, dropping many of the nuts and leaves from the trees on which they are dining. Herds of spotted deer take advantage of this bonanza by grazing below. They also use the langurs as spotters. When langurs, from their high perch, see an approaching predator they give their chuck! chuck! alarm call. This alerts the chital herd and they race away. They know in which direction the danger lies, because the whole tribe of langurs stop eating and look at the approaching big cat. The chitals run in the opposite direction! The sight of the white flash of their lifted tails gives a danger signal to other forest creatures.

Good forest guides recognise these Early Warning Signals and can generally assess how far away the predator is.

Sal forest of Kanha

Accommodation in Kanha

MPT Jungle Resort Sarhi

6265416431

sarhiresort@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Swimming Pool

Located near the Sarhi gate of Kanha National Park, MPT Jungle Resort offers the real experience of jungle from the comfort of your rooms. The architecture blends with the mood of the wild and those of the explorers who are here in pursuit of the pure and the rustic. A pure blend of modern amenities with contemporary comfort standards of the industry, MPT Jungle Resort of 'MPT Hotels & Resorts' offers 16 plush AC rooms, interpretation center, indoor games. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property. For Jungle Safari Booking Visit: forest.mponline.gov.in

Accommodation in Kanha

MPT Safari Lodge Mukki

9329908054

ksl@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Conference Hall

Swimming Pool

Rejuvenate yourself at the MPT Safari Lodge Mukki, located near the Mukki gate. It is surrounded by dense forests and rooms with spectacular views. This MPT resort in Kanha National Park is situated beside the Banjar river. Guests can also indulge in multifarious activities in & around the property, such as bird watching, nature trails, jungle safari, village tours, jungle canopy walk which surely makes your staycation here packed with fun, adventure and entertainment. The property also boasts of a swimming pool. Guests can now also experience the ISO 14001:2015 EMS CertifiedAll guests are advised to carry a copy of their COVID-19 vaccination certificates & present the same at the time of check in.For Jungle Safari Booking Visit: forest.mponline.gov.in NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Kanha

MPT Baghira Jungle Resort Mocha

7049838369

bjrmocha@mpstdc.com

Facilities

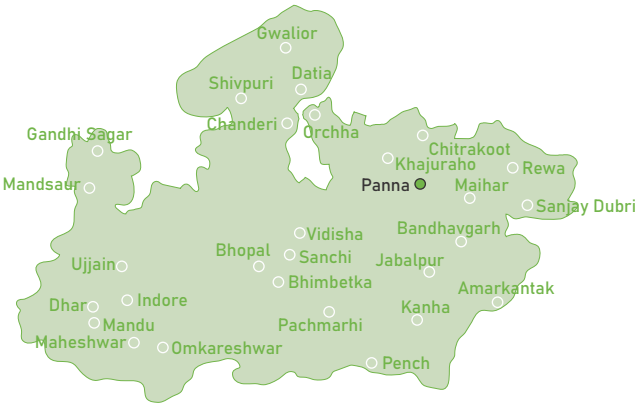
AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Swimming Pool
Panchkarma | Bar | Conference Hall

There could not be a better location for a jungle resort than MPT Baghira Jungle Resort, Mocha at the Khatia gate of Kanha National Park. Located on the banks of Banjar river, this property brings together serenity, stunning views and excellent hospitality. You may behold small animals around the river right from your hotel room, take walks down the river and even enjoy beach volleyball.ISO 14001:2015 EMS CertifiedAll guests are advised to carry a copy of their COVID-19 vaccination certificates & present the same at the time of check in.For Jungle Safari Booking Visit: forest.mponline.gov.in. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Jeep Safari in the Jungles of Panna

Panna

Not quiet a Jurassic Park but a gharial haven.



32 kms from Khajuraho. Area approximately 666 sq kms. In the Ken 3 River flowing through this Reserve there is a sanctuary for the long-snouted, fish-eating gharial-crocodiles. From a viewpoint, high above the river, visitors can see them like grey logs basking on the white sand-banks of the Ken. Closer encounters with these descendants of dinosaurs can be had in boats.

The topography of Panna consists of two plateaus, scattered hills and valleys including that of the Ken River. The flora, here, is southern tropical dry teak forests (See Box - Trees) and northern dry deciduous mixed forests.

A Leopard in the Jungle

As in many other National Parks, it is best to get out as early as possible ensuring that you are suitably dressed for the cold, damp micro-climate of a forest at dawn. Your camera lens could get fogged but, then again, when you look through your view-finder it need not be the lens that is a misted, it could be the forest. Early morning in a slightly damp forest can give some interesting soft-focus, back-lit shots.

The animals here seem to be particularly unperturbed by visitors peering at them from vehicles. Be on the lookout for unusual close-ups of furry ingals, and fat mongooses bustling along busily looking for snakes or other forest-floor creatures. And if the Peafowl are in an amorous mood, you might see a peacock performing in a forest glade. He struts, opens brown fans of feathers to rustle against his legs, spreads his extravagant tail and, with the sun glistening on his iridescent neck, turns very slowly like a well-oiled body-builder under a spotlight. Somewhere at the edge of the glade there will be one or two dowdy hens seemingly unconcerned about the beach-boy posturing of their male!

Do, also, take a boat-ride on the Ken river to have a close encounter with the gharials. These crocodiles look like refugees from Jurassic Park but they are quite harmless because you are not their preferred fast food. Their elongated jaws are designed to snap up fish, not bulky humans.

The chances of seeing a tiger here are good because much of the forest is fairly open.

The other animals inhabiting this Reserve are nilgai, chital chinkara, sloth bear, chausingha, wild-boar, jackal, hyena, rhesus and langur monkeys; and leopards.

There are about 200 species of birds, the common ones being egrets, paradise fly-catcher, adjutant stork, crested serpent eagle, quail, kingfishers, doves, parakeets, and vultures. These wide-winged scavengers nest in the cliffs of a hairpin-shaped gorge, coasting in and out, with silent grace, on the invisible columns of rising air called thermals.

The Ken River

TREES

The tree most likely to catch the eye of the visitor to the Tiger Reserves is a giant of the verbena family. It is a hardwood and one of the most valuable timbers in the world. It is teak (Tectona grandis). It has a straight stem, often thickened at the base. It is broad, raspy laves rustle in the wind and carpet the forest floor in a thick pile during the dry season when the tree is leafless. It is an extremely versatile wood for fine furniture, sturdy floors and beams that have stood for more than 1,000 years: the wood is virtually imperishable under cover. The legendary ship of Sinbad the sailor was made of Indian teak and so were the ships of the British East India Company constructed by the famed Wadia Ship-builders of the west coast of India.

Sal - pronounced 'saal' is - second only to teak in its value as a timber, and its durability. It justifies its Latin name, Shorea robusta, it is extremely robust: virtually all the rail-tracks in India's railway systems were laid on sal sleepers. It is a very gregarious tree and likes the company of its own species. A sal forest looks particularly inviting because of its broad, shining leaves and the fact that the trees are never absolutely leafless. In April it produces small fragrant cream-coloured flowers, in June it releases its winged fruit that spin away on their propeller wings. A gum from its stem is waterproof and is used for caulking boats and on roofs. Sal butter, extracted from its seeds, goes into making chocolates.

No visitor to the jungle can help notic- ing the Karaya (Sterculia urens). Forest guides call it the Ghost Tree and claim that it has a spectral glow in the dark. It does not really. But since it has a smooth white bark and its branches look a bit like the naked limbs of a ballet dancer it could have an eerie appearance on a moonlit night in a dark, still jungle. Its bark is shed in large, pale brown, papery plates. Its flowers are yellow, its fruit are red and thrust up in erect bunches till they are ready to burst open. The white gum of the Ghost Tree is used in ice-creams and cosmetics.

Then there is the world's tallest grass: the Bamboo. Most go under the generic name of Bambusa but since there are more than 1000 kinds of Bamboos in the world, some of them have been given other names. There are more than 100 kinds of bamboos in India ranging from bamboo shrubs to giants over 37 m. tall. The Tender shoots are very delicate and juicy but they contain the poisonous hydrocyanic acid. The poison is destroyed after boiling or else Chinese restaurants would be as hazardous as the Japanese ones that specialise in the lethal puffer fish.! Bamboos have a built-in cellu- lar alarm clock in their systems. When the clock decides that they should all die, they flower, and then all of them die together even though they may be 1,000 kms apart. It is a sort of communal euthanasia.

Sambar in the Jungle of Panna

Accommodation in Panna

MPT Jungles Camp Madla

7880108592

jcmadla@mpstdc.com

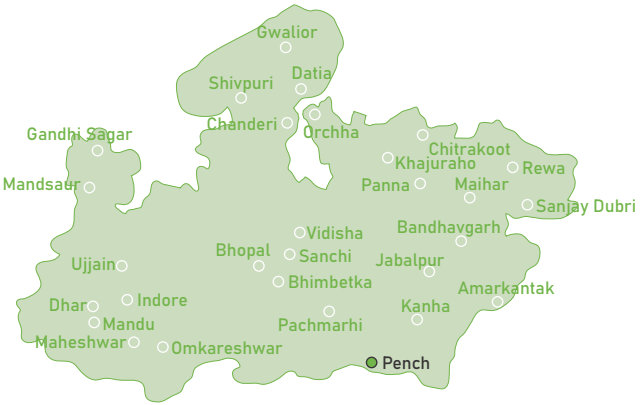
Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Swimming Pool

*MPT Jungle Camp, Panna is one of the exotic jungle stays of MPT Hotels & Resorts, being at very close proximity to the forest, located near Madla gate of the Panna National Park. You may see a grazing deer or a peacock right from your room's window, towards the back side of this hotel.ISO 14001:2015 ***EMS Certified. For Jungle Safari Booking Visit: forest.mponline.gov.in. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.*

Pench

Here, for the very first time in decades of travel in the Jungles, we saw a family of tigers together.



201 kms from Jabalpur and 93 kms from Nagpur. Area approximately: 758 sq kms. This is Mowgli country (See Box-Rudyard Kipling): a fairly rugged, undulating landscape of hill ranges, valleys and plains. It is watered by the Pench River and other seasonal streams. There are, however, a few perennial springs and the great Pench Reservoir to spread their greening influence when the streams dry up.

Its vegetation is southern tropical, slightly moist teak forests, and dry mixed deciduous forests.

Accommodation in Pench

MPT Kiplings Court

7695232830

kcpench@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Swimming Pool

Conference Hall | Bar

Situated 1 km away from the Turia gate of Pench National, MPT Kiplings Court hosts you in the lap of nature. If you are lucky enough, you may see wildlife right from the premises of this hotel. Come and stay here before you have the actual have encounter with the wild since its location makes it more convenient if you are going for the jungle safari. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. All guests are advised to carry a copy of their COVID-19 vaccination certificates & present the same at the time of check in. For jungle safari booking, visit: forest.mponline.gov.in NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

The forests of Pench have passed into folklore all across the world. Here, according to those who should know, a naked child was found walking on all-fours in the forest, back in the 19th century. From the way he behaved, people believed that he had crawled away from his village at the forest's edge and been brought up by wolves. He died after a short while but he did inspire Rudyard Kipling to write The Jungle Book about the life and times of a fictional wolf boy named Mowgli. It became a perennial best-seller and inspired the Disney animated film, Mowgli.

Those who have read The Jungle Book will discover that Pench is a familiar terrain. There are villages with hayricks at the edge of the jungle; outcrops of rounded boulders on which Akela, the leader presided over gatherings of the wolf pack; the mischievous gambolling of the Rhesus Monkeys, the Bander Log - to rhyme with 'vogue'- and the high-flying

Cheel the Kite, (who) brings home the night, That Mang the Bat sets free.

In the book, the tiger Sher Khan leads a solitary, bachelor existence. But with just a little bit of luck you might see a family of tigers purring and grooming each other like a passel of purring pussy-cats!

And since cats - even the big cats - purr only when they are contented, you are likely to see many of their prey species. Chital, our beautiful spotted deer are very common and their males sport an impressive spread of antlers during the rutting season. Then you might sight, unusually close to the road, herds of our heavily built Gaur, the Indian bison. Here, in Pench, they seem to have learnt how to push down fairly large saplings so that their calves, wearing fawn jackets, can dine on the leaves. This behaviour is generally associated with elephants SO they could have picked up a few tips from the domesticated elephants that graze in the Park at night.

The other animals here are sambar, gaur, wild-boar, chausingha, nilgai

RUDYARD KIPLING

Today more people have seen Walt Disney's animated film The Jungle Book than those who have read it in print. They have thereby missed out on a great wildlife allegory and allowed themselves to be entertained by its trivialization.

Nobel Laureate Kipling was born in India in 1865; went to school in England; then returned to India where he worked as a journalist. While he was here, filing his reports and writing about the ordinary people he met, he learnt about a boy who had been found, crawling on all fours, in the jungles of Central India. The child would eat only raw meat and make wolf- like noises. People believed that an infant had crawled away from a village and been brought up by a nursing wolf along with her cubs.

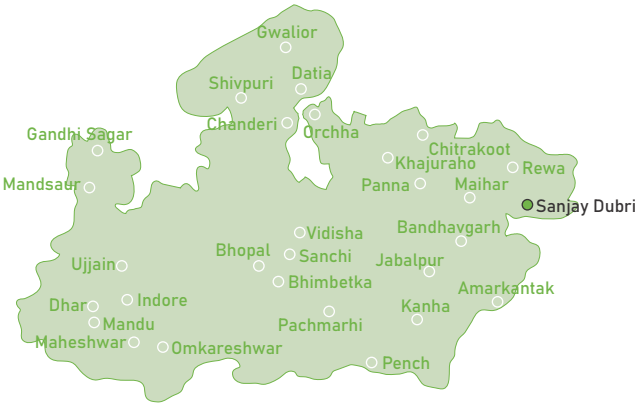
Using this sketchy background, Kipling created the story of Mowgli the Wolf Boy. His fictionalized Jungle Books followed the life of this child as he learnt to respect Ahela, the leader of his pach;, was instructed in the Laws of the Jungle by the wise bear Bhaloo; absorbed the old wisdom of Kaa, the python, was protected by the black leopard Bagheera; shied away from the frivolities of the Langur tribe, the Ban- dar Log, a nd responded to the restlessness of adolescence in The Spring Running. The Jungle Books were about the wonders of the Indian jungle, the dilemmas of growing up and the need to develop a strong moral fibre. Lord Baden Powell used these tales as the foundation for the honour-and-duty mystique of his world-wide Scouts and Cubs youth movement.

barking deer, jungle cat, leopard cat, wild dog, sloth bears and leopards. There are 260 bird species including cormorants, herons, egrets, black necked storks, lesser whistling teal, brahminy duck, crested serpent eagle, red jungle fowl, and kingfishers.

There is an enthralling forest museum in Pench. It gives fascinating, and graphically illustrated information about the National Park, its vegetation and wildlife. Visitors should see it before their first round of the park; and then again, after experiencing the forest to know more about what they have seen.

Sanjay Dubri

Where the White Tiger's Legacy Lives



Sanjay-Dubri National Park and Tiger Reserve was established in 1975 to conserve the biodiversity rich forest area of the district. There are plenty of reasons that make the Sanjay National Park one of the most beautiful wildlife-spotting destinations in central India. Its diversity of flora and fauna is adored by nature and biota enthusiasts. The green region features sharp cliffs, water bodies, valleys, hills, and deep canyons. The Guru Ghasidas National Park, which is situated in Chhattisgarh, shares its jungle with Sanjay National Park.

Furthermore, the park comprises various rivers and ponds that provide the birds and animals with water. You can get the best view of the park in the park itself, near the Banas River. The untapped wildlife heaven of Sanjay National Park and Dubri Wildlife Sanctuary falls in the Sidhi district of Madhya Pradesh. Together, they cover 831 km2. Sanjay Dubri Tiger Reserve, which is known for its rare and exquisite species of flora and fauna, is covered with sal forest and is home to 34 species of freshwater fish, 152 species of birds, 32 species of mammals, 11 species of reptiles, and 3 species of amphibians. Also, the forest is popular for its rich biodiversity, which makes it one of the perfect habitats for animals like the tiger, sloth bear, Chital, Nilgai, Chinkara, Barking Deer, leopard, Porcupine, Jackal, Fox, Jungle Cat, Hyena, Indian Wolf, Indian Python, Four-horned Antelope, Dhole (a wild dog), and Sambar (restricted to steep terrain and in very small numbers) that have been discovered.

Wildlife can be best explored while experiencing a safari. The Sanjay Dubri Tiger Reserve is best visited between October 1 and June 30. Safari is closed during the monsoon amid the rain disturbance.

It is recommended that you keep your zoom lenses in your bag when packing for a Jeep Safari in Sanjay Dubri National Park. Obviously, you would not want to miss the chance to capture some jaw-dropping shots. Who knows, your luck could lead you to see a yawning tiger or a playing bear?

PARSILI

Parsili is an idyllic place in Sidhi district and offers more than eye can see. Situated on the bank of river Banas, this unspoilt destination is 10 km away from Sanjay-Dubri National Park where your passion for wildlife can be coupled with a leisurely break. Parsili is an exotic paradise for the bird lovers. Birds like

MOHAN : THE WHITE TIGER

Mohan, the famous white tiger, had been captured in what is now the Bastua range of the Dubri Wildlife Sanctuary on May 26, 1951. Mohan was found hiding in a cave near the Pankhora nullah. For almost two decades, Mohan remained in captivity, siring virtually all the current world population of white tigers.

Herons, Egrets, White-Necked Stork, White Ibis, Whistling teal, Kites, Eagles, Harrier, King fishers, Oriole are part of the rich avifauna.
Be ready with your binoculars to catch the glimpse of an elusive bird as several varieties of migratory birds come here.

What to do

'Earthing' or walking barefoot on soil, earth or grass is an ultimate way of feeling the caressing touch of mother Earth.
A unique Bare-Foot 4 km trek on the soft and moist sand bed of the river Banas, is an out of the world experience. Trekking bare foot on a gentle turf of fine wet sand gradually turns into wading in a broad water stream with a depth of 6 to 12 inches, offering binding intimacy with Nature.
It is a de-stressing, refreshing, exciting walk surrounded by chirping birds and fresh breeze. The pure oxygen rejuvenates your body and the acupressure on the soles of your feet by the fine sand energizes you overall. You will find yourself connected to the panch tatvas- the five elements of nature(Earth, Water, Air, Space and Fire).

The Barefoot Trek : The Walk starts at morning 0600hrs, in a magnificent green surroundings in the mellow rays of the rising sun and is led by a naturalist. A small backpack containing water bottle, fruits and sandwiches is provided by the Parsili Resort, for an en-route breakfast at your diligent pace, learning the surrounding flora and avifauna.
The entire topography is set with sand dunes, lush and green vegetation, spectacular sun shine defused through hillocks, clouds and trees, making you reach for your camera repeatedly. The 4 km trek takes 2 to 3 hours ending at rustic Kathbungalow- an old wooden haveli with sprawling garden and mango trees bordering the river. After spending some time at this charming place you may either trek back or take a vehicle to the resort.
What to wear : Tourists may don a comfortable bottom/pant to easily wade in water. Must bring cap, binoculars.

Barefoot Trekking on Banas River

The Banas River, Parsili

Accommodation in Sanjay Dubri

MPT Parsili Resort

7694860497

parsuli@mpstdc.com

Facilities

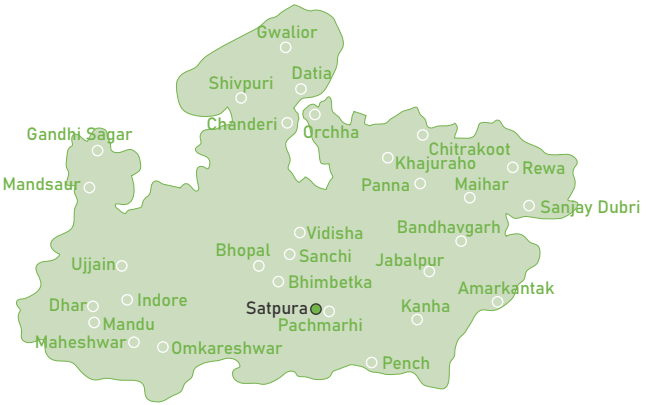
AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Wifi

Located at a stone's throw near the Banas River at Parsili, MPT Parsili Resort of MPT Hotels & Resorts will surely take your breath away. The white sand at the riverside offers a different experience. Lush greenery around is the home to a rich variety of avifauna. The resort also offers an activity called the Barefoot Walk which is a walk in the river at knee deep water. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Satpura

SANJAY DUBRI

Where the White Tiger's Legacy Lives



Awarded as the most visitor-friendly wildlife destination by TOFT (Travel Operators for Tigers), Satpura National Park is nurtured and cradled within the Satpura range of the Narmadapuram district in Madhya Pradesh. It unfolds its beauty in a tapestry of serene jungles, captivating hilly terrains, deep gorges, and meandering sharp streams.

The profound stillness of the park allows the clear transmission of natural sounds, from the gentle snoring of bears to the resonant roars of tigers.

With a rich and diverse biodiversity, the park serves as a residence for various

Satpura National Park has been added in the tentative list of World Heritage Site by UNESCO

SANJAY DUBRI

Squirrel, a rare species found in the jungle of Satpura

creatures, including Leopard, Sambar, Chital, Four-horned antelope, Chinkara, Wild boar, Bear, Blackbuck, Fox, Porcupine, Flying squirrel, Mouse deer, and more. Noteworthy among the residents is the Indian giant squirrel, affectionately known as "Nanhi" by the locals.

Elevating your safari experience in the park is the enchanting array of bird species, featuring water birds, hornbills, peacocks and more.

Beyond jungle safaris, indulge in a unique adventure by enjoying tree camping in the buffer zones. This extraordinary experience allows you to immerse yourself in the tranquillity of the forest canopy, offering a perspective of nature that goes beyond the conventional. You can also explore the surrounding treasures with attractions like Pachmarhi (approx 82 km), Panaarpani gate (72.8 km), and Churna (approx 150 km), making Satpura National Park a central point for a holistic wildlife and nature getaway.

Tree Camping in the Jungle of Satpura

SANJAY DUBRI

A WALKING SAFARI IN THE WILD

The adventure at Satpura National Park begins with a boat ride across the Denwa River, a tranquil experience that sets the tone for what lies ahead. The water glistens in the afternoon sun, and within minutes, we spot a crocodile resting on a small island. A quick swish of its tail sends it retreating into the water, a reminder of the thriving wildlife here. Nearby, a herd of sambar deer grazes peacefully along the riverbank, adding to the charm of this serene setting.

Stepping into the jungle, the scorching 3 p.m. sun is barely noticeable under the dense canopy. The towering trees, including Sal, Teak, Tendu, Mahua, and Bamboo, filter the sunlight into golden beams that pierce through the foliage, creating a mesmerizing play of light and shadow. This natural shade instantly dispels any skepticism about the timing of the walk.

Satpura is unique among India's national parks, allowing visitors to explore its core area on foot. Guided by two forest experts, Kanhaiya and Rameshwar, we tread carefully in single file, minimizing noise. Along the way, they share fascinating insights about the ecosystem, pointing out the "crocodile tree," whose bark resembles the scales of its namesake. The forest floor reveals fresh signs of wildlife—bear droppings, tiger pug marks, and clawed tree trunks, all silent witnesses to the jungle's dynamic life.

As we venture further, the jungle comes alive with sound. The rustling of leaves underfoot provides a soothing rhythm, while birdcalls echo through the trees. Vibrant species like the Oriole and Kingfisher flit about, adding bursts of color to the green expanse. While larger animals remain elusive, fleeting glimpses of an Indian gaur and langurs swinging through the treetops add to the thrill.

The walk is not just about spotting wildlife; it's an immersive journey into nature's untouched beauty. The stories etched on the forest floor, the interplay of light, and the meditative silence combine to create an unforgettable experience. Satpura's core area, spanning 1,500 square kilometers, is a testament to its rich biodiversity and careful conservation.

Recognized as a key attraction under Narmadapuram's "One District One Product" initiative, Satpura National Park is more than a wildlife destination. It offers visitors a chance to connect deeply with nature, where every sound, sight, and step brings a sense of wonder. The journey here isn't just a walk in the forest—it's an exploration of a world where nature reigns supreme.

Boat Safari in the Jungle of Satpura

UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITE

SANJAY DUBRI

SATPURA TIGER RESERVE
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

MPT Bison Resort, Madhai

9425011294

madhai@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

MPT Bison Resort situated essentially at the forest entry point of the Satpura National Park puts you in touch with nature at its pristine best. Nestled in the back waters of Tawa Reservoir, this beautiful waterfront property is popular for its fine cottages, peerless hospitality and breathtaking ambience. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. For Jungle Safari Booking Visit: forest.mponline.gov.in. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

MPT Tawa Resort, Tawa

7572273017

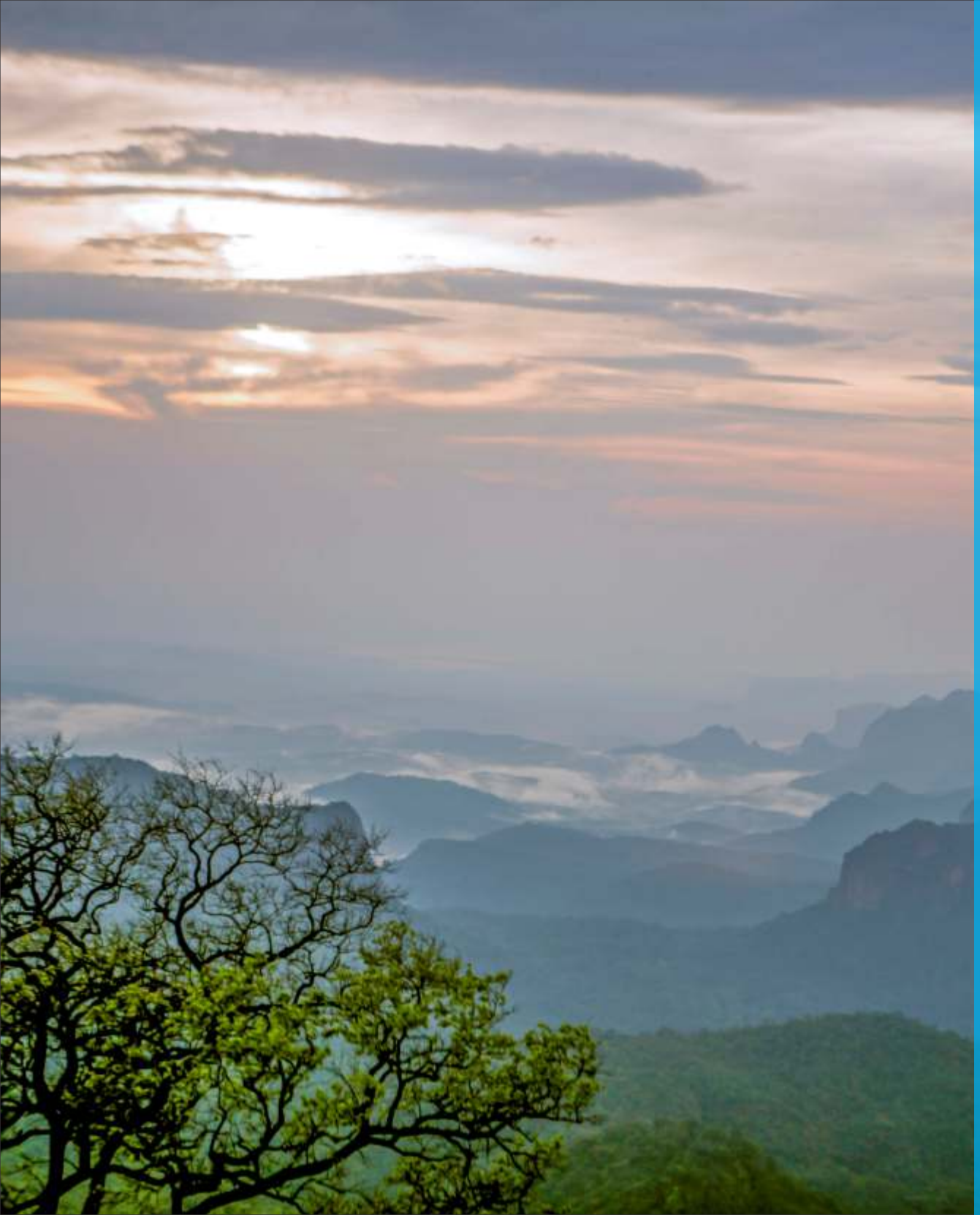
tawaresort@mp.gov.in

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Conference Hall

Swimming Pool

MPT Tawa Resort is adjoining the Tawa reservoir. The rooms in this resort are designed to capture full view of the dam. The sprawling lay out of the property offers enough space for the kids to play around. The quality food, unmatched guest service and hospitable ambience make it the best hotel its precincts. The closest airport to this property is Raja Bhoj Airport (135 km). What people love the most about this property is its great location and hospitality. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.



Leisure Destinatios

Bhopal
Jabalpur
Pachmarhi
Shivpuri

DISCOVERING MADHYA PRADESH

Leisure

Over the years we Indians have had a chameleon-like attitude towards leisure.

In the grim, grey, post-Independence years of our dalliance with hard-edged socialism, we often bandied around the phrase Aram Haram Hai: Leisure is Forbidden. Today, happily, as the pulses of globalization throb through our changing lives, we have learnt to use leisure as a very effective antidote to the 21st century ailment of Electronic Stress: the penalty of being hooked on to cell-phones, computers, Internet and jet travel that strain our diurnal cycles.

If you do not unwind when you should then your systems will shut down when you least expect it.

Happily, Madhya Pradesh offers a number of Leisure choices that you do not have to be a fitness freak to enjoy.

Bhopal, the capital, encircles two enormous lakes. You can opt for a slow, sunset cruise with the distant sounds of the muezzin calling the faithful to prayer. And in the day you could amble down the narrow lanes of the old bazaar and bargain-shop to your heart's content. Then there's that fascinating open zoo in the heart of town, great for wildlife viewing in perfect safety, including a possible audience with the regal white tigress, queen of the Van Vihar!

Women once, also, dominated the city of Jabalpur: a beautiful tribal warrior queen and a pantheon of Mother goddesses arrayed in their own circular temple. Once this shrine was a centre of Tantric rites that elevated sensuality to an extreme, metaphysical, level. Today, however, it is a monument free of the rituals of a living temple. Then there is the fascinating leisure activity of a row-boat journey through the Marble Rocks: a gorge cut into cliffs of glistening marble by the powerful Narmada River after it thunders down a cliff.

Or you could take a short drive to the lake resort of Bargi. Choose between water-sports and a long cool cruise down the Narmada.

Also pleasantly cool is the unwinding experience of the mountain resort of Pachmarhi. This temperate hill-station seems to have been frozen in the Edwardian Age when the British turned this into a summer escape from the heat of the plains. The Indian Army, proud inheritors of many of the traditions of their regimental forebears, has ensured that galloping modernity has not blighted this beautiful little town with its glens, woods, streams and waterfalls. In all likelihood you'll live in a British-era cottage with the original furniture carefully restored.

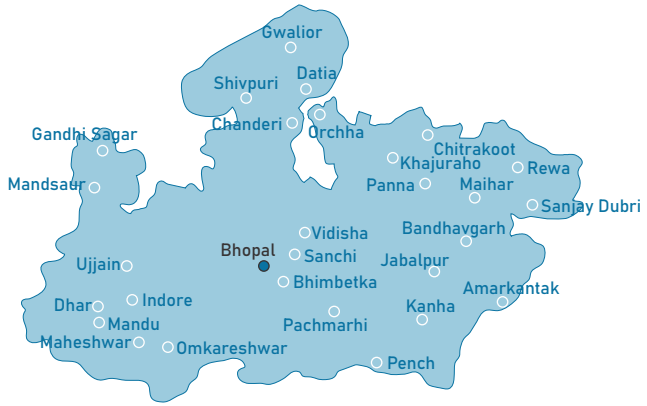
Shivpuri is a brief getaway from Gwalior and gives an elegant glimpse into the traditions of the erstwhile ruling family of this area. It is, essentially, a visit to the princely cenotaphs offering an evening recital of traditional religious music and a visit to a deer-haunted forest where there is a curious castle built for the anticipated visit of British royalty, who did not come!

Clearly, the leisure activities of Madhya Pradesh are what they should be: leisurely. That is it what makes them a gently recharging experience serenely free of stress.

Raja Bhoj Statue on Upper Lake

Bhopal

Bhopal is defined by its lakes, its spaces and its sense of serene authority.



No one is quite certain about the origin of the state capital's name. In all likelihood it was derived from 'Bhoja-Tal' or Bhoja's lake. Bhoja was an 11th century king of the Parmar dynasty who was a scholar, aesthete, great ruler and - though the term had not been invented in his time - an environmental engineer. He has been credited with creating two major water bodies, one of them outside Bhopal, which enriched the land and had a major and very benign effect on the climate.

The serene upper lake of Bhopal at sunset

RAJA BHOJA

Statue of Raja Bhoj with Sunset

As the most revered of the Parmar rulers, Raja Bhoja has become a legend and so it is difficult to sift myth from reality. Both, however, are equally fascinating.

About AD 1,000, King Bhoja Parmar suffered from an incurable disease. It was, judging from the cure prescribed, a disfiguring skin ailment. A seer advised him to create a lake fed by 365 streams and bathe in its waters every day. His scouts discovered a place, 32 kms away from Bhopal, where 359 springs flowed down from a circle of hills broken by two small gorges. A Gond named Kaliya showed them a small stream, Jed by another 6 springs, flowing down into the valley. Bhoja's engineers built dams which effectively impounded the waters of the 365 springs and created the largest lake of 11th century India. Presumably Bhoja was cured of his affliction because he reigned for fifty-five years and built up a reputation as a warrior, administrator and a man of con- siderable learning.

He compiled an authoritative work of eighty-three chapters on architecture and sculpture though only one temple is attributed to him: the great, unfinished shrine at Bhojpur. His court was enriched by poets and scholars and they helped him in com- posing works on poetry, writing and gram- mar. He once gave an award of a hundred thousand coins for one word "Alas!" - in a poem on fate, declaring that the whole poem was worth more than the value of the whole world!

Such extravagance was expected of monarchs in those days when their less-for- tunate subjects got a vicarious delight from the prodigality of their rulers.

After the Parmars, the rulers of the land changed frequently and, by the 18th century, the martial Gond tribes controlled Bhopal from the hill-fort of Ginnurgarh. The last of the Gond rulers, the beautiful queen Rani Kamlawati, also had a palace on the eastern scarp of what is now known as Kamla Park.

There is a legend that, on moonlit nights, she often cruised on the lakes of Bhopal in a royal barge, shaped like a lotus, much like the legendary Cleopatra of Egypt. She was also as astute as that Pharaonic ruler. When her husband was murdered by an ambitious relative, the queen asked the Afghan adventurer and warrior, Dost Mohammed Khan, to help her. He did so but, when the Rani died, he seized her fortress and, later, took possession of Bhopal.

He is credited with laying the foundations of present day Bhopal, erecting its protective wall and setting up the dynasty of the Nawabs. For over two years, the descendants of Dost Mohammed Khan (including the 107 year reign of 5 Begums) ruled Bhopal; and they left their lasting imprint on the town. Today, when the old city is seen from across the lake, it conjures up an impression

To the right of the pink Moti Mahal is the white Shaukat Mahal: a blend of French and Islamic architecture

of Turkey's Istanbul: pinnacles soar, domes rise in bulbous silhouette, defensive walls stretch in mirrored reflections in the still water. And when dawn and dusk settle softly on the city of the Nawabs, it is even more magical.

Visitors should start their discovery of the old city from the Chowk.

THE CHOWK

The life of the 200 year old city swirls around this central heart. Buildings with Islamic arches, turrets and balconies surround it. If the scooters, cars, delivery vans and cycles vanish, it is easy to imagine plodding camels galumphing, caparisoned lancers clip-clopping with rigid arrogance, and a curtained palanquin or two protected by liveried guards with drawn swords announcing the passage of nobility, warning mere mortals to give way.

The Chowk Market

Facing the paved square, where aspiring cricketers swing their bats and run, is a pink building with a spreading, palatial, look. This is the Moti Mahal.

MOTI MAHAL

A descriptive board outside the building says

This was built by Sikandar Jehan Begum in 1847. It is a two-storeyed build- ing with a three storeyed gate with projected windows on two upper storeys. In the middle of the upper wall crown-like structures have been built stretching from one end to the other. One portion of the palace was used for residential purposes while the other portions were the Durbar Hall, auditorium, administrative block, store and archives.

The projected, or oriel, windows are a common architectural feature and one of their functions was to capture even the slightest breeze.

At right angles to the Moti Mahal is a curiously eclectic white building. It almost looks as if the designers were eager to club a number of architectural styles together without making an effort to blend them harmoniously. This structure is known as the Shauqat Mahal.

SHAUQAT MAHAL

In the Arabic-influenced languages, there is a letter, quaf, pronounced like a guttural 'k' and it, therefore, is not followed by the 'u' that invariably comes after 'q' in English.

According to the descriptive board

This was built by Qudesia Begum in 1830. It was designed by a French architect in a fusion style of architecture. Jahangir Mohammad Khan and Sikander Begum lived here in the initial days of their rule. Shah Jehan Begum and her husband Umrao Dulha also lived here. The main portion of the palace is influenced by Islamic and European architecture. On the top portion of the gate (under which the road passes) there is a crown-like structure which is the royal emblem.

There is a local belief that the French architect was a descendant of the Bourbon royal house of France. In fact there is still a Bourbon family in Bhopal, descendants of the erstwhile kings of France, though they are Indian in every way but their surname.

Keeping the Shauqat Mahal behind you, head straight with the Moti Mahal on the right. The road ahead will lead you to the lake. Turning right here, on the road that hugs the banks of the lake, the impressive building on one side is the Gauhar Mahal.

GAUHAR MAHAL

Visitors can enter this building and it is interesting from both an architectural and a shopping point of view. To the left of the forecourt as one enters, shallow steps lead to a central quadrangle with a scalloped arch above a platform right in front. There is also a balcony just below the arch. There is strong reason to believe that this was the hall of public audience, or Diwan-i-Aam, from where the rulers appeared before their subjects. The British royal family follows this practice from a balcony in Buckingham Palace today.

To the left of this court, a passage leads to another court which was, in all likelihood, the hall of private audience, the Diwan-i-Khas.

Very pragmatically, both courts are now being used as a handicrafts market and serve as a relaxing shoppers stop after their trudge around the monuments.

There is a rather detailed descriptive board erected at the entrance of Gauhar Mahal which visitors, interested in history and architecture, would like

Gauhar Mahal: the first major palace of the Nawabs in Bhopal

to read. It says,

Gauhar Mahal is the earlierst major palace of the Nawabs of Bhopal in the city.

(Their first palace was in Islamnagar) It is presumed that construction probably began during the reign of Nawab Nazar Mohammed Khan (1816-19) or even earlier. The name is derived from Gauhar Begum. According to the 'Hayat-e-Sikandar', their daughter Sikandar Jehan Begum, was born in one of the upper storey rooms.

The palace is fairly large and includes the Nazar Mahal, Bibi-ka-Masjid, Gauhar Masjid, Qudsia Bagh, Siwan-i-Aam and the rectangular courts of the Diwan-i- Khas and the residential complex. Also the triangular court for the residence of the attendants. The architecture is an amalgam of Rajput, Mughal and local styles.

The manifold arched supports on double pillars around the Diwan-i-Khas and the floral decorations of the gate show a Mughal influence. The design of the brackets and pendants on the upper storeys of the residential complex as well as around the courtyard show a blend of Mughal and Rajput styles..

There are shades of the Gujarati, Rajasthani and Malwa styles in the beautiful decorations on the gateway leading to another courtyard (no longer in existence.)

Apart from stone and wood, lakhori bricks, lime and sukhi (brick grit) have been used in the construction (of this building).

After palaces like the Shaukat Mahal and Hawa Mahal came into existence, Gauhar Mahal was converted into offices of the state.

Though the Gauhar Mahal was the first palace to be built by the Nawabs in Bhopal, it does not dominate the old town. Pride of place must go to the Taj-ul-Masajid.

TAJ-UL-MASAJID

Literally 'The Crown of Mosques', this is said to be the largest Islamic place of worship in India, a claim also made by the Jama Masjid in Old Delhi. Nawab Shah Jehan Begum started building this mosque in 1887 and it was still under construction when she died in 1901. After a lapse of seventy years, funds were again amassed to continue with the construction of this magnificent

building.

The covered area of the mosque is over 80 m by 30 m and its minarets soar to over 67 m. The open court in the mosque is about 107 x 107 m in area. Muslims are required to wash their hands, face and feet before they pray; here, there is a tank in the open court for these obligatory ablutions. In keeping with the traditions of Islamic architecture, the interior of the prayer hall is cool and austere: representations of humans and animals are forbidden which is one reason why calligraphy has been developed to such a fine art in Muslim countries. There are examples of this elaborate lettering on the western side of the mihrab or prayer-alcoves indicating the direction of the holy city of Mecca. Muslims face Mecca when they pray. The northern and southern doors are fine examples of the lace-like jali-cut-work. Not usually noticed by visitors is its library of about 20,000 books and a school with accommodation for about 125 resident pupils.

Not far from the Taj-ul-Masajid, around a tank with the reflections of the minarets of the mosque, is another impressive structure in Islamic architecture. It is the Taj Mahal.

The Taj-ul-Masajid from inside

TAJ MAHAL

It is not anything like its famous namesake in Agra but it is beautiful in a rather bulky way. On both sides of the scalloped arch of its high gate, domed balconies thrust out. Beyond them, slim-pillared arches spread. A row of corbels stretch below the arched windows of the next floor. The floors above these seem to have been made as an after thought by builders in a hurry to construct additional rooms!

A descriptive board outside the monument says

Built by Shah Jehan Begum it was started in 1871 and completed in 1884. The attractive entrance gate of six storeys allowed both cars and carts easy entrance. There are 120 rooms and 8 huge halls. All the rooms were decorated with different colours and matching furniture. The Sheesh Mahal was decorated with coloured glass. There was a Sawan Bhado porch, arches and decorated pillars are an amalgam of Rajput and Islamic styles.

The gate accesses an open court with the upper floors of the building rising all around. It is still under restoration after years of being shuttered and neglected. When, however, the work has been completed it should be among the more significant monuments of Bhopal and a fitting tribute to the artistic sensitivities of the old Nawabs.

In the old city, too, and not far from the Chowk is the Moti Masjid.

The dramatic facade of Bhopal's Taj Mahal

MOTI MASJID

It is accessed by a flight of external steps from the road. Atop the stairs, visitors have to take off their footwear before stepping into a large courtyard. It has the obligatory pool in the centre, an arched and pillared corridor on three sides, and the beautiful white- moti' means 'pearl' - mosque in front. On a still day the reflections of the mosque in the pool are exquisite.

Architecturally, the mosque hews to that of Old Delhi's Jama Masjid. The Moti Masjid was built by Nawab Sikandar Jehan Begum, daughter of Nawab Qudsia Begum, in 1860. Delhi's Jama Masjid was completed in 1656, so this could have been patterned on the older mosque.

The causeway rising above the banks of the lakes of Bhopal will now lead the traveller to the new city of Bhopal and the Laxminarayan Temple.

The beautiful Moti Masjid or Pearl Mosque

LAXMINARAYAN TEMPLE

This modern temple, built in the traditional style with bright touches in cream and red, is also known as the Birla Temple after the well-known family of industrialists who built it. In its well-maintained gardens, just before the entrance to the temple, is a Siva shrine to the left, and one to Hanuman on the right.

Just after the entrance is a huge hall, supported by square pillars, with its walls decorated with religious murals. Narayan is another name of Vishnu and Laxmi is his consort.

Next door to the temple is the Birla Museum.

The impressive Laxminarayan Temple

BIRLA MUSEUM

There are some interesting old sculptures displayed in the garden. The entrance to the museum opens into a large, circular, hall. To the left is the Siva

gallery. Of particular interest are two 10th century sculptures from Ashapuri, a Dancing Ganesh and an Uma-Maheshwari: the latter has been attributed to the Parmars. Uma is one of the names of Parvati, consort of Maheshwar or Siva. Clockwise from the Siva gallery is a Bhimbhetka rock shelter with white-and-red Stone Age paintings. Directly in front of the rock sheltend to the right of the rock shelter, is the Vishnu Gallery. The 10th century Vishnu from Ashapuri is noteworthy as is the 8th-10th century Kalachuri Narasimha: the fourth incarnation of Lord Vishnu. To the right of the hall is the Devi gallery. Particularly unusual is the 10th century Maheshwari Trimurti: a triple-headed goddess from the 10th century Parmar period. Maheshwari is the consort of Maheshwar or Siva. The female Salbhanjika statue is particularly graceful.

Driving up to the Shamla Hills, visitors can walk around the famed Bharat Bhavan.

BHARAT BHAVAN

This centre for the performing and visual arts was designed by the internationally-famed architect Charles Correa. Much of this centre is below ground level, merging with the landscape. It has galleries, workshops, a theatre, auditoria and a strong folk-painting and tribal art section. Very often visitors can see artists and artisans at work in this unique national institution.

Also in the Shamla Hills is the State Museum.

The impressivce Laxminarayan Temple

STATE MUSEUM

Housed in a modern building filled with natural light and with wide spaces accessed by ramps, it is a place where visitors can amble through, pause, linger and observe the well-displayed exhibits at leisure. Here there are reproductions of the now-destroyed Buddhist Bagh Cave paintings, 84 rare Jaina bronzes of the 8th to 11th centuries, Avaloketeshwaras of Lamaism, Saivite sculptures and miniature paintings showing the graceful lifestyles of those distant days.

This is among the best-designed museums in India.

MP TRIBAL MUSEUM

The Museum is represents the tribal heritage of the state under one roof through life size replicas of the tribal habitat, temples, granaries, pictures and statues. Chhatisgarh is the guest state of the museum. There is a souvenir cum book shop where one may find tribal jewlleries.

One of the Gallery of Tribal Museum

At the base of the Shamla Hills is the very unusual city forest called the Van Vihar.

VAN VIHAR

It is, actually, a large zoo with open and landscaped enclosures. A motor-road winds through it, along the banks of the Upper Lake. There is also a stretch of wet-land in the Van Vihar populated by quacking, squawking, preening water birds like painted storks living in a sort of armed truce with crocodiles; a truce that is occasionally breached! Among the larger animals that can be seen from the road are bears, tawny tigers, their white cousins, leopards and their stately prey, sambar deer. With a little bit of luck, visitors might see the carnivores being fed. Though the lake is not, strictly speaking, in Van Vihar, its visiting water-birds can be seen from the Van Vihar road, swimming in enormous feeding flocks and taking off in clouds of silver spray when on-lookers get too close.

The lake also holds the Boat Club.

A tiger in its natural enclosure in the city forest - Van Vihar

Bhopal's big lake offers boat rides and cruses

BOAT CLUB

From the club, visitors can go out on the water in a Cruise Boat with two decks, or on one of their six speed boats or, if they feel up to it, or one of the 30 foot-powered pedal boats.

Bhopal was the second capital of the Nawabs. The founder of the dynasty, Sardar Dost Mohammed Khan, seized Jagdishpur, 11 kms from Bhopal, in 1715. He then renamed it Islamnagar.

JAGDISHPUR

Clearly, it is not just a palace but a palace-fortress and it is encircled by two massive, concentric walls with projecting bastions. Inside the fortifications, the palace is graceful with gardens, courtyards, terraces and a river serving as a natural moat.

A descriptive board says

The earlier name was JADISHPUR, and its (former) ruler was the Rajput chieftain DEVDA CHAUHAN.In 1715, DOST MOHAMMED KHAN slaughtered the chieftain and his soldiers.After capturing Jagdishpur, he renamed it Jagdishpur. By 1719, all Bhopal came under him, and he came to be known as the founder of Bhopal. Jagdishpur was the capital of the state before the construction of the fort at Bhopal.The second Nawab, YAA MOHAMMED KHAN, who reconstructed the palace here, died in 1742 and was buried here.In 1808, the SCINDIAS took over and retained Jagdishpur till 1817.Nawab GAUS MOHAMMAD KHAN's daughter, GAUHAR BEGUM (Qudasia Begum), was married to NAZAR MOHAMMED KHAN in 1818. Their only child was SIKANDAR JEHAN BEGUM. Nazir Mohammed Khan died in November 1819 in Jagdishpur after a pistol went off accidentally.In 1835, SIKANDAR JEHAN BEGUM, the daughter of Qudasia Begum, married JAHANGIR MOHAMMED KHAN, but due to strained relations, Qudasia Begum and Sikandar Jehan Begum left Bhopal and began to stay in Jagdishpur. Here, Sikandar Jehan Begum gave birth to a daughter, SHAH JEHAN BEGUM, who became the 11th ruler of Bhopal state. Sikandar Begum lived here with her mother and daughter till 1844.The most important monuments are Chaman Mahal, Rani Mahal, and Gond Mahal.The Chaman Mahal has the Royal Hamam and a beautiful garden developed in Char Bagh style. It is one of the very few Mughal Gardens in Central India. The architecture is an amalgam of Rajput,

The graceful Charbagh gardens

Mughal, and Malwa styles.The graves of Nawab Yaa Mohammed Khan and Nazar Mohammed Khan are situated across the river.The first monument that most visitors enter is the Rani Mahal.

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The first monument that most visitors enter is the Rani Mahal.

RANI MAHAL

This has been built around an open courtyard with a spreading mango tree at one corner. The courtyard is encircled by buildings on raised plinths, some with carved arches. On the floor above is a pavilion in the Rajasthani style. According to the descriptive board:This was constructed by Dost Mohammed Khan in AD 1720 as a residence for his queens. It is built in a combination of Rajput, Mughal, and Malwa styles.Coming out of the Rani Mahal, visitors enter an attached courtyard with the single-roomed Museum.

Portrait of Sultan Jehan Begum

MUSEUM

It could have been built as a guard room originally. Now it has the family tree of the Nawabs, portraits of many of the dynasty, including one of Dost Mohammed on a horse and another of a Begum dressed very much like Queen Victoria. Beyond the museum is the most beautiful part of Jagdishpur, the Charbagh Gardens.

CHARBAGH GARDENS

It is a sunken garden laid out in the formal Mughal style with water-courses, fountains, and water chutes called chadars or shawls: they are designed to make flowing water foam as they pour down. Water from the river just beyond the grounds of the palace was drawn up by animal-powered Persian wheels, filled into high reservoirs, and allowed to flow down into the gardens.At the far end of the gardens is a graceful pavilion, and to the left of this is the hamam.

HAMAM

The Mughals, like the Romans and the Turks, were fond of public baths: elaborate constructions with massage tables, steam rooms, hot tubs, and chill pools.All the rooms of the hamam here had openings in the domed ceiling to let in natural light. Apart from all the usual hamam facilities, this one had a room

encircled with mirrors so that the Begum could see what her maids were doing to beautify her after her bath. The rich and the famous, all through time, have shared a common obsession with themselves!Beyond the pavilion, at the end of the gardens, there is a terrace overlooking the river and the fields beyond. In those fields stand the tombs of Nawab Yaa Mohammed Khan and Nawab Nazar Mohammed Khan.And the gently flowing, rather innocuous, river is the Halali: the River of Slit Throats that ran red with blood when Dost Mohammed Khan slaughtered his guests and took over Jagdishpur.His princely victim, Narshingh Devada Chauhan, lived in a palace across the road from the Jagdishpur complex. It is known as the Gond Mahal.

GOND MAHAL

The name of this restored monument gives the impression that the princes, who called themselves Rajput Chauhans, could have been Gond chieftains.The fortified palace sits atop a small knoll with an encampment of buffalo-herders in front. Entering through narrow arches, the visitor comes to an open court with pillared and arched galleries all around. It looks a bit like a small caravanserai, but that is deceptive. The Rajasthani influence is obvious with flat roofs, projecting eaves, and arches designed to throw deep shadows into the verandahs fronting the rooms, and courts to ensure privacy while still allowing columns of hot air to rise. The nights are often cool and pleasant, and people occasionally slept on terraces under the stars.Narrow stairways lead up. They are both easy to defend and also serve as conduits for even the slightest breeze, cooling the thick walls covered in a special lime plaster with the smoothness and sheen of marble.The stairs lead to pavilions on the upper floor and give a bird's-eye view of the women's court with its long, rectangular ponds. With hordes of servants to pamper them, the ladies of the harem—literally 'the forbidden place'—led cosseted and rather indolent lives. Lolling in the privacy of cool pools of rose-scented water was an activity that they took for granted.All around the Gond Mahal spread the fields of the peasants whose hard work kept the princely families in the luxury they were used to!Returning to Bhopal, and then taking the road south, will bring visitors to a scrub-and-rock-covered outcrop dominated by the great bulk of the Siva temple of Bhojpur.

BHOJPUR

A road winds up from the parking lot to a broad, high, platform with two shrines rising to bulbous domes. One has slim pillars and feminine arches. The other is a four-squared and more assertively masculine. These are living shrines and seem to be more recent additions to this complex. But when a monument dates back to the 11th century, even the phrase 'more recent could make it older than any town in the USA, Canada, Australia or New Zealand!

The descriptive board says it all.

This unique but incomplete temple was constructed by the Parmar King Bhojadeva I (1010-1055 AD). He was a patron of the arts and learning.

The temple is west facing and built platform of 32.25 meters long, 23.50 meters wide and 5 meters high.

The sanctum is square and accessed through a moonstone entrance slab.

The polished Shivling is the tallest of its kind in India.

The door jamb of the sanctum is carved with vegetal designs and Kuber, Saiva Dwapalas, female attendants and Ganga and Jumna. Bracket capitals of the 4 mas- sive pillars of the sanctum support a circular ceiling of concentric rings with figures of Shiv-Parvati, Laxmi-Narayan, Brahma-Savitri and Rama-Janaki. The exterior has 3 decorated balconies resting on carved brackets. Most interestingly, the

masonry ramp over which heavy architectural components were carried is still intact.

Scattered all around the knoll are carved and partially-carved blocks. Some of the flat surfaces of boulders seemed to have been used as drawing boards, incised with architectural drawings and sketches. Over 1,300 masons' marks have been identified, as well as the names of fifty masons. Some of the marks could have belonged to guilds of masons or families of craftsmen. These marks would indicate the amount of work done by them so that the accountants could calculate what was due to the artisans.

Alert visitors also notice long rows of teeth-like indentations: this is where rocks had been broken by alternate heating and cooling. And the reason why these interesting marks still remain is that all work on this Siva temple stopped sud- denly, and no one has been able to give a credible reason why that happened. In the normal course, such marks would have been obliterated once the temple had been completed.

Bhoja had also created an enormous lake by building three dams to impound the waters of the Betwa and the Kaliasol rivers. The temple rose on the banks of this great reservoir. The lake, apparently, changed the climate of the area, ensured year-round irri- gation for vast stretches of fields, and generally brought prosperity to this land. Sadly, the Afghan, Hoshang Shah, destroyed this 400-year old lake by breaching two of the dams. No one really knows why he ordered this seemingly senseless act of gross vandalism, particularly as he was destroying a major source of his own wealth. There are stories that he did it to drown an invading army; or that he wanted to wreak vengeance on the prosperous farmers who had opposed him; or even that he had been advised to do so by a seer in order to prolong his own life. But all this is, largely, speculation. All that we can be certain about is that the draining of the lake defiled his image and that of his dynasty.

What remains, however, is that, after countless generations, the people of the land continue to have great reverence for the unforgettable King Bhoja.

Shiv Temple of Bhojpur

UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITE

BHOJESHWAR MAHADEV TEMPLE, BHOJPUR
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

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With the most vantage location in Bhopal, MPT Wind & Waves is where a number of Bollywood movies have been shot. Its open air restaurant provides a breath taking view of the Upper Lake front. MPT Wind & Waves is famous all over the city for its bar, again situated at the most breath taking location besides the Bada Talab. This is the choice for parties, conferences, family stay or simply an evening out with the family. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified Restaurant. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

MPT Kerwa Resort

7552696736

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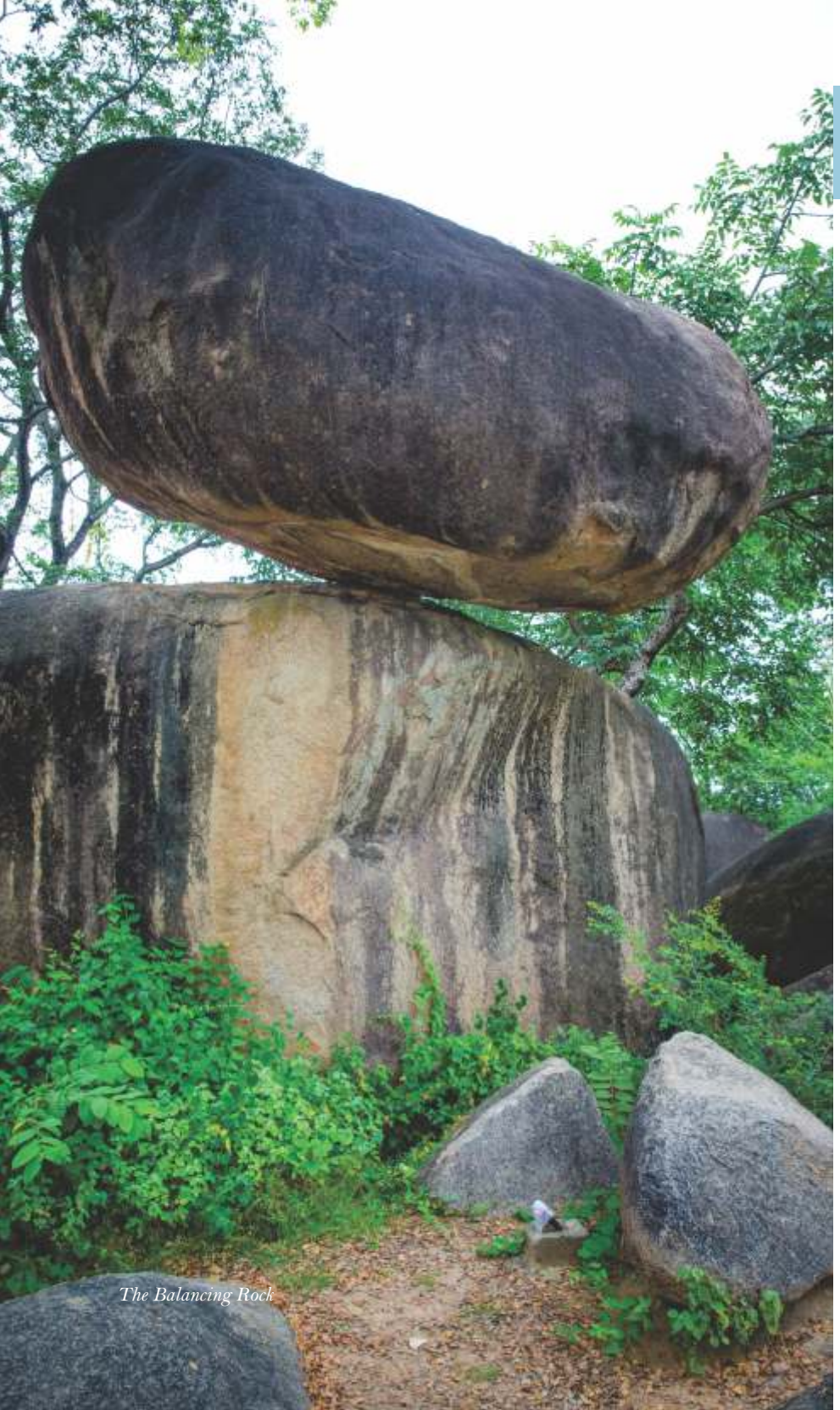
Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

14 kms from Bhopal, MPT Kerwa Resort is a leisure resort nestled at the edge of Kerwa dam. The view from the window is MPT Kerwa Resorts' USP - it being a panoramic view of the hills and a beautiful reservoir. Perfect weekend retreat for city dwellers, an ideal spot for school picnics, group lunches and team dinners. Nature lovers get to enjoy bird watching and adventure junkies get the only zip lining experience in Madhya Pradesh - here at Kerwa. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.



The Balancing Rock

Jabalpur

It is about the power of women, and of a river.

The River Narmada, too, is a beautiful woman, as most rivers are, in India. But though she passes close to Jabalpur, she shyly avoids the town. Or, perhaps the town has grown away from her, and its own past. Consequently, there is really very little in Jabalpur town to capture the attention of the visitor. But a short drive out of the long narrow plain holding the town, brings one to sub-montane lands: rocky, rugged and a natural bulwark against attackers. One of the more intriguing monuments to Jabalpur's past is the Madan Mahal Fort.

The Madan Mahal Fort

The river Narmada

MADAN MAHAL FORT

Built by the Gond ruler Raja Madan Shah, also know as Madansingh, in the 1400's, it looks like the sort of 'Organic' structure that American architect Frank Lloyd Wright might have created. It does, however, call for a fairly trying plod on a path winding up a scrub-forested hill. Shrines dot agglomerations of huge rocks and there is a serene but rather neglected pond. You might also encounter black-faced langur monkeys who can be quite aggressive. A walking stick generally stops them from getting up close and personal!

The walls and crenellated battlements of the fort seem to be natural outgrowths from a group of massive boulders. Its squat keep, the final stronghold if the rest of the fort fell to besiegers, crowns the most gigantic of the boulders. It also has an impressive arched gateway and, at its base, there is a long, flat building that could have held the fort's guards and hors- es. Take the narrow staircase leading to the top of the fort for a view that is wide-screen. Jabalpur masses white on the slim strip of plain below, quite independent of its 900 year old fort. Clearly, its priorities changed when its rulers died. After the Gonds, the Mu- ghals and Marathas swept across the plain. And then came the power that conquered the whole of India: the Brit- ish. Britain's East India Company set the shape of Jabalpur today. After the great revolution of 1857, the Brit- ish Crown took over the territories of the 19th century's most influen- tial company and decided to make Jabalpur a powerful Military sta- tion. And when they built the great railroads criss-crossing the land, they chose Jabalpur as one of its major transport hubs.

The uni-directional growth of Jabalpur becomes apparent when visitors drive from the hill-top fort of Madan Mahal into the bustling town. On the way is the beautiful Rani Tal.

RANI TAL

This lake, really a reservoir, was created by the visionary Gond queen Durgavati. (See Box - Rani Durgavati) There's a heroic statue of her mounted on an elephant in a park in the town. There is also a small statue of her, in a glass case, in the Rani Durgavati Museum.

RANI DURGAVATI MUSEUM

It has galleries devoted to Jaina, Vishnu and Siva sculptures. The Hin- du sculptures belong to the era of the Kalachuri kings: predecessors of the Gond

RANI DURGAVATI

She was a Queen for All Reasons: exceptionally beautiful, charismatic, a great administrator and a superb warrior who led her armies into battle riding a war elephant. Sadly, she is one of the most neglected hero- ines of Indian history.

Durgavati was the daughter of an impoverished prince of the once-powerful Chandela dynasty. Her father, proud of the fact that his lineage had been accepted as one of the warrior Rajputs, had to bow to circumstances and marry his daughter to a Gond prince. He considered the tribal Gonds to be his social inferiors, even though the Chandelas themselves had been Gonds before they assumed upwardly mobile airs and graces. But then, the Gond prince had a lot of money and a prosperous kingdom, and those qualities often outweigh the ben- efits of a pretended, royal bloodline!

Durgavati's husband, Dalpat, had an unremarkable reign and died seven years after succeeding to the throne. And since his son was only about four years of age then, Durgavati became the regent. She ruled from 1548 to 1564, and she brought so much prosperity to her kingdom that people paid their taxes in gold coins and elephants. Using a fine blend of tact, bravery and generosity she brought the whole of Gondwana under her rule. But for all her renowned beauty and grace, she never allowed anyone to trespass on her domains.

Between 1555 and 1560, Baz Bahadur of Mandu invaded Gondwana. Durgavati led her army of 20,000 cavalry, 1,000 war elephants and a strong force of infantry against the invader. Baz Bahadur's uncle, Fatch Khan was killed and, after an aborted second attack, Baz Bahadur was forced to flee from the battle field.

Durgavati was a born strategist and tactician and many of her battles were won on intuitive moves, and against the advice of her commanders. In the end, however, she fell a victim to spies and her own pride. Taken unawares by an insidious Mughal infiltration, when most of her army was on leave, she could have negotiated for peace but she refused to do so with a mere Mughal General instead of the great Mughal Emperor Akbar himself. And she also refused to retreat in the face of a vastly superior force. She donned her armour, mounted her favourite war elephant, and led her army into certain death. In the heat of battle, an arrow pierced her temple and another punctured her throat. She pulled out both arrows but became faint with loss of blood. She ordered her elephant mahaut to kill her but he refused to do so and urged his elephant on trying to carry his beloved queen to safety. In desperation, she stabbed herself in her heart rather than face the humiliation of falling into the hands of her enemies. Her 21 year old son died in the same battle.

And with their deaths, the last great kingdom of the Gonds came to an end.

rulers. Particularly fascinating is the way the Kalachuri craftsmen depicted Lord Siva interrupting Par- vati dressing her hair, tilting her chin up tenderly; Lakshmi presses her face close to Lord Vishnu; and Swaha sits on Agni's lap. The expressions of such emotions are typical of Kalachuri art..

Anyone can relate to such loving gods and goddesses. For the ultimate achievement of human ecstasy, however, drive out 23 kilometres from Jabalpur to the strange circular temple of the Chausath Yoginis in Bhedaghat.

The Chausath Yogini Temple

CHAUSATH YOGINIS IN BHEDAGHAT

This area, rising from the banks of the swift-flowing Narmada River, is known as Bhedaghat. Most people head for this riverine hamlet to see the attractions associated with the river. But the temple of the Sixty Four attendants of the Mother Goddess belongs to a faith that had its origins in the Stone Age.

Access to the temple is up a flight of 108 steps rising through a wooded hillside. The Archaeological Survey of India's (ASI) board outside the circular, inward-looking, temple says:

The circular cloister has 81 images of different Brahmanical goddesses plus a few images of gods including Ganesh. This temple is popularly known as the temple of the 64 Yoginis or attendants of the Goddess Durga. The names of most of the goddesses inscribed on the pedestals differ from the lists given in Sanskrit texts. The inscribed images belong to circa 10th century AD when they were worshipped in an open-air shrine, while the pillared roof appears to have been added later. Among the uninscribed images is seen a crude Kushana (circa 2nd century AD) image and some dancing images in red sandstone assignable to the 8th century AD. This indicates the existence of an earlier shrine.

It is possible that the visitor might not find all 81 images. Some of these superb sculptures could have been removed for cleaning or sent away to be displayed in exhibitions in other places.

In the centre of this circular unroofed gallery, there is a platform with a living Siva temple. Installed in the temple are idols of Siva and his consort Parvati, riding on Siva's bull Nandi. Gauri and Shankar - other appellations for Parvati and Siva respectively - are flanked by the sun god Surya and a dancing Ganesh. Ganesh is one of the two sons of Siva and Parvati.

Another board, installed by the ASI at the base of the platform indicates that

the temple in the court of the Chausat Yoginis is enshrining an image of Gauri-Shankar inscribed as Vareshvara, originally erected by the Kalachuri queen Alhana Devi during the reign of her son Narasimha Deva. There is an inscription on the front wall of the sanctum referring to the daily worship of the deity by Gosala Devi, mother of the Kalachuri king Vijayasimha (AD 1180-1195). Of the original temple only the lower portion of the sanctum has survived.

Siva is generally, if not invariably, associated with the Mother Goddess. The image of power conjured up by the Mother Goddess is particularly appropriate for Bhedaghat. A little less than 2 km away are the surging Dhuandhar Falls.

DHUANDHAR FALLS

Here, the Narmada pours over a cliff, roaring and fuming in a cloud of white mist: Dhuandhar means 'a cascade of smoke'. It is awesome and the spray from the falls reaches out to the platforms built over the enraged river. From here visitors can get a close view of the furious gush of water. Rocks in the main channel have created comparatively calmer, subsidiary streams where bathers can dip their feet in the sacred river or throw water over themselves, washing away the burden of their transgressions.

As happens all over our land, this hallowed spot presents a very festive scene with saffron-robed mendicants; carvers of marble statuettes; snack sellers; purveyors of black water-chestnuts; a woman imprinting patterns on palms with fabric printing blocks; little boys urging visitors to throw coins into the maelstrom at the base of the falls so that they could dive in from the cliffs and retrieve them; a blind beggar playing a single-string plucked instrument and singing in a very clear voice; and women perched picturesquely on sun-drenched rocks, near the patchwork quilt of their drying saris.

Visitors are often surprised to learn that these stupendous falls are not so stupendous after all. According to the official record, the cliff over which the Narmada tumbles, to create the mighty Dhuandhar, is a mere 9 meters high!

After raging down the cliff, the Narmada is forced to snarl through a narrow canyon. To meet the river on the other side, visitors will have to return past the bottom of the steps leading to the Chausath Yogini Temple, and into the Bhedaghat Bazaar.

BHEDAGHAT BAZAAR

The bazaar can be heard even before it is seen. An incessant chip-chip-chip! of hammers and chisels comes from most of the open-fronted shops. This is a precinct of sculptures. Everyone, from silver-haired senior citizens to sub-junior apprentices after returning from school, is busy transforming stone into works of art, or near art. Plaques, statues, three-dimensional landscapes, jewel boxes, lampshades, even wine glasses reputedly crafted from translucent onyx marble with watered patterns: everything is available for a hotly bargained price. And for most visitors, even at the un-bargained price, everything is a bargain!

Soap stone craft

The sculpture-bazaar lines both sides of a stepped road sloping down to the bathing ghats and boat landings for the unforgettable row-boat cruise through the wondrous Marble Rocks.

Dhuandhar Fall

MOTHER GODDESSES

Humans worshipped women before they worshipped men. The earliest sculpted depiction of a divine being was the Venus of Willendorf: it is a 10.45 cm.high figurine of a mature, unusually fat female. It was found in Willendorf, Austria and was created between 28,000 and 22,000 BC. But she was not alone. In that Upper Paleolithic Age, our Stone Age ancestors made a number of these statuettes, now called Venus Figures. In all likelihood, Early Man felt that by holding these portable images he had control over the most mysterious force of all: fertility.

So awesome was this force, that it was often used to control that exclusively male activity, hunting. Writes researcher Karen Amstrong, in her wide-ranging A Short History of Myth:

…one of the most powerful hunters in the Palaeolithic era was female Artemis is simply one embodiment of the Great God- dess, a fearsome deity who was not only Mistress of Animals, but the source of life

…The hunters could see that women were the source of new life; it was - - - they not the expendable males - - - who ensured the continuation of the tribe. The female thus became the awe-inspiring icon of life itself…

This reverential awe of the female gave rise to one of the major forms of modern Hinduism:Shaktism (The other two are Vaisnavism and Saivism) Shakti literally means 'power' or 'energy'. Male gods are often regarded as quiescent and have to be activated by their shaktis. In fact many people believe that, though the different shaktis vary dramatically in appearance, they are really different aspects of the same primal female power: the Devi or Mother Goddess.

This devotion to the Mother Goddess evolved into a very specialised form of worship called Trantrism. In its most secret form it called for a ritual satiation of the senses by, what the uninitiated would consider to be, orgies, Such a numbing overload of the senses has the same effect as cutting oneself off from the world by retiring into a dark, quiet, cave so that your mind can be focused on releasing the metaphysical powers that lie untapped in every human.

Clearly, by its very nature, these rituals can not be performed by lone individuals: they call for multiple hetero-sexual par- ticipation. Equally obvious is the fact that they must be performed in secret though under the open sky. It is also presumed that the practitioners of these dangerous rituals would concentrate their attention on one of the 64 aspects of female power manifested in the 64 Yoginis, the Chausat Yoginis. In other words, every person sought to activate his or her own 'Shakti' or strength and mould it to the dynamic form of one of the power- ful Chausat Yoginis like the contented and cow-faced Erudi, the contemplative Pamdavi sitting in the lotus pose, or the dynamic Tera Mua. The idols of the Yoginis were not an array of bizarre god- desses. They served as focal points for the concentration of meta-

One of the 64 Mother Goddnesses, Phanendri

physical energies generated and released through Tantra in much the same way that a magnifying glass focuses the rays of the sun.

"Though, to our modern minds, this might all sound like so much mumbo-jumbo, it seems to have been very popular in our medieval period." Famed archaeologist Krishna Deva wrote that "The concentration of so many Yogini temples in and around Central India proves that the Yogini cult was widely prevalent (here)."

MARBLE ROCKS

The landing at the bottom of the steps is usually crowded with visitors and bobbing with boats of various sizes. A metal frame on the boat holds a canopy because it can be quite bright and warm out on the river. There is usually a guide in every boat ready with a lively commentary, often in verse, or worse! Do take a rowboat and not the single motor boat: the mechanical one goes too fast and is polluting and noisy.

Out on the stream, your boat moves against the current caused by the restricted Narmada rushing away from the Dhuandhar Falls, up ahead. Over the centuries, the force of the river has cut this gorge through soft limestone and marble in colours ranging from snow-white through cream, yellow, amber, pale green, blue, mauve, a pale rose and even black. At its highest point the marble gorge towers over 33 m above the water line and ranges - according to the boatmen-guides - from 26 m to 215 m in depth. At one spot the tops of the canyon seem to be so close that a monkey leapt from one side to the other: or so the boatman-commentator proclaimed.

The two oarsmen go creak-splash! creak-splash! The commentary weaves sound-pictures around you. Grey rock pigeons nest in holes in the cliffs. Fish jump and vanish into concentric ripples. You pass other boats laden to the gunnels with delighted visitors. The current gets swifter revealing its rippled muscles on the surface. A man perched on a rock sits fishing, patiently. Three bare-bodied boys dance on a rock, begging for coins to be thrown into the river. A kingfisher, like a bright chip of flame, hovers over the water and then plummets in, emerging with a silver fish wriggling in its beak. The commentator intones: *"This-is-where-Raj-Kapoor-sang-that-love-song-and-a-horse-slid-down-the- cliff-see-its-hoof-marks-two-black-wrestlers-fighting-at-the-WWF-Championships- and-now-we-will-rest-in-the-cove-for-the-current-is-very-strong-and we-shall-turn-and-catch-the-fast-currtnt-back-but-it-is-best-to-be-her e-on-the-night-of-fullmoon-the-marble-rocks-glow-as-if-we-have-entered-another-world..."*

The cruise last from 20 minutes. to half-an-hour and it's best to hire a boat for yourselves because unknown fellow passengers can be uncomfortably noisy.

There's another water experience waiting you, 50 km from Bhedaghat or 31 kms from Jabalpur. This is to the enormous lake created by the dam at Bargi Lakeside Resort.

Marble Rocks

GOND MONUMENTS OF RAMNAGAR MANDLA
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

BHEDAGHAT & LAMEHTAGHAT
IN TENTATIVE LIST OF UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITES

Accommodation in Jabalpur

MPT Kalchuri Residency

7612678491

kalchuri@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Bar | Parking

Transport | Conference Hall | Gym | Swimming Pool

Stylish & Contemporary, MPT Kalchuri Residency is MPT Hotels Resorts' premium residency, located in the heart of Jabalpur city. An elegant restaurant, a swimming pool and its proximity to the central business districts of Jabalpur and market makes it a favourite hotel between leisure and business travellers. It is best suited for any grand event - wedding, conference, banquets as well as family gatherings. ISO 22000:2018 FSMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Jabalpur

MPT Marble Rocks, Bhedaghat

8253040377

mmr@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Swimming Pool

The best place to enjoy the dazzling Marble Rocks towering above a meandering Narmada is MPT Hotels & Resorts' MPT Marble Rocks. You could stay in our comfortable and uniquely positioned rooms or take a tent to feel one with nature. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Pachmarhi

Bagpipes skirled in a flower-bright valley while ancient dancers cavorted on a rock in Pachmarhi.

The pipes and the dancers were separated by thousands of years: T typical of this little town in the Satpura Mountains. Contrasting cultures and ages exist in harmony as if time and trends mean lit- tle in this serene, wooded place. Pachmarhi is for unwinding, effortlessly. Roads meander gently past groves of trees, open spaces and heritage cottages sitting contentedly in their old gardens. The town has a quiet gentility about it as if Victorian traditions and high collars still governed most people's lives. Much of this ambience has been set, and is still being maintained, by the strong presence of the Army whose Education Corps is headquartered here. (See Box- Cantonments) The old cottages, meticulously maintained by the Military Engineering Services, have changed little since the days of Kipling.

Priyadarshini Point

Valleys of Pachmarhi

Also, all military stations had to have their churches. Two, dating back to the 19th century, still stand in all their gem-like glory. One of them is Christ Church.

CHRIST CHURCH

It was built in 1875 and many rank this Gothic church as the most beautiful in the state. On either side of the nave are exquisite stained glass windows, all erected as memorials to their friends by members of the congregation. One on the left has Jesus raising Lazarus from the dead and Martha from her sick bed. The inscription reads:

Erected by his friends in memory of Richard Jackson, MD, who was stung to death by wasps near this place - October 1883

Then, there is a plaque just outside the altar which says:

The Tower of this church has been erected in thanksgiving to Almighty God for our victory in the Great War and as a memorial to the fallen. It was consecrated by Eyre First Bishop of Nagpur on Sunday January 10, 1923

The 'Great War' was the First World War: 1914-1918. Time moves slowly in Pachmarhi.

Just before leaving the church, do look up. There is a superb rose window high above the entrance emblazoned with regimental crests.
Then there is the Catholic Church.

THE CATHOLIC CHURCH

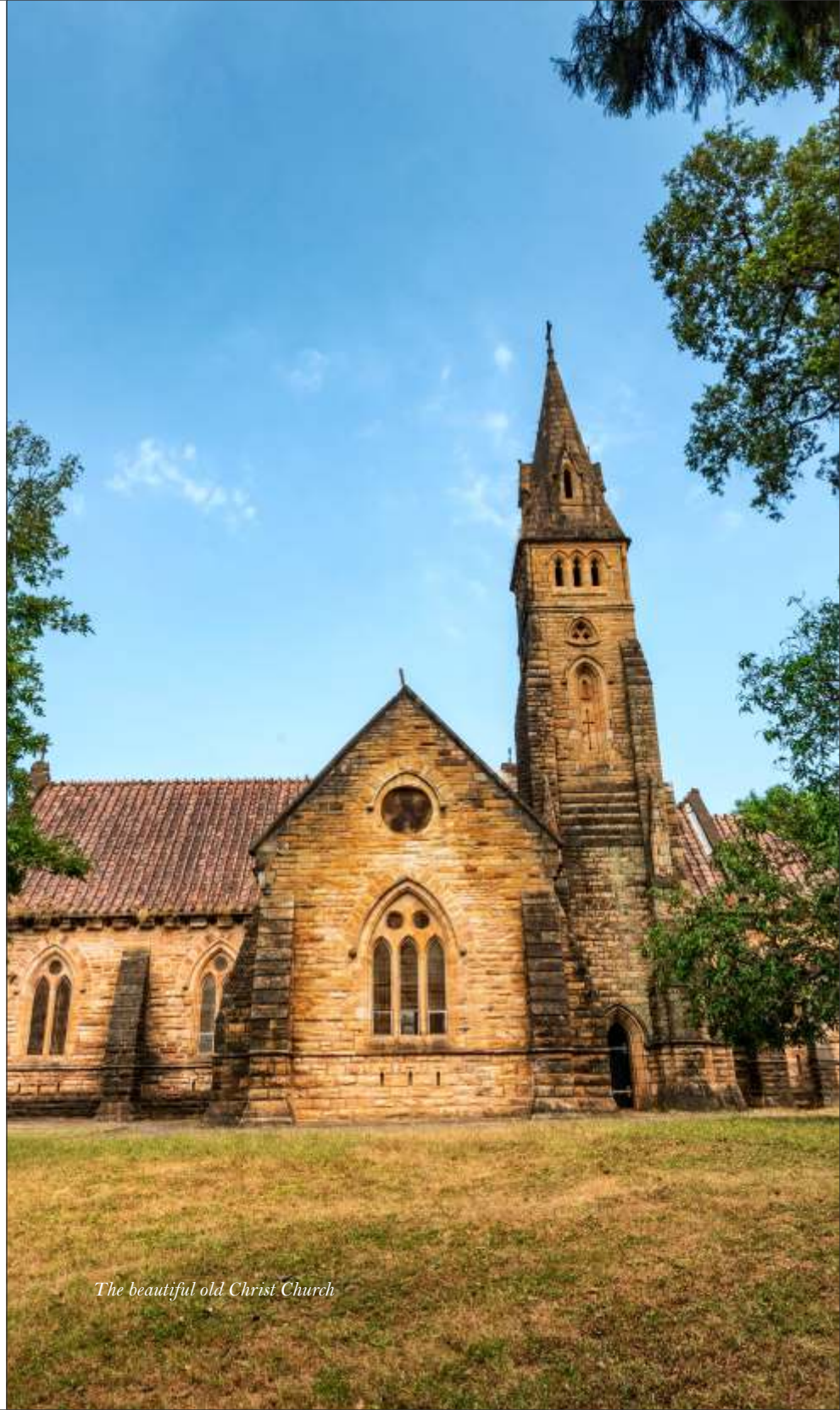
Formally known as the Church of Our Lady, the Mother of Christ, and she is shown wearing an unusual, high, silver crown. It is a beautiful, well-maintained stone church with excellent stained glass windows. It was built in 1892 and local guides say that it shows a blend of French and Irish architecture. In fact, judging from the slim lancet windows, the flying buttresses and the pointed arches, this church replicates the architecture of the early English period, between 1200 and 1300. The reference to the Irish probably came about when an Irish regiment was based in Pachmarhi or there was a substantial number of Irish Catholic personnel posted here.

CANTONMENTS

Pronounced can-toon-ment are permanent military camps, run by the Min- istry of Defence, and generally situated on the outskirts of a town. Cantonments were started by the East India Company, a cor- porate body that owned all the territories taken over, by British traders, from the old Mughal Empire and the princely states. Originally, the Company stationed their troops in their fortified trading stations, or 'factories', but when these became too crowded, they were moved out to canton- ments. These permanent camps provided hygienic living conditions, with adequate space for barracks, the officers' mess, living quarters, a church, a parade ground and, more often than not, a race course.

Even after the British government took over the territories of the Company, following the events of 1857, cantonments survived; as they did after India became an independent country.

Cantonments are, generally, marked by an air of good order and discipline. Their civic services are controlled by a Cantonment Board presided over by a senior, often the senior-most military officer.



The beautiful old Christ Church

One of the most striking features of this church is the Baptismal Font: backed by a marble sculpture depicting Jesus being baptised in the Jordan by John the Baptist.

From the Catholic Church it is best to go to the office of the Forest Department in Bison Lodge.

BISON LODGE

According to the Department, the oldest building in Pachmarhi was the original Bison Lodge. They claim that in 1862, the Forest Department of the then Central Provinces, was started in a building known as Bison Lodge. The Department was founded in 1861 by Captains G.F. Pearson and J. Forsyth. The original building had to be demolished and the present building, also called Bison Lodge, was constructed on the site of the earlier one.

Bison Lodge holds a small but reasonably interesting museum. As sightings of bison, leopards or tigers in the wild are unlikely during a short visit to this area, the dioramas of these animals in the museum should give visitors a fair idea of what they have missed. Moreover, since many of the listed attractions of Pachmarhi are within the protected forests guarded by the Forest Department, tickets for such entry must be bought here, and the obligatory services of a Forest Guide have to be booked in Bi- son Lodge. Please remember, however, that though a single ticket permits en- try to all the attractions in the forest, this is valid for only one day. Buy this ticket after you have planned out your itinerary. Bison Lodge is one of the attrac- tions in town. There are two others. One of them is the Gond Baba Udyan.

The Bison Lodge

GOND BABA UDYAN

Long before the British came to Pachmarhi, this area was inhabited by tribal people who still live in settlements in the forests. The Gonds are one such tribe. They have a fenced-off memorial shrine at the base of a revered mango tree, accessed from the road leading from Bison Lodge to the Pandav Caves. On a platform at the base of the tree are stacked wooden memo- rial plaques referred to by the Gonds as 'gathas'. According to the Gonds, they are carved by specialists and are always made of teak. A gatha is installed within a year of the death of the relative. When it is ready, it is brought in ceremonial procession

from the village, accompanied by a number of men and women carrying double headed dholaks and kettle drums. Also simple camping gear, cooking pots, rice, besan or gram flour and spices. Their pilgrimage can take them a whole day but when they arrive, sometimes late at night, they set up their temporary kitchen and, to the beat of drums, they dance in a moving circle while one of the men chants. People who have seen this ceremony say that the Gonds seem to be charged by the ritual and are quite tireless. No one knows how old this ceremony is but it could go back to the Stone Age.

A descriptive board standing at the entrance to the grounds says

... that if a carving is not laid here within one year of death, the soul of the dead person will not rest in peace. The symbols in the carvings are those of the sun, moon and horse. The carvings are first taken to the cremation ground in worshipful procession. It is believed that anyone disturbing these pallets will get a fever or suffer other bodily harm.

Some distance away from this sacred mango tree is a well-tended garden at the far end of which is a flight of railed steps cut into a large outcrop of rock and leading to the Pandav Caves.

PANDAV CAVES

As most Indians know, the Pandavs were five brothers who were the heroes of the world's longest epic, the Mahabharat. After a great war that they had fought against their kinfolk, they went into an extended exile. There are legends all over India claiming that they visited the remotest parts of the country and various places have been named after them. The Pandav Caves have been so called after their supposed visit and stay here. Pachmarhi has been named after these live caves.

According to a descriptive board installed at the start of the stairs,

The caves are simple in plan, some having a pillared verandah only. The façade of Cave 2 is carved with a simple chaitya arch (This is a typically Buddhist horseshoe arch generally used at the entrance of their cave shrines) The door jamb of cave No. 4 is decorated with miniature figures of Jambhal (God of Wealth) At the bottom of Cave 3 there is an inscription on the basis of which these couldn't have been carved before the Gupta Period-4th-5th century. They seem to be of Buddhist origin. The remains of a brick Buddhist structure were found above the Pandav Caves in 1999.

The Pandav Caves

GONDS

The Gonds are, largely, a forest dwell- ing and rural people who are of Dravidian ethnic stock. Migrants of the Dravidian race probably came into India between 2,500 and 3,000 years ago. Anthropolo- gists believe that they are people of the same stock as the people of Asia Minor, Crete, and the pre-Hellenic Aegeans of Greece.

The Gond language, Gondi, is an unwritten one and has a number of dialects, many of which are unintelligible to each other. Their religion centres around their clan and village deities along with ancestor worship. They do not seem to have a community of priests, preferring to conduct their religious rituals themselves. The Gonds are skilled bowmen and fight- ers and many of them had carved out their own principalities maintaining their independence even against the formidable forces of the Mughals. A few Gond rajas continued to rule their territories till India became independent in 1947.

The ancient super-continent of the southern hemisphere was called Gondwanaland after the Gond people.

Gond Woman

Apart from the decorative features mentioned on the board, there is nothing else of intrinsic interest to the casual visitor in these caves.

Beyond the spread of the green valley, where the caves have been carved, other legends wreath around other caves and view-points. The view-points offer breath-taking panoramas of wooded hills, span deep gorges and give glimpses of distant waterfalls spilling' like silvery moonlight down the dusk of a canyon wall.' A particularly impressive sight is that of the Big Falls.

BIG FALLS OR RAJAT PRAPAT

The road that leads to this view-point, however, is rugged. From the barrier set up by the Forest Department, there is a cemented road winding down but only 4 x 4 vehicles are allowed on it. Even these have to park after some distance and then one has to walk on a forest path and, at one point, scramble over some boulders. At the end of this path, is the fenced-off view-point at the edge of the escarpment. There, across a deep gorge, a stream falls like a strip of glittering tinsel, down a 120 m cleft in the brown, scrub-patched cliffs.

The Rajat Prapat

The Apsara Vihar

Most visitors agree that the sight of the falls is worth the effort of trekking down to this point.

From here, it is advisable to go back up the road for some distance and then to take a path that branches off to the left. This path winds fairly close to the edge of the escarpment, but not dangerously so. At the end of this path, however, the going does get increasingly hazardous. Initially it involves inching down rocks till one reaches a flat boulder. This gives a reasonably good view of the green dell below and the waterfall that cascades into an inviting blue pool. That is the Fairy Pool.

FAIRY POOL OR APSARA VIHAR

For those who are confident of their sense of balance and are surefooted, the climb down to the level of the pool below will be rewarding. This, apparently, was a favourite picnic spot with the British. Those visitors, however, must have been an intrepid lot particularly the women with their ankle-length skirts, large hats, and obligatory parasols!

Moreover, Victorian and Edwardian picnics were formida- ble meals with bread, lashings of butter, a wide range of roasts and cold-cuts, boiled eggs and eggs in aspic, patties and cakes, all washed down with draughts of beer, cider and shandy. The climb up must have been even more daunting than the journey down!

Allow a whole morning for this trip, more if you plan to get into the water and then have a picnic.

The next port of call in Pachmarhi should be the religious caves associ- ated with Lord Shiva. The first is the dramatic Jata Shankar.

JATA SHANKAR

Vehicles go only as far as a row of shops at the top of the gorge that leads to the sacred cave. From there it is a ten or fifteen minute walk down a well-constructed path with occasional steps, terraces, wayside stalls and railed sections. This wooded descent into a valley is full of interesting rock forma- tions that often look like grotesque gnomes, trolls and hobgoblins with a little help from the imagination!

The priests who look after the cave shrine are working to make its access

Jata Shankar

pilgrim-friendly. They are planting trees, making flower-beds, constructing steps and building cement benches, seats and a terrace. Visitors take off their shoes at this terrace about three-quarters of the way down. It is a fairly easy walk, even barefooted, to the cave. In fact, it is partly an overhang and partly a cave.

Natural geological forces and the action of water dripping over rocks have created a number of intriguing shapes which could be crocodiles and shivlings. Visitors can get close to them if they are willing to risk climbing down rather slippery steps. The shivlings are in the cave part of the shrine so, too, is an overhanging rock that resembles the extended hood of a snake. Beyond that, lies a narrow opening, leading out. On the far side of the opening, bulging rocks stand like sentinels. Between them is wedged a huge boulder. This is revered as the Jata, or topknot, of Lord Siva.

According to an articulate priest, there is an intriguing belief connected with this cave temple.

Long, long, ago Bhasmasura ... the Asuras are semi-divine beings who are opposed to the divine Devas acquired great spiritual merit by embarking on a rigorous regimen of austerities. Using this vast reservoir of merit he persuaded Lord Siva, the Lord of Destruction, to give him the powerful kara-bangle that the Lord wore. This had the power of reducing to ashes everyone over whose head it was held. Bhasmasura boasted about his acquisition to his fellow Asuras but they mocked him saying "We will believe you only when you use this power against its donor: hold the kara bangle over Lord Siva and see if he is reduced to ashes". Convinced that they were right, Bhasmasura set off in pursuit of Lord Siva.

When Siva learnt about the ungrateful Asura's evil plans he tried to divert him. He left his jata here, his snake in Nagdwar, and his Trishul at the crest of the hill of Chauragarh. But when he could not shake off his determined hunter, Siva took shelter in the depths of Mahadeo.

MAHADEO

This cave-shrine, at the other end of Pachmarhi, is at the top of a flight of steps rising up a wooded hill and running alongside a ravine with a gushing stream. The stream is charged by another that begins inside Mahadeo and flows down the centre of the cave. Pilgrims walk along a parapet stretching into the

cave-shrine. In continuation of the Jata Shankar belief

Hiding inside the Mahadeo cave, Siva realised that he had still not thrown off his determined assassin. He prayed to Lord Vishnu, the Preserver. Vishnu assumed the form of the celestial enchantress, Mohini, and appeared at the mouth of a smaller cave on the other side of the ravine. Bhasmasura got a glimpse of her and was ensnared. He thought that she was Parvati, the spouse of Shiva, and he stared at her. He heard the seductress ask "Who are you looking for?" Riven by conflicting emotions, he answered "Siva!" She gave him a dazzling smile and asked "Why do you want him, when you can have me?" Bhasmasura leapt across the ravine, blind with passion. But the woman held up her hand "First, however, you must learn to dance like Siva. I shall teach you" The besotted Bhasmasura started mimicking her movements. When she placed her right hand on her head, he did the same with his. He was reduced to ashes. The instant before he was extinguished, however, he made a fervent plea to Vishnu not to be forgotten.

Just outside the entrance of the cave, there is a face painted on a round rock. This, as any local priest will tell you, is all that is now left of Bhasmasura; but he is still remembered. The cave across the ravine is generally known as Parvati's Cave.

PARVATI'S CAVE

There are steps leading down from the platform in front of Mahadeo to the bridge crossing the ravine, and then more steps to the mouth of Parvati's cave. It is now a minor shrine with three idols.

The road that serves both Mahadeo and Parvati's cave, becomes a trekking pilgrim trail shortly after it passes the Mahadeo access. It then leads to the mountain-top temple of Chauragarh where Lord Siva left his trishul-trident when trying to escape from Bhasmasura. This trail is not motorable.

On the way back to Pachmarhi, stop on the road and walk up through a pebble-floored sal forest to Priyadarshini point.

PRIYADARSHINI AKA FORSYTH POINT

It offers wide-screen views of the surrounding hills and wooded valleys. According to legend, Captain Forsyth, who was in all likelihood a keen hunter, stood here in 1857 and decided that Pachmarhi was an ideal location for a sanatorium. (See Box Hill Stations) Though this is a widely accepted tale it does not seem to be true: the verdant valley of Pachmarhi is not visible from this point.

On the same road is a view-point over Handi Koh.

HANDI KOH

This is a deep, forested gorge almost a hundred meters to the bottom. Two reasons are given for its name: one that it was here that a British officer named Handi committed suicide, and the second, that it is shaped like a deep cooking vessel or handi. The second explanation seems more plausible.

Further along this road, and before it reaches MP Tourism's Satpura Retreat, a road leads to the left and around one side of the Jheel.

JHEEL OR LAKE

The lake is popular with holiday makers because it offers Pedal Boats on hire. This is a cool way to exercise, out on the water, though it can be quite tiring if the leg and stomach muscles are a bit flabby!

Driving back along the road that serves the Jheel, and taking the second major turning to the right, will bring visitors to

Handi Koh

PANORAMA HILL OR RAJENDRA GIRI

Situated at the far end of a pleasant garden, the view is not spectacular but it does give a panorama of gently rolling forested hills. It is major advantage is that it is seldom crowded and so is a good place in which to unwind after a strenuous day of sightseeing

Those keen to test their walking skills might like to try two attractive destinations. The first is Bee Falls.

BEE FALLS

An interesting hiking trail through forest and scrubland, across a cascading stream that is a delightful spot to have a picnic, continues further down the valley to the bottom of the Falls. They are among the most photographed sights of Pachmarhi. Water foams and roars, frothing and spuming from a moderate height of a shade over 16m. Visitors bathing in the falls often compare its cold, tingling, spray to the stings of a myriad tiny bees.

Then there is the beautiful Irene Pool.

Bee Fall

IRENE POOL

The path down to the pool is mildly challenging but it leads to what must be the most enchanting place in Pachmarhi.

At the bottom of 177 steps, including a few wide and shallow ones, there is a wooded gorge that has a tiny rivulet flowing down to the pool. The cliffs, rising all around, are towering, parts of them forested. They open far above to admit a shaft of sunlight to illuminate the pool. From a small cave, spot-lit by the beam of the sun, a stream of water gurgles out and spills over a miniature waterfall, into the pool. It is so crystal clear that the pebbles on its bottom are visible. From the pool, the water flows out into another wooded gorge and disappears beyond. This is such a magical and peaceful place that many Visitors have said that they were most reluctant to leave.

Another wondrous place is the Reechhgarh.

REECHHGARH

This Bears' abode, which is what Reechhgarh means, has not been home to bears in living memory. It is, in fact, a high cavern open at both ends. To enter it from one side visitors have to scramble over a tumble of boulders. The other end opens into a narrow canyon, scarred and striated by the action of ancient streams that must have gushed through the Reechhgarh at great speed. They sculpted and scoured, rounded, polished and etched the rocks leaving openings that vary from huge, irregular, balloons to oth- ers that look as if they had been sliced by a giant scimitar. It is a place of soaring silences as imminent with meaning as a great stage an instant before the first player steps out of the wings and the first flute begins to signal the overture.

Reechhgarh and Irene Pool give a mental, possibly even spiritual, high. For a more physical, and certainly more literal high, visitors opt for Parasailing.

PARASAILING

It looks difficult but is not really, though it is every bit as exciting. Strapped into safety gear, a crash helmet and a parachute, visitors are towed behind a jeep till the parachute fills with air and carries them into the sky. From there, after having been borne on the wings of the wind for a few minutes, parasailers descend to earth to be received by their handlers in a soft landing. Most parasailers in Pachmarhi are beginners with no previous experience of this exhilarating air sport.

Then there is the almost obligatory evening visit to Dhoopgarh.

Parasailing

DHOOPGARH

This is the highest point in Pachmarhi at 1,350 m above mean sea level. Here, every evening, visitors assemble to sit on the grassy slopes of this west-facing point. The range of hills beyond is the backdrop of a vast amphitheatre. And it is on this mega-screen that the sun plays out its pre-dusk drama: the spectacle of sunset over the hills of Pachmarhi. For most people this is an unforgettable finale to their visit to this hill station.

For others, however, the most exciting discoveries are the Painted Rock Shelters.

PAINTED ROCK SHELTERS

Long before the British came to Pachmarhi, or Jata Shankar and Mahadeo were discovered by pilgrims, Stone Age man had made his home here. He chose well-protected groups of rocks, generally with deep overhangs, and horizon-spanning views over the surrounding countryside. Here he made his temporary camps, from here he hunted for his food, and in here he painted his wishes and dreams onto the rocks. There are many such places around Pachmarhi and among them is the Manna Deo Rock Painting Site. Visitors should drive on the old Pipariya Road till they reach the Amba Devi Temple. Leave the temple on the right. A little ahead there is a road on the right. This leads to the parking area for the caves. The caves are about a ten-minute trek away, through a fairly open forest, across step-like slabs of rock, to the base of a rising hillock. Keep the hillock to the right, a forested valley to the left. The 'caves' are really rock-shelters: projecting overhangs thrusting out from flat rock-faces. Hunters and their families camped here, thousands of years ago. And, on the surface of the rock behind, they used coloured earths, emulsified with animal fat, and painted the everyday activities of their lives: women collecting water from a stream, fleeing from an attacking tiger. And men hunting, fighting, dancing.

Then perhaps, just perhaps, when you are enthralled with these Stone Age dancers, the wind might bring you the faint accompanying skirl of bagpipes...

Reechgarh

Dhoopgarh

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Glen View

7578252533

gview@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Bar | Parking

Panchkarma | Conference Hall | Gym | Swimming Pool

Discover the colonial elegance of MPT Glen View in Pachmarhi, featuring spacious rooms and antique-themed balconies. Surrounded by lush greenery, our hotel offers a picturesque backdrop, while the garden serves as an ideal venue for events like parties, exhibitions, weddings, and gatherings. For family fun, there's a dedicated children's play center. Immerse yourself in timeless charm and plan your stay at MPT Glen View for an unforgettable experience. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Highlands

7880108558

highland@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Bar | Conference Hall

MPT Highland, which was originally a British-era barracks, has now been transformed into a comfortable accommodation by 'MPT Hotels & Resorts' in Pachmarhi. The interior design blends effortlessly with the surrounding environment while retaining its vintage appeal. Furthermore, it is reasonably priced. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Champak Bungalow,

7880108561

champak@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Bar | Parking

Conference Hall | Gym | Swimming Pool

The MPT Champak Bungalow showcases the classic architecture of the British era and is located in the peaceful vicinity of Pachmarhi Lake. This historic accommodation is bound to captivate you with its charming atmosphere, recreational activities, and exceptional elegance. Additionally, MPT Champak Bungalow is among the limited number of resorts in Pachmarhi that offer a swimming pool. What people love the most about this property is its great location and hospitality. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Rock End Manor

7880108566

rem@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

Undoubtedly one of the finest establishments of MPT Hotels & Resorts, this charming boutique hotel has been created from a British bungalow perched atop a scenic hill. There is no shortage of features to appreciate at this inviting retreat - be it the breathtaking vistas, the lovely balconies, or the unmatched service - all of which combine to make MPT Rock End Manor a true gem of the Satpura region. What people love the most about this property is its great location and hospitality. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Nilamber Cottages

7880108566
pachmarhi@mp.gov.in

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Swimming Pool

MPT Nilamber Cottages is an ideal retreat for those who seeks some time by themselves - in serenity, amidst pristine nature. This recently renovated property now houses a swimming pool which offers a serene view of the valley. A home away from home, this is a perfect hotel for couples and families alike which not only offers tastefully done rooms but also lipsmacking dishes. What people love the most about this property is its great location and hospitality. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Karnikar Bungalow

7578292286
karnikar@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

An ideal retreat located in Pachmarhi for those who seeks some time by themselves - in serenity, amidst pristine nature. A home away from home, MPT Karnikar Bungalow of 'MPT Hotels & Resorts' is perfect for couples and families alike. The restaurant is present in the nearby MPT property (Approx. 100 mts.). NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Club View

7578252247

clubview@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant

MPT Club View in Pachmarhi is a colonial architecture, spacious rooms and balconies carry an old world charm. The lush green surrounding adds to the picturesque landscape. The lawn/ garden provides you an apt venue for parties, exhibitions, marriages and get togethers. There is a Children Play Center as well to make your kids happy. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Accommodation in Pachmarhi

MPT Amaltas

7578252098

amaltas@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Conference Hall

A stunning property nestled in the serene hills of Pachmarhi, surrounded by lush greenery and breathtaking views. Operated entirely by women staff, MPT Amaltas offers a calm and welcoming environment that will make you want to return. Known for its unmatched hospitality and comfort, this pure vegetarian property is especially famous in Pachmarhi for its delicious South Indian cuisine.
Note:Pets are not allowed on the property.

MPT Satpura Retreat

7880108555

satpura@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Restaurant | Parking

MPT Satpura Retreat is an erstwhile British Bungalow, now turned into a heritage hotel. The sprawling garden, spacious verandahs and the slanting roofs are some of the features of its old architecture. The sprawling garden offers a welcoming venue for weddings, exhibitions and parties. Times seems to re-wind once you are here. This hotel is known for its first class service, quality food and friendly staff who make the guests feel at home. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

MPT Devdaru Bungalow

7578252249

devdaru@mpstdc.com

Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant

An ideal retreat for those who seeks some time by themselves - in serenity, amidst pristine nature. A home away from home, MPT Devdaru in Pachmarhi is perfect for couples and families alike. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

A beautifully inlaid Dome crowns the Chhatri of Madhav Rao

Shivpuri

Hunting was the original Sport of Kings and they sported not wisely, but too well in Shivpuri.

The great Mughal Emperor Akbar, reputedly caught a large herd of elephants in the forests of Shivpuri in the 16th century. Since elephants don't like the dry deciduous forests that now dominate in the area, the jungles of Shivpuri must have been much denser five hundred years ago. Later, in the 1800s, after the Scindias became the ruling dynasty of Gwalior state, they declared that a significant part of the present 355 sq km Madhav National Park was their private hunting preserve. Sir Madhao Rao Scindia built a dam across the

Crocodile at Sakhya Sagar Lake

A CASTLE FOR A KING'S NIGHT

The forlorn George Castle

In 1911, the King Emperor of India, His Majesty George V, decided to visit his Indian subjects. Long before he set sail, however, his proposed visit was announced. This caused a great flurry among the Rul- ing Princes who vied with each other to host their Lord.

The Maharaja of Gwalior was particularly delighted. His Majesty had cho- sen Shivpuri for a day of tiger shooting. The Maharaja decided to steal a march over his fellow Princes. Not for him the usual jungle camp with huge tents, crystal and silver on the tables, and enormous riding elephants. He would go one better. And so orders were placed in England and Europe for curtains, furniture, floor tiles and the ultimate in luxury ceramic loos. While all this was being brought in by steamship, local archi- tects and artisans chipped and carved, cut, assembled and began to build a turreted, stone, Tudor castle in the heart of the jungle. And it was all for the visit of His Majesty, the King Emperor, for one day.

But when the long awaited day arrived, His Majesty was shown a tiger on the way to Shivpuri. He shot it. And then decided that he wouldn't spend the night in the castle, after all! George Castle still stands, crum- bling slowly in the Shivpuri sun.

Manihar River creating the Madhav and the Sakhya Sagar Lakes. This brought considerable relief to this otherwise dry area. An increase in the grasslands and forest cover led to a burgeoning of herds of herbivores and this, in turn, gave a boost to its tiger population. Shivpuri had acquired such a reputation for its tigers that when Britain's George V decided to visit India, in 1911, his itinerary included a day of tiger shooting in the forests of Shivpuri (See Box - A Castle for a King's Night). Five years later, in 1916, the Viceroy of India, shot eight tigers in Shivpuri in a single day!

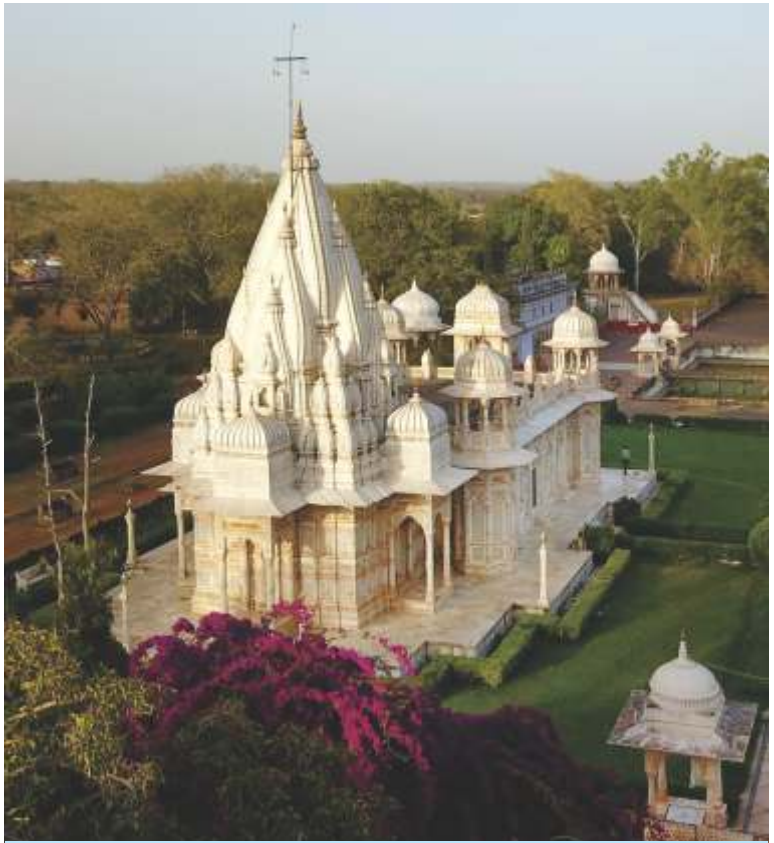
Even with such massacres, the fact that the park was protected for much of the year, restricting hunting to His Highness and his guests, gave wild animals time to recover and multiply. But though an Indian Prince could enforce his exclusive right to hunt in his park; democratic India does not recognise such rights. In 1948 the princes lost their powers and most of their properties when

Mother & Baby Deer in Madhav National Park

their states were merged with the Indian Union. From that year till the former hunting preserve became the Madhav National Park in 1958, it was fairly easy for anyone with a gun to shoot animals in the former hunting preserve. Many professional and amateur hunters took advantage of it. Rich foreigners, armed with high-powered repeating rifles, paid huge amounts for shikar trips in which their trophies would be guaranteed so they could hang the heads of their slaughtered animals in their homes. They decimated whatever wildlife had been left by the guests of the Princes. Then there was human pressure on the land. Farmers and herdsmen in the villages around started encroaching on forest land, felling trees for timber, firewood and fields, driving their destructive herds of cattle, sheep and goats to graze on the grass and young leaves. A forest can be wiped out by human activities in ten years. The forests and wildlife of Shivpuri suffered badly.

Today, there are no tigers living free in the Madhav National Park. Nevertheless, the Park does offer a very pleasant experience to those who want to get away from the frenzy of city living. Since it's a National Park, visitors have to pay an entry fee, engage the services of an offi- cial guide, and use a petrol-driven vehicle. Your best chance of seeing wildlife is on the grass- lands near the lakes. Here you're likely to meet spotted deer, sambar and wild-boar. On the lakes look for winter migrants like demoiselle cranes, spot-bill ducks, spoonbills, shovellers and bar-headed geese. There are also marsh crocodiles in the water, and visitors can hire a boat for closer views of these giant reptiles. During rounds of the forest, nilgai, chinkara and chowsingha sightings could be had. Packs of wild dogs also appear occasionally but one would have to be very lucky to spot the lesser carnivores like jungle cats, wolves, jackals, hyenas and foxes. Leopards are very wary and the chances of seeing one are remote. There are also 227 recorded species of birds.

Outside the Park are the very elegant Chhatris.



The Scindia Chhatris in Shivpuri have been carved exquisitely

CHHATRIS

The grounds in which these two cenotaphs stand are extensive. In the middle is a large, square tank with a walkway leading to an island pavilion in which a statue of a Nandi bull, the vehicle of Lord Siva, has been installed. Around the tank are beautiful iron benches in the ornate designs favoured by Victorian architects.

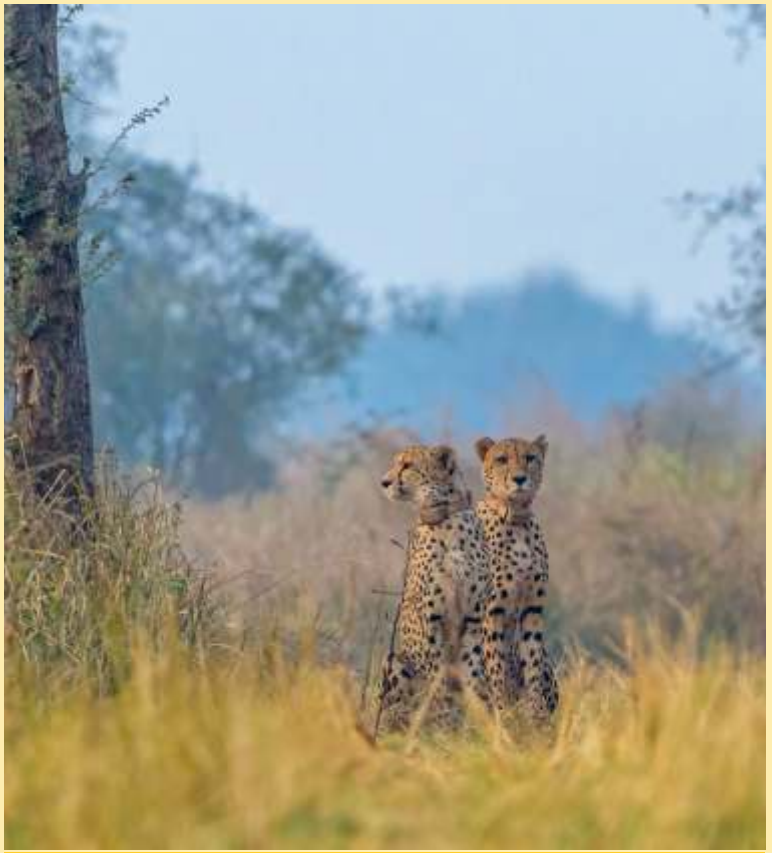
To the left of the entrance is a sandstone chhatri, beautifully carved. Within it is a large congregational hall normally filled with devotees for the evening aarti worship with oil lamps and chants. Beyond the hall is another room with a large statue of Jijabai, the wife of the former ruler Jayaji Rao: his portrait stands to the left of the statue. There are also other portraits of the former rulers of Gwalior State.

On the other side of the tank, from this chhatri, is the white marble cenotaph of Madho Rao. This beautiful memorial is embellished in the pietre commesse style with semi-precious stones inlaid in marble representing flowers etc. Inside, the hall is opulent with chandeliers. Beyond that is another room with a Nandi and a Shivling. And still beyond this shrine is a seated statue of Maharaja Madho Rao. Here, too, there is an aarti in the evenings: well worth attending.

The Chhatri of Jijabai

EXPLORER'S MADHYA PRADESH

OUT OF SHIVPURI



Cheetah in the Jungle of Kuno

KUNO NATIONAL PARK

Located about 70 km from Shivpuri, Kuno offers an exceptional wildlife experience with its diverse flora and fauna. Known for the reintroduction of Cheetahs in India, the park is a haven for nature lovers and bird watchers, featuring unique landscapes and abundant wildlife.

SURWAYA

21 km away, Surwaya is noteworthy for the remains of a fort, three Hindu temples, a monastery and a step-well. The charming gadi has recently been painstakingly restored inside.

NARWAR

41 km away, Narwar is the one-time capital of Raja Nal of Naisadha, and his consort Damayanti. It is remarkable for its medieval fortress atop a hill.

CHANDERI

127 km away, Chanderi has some of the finest examples of Bundela Rajput and Malwa Sultanate architecture. A Mughal fort dominates the skyline of this lovely old town, which is famed for its brocades and muslins today.

SHESHAI

Sun temple of Pratihar Period (8-9 th century AD)

Garhi of Surwaya

Accommodation in Shivpuri

MPT Tourist Village

7492223760

tvshivpuri@mpstdc.com

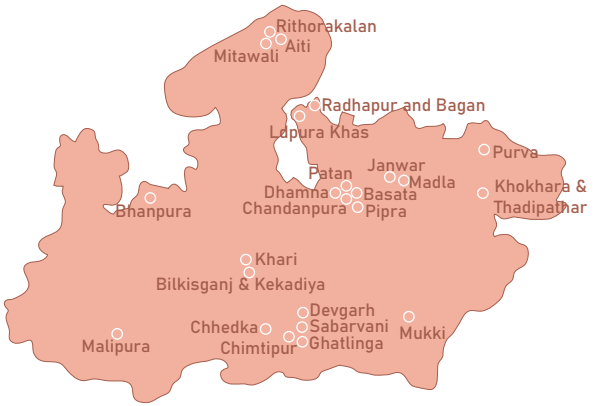
Facilities

AC Rooms | Parking | Restaurant | Bar | Parking | Wifi

Gym | Conference Hall | Swimming Pool

MPT Tourist Village, Shivpuri is wrapped in natural beauty and vibrant colours, characteristic Shivpuri. The whites of marbles and pinks of bougainvillea, will make you come back to stay with us again. The exquisitely designed rooms and Conference hall, the personalized attention shall make your experience an unforgettable one. ISO 9001:2015 QMS Certified. NOTE: Pets are not allowed on the property.

Rural Tourism



Madhya Pradesh is a state rich in cultural and natural resources. State's maximum population still resides in its villages; hence it's a great opportunity to promote Rural Tourism in the state. Rural Tourism is a niche market which develops a strong sense of emotion between both, the community members and tourists, so as to preserve and promote the local culture and heritage.

Madhya Pradesh has divided into six major cultural experience regions viz. Baghelkhand, Bundelkhand Chambal, Malwa, Nimad and Mahakaushal due to diverse cultural and geographical features; where housing configuration includes types of local food and procedure worn, dialect, customs, traditions, songs, musical instruments, choreography, painting, jewellery, decoration, methods of preservation of grain and food, local means of transport, local sports, etc.

Through rural tourism and excursions, the "culture-based" experience of rural lifestyle, culture, simple living with pollution free clean air and greenery in rural areas near the state tourist places will be enjoyed by the tourists.

Madhya Pradesh Tourism Board implements its Rural Tourism Project in 100 villages. The project is devised to give the tourist, the most authentic and ground breaking rural experience through several Rural activities.

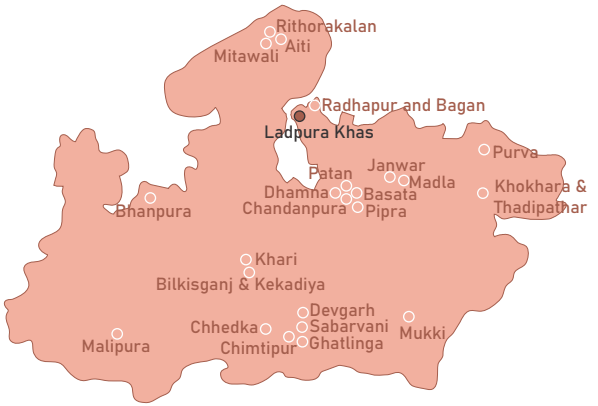
The main objectives of developing rural tourism and excursions are as follows: -

- To increase the number of tourists by establishing cultural experience, sustainable responsible tourism, tourism in Madhya Pradesh.
- Improving economic and living standard.
- Identifying the people associated with handicraft and other ancient arts in different villages of the state and enhancing their art.

COMPONENTS: The Major Components of Rural Tourism are:

1. Local Excursion
2. Local Culture
3. Convenient Stay at village
4. Art & Craft Promotion:
5. Local Cuisine
6. Skilling, Certification and Employment for youth.

Ladpura Khas



Ladpura Khas, situated 8 km from Orchha in the Niwari district, holds the distinction of being the first Rural Tourism Village under the Responsible Tourism Mission of the Madhya Pradesh Tourism Board. Nestled in the heart of the Bundelkhand cultural zone, Ladpura Khas provides a unique opportunity for guests to immerse themselves in the exquisite Bundeli culture and traditions.

Surrounded by captivating landscapes, rolling hills, lush agriculture fields, and rural life, Ladpura Khas offers unmatched views of nature. The village's stay experience is not only cozy and comfortable but also a genuine reflection of community life. Homestays, constructed in vernacular architecture and adorned with hand-made wall paintings, showcase the authentic charm of Ladpura Khas. The warm hospitality of the local tribal community adds to the cultural richness, ensuring that tourists receive an enriched experience.

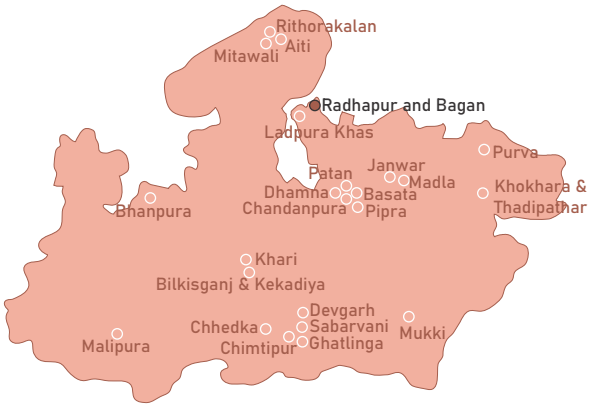
AWARD : Reka Kushwaha owner of REKHA KAMLA homestay grabbed MAWE SHINE AWARD 2024 organized by MAWE (Madhya Pradesh Association of Women Entrepreneurs), also

Ladpura Khas is selected under the Rural Tourism Project by the Ministry of Government of India, as the Best Tourism Village Award 2024 in the Responsible Tourism category.

HOMESTAYS IN LADPURA KHAS

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Hill View Home Stay	Uma Sharma	7999744711
2	The Mahua Home Stay	Kamla Sharma	7987970692
3	Madhav Home Stay	Aneeta Patel	7770831159
4	Green Hill View	Ritu Kushwaha	8463023466
5	Top Hill View	Maya Kushwaha	8463023466
6	Madhav Home Stay	Aneeta Patel	7770831159
7	Green Hill View	Ritu Kushwaha	8463023466
8	Top Hill View	Maya Kushwaha	8463023466

Radhapur and Bagan



Radhapur and Bagan are twin villages located in Niwari district, Madhya Pradesh. According to local elders, Radhapur was once part of Bagan until Brahmin Radhalal ji built his house about 1 km away, leading to the creation of a new village named after him. Surrounded by picturesque hills and lush rural landscapes, Radhapur boasts serene natural beauty, with parts of the village bordered by a rivulet and Chandela Pond (Ladpura Khas).

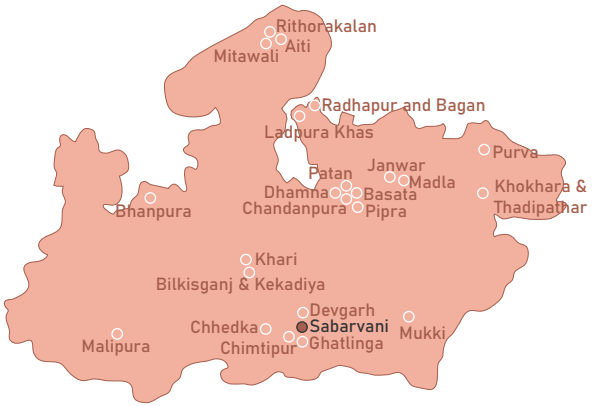
These villages, located in the Bundelkhand region, offer visitors a unique cultural and traditional experience, showcasing rural life, local art, and crafts. Rural homestays in the area provide guests with a warm Bundelkhandi hospitality experience, featuring open brick architecture, hand-painted walls, and views of vibrant agricultural fields. Visitors can also enjoy the charm of traditional swings, unique Machan structures, and breathtaking sunrises.

Activities include village walks, milking cows, crop harvesting, cooking on wood or mud stoves, and cycling along rugged paths. Guests can also participate in traditional games and work on handmade flour mills. The local cuisine features dishes like Maleeda, Maheri, and Gujia, while the region is known for its traditional music and dance, such as Moniya and Bhajan Mandali, celebrating local deities and festivals. Local crafts are typically created from natural materials for everyday use.

HOMESTAYS IN RADHAPUR & BAGAN

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Kamala Home Stay	Kamla Kushwaha	7985168811
2	Priti Green Home Stay	Mrs. Priti Ghoshi	9452118822
3	Sheetla Green Home Stay	Mrs. Vandana Sharma	8840177568
4	Nature View	Bina	8957453744
5	Green View	Shilpi Rathore	8957453744
6	Sona Ka Ghar	Sona kushwaha	7745921557
7	Palash View	Geeta	7985168811
8	Gulmohar View	Kavita kushwaha	6392071364
9	Pinki's Homestay	Pinki Yadav	8313562596
10	Poonam Homestay	Poonam Yadav	8318331294
11	Betwa View	Kranti Kushwaha	8840974419

Sabarvani



Sabarvani village, nestled in Tamia tehsil of Chhindwara district, Madhya Pradesh, spans 1958.55 hectares with a population of 712, reflecting the rich Gond tribal culture. Embraced by Satpura National Park's buffer zone, the village boasts a serene environment, abundant bird species, and captivating landscapes. Mahakaushal's cultural heaven, Sabarvani, houses the Gond tribe in traditional mud houses, offering a cool refuge in summers and warmth in winters.

The village welcomes visitors with check-in in homestays, providing an authentic rural experience. The mornings unfold with picturesque farmlands, resonating bird melodies, and the allure of surrounding mountains. Stay experiences blend comfort with traditional charm, revealing paradisiacal sunrises, fresh air, and wildlife encounters.

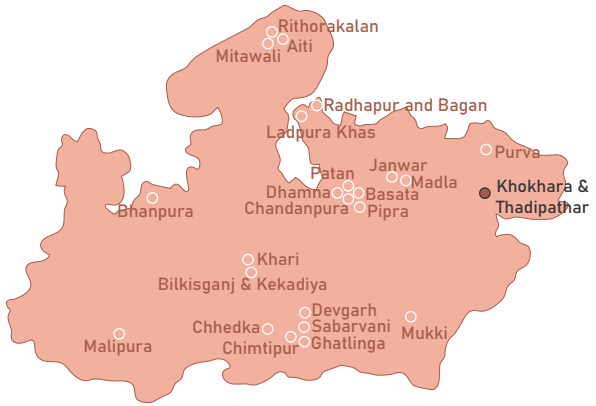
Award - Sabarvani is selected under Best Tourism Village,2024 by Ministry of Tourism, Government of India in the Responsible Tourism category.

Selected by ICRT, India Awards 2023 for Nature Positive Tourism, Ones to Watch Category.

HOMESTAYS IN SABARVANI

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Sumans Courtyard	Suman Bhorwanshi	7999040187
2	Vedika Hills View Homestay	Neeta Yaduwanshi	9479756395
3	Sharda Homestay	Anju Yaduwanshi	6263220455
4	Jungle Aashiyana	Sanchita Dhar	9407536603

Khokhara & Thadipathar



Khokhara village, nestled in Sidhi district, is surrounded by lush green forests, mountains, and deep caves, inspiring its name. Khokhara village is situated in the lush green forest. It is surrounded by mountains and caves and that is the reason the name of the village is 'Khokhara' which means surrounded by deep caves. The big caves surrounding the villages with a dam nearby and the mountains in the periphery of the village are a gift of nature for the village. The periphery is covered with the forest and two rivers are flowing near it, which shows the proper conservation management of natural resources. The Gond and Baiga tribes in Khokhara excel in identifying and using medicinal plants, offering tourists an immersive experience in natural and adventure activities like fishing, boating, and waterfall picnics.

The village's sustainable eco-friendly houses, crafted from locally available raw materials, feature organic paints, contributing to a harmonious environment. Embracing the Rural Tourism concept, Khokhara provides convenient stays managed by women, local excursions, authentic cuisines, and a showcase of unique arts and crafts, including caps made from peacock feathers and bamboo.

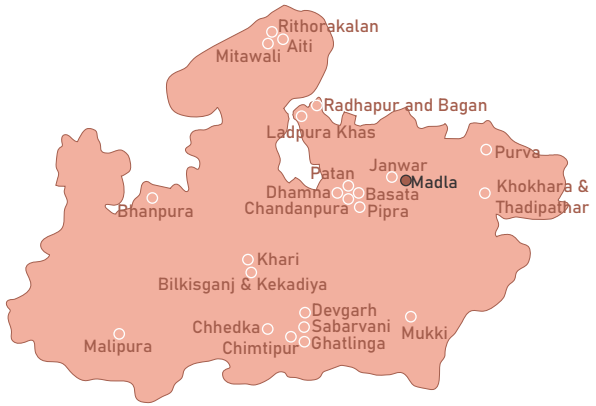
Similarly, in Thadipathar village, also in Sidhi district, the Saal forest, fresh air, organic food, and rural tribal lifestyle make it an extraordinary destination especially for forest bathing. The Gond and Baiga tribes here specialize in identifying and using medicinal plants. The village exemplifies sustainable living, with a focus on nature worship, organic clothing, and natural food consumption. The regular market offers forest-produced items like lamps and musical instruments, completing the immersive experience.

Award – Khokhara grabbed Bronze, Best Tourism Village Competition organised by MOT, GOI. 2023

HOMESTAYS IN SABARVANI

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Daiyabai Homestay (Sal tree)	Girdhan singh	7879222933
2	Gudiya Homestay (Mahua)	Ram Kumar Singh	9516246902
3	Kaushilya Homestay (Bamboo)	Jagdish Singh	9407070820
4	Keshwati Homestay	Kalyan Singh	7489745356
5	Eucalyptus House	Balraj Singh	7489745356
6	Gauva Homestay	Rajkumari Saket	9516246902

Madla



Madla, nestled in the Panna district of Madhya Pradesh, serves as a gateway to the captivating Panna Tiger Reserve, drawing in numerous tourists annually with its exotic wildlife and breathtaking landscapes. Positioned against the backdrop of the Vindhya Hills, Madla offers visitors a visually soothing panorama that complements the adrenaline-pumping encounters with diverse wildlife within the forest. As the entry point to the Panna Tiger Reserve, Madla provides an unparalleled opportunity for wildlife enthusiasts to immerse themselves in the natural beauty and diverse ecosystems of the region. The village is also situated along the banks of the Karnavati or Ken River, offering a spiritual retreat amidst serene surroundings. Madla's significance extends beyond its natural wonders; it is a part of the Bundelkhand cultural zone, where visitors can immerse themselves in the unique Bundelkhandi traditions and culture.

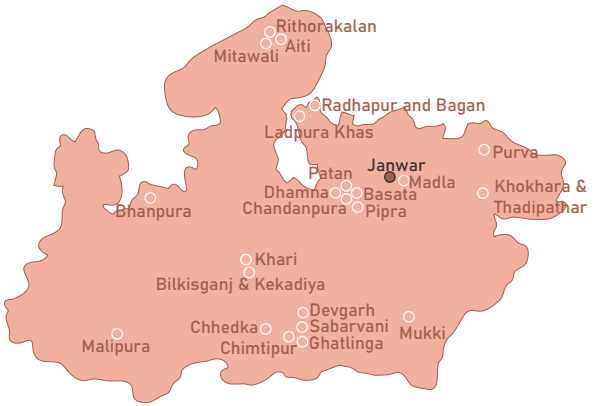
Award : – Grabbed Gold, Best Tourism Village Competition organised by MOT, GOI. 2023, also

UNWTO, Best Tourism Village upgrade programme 2023 Rural Tourism also, Silver in Local Sourcing Craft and Food ICRT, INDIA, 2023

HOMESTAYS IN MADLA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Rama Bai Homestay	Balbeer Singh	9893676164
2	Aryan Camp Homestay	Mr. Jagdish Prasad Tiwari	9589307856
3	Sparrow Homestay	Parwati Ahirwar	9131211892
4	Sadhna Sadan Homestay	Ghanshyam Tiwari	7999772537
5	Krishna Homestay	Piyush Kumar Sharma	9179324060
6	Shanti Sadan Home Stay	Mamta Soni	9691598092
7	Vindhya Van Mud House	Dhaniram Ahirwar	9755114121

Janwar



Nestled in the Panna district of Madhya Pradesh, Janwar unfolds as a serene gem in the heart of the Bundelkhand region. Encompassing a total geographical area of 772.4 hectares, the village is a bucolic heaven surrounded by a tropical dry deciduous forest adorned with teak, Indian laurel (Saaj), mango, mahua, and khair trees, some of which are utilized for medicinal purposes.

Janwar offers an enriched stay experience in the beautiful rural homestays surrounded by majestic Vindhya Hills and Wildlife. Janwar village is a part of the Akola Buffer Zone of Panna National Park which attracts a variety of birds in and around the village, the major species one can see are – Rufous Woodpecker, Indian Scimitar Babbler, Golden-fronted leafbird, Indian Paradise flycatcher, Grey Francolin, Black-winged kite, Indian Grey Hornbill, etc. Being part of nature in the beautiful rural paradise fills the soul of tourists and helps them build a real connection.

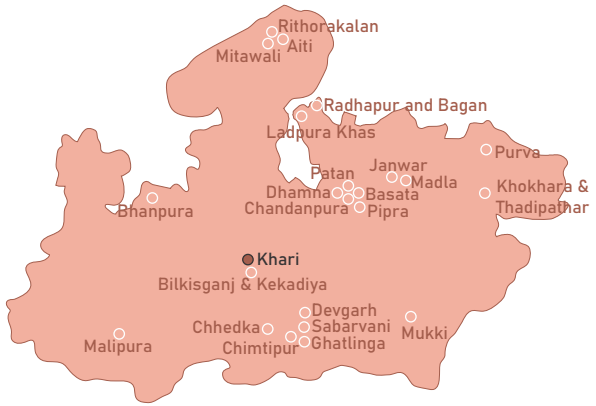
The village is known for its beautiful multilayer kitchen gardens and Guava orchids, which add freshness, balance the ecology.

In Janwar, visitors are treated to a multifaceted experience that encapsulates the essence of rural life, artistic expression, and the unspoiled beauty of nature. Remarkably, Janwar has earned recognition as the home of internationally acclaimed skateboarders who have showcased their talent worldwide and inspired the local community to create a new source of income. This harmonious blend of tradition, nature, and contemporary pursuits makes Janwar an enchanting destination where visitors can revel in the tranquility of rural life and witness the flourishing beauty of the Bundelkhand region.

HOMESTAYS IN MADLA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Farmyard Homestay	Bimlesh Singh	9406904110
2	Naturs Nest Homestay	Mangal Singh Yadav	6263595591
3	Haldu Tree	Gulab Singh Yadav	7828237358

Khari



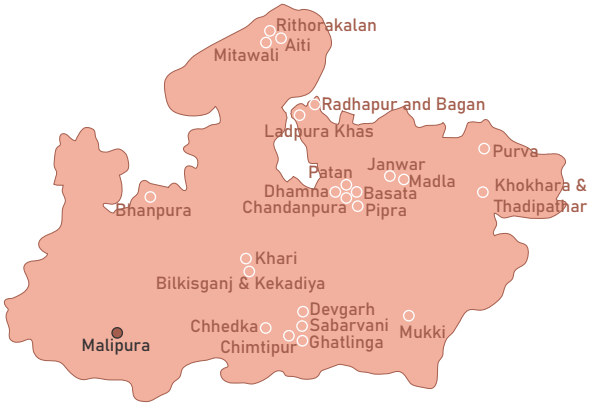
Nestled in Sehore district, Kahri Village stands as a cultural mosaic, embracing the Gond, Bhil, and Bhilala Tribes alongside other castes. The village offers a unique blend of traditions and activities for visitors to immerse themselves in.

At Kahri, the hilly terrain of Mata Mahal provides a breathtaking backdrop for witnessing a beautiful sunrise, complemented by rock shelters and paintings that add to the cultural richness. Kahri Village caters to a diverse audience, making it ideal for both youth and families. Adventure seekers can partake in activities like trekking, bird watching, and nature walks, while those seeking leisure and fun can engage in team-building activities organized by the vibrant community. The village, with its cultural richness and diverse activities, offers a memorable and immersive experience for all who visit.

HOMESTAYS IN KHARI

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Girija Homestay	Girija Maran	9977992833
2	Koyal Home Stay	Prarthna Gour	9617909856
3	Radhe Radhe Home Stay	Krishna Gour	9977992618
4	Twins Villa View Home Stay	Maya Bai	9753327663

Malipura



Nestled just 5 km from Mandu, Malipura is an enchanting tribal village, a hidden gem adorned with serene landscapes and captivating natural beauty. The village exudes a sense of tranquility, with its calm atmosphere, astounding vistas, and pristine surroundings. Surrounded by mountains and lush forests, Malipura's captivating charm is enhanced by a central lake, now a sought-after location for pre-wedding photoshoots.

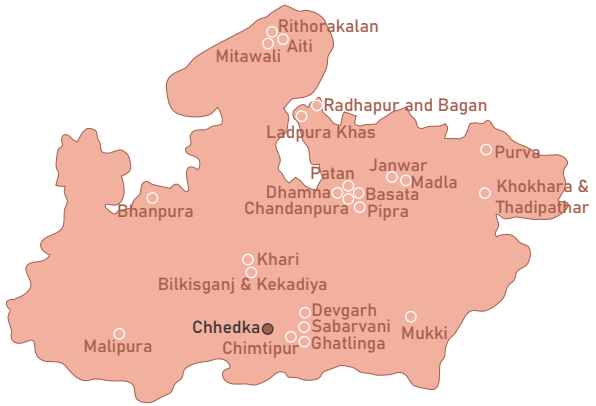
Visiting Malipura offers an extraordinary opportunity to engage with local communities, providing support and immersing oneself in the authentic local culture. The warm hospitality of the villagers adds to the experience, as they eagerly welcome visitors. Malipura provides a unique chance to witness traditional practices and forge connections with local families, offering a glimpse into their rich heritage.

In Malipura, every step unfolds the legacy of Indian tribal traditions deeply ingrained in the villagers' way of life. The experience goes beyond the scenic beauty, allowing visitors to appreciate the cultural richness, and fostering a deeper understanding of the local lifestyle. This hidden treasure promises a memorable journey, where mountains, lakes, and forests harmonize with the welcoming spirit of the villagers, creating an immersive and unforgettable exploration.

HOMESTAYS IN MALIPURA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Dinesh Katare	Dinesh Katare	9669327496

Chhedka

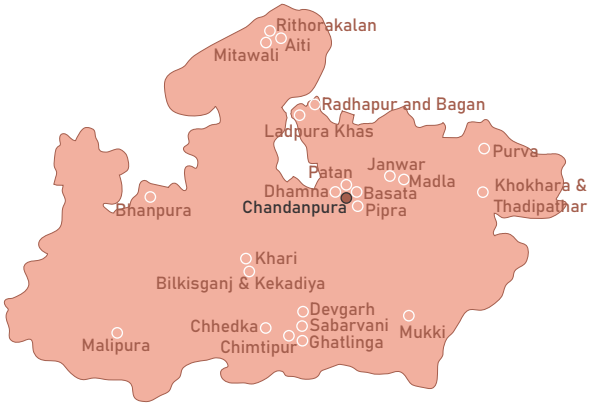


Chhedka village, nestled on the fringes of Satpura National Park, stands as a testament to the rich heritage and tradition of the Gond community, with its roots tracing back around 300 years. It is located in district Narmadapuram of Madhya Pradesh. This historic tribal settlement offers a glimpse into a bygone era, preserving the essence of its cultural legacy. The village exudes warmth and hospitality, inviting visitors to immerse themselves in its vibrant tapestry of customs and rituals.

Daily life in Chhedka is a bustling affair, with the community orchestrating a myriad of activities to engage visitors. Guided village walks and nature trails offer a deeper understanding of the local ecosystem, revealing the intricate connection between the community and its natural surroundings.

To enhance the rural tourism experience, Chhedka village offers seven charming rural homestays, providing an authentic immersion into the local way of life. These homestays serve as portals to the heart of the community, fostering meaningful interactions and cultural exchange between guests and hosts. In essence, Chhedka village is a beacon of cultural preservation and sustainable tourism, offering visitors an unforgettable journey into the heart of Gond heritage and tradition.

Chandanpura

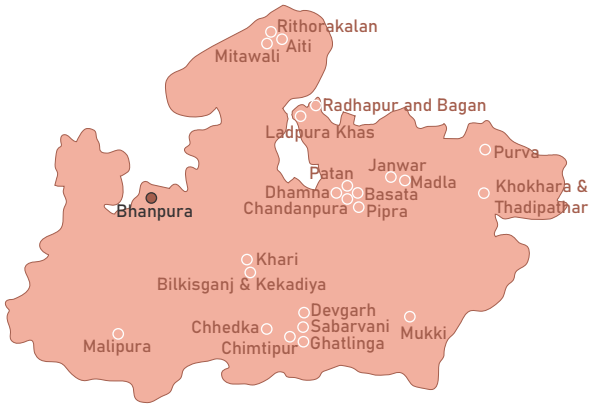


Chandanpura, a tranquil village in Chhatarpur district, Madhya Pradesh, envelops visitors in the serene beauty of teak forests, water bodies, and lush fields. Home to the Sora tribe, the village thrives on agriculture and animal husbandry, offering a peaceful escape.

As part of the Bundelkhand cultural zone, Chandanpura unfolds the rich culture of the Sora tribe through traditions, customs, dance, music, and cuisine. Activities in Chandanpura include sunrise marvels, bird-watching, farming engagements, bullock cart rides, and various village activities. Delight in local cuisine with specialties like Guiyan, Thadula, Khurma Batiya, Dubri, and Gujiya.

Craftsmanship in Chandanpura focuses on daily-use items like bamboo utensils and clay products. Proximity to sites like Bandriya Hill, Badal Mahal Fort, Sheetal Gadi, Ghogra Waterfall, Chandi Mata Temple, and Bheem Kund adds to the village's allure. Chandanpura beckons visitors to embrace its unexplored wildlife and historical wonders in a sublime rural setting.

Bhanpura



Bhanpura is nestled within the hinterlands of Agar district in Madhya Pradesh. This quaint village, predominantly inhabited by the Malvi community, boasts a vibrant tapestry of cultural traditions. Festivals, fairs, and social gatherings punctuate the village calendar, offering visitors an immersive experience of the rich heritage of the region.

Agricultural tourism thrives in Bhanpura, where locals showcase best practices such as orange orchards, nutrition gardens, and water security initiatives. Agriculture, animal husbandry, and organic farming form the backbone of the community's livelihood.

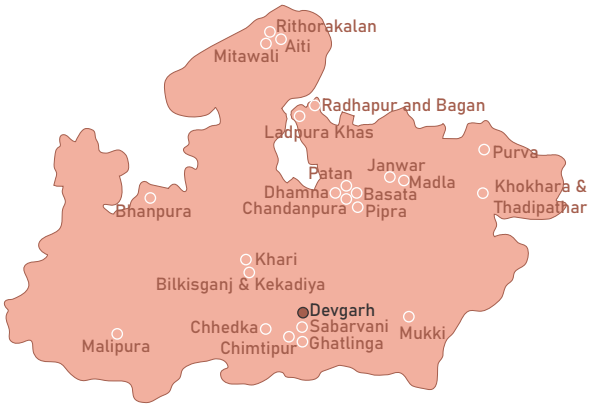
As part of the Malwa cultural zone, Bhanpura presents guests with an authentic glimpse into Malvi culture, traditions, and cuisine. Beyond cultural experiences, the village's surroundings boast stunning heritage sites, unexplored landscapes, and natural wonders.

Community engagement is integral to Bhanpura's ethos, with members actively participating in cultural activities like communal feasts, local entertainment, and folk-art performances. Despite its small size, Bhanpura exudes a profound connection to rural roots, where daily life unfolds amidst the backdrop of women tending to cattle, managing household chores, and contributing to agricultural endeavors.

HOMESTAYS IN BHANPURA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	SHRAVAN GURJAR	Shravan Gurjar	6261917386
2	KAMLA BAI	KAMLA BAI	7999820324
3	Green View	Balu Singh	7389858381
4	Padam Homestay	Gordhan Singh	9752838968
5	Babli Bai Homestay	Rahul Gurjar	9685656644
6	Lila Bai homestay	Narayan Thakur	7389224413

Devgarh



Devgarh is nestled in Chhindwara district, Madhya Pradesh, and mainly comprises the Gond tribe. The village, part of the Mahakoshal cultural zone, offers an authentic rural experience amid lush forests and hills. Notably, the Deogarh Fort, a 16th-century Gond tribal creation, lies just 46 km away, drawing tourists with its archaeological significance and rain-harvesting step-wells.

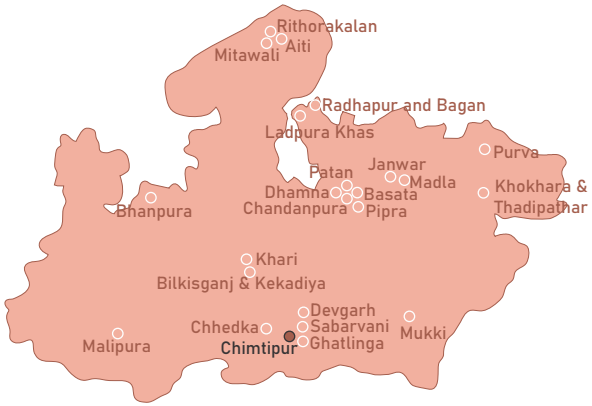
The village provides a stay in traditional architecture surrounded by farmland and teak forests.

The culinary delights of Makke ki Roti, Jawar Roti, Kutki ka Bhatt, Kaddu ki Kheer, Aam ki Chutney, and Moongfali ki Chutney showcase the vibrant local cuisine. The village pulsates with folk dance (Shaila Nritya) and music (Gondi Geet), celebrated during festivals like Chaitra Purnima Fair and Durga Puja. Local crafts include woodcraft, mud-made articles, and Chhind Mukut.

HOMESTAYS IN DEVGARH

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Divya Joyti Home Stay	Pushpa Chherke	9754814088
2	Deshmukh Home Stay	Ahilya Deshmukh	8435330231

Chimtipur

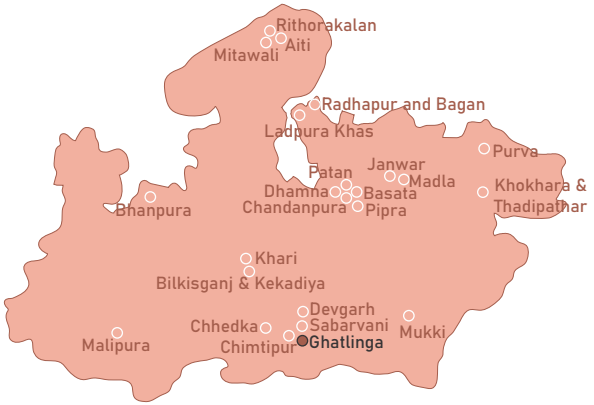


Nestled in the heart of Chhindwara district, Madhya Pradesh, Chimtipur is a serene expanse, locals predominantly engaged in agriculture, forest produce collection, and animal husbandry. The village, part of the Mahakaushal cultural zone, boasts a rich Gond tribal heritage, evident in its customs, art, cuisine, and lifestyle.

Chimtipur offers a tranquil retreat with homestays providing a genuine tribal experience amid the fragrance of burnt wood and mud carvings. The village's immersive activities include wildlife exploration, adventure in the mountains, and a glimpse into rural life along the Doodhi River. Chimtipur beckons visitors to explore its natural, spiritual, and cultural treasures.

Local cuisine brings people together, offering delicacies like Makke ki Peji, Ballar ki Dal, Kutki Rice, Mahua ke Laddoo, and Bhaji–Dhobe. The village resonates with cultural celebrations, featuring Setam Dance, Saila Dance, Karma Dance, Gedi Nritya, Kunjan Toli, Nangada, Nirbhaypur, Jas Mandal, and Gedi Nritya Team, each reflecting the vibrancy of local life.

Ghatlinga

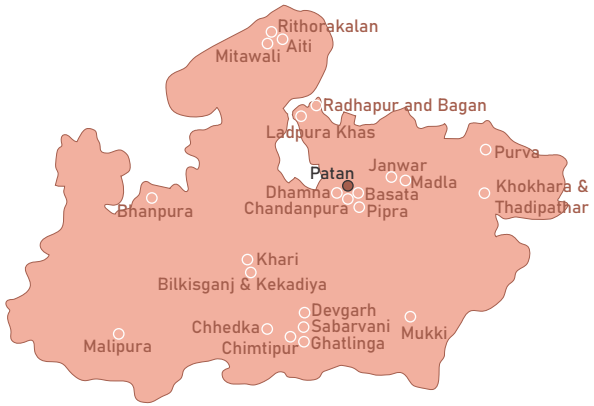


Ghatlinga is situated in the remote landscapes of Chhindwara district, Madhya Pradesh. The locals, primarily engaged in agriculture, forest produce collection, and animal husbandry, belong to the Bhariya tribal community. The village, nestled near the Patalkot territory for the past 250 years, offers a unique cultural experience, with elders donning Dhoti Kurta and females adorning sarees. It's an everyday joy that you can experience in Patalkot. Situated in the Chhindwara district of Madhya Pradesh, Patalkot is 23 km from Tamia. Patalkot-Tamia Valley has so much for its visitors. Patalkot is engulfed with dense forest and is surrounded by ascended granite walls and sandstone rock. It's a fascinating world of natural treasures. Dense and deep, Patalkot looks like a horseshoe when viewed from the top.

Ghatlinga's location in the forest's heart enriches wildlife experiences, offering close encounters with diverse flora and fauna. Satpura Adventure Sports Festival Kareaam Rated viewpoint (50 km)from the village is organized in October. It offers a thrilling experience of adventure activities like parasailing, paragliding, rock climbing, trekking, bird watching, and water sports. Walking on the pugdundee through the narrow mountain path that leads you to a dense mango grove and a small dam also gives a chance for swimming amidst nature. The trail showcases the hidden attractions of Patalkot are Raja Kho and Zingaria Waterfall (ghatlinga) 10 km as well.Dusshera time mela on mountain peak “chandi mai mandir”

The village's culinary offerings, a means of bonding, include regular and festival specialties such as Makke ki Peji & Chapati, Ballar ki Dal, Kutki Rice, and Mahua ke Laddoo. Local entertainment unfolds through traditional dances like Setam Dance, Saila Dance, Karma Dance, and festive fairs like Bidari and Pol aka Mela. Ghatlinga's residents craft beautiful products, including Kashtha Art, small sculptures made from wood or bamboo.

Patan



Bilkisganj in Sehore and Kekadiya in Bhopal District, Madhya Pradesh, offers a transformative journey into rural life, embodying a unique blend of ecotourism and responsible tourism. These villages serve as gateways to a rich cultural tapestry, providing an unforgettable experience that immerses visitors in the traditions of ancient India.

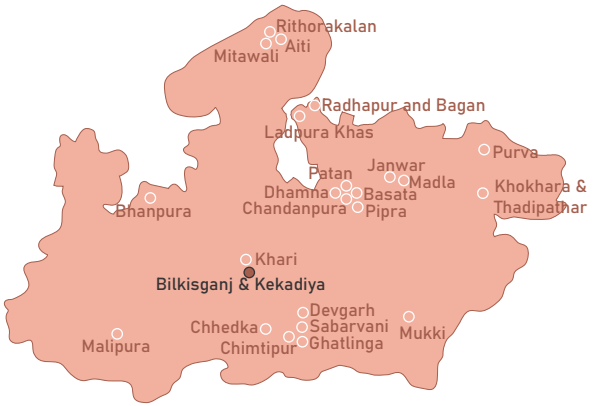
The villages boast stunning landscapes, featuring mountains, lakes, forests, and fertile farms, creating a picturesque backdrop for recreational activities. The warm hospitality of the villagers adds to the charm, as they eagerly welcome visitors into their community.

Exploring Bilkisganj and Kekadiya provides a firsthand experience of traditional practices, allowing guests to connect with local families and witness the authentic rural lifestyle. This variant of tourism not only showcases the natural beauty of the region but also fosters cultural exchange, making it a memorable and enriching experience for those seeking a deeper connection with the roots of India.

HOMESTAYS IN BILKISGANJ & KEKADIYA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Cozy Heaven	Ram Singh Narke	6261958841
2	Basant Home Stay	Pramod Parmar	9713971434

Bilkisganj & Kekadiya



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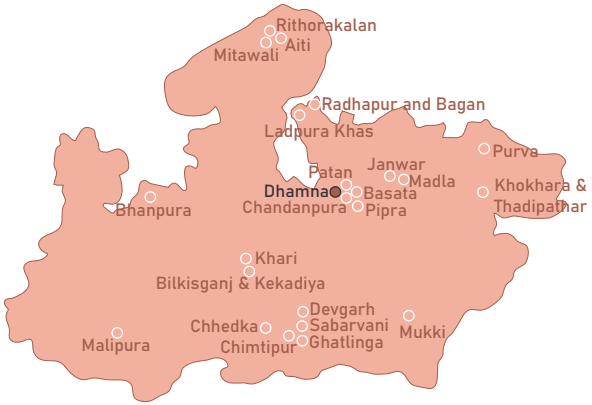
	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Cozy Heaven	Ram Singh Narke	6261958841
2	Basant Home Stay	Pramod Parmar	9713971434

Dhamna



Dhamna village, nestled in the embrace of Chhatarpur district, Madhya Pradesh. Surrounded by hills, forests, and the flowing Ken River, Dhamna is a part of the Bundelkhand cultural zone, showcasing unique traditions. The village boasts a serene environment, and the Shiv temple stands as a spiritual center for the community.

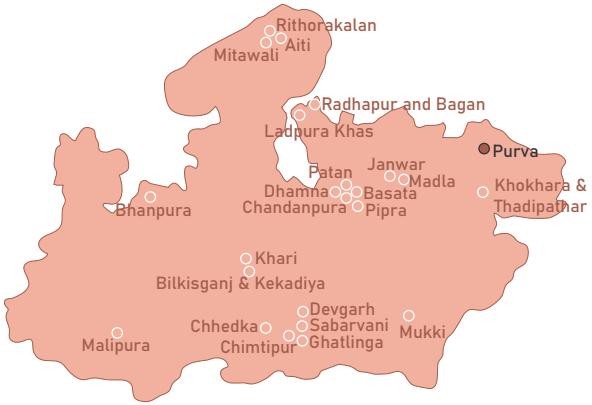
Homestays offer Bundelkhandi hospitality amidst verdant surroundings. Dhamna's cuisine, known for its toothsome delicacies, features Mangodi, Kaitha ki Chutney, and Thadula. The region's traditional dance forms like Moniya, Kartik Parv, Bhajan Mandali, Phaag, and local crafts showcase the vibrant cultural tapestry.

The village is surrounded by various attractions. A Responsible Souvenir Center also promotes rural art and crafts including Terracotta, providing tourists with authentic experiences and unique local products.

HOMESTAYS IN DHAMNA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Maya Homestay	Narayan Das Pathak	7470460997
2	Kamini Homestay	Ravi Pathak	9755266171

Purva



Nestled in the heart of Madhya Pradesh's Rewa district, Purva unfolds as a pastoral heaven, spanning a total geographical area of 223 hectares. Embraced by the unique tribal community, this village becomes a living canvas, showcasing distinct tribal cultures and traditions to its visitors. The primary livelihood of the villagers revolves around agriculture and the sustainable collection of forest produce.

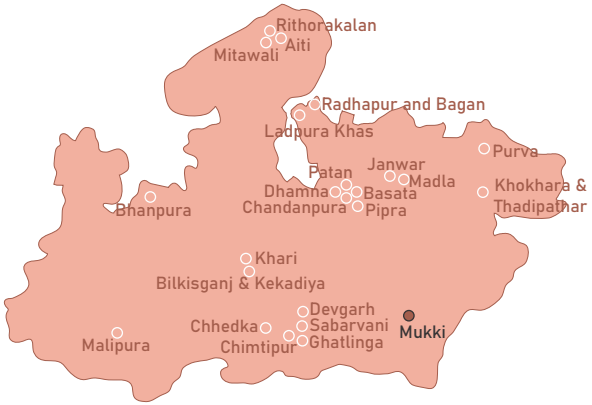
Purva's location is enchanting, surrounded by dense forests that offer glimpses of diverse wildlife, including deer, nilgai, bears, peacocks, leopards, and occasionally even tigers. As part of the Baghelkhand cultural zone, Purva unravels the rich tapestry of Bagheli traditions and customs, providing a truly authentic experience.

The village's allure lies in its exorbitant natural beauty, characterized by lush green fields and a serene ambiance. Surrounded by undulating hills, Purva offers a perfect sanctuary for relaxation, inviting visitors to soak in the tranquil atmosphere. Additionally, the village is blessed with a rich variety of flora and fauna, making it a heaven for nature lovers and enthusiasts alike. Purva stands as a testament to the harmonious coexistence of traditional life and the bountiful natural splendour found in the heart of Madhya Pradesh.

HOMESTAYS IN PURVA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Asha Home Stay	Shyamlal Chaturvedi	9644927068
2	Mahua Home Stay	Brijlal Saket	9669315415
3	Red Field Homestay	Jay Ram Saket	7509357347
4	Green Field Home Stay	Ramashray saket	7999773194

Mukki



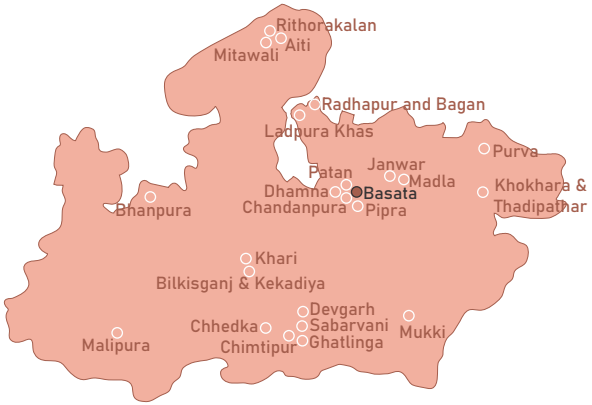
Mukki, nestled in the Balaghat district of Madhya Pradesh, spans an expansive 484.12 hectares of bucolic charm. This unexplored heaven boasts a natural territory that serves as a nestle for diverse bird species, filling the air with melodious tunes and creating a tranquil environment. The captivating landscape features lush green fields, dense forests, and the majestic Satpura mountain valley, providing a perfect retreat for those seeking solace from the urban hustle and bustle.

Beyond its scenic beauty, Mukki is enriched by its tribal population, offering a unique cultural experience. The locals, with their exquisite art, cuisine, and lifestyle, provide a window into the rich tapestry of tribal traditions. Visitors can engage in one-on-one interactions with the indigenous communities, gaining insights into their customs, traditions, and beliefs.

HOMESTAYS IN MUKKI

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Tiger Retreat	Preetam Singh Dhurwey	9301450752
2	Lavnya Homestay	Prem Singh Uikey	8889352074
3	Nest Wood	Butto Bai	8305531754

Basata



Basata village, nestled in Madhya Pradesh's Chhatarpur district, offers a serene rural experience. Residents engaged in agriculture, organic farming, and animal husbandry. As part of the Bundelkhand cultural zone, Basata unfolds Bundelkhand's unique traditions, folk arts, festivals, and culinary delights.

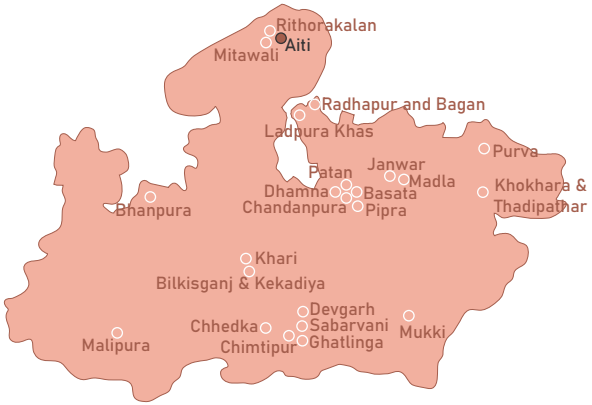
Homestays provide diverse perspectives on village life, offering views of beautiful sunrises, riverbanks, Vindhya Range, and organic farming fields. Engage in various village activities, from boating and fishing on the Ken River to learning organic farming techniques and experiencing horse riding or a bullock cart ride. The festivals bring forth mouth-watering local delicacies like Dubri, Murakka, Sattu, Latta, and Kadhi.

Immerse yourself in Basata's cultural activities, including Rai Dance, Badhai Nritya, and Diwari Dance. The local craft involves creating Mitti ke Bartan and Bans ka Kaam for household use. Basata is well-connected to heritage sites like Ken Ghariyal Sanctuary, Toriya ki Pahadi, Rajgarh Palace, Panna National Park Madla Gate, Bagheshwar Dham, Pandav Falls, Raneh Falls, and the UNESCO World Heritage Site Khajuraho.

HOMESTAYS IN BASATA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Sun Rise Homestay	Surya Narayan Dwivedi	9981813559
2	Riverside	Chatur Singh Parihar	9993995232
3	Uma Shri	Ramcharan Pal	7354490882

Aiti



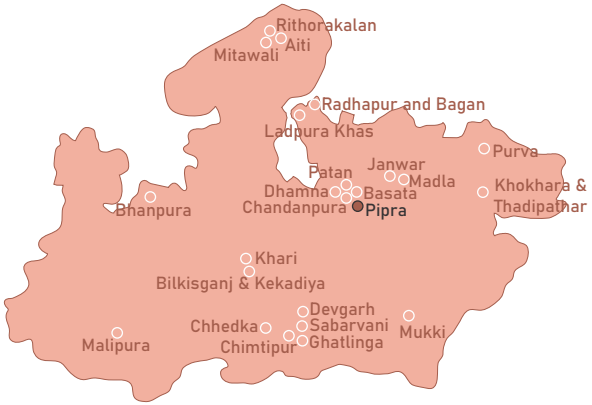
Aiti, nestled in Morena district, Madhya Pradesh, is renowned as the tapobhoomi of Shanideva, featuring the significant Shanichara Hill and Shri Shanichara Temple. Legend has it that Lord Shani fell here, forming a crater, and the iconic Shani Shila in Maharashtra's Sighnapur Temple originated from this hill in the 17th century. The annual Shani Jayanti fair attracts devotees for rituals, holy baths, and a unique tradition of leaving old clothes behind for a fresh start.

Aiti, part of the Chambal cultural zone, blends heritage, spirituality, and agriculture. The village homestays provide an authentic rural experience amidst lush greenery and heritage buildings. Visitors can engage in heritage walks, camping, trekking, and activities like milking cows, organic farming, and fishing. Local cuisine delights with Malpua, Rabri, and savory meals cooked on mud stoves. Folk dances like Languriya and Bhajans, along with crafts like Chickpea Utensils, enrich the cultural experience. Aiti connects to archaeological sites like Padavali Fortress, Bateshwar Group of Temple, and Chausath Yogini Temple.

HOMESTAYS IN AITI

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Kanchan Home Stay	Suneel Kushwah	9131687776

Pipra



Nestled in the Chhatarpur district of Madhya Pradesh. The village is enveloped by dense forests and shares its borders with the renowned Panna National Park, offering glimpses of wildlife.

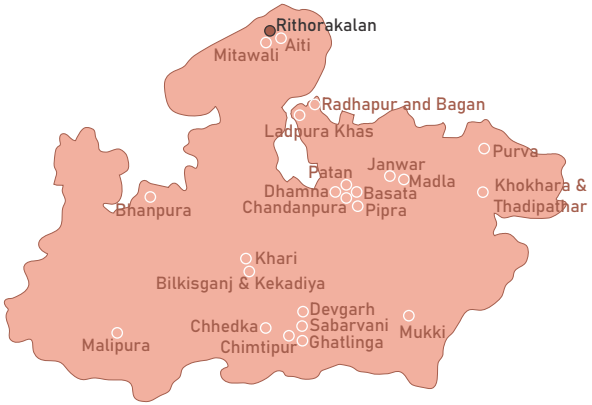
Pipra is a proud contributor to the Bundelkhand cultural zone, preserving its distinctive Bundelkhandi traditions and customs. The village unfolds a rich tapestry of experiences, from vibrant festivals and folk arts to handicrafts and heritage. Encompassing folk music, traditional dance, local festivals, and delectable Bundelkhandi cuisine, Pipra provides a holistic cultural encounter.

Surrounded by tropical dry deciduous forests, adorned with teak, Indian laurel (Saaj), mango, mahua, and khair trees, Pipra's landscape is not only visually enchanting but also serves medicinal purposes. The village, with its captivating views, ancient architecture, fertile farm fields, and exotic wildlife, emerges as an ideal destination for tourists seeking an immersive rural experience in the heart of Madhya Pradesh.

HOMESTAYS IN PIPRA

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Leaf Wood	Rammu Patel	7828168461

Rithorakalan



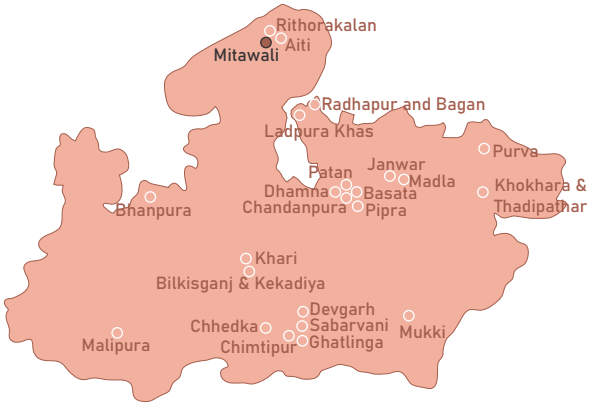
RithauraKalan, situated in Morena district, Madhya Pradesh, embraces religious diversity with an ancient Radha-Krishna temple, a century-old Masjid, and a millennium-old Goddess Kali shrine, exemplifying communal harmony. As part of the Chambal cultural zone, the village exudes heritage, spirituality, and agricultural traditions. Six homestays, such as The Peepal and Saba Homestay, immerse visitors in the daily lives of locals. The village's heartwarming gastronomy, rooted in fresh mustard oil, offers a connection-building experience.

Activities in RithauraKalan encompass observing wood-fired culinary traditions, experiencing the aroma of mud-plastered homes, and relishing sunsets over farmlands. Local artisans craft bamboo and mud products like brooms, baskets, and utensils, providing hands-on learning opportunities. The village hosts vibrant festivals, with folk music styles like Faag Gayan and Maata ki Bhainth adding to the cultural tapestry. Nearby attractions, including Shanideva Temple and Bateshwar Group of Temples, enhance the cultural exploration of this rural gem. RithauraKalan promises a soulful escape, harmonizing tradition, art, and hospitality.

HOMESTAYS IN RITHORAKALAN

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	Peepal Home Stay	Mr. Ummed Singh	9926646431
2	Sneha Homestay	Mr. Lajjaram	8120145083
3	Saba Homestay	Mr. Ishak Kha	8827193184
4	The Vaikuntha Home	Akhilesh Singh Kourav	8770909747

Mitawali



Mitawali, a historically significant village in Morena district, Madhya Pradesh, houses the Chausath Yogini and Ekattarso Mahadeva temples atop a lush green hill. Constructed in the kachchhapaghata style by King Devapala in 1323 CE, the circular design of Mitawali temple is believed to have inspired the Parliament House in New Delhi. The temple served as an educational hub for astrology and mathematics based on sun transit. As part of the Chambal cultural zone, Mitawali is rich in heritage, spirituality, and agricultural traditions, with villagers engaged in farming and animal husbandry.

Offering a captivating rural experience, Mitawali boasts homestays which are fostering community development. Visitors immerse themselves in village life, participating in activities like milking cattle, crop harvesting, and crafting with local women. The village's culinary delights, such as Malpua Kheer and Bajra Roti, enrich the experience. Folk dances like Languriya and Bhajans, along with crafts like Chickpea Utensils, showcase the vibrant local culture. Mitawali's proximity to archaeological sites like Padavali and Bateshwar further enhances its allure, offering a holistic journey through history, culture, and rural life.

HOMESTAYS IN MITAWALI

	Homestay Name	Owner	Contact
1	The Geeta Ummed Homestay	Mr. Ummed Singh	9926646431
2	Suneeta Home Stay	Suneeta Kaurav	9171367539
3	Meera Ki Haweli	Dharmendra Singh	9098750991

Madhya Pradesh

A state steeped in colourful

Fairs & Festivals

Fairs & Festivals

A CONFLUENCE OF CULTURE MADHYA PRADESH

The Heart of Incredible India is known for its rich heritage, culture, tribal art forms, traditional weaving methods, fairs & festivals, and sacred cities.

A one-stop destination for music and heritage lovers, Madhya Pradesh has something to offer to every traveller. Places like Gwalior, nursery of Indian classical music and the oldest Khayal Gharana, attract tourists from all over the globe. The waves of chills flowing down your spine during the Bhasma Aarti in Ujjain, the splendid view of river Narmada during the Gwarighat Aarti, Jabalpur, tribal and folk art practiced with traditional methods, the stories portrayed through Bhil and Gond art pervade the visitors of Madhya Pradesh with emotions.

Few regions in India can match Madhya Pradesh in the sheer diversity of its offerings. The rich cultural heritage, legendary pilgrimage centres, breathtaking scenic beauty, and unparalleled wildlife offerings make it truly unique.

Welcome to the heart of Incredible India.

Khajuraho Dance Festival

Raag Ameer

Classical Music Festival

INDORE

January & March

A three-day music festival, Raag Ameer is organised in the memory of Ustad Amir Khan by Ustad Alauddin Khan Sangeet Evam Kala Academy of Department of Culture, Govt. of Madhya Pradesh. The musician contributed immensely to the domain of Indian classical music as he was a court musician and he reshaped the Maihar Gharana. Though the Maihar Gharana came into existence in the 19th century, Ustad Amir Khan's contribution to this genre of music was so crucial that he is frequently considered to be its creator.
www.culturemp.in

Orchha Festival

Celebration of a Medieval Splendour

ORCHHA

January

The historic town of Orchha, nestled on the banks of river Betwa, was founded in the 16th century. The ancient town seems frozen in time, with its many monuments which include palaces, temples, and cenotaphs (known as Chattris) continuing to retain their original grandeur even to this day. To present this grandeur in an artistic format, Namaste Orccha was organised. The performances in this event include fabulous performances on the Betwa Ghats, in the shadows of Chhattris under an atmosphere rarely experienced.
The Namaste Orchha Festival takes place every year in March and it serves to showcase the wondrous glories of this town which features on the tentative list of UNESCO World Heritage Sites and is filled with ancient monuments and unforgettable silhouettes.
www.mptourism.com/events

Khajuraho Dance Festival

Festival of Classical Dances

KHAJURAHO

February

The Khajuraho Dance Festival is being held since 1975 and it has been one of the most popular cultural events in India, attended by local, national, and international audiences. Held in the spectacular vicinity of the evocative Khajuraho Temples, performing artists offer tributes to gods and leave the audience enthralled. The setting sun, soft lights, sounds of anklets, and musical instruments create an enchanting spell on the audience. Indian classical dance forms like Bharatanatyam, Kathakali, Odissi, Manipuri, Kathak, and Mohiniyattam are showcased at the festival.
www.khajurahodancefestival.com

Bhagoria Festival

A Tribal Festival

JHABUA

March

The Bhagoria Festival coincides with the completion of harvest time for the primarily agrarian population of Madhya Pradesh, thus adding the dimension of being an agriculture festival alongside a tribal festivity that has been celebrated from time immemorial. If the crops have been good, the festival assumes an additional air of gaiety in the life of the Bhils and Bhilalas (the aboriginal tribals). Bhagoria is not merely one festival but in fact, a series of fairs held one by one at various villages on their specific market days, commencing seven days before Holi.
www.culturemp.in

Prakatya Parv

Festival of Lord Rama

ACROSS THE STATE

April

Rama is a major deity in Hinduism. He is the seventh and one of the most popular avatars of Vishnu and is the main protagonist of the famous Indian classic, Ramayana.

In Hinduism, the birth of Lord Ram is celebrated as Ramnavami. In Madhya Pradesh, this important Hindu festival is celebrated as Prakatyaparv by the Department of Culture, Government of Madhya Pradesh. Multiple art forms related to Lord Ram are combined to form an elaborate ceremony. This cultural extravaganza is celebrated for seven days across the state.

Ram Raja Temple, Orchha

Chanderi Festival

Beauty of Chanderi

CHANDERI

October

The Chanderi Festival is celebrated in the enchanting town of Chanderi, Madhya Pradesh, to embrace its rich heritage and exquisite handloom traditions. This eagerly anticipated festival aims to showcase the beauty and craftsmanship of Chanderi's handwoven textiles, known for their intricate designs and timeless elegance. Going beyond the realm of textiles, the festival will also offer an array of exciting activities, combining adventure and recreation.

For those seeking relaxation and rejuvenation, there will be yoga sessions to harmonize the mind, body, and soul. Families can enjoy a dedicated kids zone, ensuring that the festival is a memorable experience for all age groups. The festival will span over five days, commencing after the monsoon season, when the natural beauty of Chanderi is at its peak.

A tent city will be set up for the guests to explore and immerse themselves in the cultural extravaganza of the Chanderi Festival.
www.mptourism.com/events

Pranpur Village

Gandhisagar Floating Festival

Festival of Adventure & Water Sports

MANDSAUR

October - November

The Gandhisagar Floating Festival, held in the Mandsaur district of Madhya Pradesh, is a unique glamping experience that offers a unique space for nature lovers and adventure seekers alike. Initiated by MP Tourism, the festival allows guests to indulge in various exhilarating air, land, and water-based activities, such as parasailing, hot air balloon rides, jet skiing, kayaking, ATV riding, speed boating, pontoon boat riding, jungle safaris, and night walks.

The festival is attracting tourists from different areas to explore the state's diverse landscapes while establishing Gandhisagar as the 'Adventure Capital of Madhya Pradesh.'

www.mptourism.com/events

Kuno Forest Festival

Thrilling Safari, Wildlife & more

SHEOPUR

October - November

The enticing Kuno Festival is celebrated near the picturesque Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh. Organized by Madhya Pradesh Tourism Board, this five-day extravaganza will serve as a celebration of the state's remarkable wildlife offerings, with a special highlight being the translocation of cheetahs in India for the first time in 70 years.

The festival takes place post-monsoon where the tourists can revel in the pleasant weather of the region. Furthermore, a tent city will be set up, offering a unique and immersive experience in close proximity to the festivities. The tent city will be set up for the guests to explore and enjoy the wonders of the Kuno Festival.

The festival promises an unforgettable experience for nature enthusiasts, adventure seekers, and those in search of relaxation. Attendees can partake in a variety of land, water, and air adventure activities, ranging from thrilling safaris to serene cycling tours. Yoga, meditation, and wellness sessions will also be available to provide a harmonious balance amidst the natural surroundings.

www.mptourism.com/events

Allauddin Khan Samaroh

Celebration of the Great Musician

MAIHAR

November

Allauddin Khan Samaroh of Maihar is a three-day music festival that is organized in the month of February every year. As Allauddin Khan Sangeet Samaroh at Maihar, Satna is invariably linked to Allauddin Khan, it would be better to know who this person was and how he contributed to the domain of Indian classical music. While he was a court musician, Allauddin Khan totally reshaped Indian classical music's Maihar gharana. Though the Maihar gharana came into existence in the 19th century, Khan's contribution to this genre of music was so rudimentary that he is frequenty taken to be its creator.
www.culturemp.in

Akhil Bhartiya Kalidas Samaroh

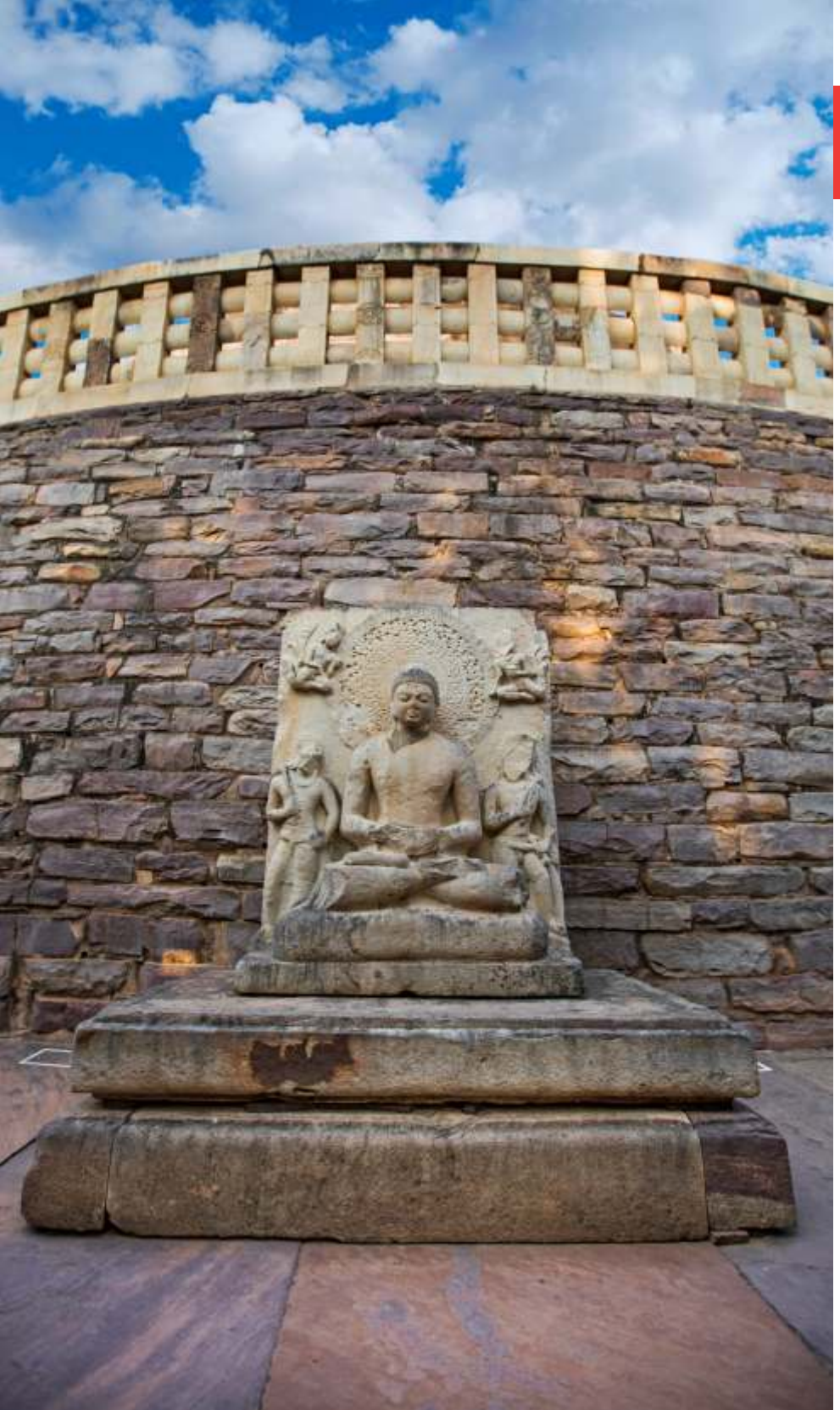
All India Kalidas Festival

UJJAIN

November

The Kalidas Festival in Ujjain takes pride in its association with Kalidas, one of the greatest poets of the country. Kalidas is a poet who has contributed considerably to Sanskrit literature. In his works, this great poet has pictured the beauty of life and the glory of existence. Several cultural performances are organized during this time to mark the occasion and a sense of intellectual fervour and gaiety mark the days of the festival in the holy city of Ujjain.

Sanskrit is a classical language of South Asia that belongs to the Indo-Aryan branch of the Indo-European languages. It arose in South Asia after its predecessor languages had diffused from the northwest in the late Bronze Age.
www.kalidasacademy.com



Mahabodhi Festival

Festival of Lord Buddha

SANCHI

November

Every year, the Mahabodhi Festival is held in Sanchi on the last Saturday of November to honour the teachings of Lord Buddha. Sanchi is a UNESCO World Heritage site that houses the Jambudweep theme park and several museums dedicated to the preservation of Buddhist history and art. During this festival, remains of the disciples of Lord Buddha are kept for public viewing. These precious relics were brought to Sanchi from Sri Lanka at the behest of India's first Prime Minister, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru.

This two-day festival enthralls audiences with theatrical ballads based on the Jataka Tales of Lord Buddha which are performed by renowned artists at the pilgrimage town of Sanchi. Mahabodhi is a prestigious festival organized by the Culture Department of the Madhya Pradesh Government in association with the local authorities in Raisen and Sanchi, who lend their support and cooperation to carry out this event successfully.

Jal Mahotsav

Water Carnival

HANUWANTIYA

November - January

Jal Mahotsav has been instrumental in establishing Madhya Pradesh as a frontrunner in the national arena of adventure and water tourism. This event has brought together different kinds of adventure activities on one platform and has earned the title of India's foremost Adventure Festival. This month-long event is India's largest water, land, and air carnival where an array of activities such as parasailing, water zorbing, banana, and speed boating are offered alongside All Terrain Vehicle racing and hot air ballooning. The island becomes a hub of activity with many yoga sessions, food stalls, and craft bazaars springing up to offer a wholesome cultural experience.
www.jalmahotsav.com

Tansen Samaroh

Tansen Festival

GWALIOR

December

Celebrated in the memory of music maestro Tansen, Tansen Samaroh is celebrated every year in December in Behat village of Gwalior district, Madhya Pradesh. It is organised jointly by the Department of Culture, Govt. of Madhya Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh Tourism, in December. This 4-day musical extravaganza is organised near the tomb of Tansen with the support of Ustad Alauddin Khan Kala Evam Sangeet Academy.

It hosts renowned musical maestros as well as upcoming artists of Indian classical music. It is awaited by music lovers across the country and the interactive sessions on Indian classical music are also a part of the event.
www.mptourism.com/events

Mandu Festival

Celebration of Heritage

MANDU

December/January

A three-day music festival, Raag Ameer is organised in the memory of Ustad Amir Khan by Ustad Alauddin Khan Sangeet Evam Kala Academy of Department of Culture, Govt. of Madhya Pradesh. The musician contributed immensely to the domain of Indian classical music as he was a court musician and he reshaped the Maihar Gharana. Though the Maihar Gharana came into existence in the 19th century, Ustad Amir Khan's contribution to this genre of music was so crucial that he is frequently considered to be its creator.
www.culturemp.in

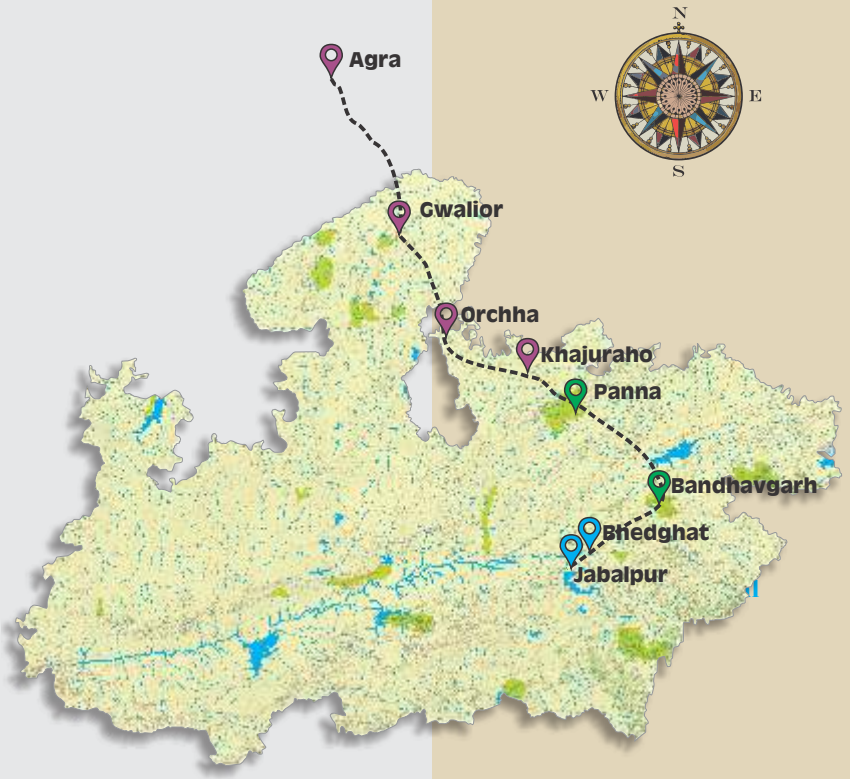
MADHYA PRADESH

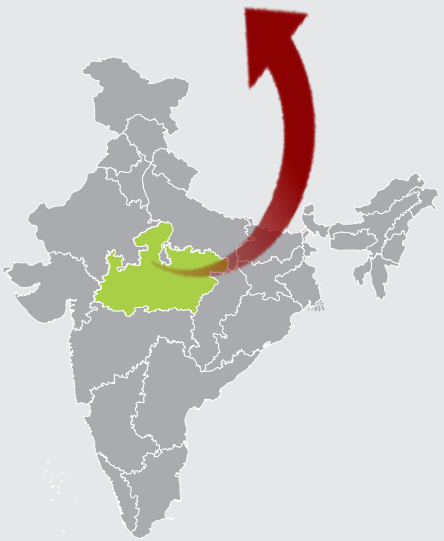
The heart of Incredible India

Gateway to the Heart of India!

The North East Fringe of Madhya Pradesh

Best Season - October to March





10N/11D

- Arrival from Agra
- Gwalior (2N)
- Orchha (2N)
- Khajuraho (2N)
- Panna (1N)
- Bandhavgarh (2N)
- Jabalpur (1N)
- Departure to Delhi/Mumbai

or

7N/8D

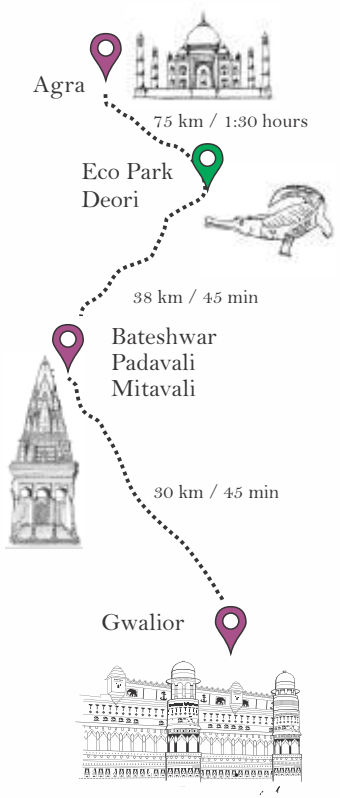
- Arrival from Agra
- Gwalior (2N)
- Orchha (2N)
- Khajuraho (2N)
- Panna (1N)
- Departure to Varanasi from Khajuraho

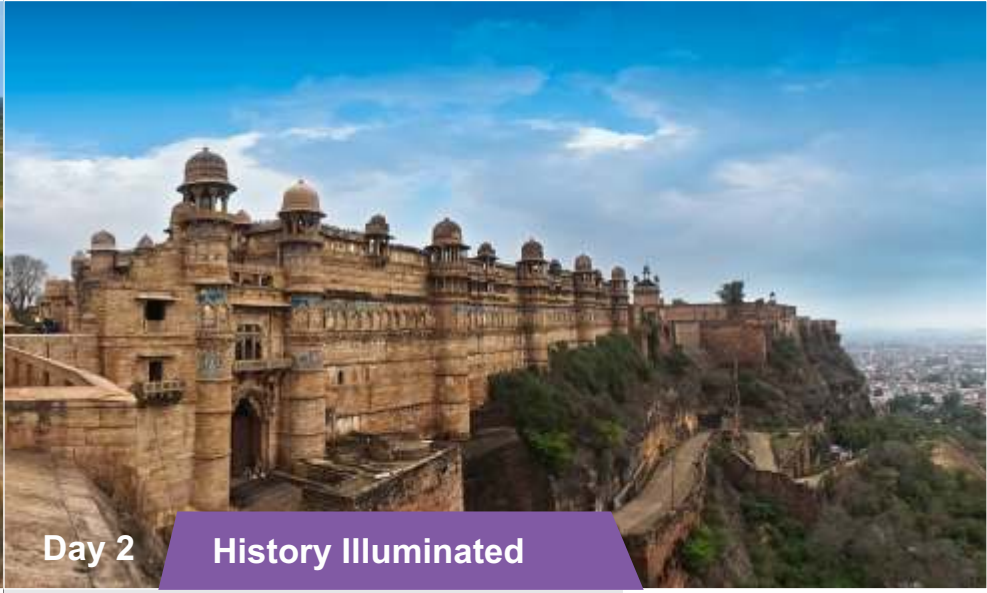
Day 1 Historic Wonders

- After breakfast Departure from Agra to Gwalior at 09.30 hrs by road (120KM 3hrs).
- Enroute Visit to Eco Park Deori, Morena 11:00 hrs. (Crocodile breeding center 74 Kms from Agra)
- Visit Padavali 13:00 hrs
  (The notable Padavali fortress was built in the 18th century by the Jat Ranas rulers of Dhaulpur. Graciously guarded by a lion and lioness, the fort also has a temple that once served as a divine place to worship Lord Shiva.
  Lunch @MPT Padavali Way side amenity 14:00 hrs
- Departure for Mitavali 15:00 hrs
  (Mitavali is a village where the popular Chausath Yogini Temple lies - The temple is perched atop a hill surrounded by the lush greenery. A climb of approximately 100 steps will take you to the beauty of this splendid round temple.)
- Arrival at Gwalior, check-in in your hotel 18:00 hrs
- Free evening night Stay

Stay Option

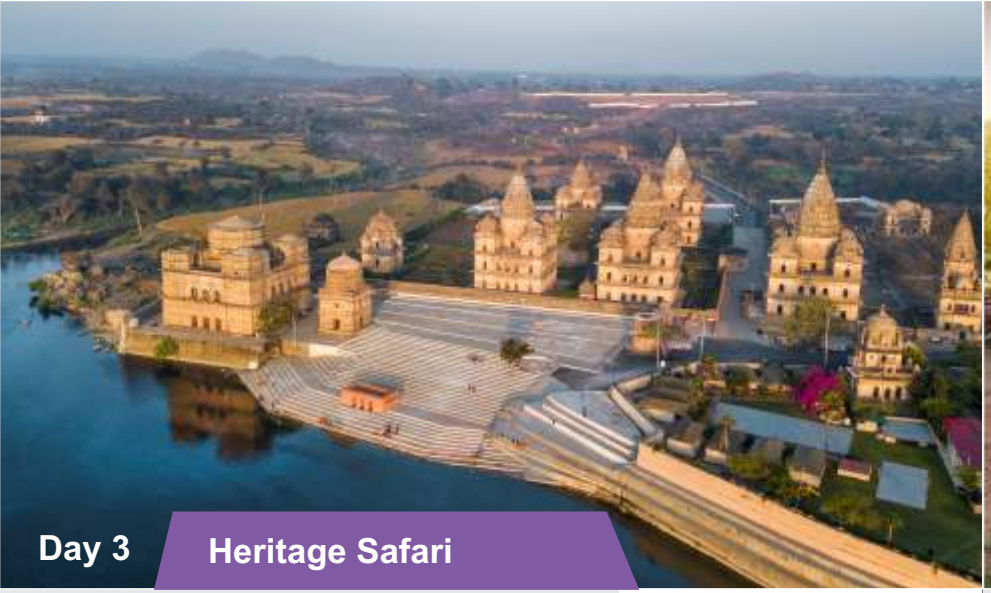
- Taj Usha Kiran Palace, Gwalior – Tajhotels.com
- Deo Bagh, Gwalior – neemranahotels.com
- MPT Tansen Residency, Gwalior – MPSTDC.com
- Clarks inn suites, Gwalior – theclarkshotels.com
- Many more Hotels and comfortable Homestays are available in and around Gwalior





Day 2 History Illuminated

- Early Morning "Sunrise Tour of Gwalior Fort"
- 06:00 hrs – 11:00hrs (duration 4 hrs)
- (Visit Sun Temple, Gwalior Fort, Gujari Mahal, Saas Bahu Temple & Teli Temple)
- Back to hotel Lunch & Rest
  Visit Jai Villas Palace Museum 15:00 hrs (The Jai Vilas Palace, is a nineteenth century palace in Gwalior, India. It was built in 1874 by Jayajirao Scindia, the Maharaja of Gwalior. While the major part of the palace is now the "Jiwajirao Scindia Museum" which is opened for the public since 1964, a part of it is still the residence of some of his descendants)
- Visit Maharaj Bada 18:30hrs (old city center) (Maharaj Bada or Jiwaji Chowk, which is famous as Bada is the most significant places of Gwalior in Madhya Pradesh. This phenomenal grand square is surrounded by various heritage buildings of British, Greek, French, Mughal & Indian Architecture.)
- Sound & Light Show @ Gwalior Fort @ 8:00 PM
- Back to hotel, dinner & night stay



Day 3 Heritage Safari

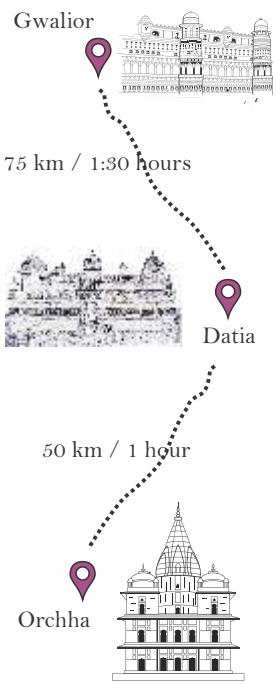
- After Breakfast Departure to Orchha 10:00 hrs (125 Km 2:30 hrs)
- Enroute visit Datia palace (75 Km from Gwalior 1:30 hrs) 11:30 hrs

  (An astonishing confluence of Mughal and Rajput architecture, the 7 storeyed Datia Palace stands tall in the historic city of Datia. While its exterior is adorned with arches, chhatris and oriel windows, the Bundela paintings beautify the interior. Datia is blessed with history as well as divinity. The Pitambara Peeth in Datia is a Shakti Peeth a religious center)
- Departure to Orchha (50 Kms 1:00 hrs)
- Check in and Lunch & Relax.
- Sight Seeing Jahangir Palace, Kanchana Ghat, Chhatris, Laxmi Narayan Temple. 16:00 hrs

  Exhibiting the wonderful Bundela-era legends, Orchha remains steadfast as the major historical site that has maintained the culture and legends of the rulers of the Bundela dynasty. This amazing town will fascinate you during your adventure, as it is a perfect destination to tour with friends and family.
- Sound & Light Show @ Raja Mahal 19:30 hrs (40 min Show)
- Back to hotel, dinner & night stay

Stay Option

- MPT Sheesh Mahal, Orchha – mpstdc.com
- Amar Mahal, Orchha – amarmahal.com
- Orchha Palace & Resort, Orchha – orchhapalace.com
- Many more Hotels and comfortable Homestays are available in and around Orchha



Day 4 Past & Pleasure

- Early Morning Activities (Cycling or Rafting) 6:00 hrs (2:00 hrs Activity)
- Back to Hotel have Breakfast
- Visit Ladpura Khaas (Rural Tourism Project) Brunch & Folk song / dance Performance 11:00 hrs (4 hrs) Ladpura Khas is full of natural scenic beauty of hills, forest and river within the vicinity. The village is a perfect destination to relax and enjoy nature. The cultural diversity within the community, the traditional values and beliefs of the Bundelkhand region with the traditional rural life makes the community more diverse and attracts more tourists to the place.
- Visit Ram Raja Temple 19:00 hrs (For Evening Prayer Aarti) (The Ram Raja Temple is the only temple in the country where Lord Rama is worshipped as the King rather than a God. It is also known as Orchha Temple. Shri Ram Raja Temple in Orchha is beautifully painted in hues of white, pink, and yellow)
- Back to hotel, dinner & night stay

Morning Activity

Ram Raja Temple

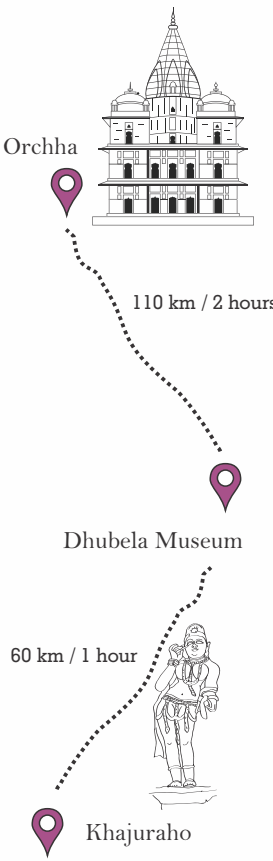
Day 5 Past Unveiling

- After Breakfast Departure for Khajuraho 9:30 hrs (170 Km / 3 hrs).
- Enroute Visit Dhubela Museum 11:30 hrs (110 Km from Orchha)

  Popularly known as Dhubela Museum, Maharaja Chhatrasal Museum is housed in a palace built by Maharaja Chhatrasal on the banks of Dhubela Lake. The museum houses a rich collection of artefacts from the ancient and the modern era. The collection displayed in the museum helps tourists to know more about the history, development and decline of the famous Bundela dynasty of Khajuraho.
- Arrival Khajuraho @ 14:00 hrs check –in in your hotel Lunch & Relax
- Visit Southern & Eastern Group of Monuments 16:00 hrs (2 hrs visit)

  (Eastern Group of Monuments Consist of Javari, Vamana & Parshwanath Temples where southern group consists Dulhadeo & Chaturbhuj temple)
- Sound & Light Show @ Western Group 19:00 hrs
- Back to hotel, dinner & night stay

Stay Option
- MPT Hotel Payal, Khajuraho – mpstdc.com
- The Lalit Temple View, Khajuraho – thelalit.com
- Ramada, Khajuraho – ramadakhajuraho.com
- The Chandela, Khajuraho – chandela.in
- Many more Hotels and comfortable Homestays are available in and around Khajuraho

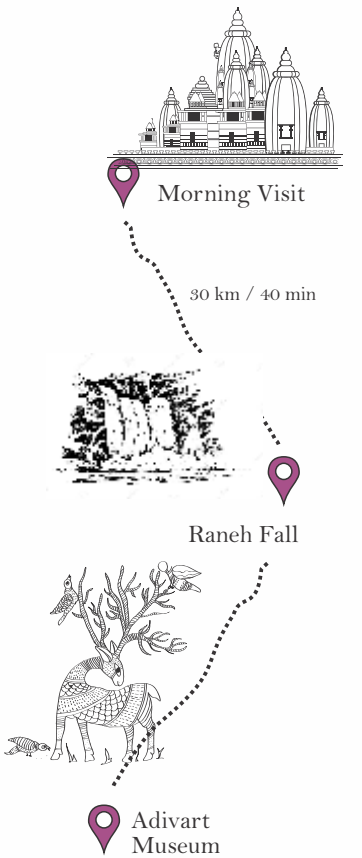


Day 6 Historical Cascades

- Early morning Visit of Western group of temples (6:30 hrs) 3 Hr Visit

  The Western group is very close to the archaeological museum and it includes the temples of Lakshmana, Matangeshwara, Varaha,Kandariya Mahadev, Chitragupta, Parvati, Vishwanatha and Nandi. (This group of temples has approximately 870 marvellous sculptures engraved on the interior and exterior walls.) Just after entering the Western group, the plaque on the right gives a brief introduction to the history of the Khajuraho. The main attraction of this place is a Shivling and the beautiful floral carving in the Sanctum of the temple.
- Back to Hotel Breakfast
- Visit Raneh waterfall 14:00 hrs (30 Km) (3 hrs excursion)
- Visit Adivart Tribal and Folk Art Museum 17:30 hrs

  The Adivart Tribal and Folk Art Museum. With 12 traditional houses representing major tribal communities (Bhil, Korku, Baiga, Gond, Saharia, Bharia and Gond) and five regions of the state, visitors can explore and immerse themselves in the fascinating tribal culture of Madhya Pradesh.
- Explore the Local Market & shopping.
- Back to hotel, dinner & night stay



Day 7 Cultural Escape

- After breakfast departure to Panna Tiger Reserve, Madla 10.00 hrs (25 km , 30 Min)

  The natural scenic beauty with the river, mountains and forest within just one km of the area, Madla is a rare village in India to have all the three natural geography features in a kilometre. The community awareness for the natural resources is incredible.
- Check in Homestay, Rural Activities & Lunch Visit Rural Tourism Project 11:00 hrs

  The traditional art special emphasis is on the stitching and manufacturing of the local souvenir. The traditional games are still played in the homestays to provide the essence of local community to tourist. The local excursion is provided through nature walks, cycle rides, and village tours.
- Nature Walk "Walk with Pardhis" 15:30 hrs (2:30 hrs nature walk)

  An experiential walk in the wilderness with the people of the forest wherein, you will be privy to the age old knowledge of the Pardhi community members along with some spectacular stories from the forest. This initiative is also bound to help you reconnect with the wilderness, as well as help 'read' the forest as the Pardhis do, where the trained Pardhi guide will lead a nature trail for tourists
- Cultural Performances by folk artist group
- Back to hotel, dinner & night stay

Stay Option
- Tendu Leaf Jungle Resort, Madla – tenduleafjungleresort.com
- Pashangarh, a Taj safari, Panna - tajhotels.com
- The Sarai at Toria, Madla – saraiattoria.com
- Jungle Camp, Madla – mpstdc.com
- Many more Hotels and comfortable Homestays are available in and around Panna

Rural Stay

30 km / 40 min

Walk with Pardhis

Cultural Activity & Dinner

Day 8 Wild Chronicles

- Early morning Jeep Safari in Panna Tiger Reserve, Madla 06:00 - 10:00 hrs (4 hrs)

  Panna National Park boasts of seven different species of vultures. Panna tiger reserve is an ideal place to spot these in their natural habitat. You will also come across a variety of Flora and fauna here.
- Back to Rural Stay & early Lunch 12:00 hrs
- Departure to Bandhavgarh (220 Km 4:30 hrs)
- Check in, Hotel Hi Tea (17:00 hrs), Free evening.
- Cultural Performances by Folk artist group.
- Dinner & night Stay @ Resort

Stay Option
- Mahua Kothi by Taj, Bandhavgarh – Tajhotels.com
- Kings lodge, Bandhavgarh – kingslodge.in
- MPT White Tiger Forest Lodge, Bandhavgarh – mpstdc.com
- Samode safari lodge, Bandhavgarh - samode.com
- Many more Hotels and comfortable Homestays are available in and around Bandhavgarh

Panna

220 km / 4:30 Hours

Bandhavgarh

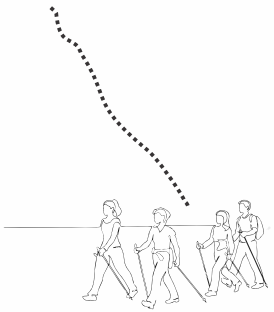
Day 9 Relax, Connect, Explore

- Early morning Jeep Safari in Bandhavgarh National Park.

  06:00 - 10:00 hrs (4 hrs)

  Bandhavgarh National Park and home to the royal Bengal tiger, 37 other species of mammals, 250 species of birds, 80 species of butterflies. Bandhavgarh National Park, Madhya Pradesh is the place to visit if you want to spot the big cat. India's top dwelling for tigers, it has the highest density of Royal Bengal tigers in the world.
- Back to Hotel & Lunch 12:30 hrs, Relax.
- Optional Visit to rural School for interaction with school kids (14:00 hrs – 15:00 hrs)
- Nature Walk in Bandhavgarh National Park
- Buffer Zone (16:00 hrs – 18:00 hrs) / interaction with villagers.
- Back to hotel
- Dinner & night Stay.

Jeep Safari



Nature Walk

Day 10 Sacred Repose

- Early morning Jeep Safari of Bandhavgarh National Park

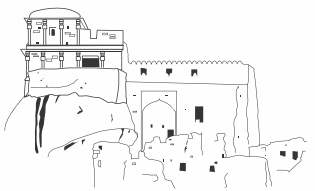
  06:00 - 10:00 hrs (4 hrs)

  Bandhavgarh National Park and home to the royal Bengal tiger, 37 other species of mammals, 250 species of birds, 80 species of butterflies. Bandhavgarh National Park, Madhya Pradesh is the place to visit if you want to spot the big cat. India's top dwelling for tigers, it has the highest density of Royal Bengal tigers in the world.
- Back to Hotel & Lunch 12:30 hrs
- Departure to Jabalpur (190 Km 4 hrs)
- Checkin Hotel @ 17:00 hrs
- Visit to Gwarighat @ 17:30 hrs participate in
- evening prayer aarti.
- Back to hotel
- Dinner & night Stay.

Bandhavgarh

190 km / 4 Hours

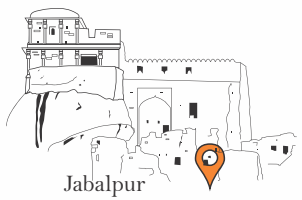
Jabalpur



Day 11 Exploring Nature Bidding Adieu

- After Breakfast Check out hotel
- departure to Bhedaghat @ 10:00 hrs
- Visit Dhuandhar Waterfall

  It is a mesmerizing experience to witness the marble rocks adjoining the graceful Narmada River in Bhedaghat, Jabalpur. These soaring white rocks, are known to magically change shapes as you sail along the river. Treat yourself with a boat ride on a moonlit night at the marble rocks when it shines like silver.
- Lunch @ Bhedaghat 13:00 hrs
- Departure to Airport (20 Km 40 min)
- Proceed journey back to Mumbai / Delhi by evening flight.



Jabalpur

20 km / 40 min

Bhedaghat

Fly back to

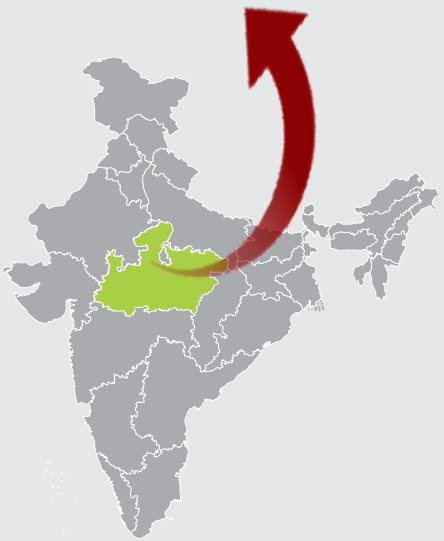
Mumbai/Delhi

The heart of Incredible India

Gateway to the Heart of India!

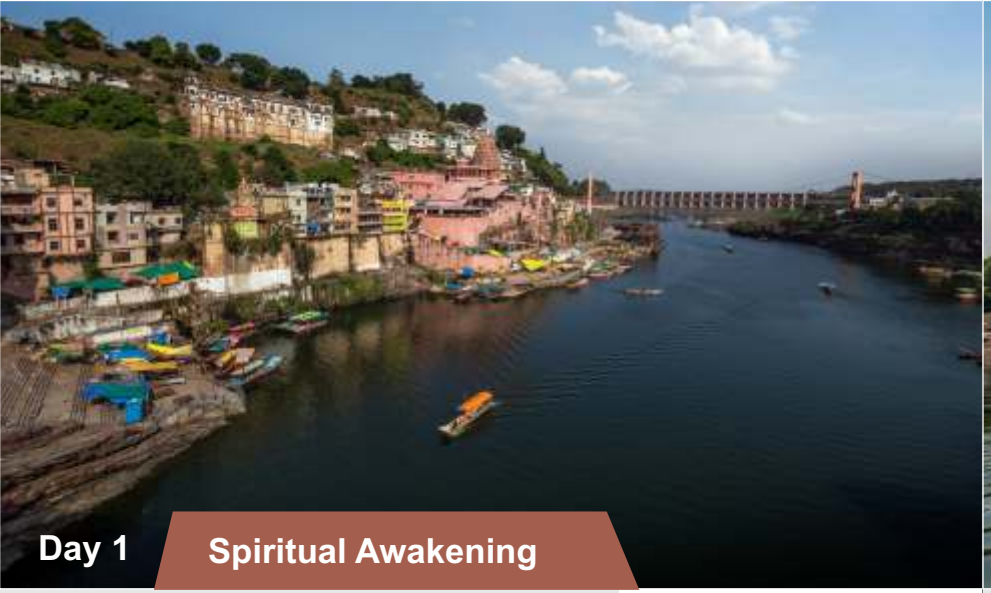
West and Central Madhya Pradesh

Best Season - October to March



9 Nights / 10 Days

- Arrival from Mumbai/Delhi at Indore
- Omkareshwar (1N)
- Maheshwar (1N)
- Mandu (1 N)
- Ujjain (1N)
- Bhopal (2N) – Sanchi & Bhimbetka Day Tour
- Madhai (1N) – Jungle Safari
- Pench (2N) – Jungle Safari
- Departure from Nagpur



Day 1 Spiritual Awakening

- Morning Arrival from Delhi/Mumbai to Indore
- Departure for Omkareshwar (75Kms, 02:00hrs)
- Hotel Check In
- Visit to "Lord Omkar" Jyotirlinga and Siddhanath Temple (archaeological site)

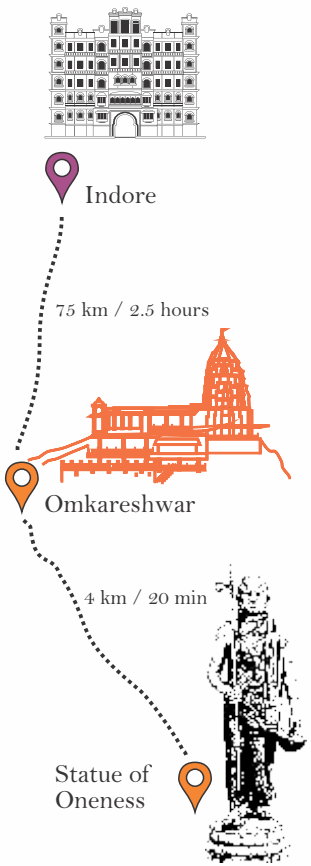
  It can only be termed as a blessing by the lords and mother nature, that Omkareshwar, the sacred island, is shaped like Om - the holiest symbol of Hinduism. It is adorned with lofty hills, between which the river Narmada forms a serene pool. Out of the major places to visit in Omkareshwar, the Omkareshwar Jyotirlinga shrine tops the list. Popularly known as 'Omkar Mandhata'
- Lunch at Temple View Hotel (MP Tourism)
- Visit Ekatma Dham – Statue of Oneness

  Ekatma Dham, radiates the message of oneness through the celebration of Sanatana Dharma and the legacy of Adi Shankaracharya standing tall at 108 feet, the Statue of Oneness in Omkareshwar is a towering monument of spiritual enlightenment. Crafted from multiple metals, this awe-inspiring statue pays tribute to the timeless wisdom of Adi Shankaracharya and his Advaita Vedanta philosophy. It rests atop a 54-ft pedestal, supported by a 27-ft lotus petal base, creating an impressive sight to behold.
- Dinner & Night Stay

Stay Option

1. MPT Temple View, Omkareshwar - mpstdc.com
2. MPT Sailani Island Resort, Omkareshwar - mpstdc.com

- Many more Hotels are available in and around Omkareshwar



Day 2 Heritage Sojourn

- After Breakfast check out Hotel
- Depart for Maheshwar 09:00 hrs – (60Kms duration 1:30hrs)
- Visit Rajwada & Devi Ahilya Museum

  A public courtyard-cum-hotel, Rajwada has a glass-cased statue of Ahilyabai. It also houses a Shiva temple with a golden lingam. This east-facing palace is simple in its design and portrays the austere lifestyle of Rani Ahilyabai Holkar.
- Lunch at Narmada Resort (MP Tourism)
- Fort, Ghats and other monuments

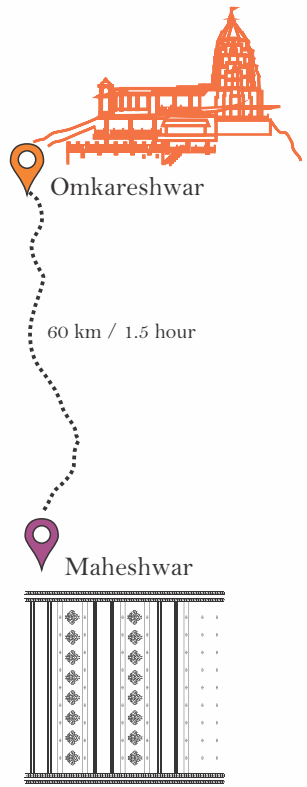
  The massive fort stands on a hill with the holy Narmada on one side and the modern town of Maheshwar on the other side. The Ahilyabai fort and palace house a beautiful life-size statue of Rani Ahilyabai on a throne and a Shiva temple.
- Visit Rehwa Society & Interact with Local Weavers Community

  This society in Maheshwar was formed to support the local weavers and sustain their craft. Society now provides an outlet for their work and also a medium for Maheshwari saree lovers to buy these beautiful sarees. (Famous Handmade fabric)
- Enjoy Local Story telling & boating in river Narmada in the evening
- Maheshwar Fort & Ghats are popular locations for films
- Back to hotel, Dinner & night Stay

Stay Options

1. MPT Narmada Resort, Maheshwar - mpstdc.com
2. Ahilya Fort Heritage Hotel , Maheshwar - ahilyafort.com

- Many more Hotels & comfortable Homestays are available in and around Maheshwar



Day 3 Love & Legacy

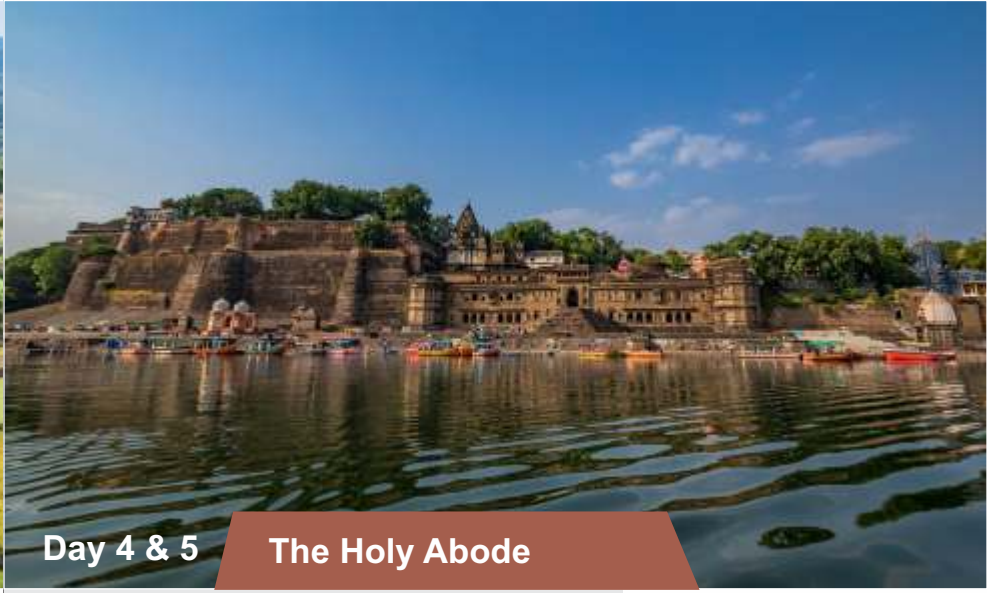
- After breakfast check out Hotel
- Departure for Mandu -09:00hrs (65kms. 2.00hrs)
- Hotel Check In
- Visit famous Rani Roopmati Pavilion

  The pavilion was originally built as an army observation post. From its hilltop perch, this graceful structure with its two pavilions was a retreat of the queen, from where she could see Baz Bahadur's palace and the Narmada flowing through the Nimar plains far below.
- Lunch at Malwa Resort (MP Tourism)
- Jami Masjid - Inspired by the great mosque of Damascus, the Jami Masjid was conceived on a grand scale, with a high plinth and a huge domed porch.
- Hoshang Shah's Tomb -It is India's first marble edifice and is adorned with a magnificently proportioned dome, marble lattice work, porticoed courts, and towers to mark the four corners of the rectangle. Shah Jehan sent four of his great architects to study the design and draw inspiration from the tomb.
- Visit Jahaz Mahal (Ship Palace)

  This 120-meter-long 'Jahaz Mahal' built between two artificial lakes, Munj Talao and Kapur Talao, is an elegant two-storeyed palace. With its open pavilions, balconies overhanging the water and open terrace, Jahaz Mahal is an imaginative recreation in stones of a royal pleasure craft.
- Sound & Light Show – 19:00hrs
- Dinner & Night Stay

Stay Options
MPT Malwa Resort, Mandu - mpstdc.com

- Many more Hotels & comfortable Homestays are available in and around Mandu



Day 4 & 5 The Holy Abode

- After breakfast Depart for Ujjain 09:00hrs (130Kms. -3:00hrs)
- Enroute Visit "Dinasaur Fossil" Park. – 6Kms from Mandu
- Enroute Visit Kelkar Museum Dhar, Shopping - Handloom Fabric with Bagh Print (Block) & handicraft items.
- Arrival Ujjain – Hotel Check In, Lunch and Relax.
- Visit Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga Temple

  The Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga Temple is one of the 12 jyotirlingas, where Bhasma Aarti is a daily ritual that you must not miss and this is what Ujjain is famous for. The process begins with the 'Abhishek' or the ritual bath of the shivling then smearing it with multiple offerings like curd, honey, sandal paste and finally cleaning it with milk and water. Finally, the Shivling is decorated with ash and shringaar material.
- Visit Mahakal Lok Corridor

  To develop tourism, preserve ancient heritage, and provide world-class modern facilities to the pilgrims, the 'Mahakal Lok' project has been implemented in Ujjain.

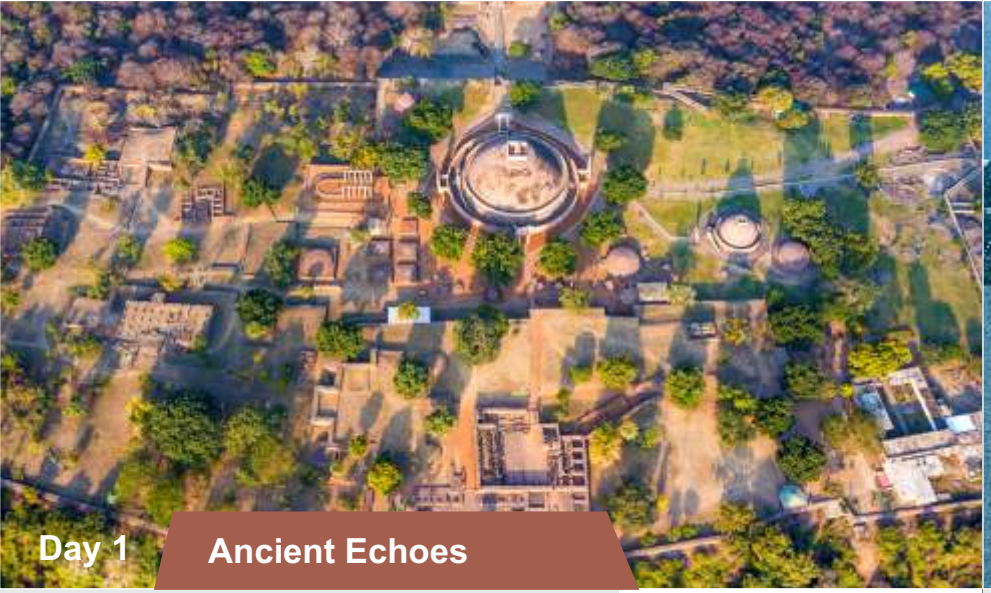
  The Mahakal Lok Corridor is surrounded by the old Rudrasagar Lake. Once you enter the corridor, you will see 108 pillars, around 200 statues, and murals that display stories of Shiva.
- Visit other important temples in Ujjain (Kal Bhairav Temple, Harsiddhi Temple, Vedh Shala)
- Dinner & Night Stay

Day 5

- Early morning Bhasm Aarti - 04:00hrs (Optional)
- Depart to Indore Airport – (65 Kms, 2 hrs.) for return journey to Mumbai/Delhi OR
- Continue your tour to Bhopal and around

Stay Options
1. MPT Shipra Residency, Ujjain - mpstdc.com
2. Hotel Anjushree, Ujjain - anjushree.com
3. Hotel Mittal Paradise - mittalresorts.in

- Many more Hotels & comfortable Homestays are available in and around Ujjain



Day 1 Ancient Echoes

- Morning Flight from Mumbai/Delhi/ Indore (200kms 4hrs) to Bhopal
- Check In at Hotel
- Departure for Sanchi 12 Noon (55kms, 1.30hrs.)

  This UNESCO World Heritage Site is famous for Buddhist Stupa & Vihar dating from 3rd century BC to 12 century AD. Built by the great Mauryan King Ashoka the architectural structure contains the relics of the disciples of Lord Buddha.
- Lunch at Hotel Gateway retreat (MP Tourism)
- Visit Udaygiri Caves - Located only 16 km away from Sanchi, the Udaigiri Caves offers 20 caves, consisting of 18 Hindu and 2 Jain caves with intricate religious iconography and sculpted stories dating back to the 4th and 5th centuries AD.
- Sound and Light Show, Sanchi -19:00hrs

  Against the stunning backdrop of the Stupas, this unique show beautifully narrates the story of these ancient monuments while evoking the life of Gautam Buddha and Emperor Ashoka.
- Back to Bhopal
- Dinner & Night Stay at Hotel

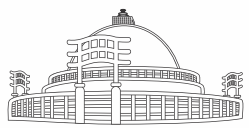
Stay Options

1. MPT Palash Residency, Bhopal - mpstdc.com
2. Taj Lakefront, Bhopal - tajhotels.com
3. Hotel Jehanuma Palace, Bhopal - jehannuma.com
4. Courtyard by Marriott, Bhopal - marriott.com
5. Enrise by Sayaji, Bhopal - sayajihotels.com
6. Radisson Hotel, Bhopal - radissonhotels.com
7. Lemon Tree, Bhopal - lemontreehotels.com

- Many more Hotels & comfortable Homestays are available in and around Bhopal

Bhopal

55 km / 1.5 hour



Sanchi

16 km / 30 min

Udaygiri Caves

Day 2 Exploring the City of Lakes

- Early Morning departure for Heritage Walk 07:30 hrs (2hrs)
- Back to Hotel, Breakfast
- Lunch
- Visit Tribal Museum & State Museum

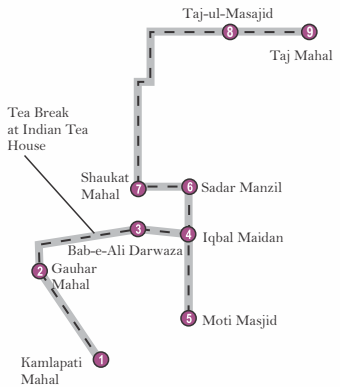
  The Madhya Pradesh Tribal Museum in Bhopal takes you on an immersive journey through the culture and tells the stories of tribal heritage through full-scale models and colourful art installations and performances. It is one of the best museums in India where one can also witness magnificent traditional music, dance and drama performances hosted by the museum.
- Visit Museum of Mankind (Anthropological Museum)

  South of the Upper Lake sprawls the Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Manav Sangrahalaya a.k.a. the National Museum of Man, the largest anthropological museum in India, and one of the biggest in Asia. On an undulating terrain of over 200 acres, one can see an open-air exhibition of human habitations. Life-size dwelling units of the tribal, coastal and Himalayan villages are built in traditional architectural styles using indigenous raw materials, housing different ethnographic objects.
- Evening Cruise ride at Boat Club, Upper Lake
- Dinner & Night Stay at Hotel

Heritage Walk Route

Distance 2.5 kms

Duration 2 hrs



Tribal Museum

Tue - Sun

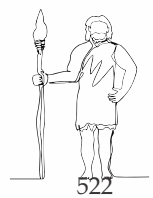
Feb to Oct, 12PM to 8PM

Nov to Jan, 12PM to 7PM

Museum of Mankind

Tue - Sun

10AM to 5:30PM



Day 3 From History to Wilderness

- After Breakfast, Check Out from Hotel
- Departure for Satpura National Park at 10:00hrs
- Enroute Visit UNESCO world heritage Site Bhimbetka (45kms, 1 Hr) Cave paintings dating back to approximately 30,000 years. Rock shelters that were home to humans, millennia ago. And a rich flora and fauna surrounding these, indeed, make Bhimbetka a gift to us from our earliest ancestors. The Bhimbetka Rock Shelter has the oldest-known rock art in India, and is one of the largest prehistoric complexes. An archaeological treasure, Bhimbetka has around 243 rock shelters and is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- Lunch at Highway Treat (MP Tourism), Bhimbetka
- Proceed to Satpura National Park- Madhai –(90kms 2:30hrs.)
- Check in Hotel
- Other Activities – Photography, Bird Watching, Canoeing in Back water of Tawa Dam (Please check Availability), Cycling, Interaction with villagers/ Homestay
- Dinner & Night Stay

Stay Options

1. MPT Bison Resort, Madhai - mpstdc.com
2. Denwa Backwater, Madhai - denwabackwaterescape.com
3. Reni Pani Jungle Lodge, Madhai - jehannuma.com
4. Forsyth Lodge, Madhai - forsythlodge.com

Bhopal

45 km / 1 hour

Bhimbetka

90 km / 2.5 hours

Satpura Tiger Reserve

Day 4 A Safari to Remember

- Early morning Jungle Safari at Satpura National Park, Madhai 06:00 - 10:00 hrs (4 hrs)

  Satpura National Park is highly recognized for its tranquil surroundings and its rich flora and fauna. The Satpura range, which has many towering hills and stunning waterfalls, is bordered by the Pachmarhi and Bori Sanctuaries. The experience of a river and a forest safari can be experienced in this national park of central India. A night Jungle safari in the buffer zone is another option for experiencing night-time activity, along with the normal morning safaris. Your journey will undoubtedly take you to the serene habitat of a variety of species, including the leopard, sambar, chital, nilgai, flying squirrel, and Indian giant squirrel, as well as a rich flora that includes sal, teak, tendu, mahua, bel, bamboo, and medicinal plants.
- Back to Hotel, relax
- Lunch at 12:00 noon
- Departure for Pench Tiger Reserve 13:00hrs.(250 Kms, 6hrs)
- Check in Hotel
- Dinner & Night Stay in Pench

Stay Options

1. MPT Kipling's Court, Pench - mpstdc.com
2. Baghvan Taj Safaris, Pench - tajhotels.com
3. Tathastu Resort, Pench - tathasturesorts.com
4. Riverwood Resort, Pench - waxpolhotels.com
5. Jungle Home Resort, Pench - junglehomepench.com

- Many more Hotels & comfortable Homestays are available in and around Bhopal

Satpura Tiger Reserve

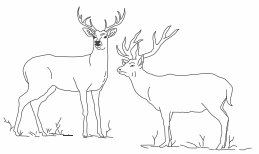
250 km / 6 hours

Pench Tiger Reserve

Day 5 Rural Charm and Natures Bliss

- Early morning Jungle Safari at Pench National Park, 06:00 - 10:00 hrs (4 hrs)
- Back to Hotel, Breakfast

  A magnificent expanse in Madhya Pradesh, Pench Tiger Reserve also shelters a dense population of cheetal (Spotted Deer), leopard, sambhar, gaur (Indian bison), chousingha (four-horned antelope), chinkara (Indian gazelle), barking deer, small Indian civet, and porcupine. It is also home to the migratory birds such as Malabar pied hornbill, Indian pitta and osprey. The "Jungle Book" written by Rudyard Kipling was inspired by the Pench National Park.
- Lunch at 13:00 hrs
- Activities – Pottery Village (Pachdhar) Visit
- Village Tour (Kohka) Interaction with villagers
- Nature Walk (with guide)
- Photography, Bird Watching, cycling
- Dinner & night stay at Resort



Pench Tiger Reserve

90 km / 2 hours

Nagpur

Day 6

- After Breakfast Departure to Nagpur Airport (90 Km 2hrs)
- Proceed journey to Mumbai / Delhi or further destinations

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